Sacrifice as GIFT

Eucharist, Grace, and Contemplative Prayer in Maurice de la Taille



Michon M. Matthiesen

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In memory of my father
Jerry Andrew Matthiesen
d. September 14, 2006
whom God called to Himself through
the Eucharist

and my friend
Gregor Goethals
d. February 1, 2008
who lived in wonder of the Mystery

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Preface

Scholarship that seeks publication aims at making a serious contribution to the field of research addressed by that work. This book is no different. I desire not only to retrieve the thought of a forgotten voice in the Catholic theological tradition, but also to address what I take to be a diminished understanding of eucharistic sacrifice in much contemporary liturgical theology. Should this exposition of Maurice de la Taille's eucharistic theology call into question prevailing presumptions against a theology of the Mass as sacrifice, then it will have made its humble contribution to the church's knowledge of faith and sacramental practice. I confess, however, to a second, "secret" objective, equal in significance to the goal of advancing scholarship. That is to say, I deeply hope that this book, mirroring my own experience of reading de la Taille, *excites* a hunger for the Eucharist, a longing for intimate union with the sacrificial Lamb from whom all grace and life flow. If the reader senses but a small movement of desire toward the ritual offering of sacrifice and the reception of eucharistic grace, then the book shall be a worthy tribute to the faith and *devotio* of the master theologian who wrote *Mysterium Fidei*.

The time I spent reading, translating, and thinking and writing about the work of Maurice de la Taille, S.J.—at my desk, in coffee shops, cycling along the Charles River, battling through New England winters, in the classroom with students—has been fruitfully and memorably enhanced by the intersection of several mentors and friends. I want to acknowledge and thank those who have buoyed my labors, who have been Barnabases—"sons (and daughters) of encouragement."

I first thank the gifted Frances Millican (now Sister Sofia, a Cistercian nun at Mount St. Mary's in Wrentham, Massachusetts), who graciously suffered all my virginal excitement over the discovery of de la Taille's thought, and who lent her linguistic expertise over those Latin passages that resisted being known in English.

I am deeply grateful to Sarah Coakley, who *liberally* expended time and energy with this project, ever prodding me to go more deeply into the central questions and to be more lucid in my writing. More, her commitment to the integration of rigorous theological thought and contemplative prayer and her modeling of this remain a permanent icon on my mental terrain. I likewise thank John Baldovin, S.J., who also deftly shepherded this study in its doctoral stage.

I wish to recognize a trinity of men who shaped and sustained this manuscript in quiet and faithful ways. David Burrell, C.S.C., longtime friend and mentor, is likely a chief secondary cause in my taking on this project: long ago he planted the seed of my affection for St. Thomas, and he continues to hone my capacity for reading and comprehending a Thomist of de la Taille's philosophical and theological acumen. My deep gratitude to the constant Peter Hawkins (Yale Divinity School), whose expert and theologically attuned teaching of the *Commedia* reminded me that the *telos* of theology is a transformative journey of desire, and who insisted that theology can be—indeed ought to be—a *bella lingua*. When lost mid-course in woods of writing and editing, he turned me again and again toward the light through the potency of words and images (often from scripture). A Vergil—but so much more. I count it proof of beneficent providence that I fell under the liturgical formation of Fr. James Savage, parochial vicar at St Paul's Parish in Cambridge, Massachusetts. His love of the liturgy, Eastern and Western, and of the Word, or rather, his saturation in these realities, made him a most splendid mystagogue, an instantiation of the liturgical spirituality that surfaces repeatedly in de la Taille's work. I am (impossibly) indebted to him for the food of inspiration and insight that I regularly took away from his preaching and prayer while writing this work.

I also wish to thank my third-year Eucharistic Theology students at Saint Patrick's Seminary (Menlo Park, California) for their enthusi-

astic and challenging response to my lectures on Maurice de la Taille. Their genuine interest, along with that of my colleague Frederick Cwiekowski, S.S., prompted me to persevere in finding a publisher for this manuscript. I express thanks as well to Monsignor Warren Holleran, not only for his keen and delightful grasp of de la Taille's thought on desire and the purification of the ego, but also for the seasoned wisdom he has shared with me about prayer, trust, and that long and narrow road of faith.

Finally, I extend my gratitude to the Ernest Fortin, S.J., Memorial Foundation, which funded my research at the Jesuit Archives located just outside Paris. The trip initiated a more intimate acquaintance with Père de la Taille as I pored over his letters and spent time at his humble gravesite. Along the arduous way of writing this study, that relationship has been a sustaining one.

June 26, 2011
The Solemnity of Corpus Christi
Los Angeles, California

Abbreviations

CP *Contemplative Prayer.* By Maurice de la Taille, Translated by a Carmelite Tertiary. London: Burns, Oates, and Washbourne, 1929.

EH *Ecclesiastical Hierarchy*

MF *Mysterium Fidei: De augustissimo corporis et sanguinis Christi sacrificio atque sacramento, Elucidationes L in tres libros distinctae.* By Maurice de la Taille. Paris: Beauchesne, 1921.

MF 1 *The Mystery of Faith: Regarding the Most August Sacrament and Sacrifice of the Body and Blood of Christ.* Book 1, The Sacrifice of Our Lord. New York: Sheed and Ward, 1940.

MF 2 *The Mystery of Faith: Regarding the Most August Sacrament and Sacrifice of the Body and Blood of Christ.* By Maurice de la Taille. Book 2, The Sacrifice of the Church. New York: Sheed and Ward, 1950.

PG Patrologiae Cursus Completus. Series Graeca [Patrologia Graeca]. Edited by J.-P. Migne. Paris, 1857–1912.

PL Patrologiae Cursus Completus. Series Latina [Patrologia Latina]. Edited by J.-P. Migne. Paris, 1878–1890.

PS Patrologia Syriaca. Edited by R. Graffin. Vol. 1. Paris: 1894.

SC Sources Chrétiennes. 529 vols. Paris: Cerf, 1941–.

SCG *Summa contra Gentiles*

ST *Summa theologiae*

TS *Theological Studies*

Sacrifice as Gift

Introduction

This study reconsiders the question of sacrifice for contemporary eucharistic theology through the thought of Maurice de la Taille, S.J. (1872–1933), whose masterwork, *Mysterium Fidei,* has been largely forgotten. To be sure, the topic of sacrifice is not without controversy. On the one hand, an emphasis on sacrifice tends to be emblematic of a growing segment of Roman Catholics who ostensibly desire to return to a pre-Vatican II eucharistic piety and worship style. Greater reflection is warranted on the question of whether the Tridentine, or 1962 Latin Rite, is, in its enactment, particularly susceptible to projecting an image of a God who yet needs to be appeased by sacrifice. On the other hand, a large and respected body of liturgical theologians, inspired by the liturgical renewal and revisions of Vatican II, has labored to reconceive eucharistic sacrifice, eager to remove any lingering suggestion of immolation, destruction, or violence. A more radical minority within this group contends—on pastoral, ecumenical, and theological grounds—that the church ought to eliminate sacrificial language entirely from the liturgy, often proposing in its stead the language of *gift*. These efforts to purge the notion of sacrifice have been fueled also by scholarly work in the fields of socioanthropology and feminist studies. The immensely influential thought of René Girard, for instance, has "unveiled" sacrifice as a mechanism for the maintenance of social order: a victim becomes necessary for diffusing the violence that mounts with rampant mimetic desire among humans. The feminist critique, for its part, contends that the sacrificial system is unavoidably patri-

archal and violent.[1] In short, any positive theologizing about sacrifice would have a difficult road to negotiate.

I submit, however, that Maurice de la Taille's work on eucharistic sacrifice effectively provides a way forward. His thought eschews controversy by destabilizing the unfruitful divide that has emerged between the objectivist language found frequently in official twentieth-century church teaching on sacrifice and the anti-sacrifice concerns of contemporary liturgical and sacramental theology. Contemporary eucharistic theologians like Robert Daly and Edward Kilmartin have expressed "embarrassment" over these official teachings, pointing out their "ossified," post-Tridentine positions.[2] Whether or not the Daly

1. For a feminist like Nancy Jay, for example, Christian sacrifice is a ritual tool to shore up an all-male Roman hierarchy; sacrifice, she memorably writes, is "childbirth done better"—no women need apply. Indeed, for Jay and most feminists, women ought to refuse—*tout court*—to participate in a liturgy of sacrifice. Sacrifice is necessary only for the "pure" man—and as ritually securing of his power; Jay, *Throughout Your Generations Forever: Sacrifice, Religion and Paternity* (Chicago: Chicago University Press, 1992). Sarah Coakley is a rare exception to this anti-sacrifice rule among feminist thinkers and theologians. See her provocative argument for women offering sacrifice in her *Flesh and Blood: The Eucharist, Desire and Fragmentation,* The Hensley Henson Lecture Series (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004–2005).

2. By "official church teaching" I intend the twentieth-century magisterial delineations of eucharistic sacrifice, found in a variety of papal encyclicals and apostolic letters from Pius XII's *Mediator Dei* (1947) to John Paul II's *Dominicae Cenae* (1980) and *Ecclesia de Eucharistia* (2003). I am here exposing, though not endorsing, the perspectives of Robert Daly, S.J., cf. "Robert Bellarmine and Post-Tridentine Eucharistic Theology," *Theological Studies* 61 (2000): 239–60, and Edward Kilmartin, S.J., *The Eucharist in the West: History and Theology* (Collegeville, Minn.: Liturgical Press, 1998) 189–204, 291–300. In brief, Daly finds the official teaching of the magisterium out of step with current theology on such issues as: (1) *in persona Christi* (the magisterium still considering the axiom far too narrowly); (2) a sacrificial and consecratory understanding of the Eucharist (the legacy of an erroneous history-of-religions approach to the Eucharist, as well as an overemphasis on the Words of Institution); (3) the ecclesiological and Trinitarian dynamic of the Eucharist (still overshadowed by an overly Christological and scholastic approach); and (4) the central goal of the Eucharist—transformation in Christ (which is muted by concerns about real presence and the Mass as sacrifice). Daly argues that the "embarrassing dichotomy" between "sound" eucharistic theology and magisterial teaching can be best broached by exposing the shortcomings of Tridentine theology (still plaguing official doctrine) and by explicating a more adequate understanding of the Eucharist—and one that accents a "continuity with the fullness of the Catholic tradition"; Daly, "Robert Bellarmine," 239–43, 260.

In his most recent book, *Sacrifice Unveiled: The True Meaning of Christian Sacrifice* (London: Continuum and T. and T. Clark, 2009), 160, Daly repeats these theological "shortcomings" of magisterial teaching. However, in a footnote (151n79), he does concede that Pope Benedict XVI's *Sacramentum Caritatis* (2007) presents a more "nuanced" approach to eucharistic sacrifice, one more resonant with that of "critical liturgical theologians"—which is to say, Daly perceives that the divide that he and Kilmartin have articulated may be closing, as the "traditional" magisterial teaching of the Catholic Church seems to be drawing closer to his perspective on eucharistic sacrifice.

and Kilmartin critique is entirely accurate—and I find their interpretation of the documents to be heavy-handed—my project here is to demonstrate how, in surprising ways, de la Taille's magisterial eucharistic theology forestalls prevalent post-Vatican II anxieties about sacrifice. It does so by decidedly challenging the formidable heritage of sixteenth- and seventeenth-century immolation-focused eucharistic theology *and* by providing a patristically rich theology of sacrifice that stands rooted in a spirituality of prayer and ascetic practice and that cannot be segregated from the ecclesial offering of Christ's sacrifice. Granted, these initial, broadly painted statements about the *status quaestionis* need to be substantiated and nuanced. However, before presenting a detailed account of current theological thought on sacrifice, I want to introduce Maurice de la Taille, the Jesuit whose impressive work on eucharistic sacrifice, *Mysterium Fidei* (1921), elicited praise as a veritable "événement théologique," but also denunciation as "heretical" theology.[3]

Maurice de la Taille, S.J. (1872–1933): His Life, His Methodology, His Sources

Maurice de la Taille, one of eleven boys in a family of nobility from Indre-et-Loire, belongs to that rather eminent group of French Jesuits whose education and formation were disrupted by the secularist laws exiling religious orders from France. For example, among his exiled confrères at St. Mary's in Canterbury were Jules Lebreton, who would be a life-long friend, and Adhémar d'Alès; both are well-known for their careful theological and historical retrieval of scripture and the church fathers.[4] More, it is almost sure that de la Taille and Pierre Rousselot were classmates at some point on British soil and, at the very least, were both taught by the renowned Léonce Grandmaison, for whom de

3. The accusation of heresy referred to the view that de la Taille's thought flagrantly denied the Council of Trent's teaching on eucharistic sacrifice (Session 22). We shall respond in full to these false denunciations in chapters 2 and 3.

4. Bernard Leeming, "A Master Theologian: Father Maurice de la Taille," *The Month* 163 (1934): 31–32. Jules Lebreton would write on the history and doctrine of the Trinity, and d'Alès is remebered for his historical work on the sacrament of penance and baptism, as well as for editing the *Dictionnaire Apologétique de la Foi Catholique.*

la Taille had an enduring, strong affection.[5] Because of weak health, de la Taille spent a year of his early Jesuit formation (and later intervals as well) at the Benedictine monastery of Ramsgate. I mention this biographical point because he there seems to have ingested a profound appreciation for the church's liturgy. His friend Lebreton comments that de la Taille would willingly preside at the later Sunday Eucharist merely for the "joy of celebrating solemnly."[6] Others have also remarked that he presided at the Eucharist as if he were an abbot leading in prayer a community of monks.[7] As we shall also note in examining de la Taille's thought on contemplation, he would retain a deep sympathy with the Benedictine religious order throughout his life.

With the temporary easing of anti-clerical measures in the mid- to late 1890s, de la Taille was able to return to France, where he studied theology at the L'Institut catholique and earned a Licentiate in philosophy at the Sorbonne. He was ordained at Tours in 1901. The following year, with the passing of the Associations Law, he was again forced to return to England, where he continued studies at Canterbury. During this second sojourn at St. Mary's, de la Taille followed the counsel of a spiritual director, P. Mazoyer, and began to study the Epistle to the Hebrews. He frequently recounted that this New Testament text was as a bright beacon of light across his intellectual and spiritual terrain and absolutely seminal to his thought.[8]

De la Taille's tertianship year (1904–1905) at Mold, in Wales, seems to have been a generative one. It was here that he came under the direction of Réne de Maumigny, who enflamed and shaped his inter-

5. Jules Lebreton, "*In memoriam:* Le Père Maurice de la Taille," *Récherches de science réligieuse* 24 (1934): 7: "[I]l faut en rapprocher l'influence du P. de Grandmaison; il avait été le condisciple du P. de la Taille à son arrivée en théologie, puis son maître; il fut toujours son ami; il a été par lui aimé et compris comme par bien peu d'hommes, et de cette intuition fleurissait une vénération qui resta toujours discrète, mème après la mort du P. Léonce, mais que les plus intimes amis de P. Maurice connaissaient bien."

6. Lebreton, "*In memoriam*," 6. Lebreton also notes that during de la Taille's time at the monastery, he grew fond of English literature and acquired a rare command of the language. This is borne out in his personal correspondences later in life with English friends.

7. Lebreton, "*In memoriam*," 6. Apparently, the volume of his voice and his grand gestures were not appreciated by those celebrating Mass at private altars nearby!

8. Lebreton comments that Hebrews was a fountain for de la Taille's theological work: "toute sa construction théologique en sortit"; Lebreton, "*In memoriam*," 7.

est in contemplative prayer.[9] It was also in Wales that he composed a Lenten series of sermons on "The Sacrifice of the Mass," in which he gives an initial articulation of his insight on eucharistic sacrifice. In 1905 he returned to France as professor at the School of Theology at Angers, where he developed lectures on eucharistic theology and, over a ten-year period, wrote the major work of his life, *Mysterium Fidei: De augustissimo corporis et sanguinis Christi sacrificio atque sacramento, Elucidationes L in tres libros distinctae*.[10] Though completed in 1915, the volume did not see publication until 1921, after he returned from serving as a chaplain in the First World War. Immediately following the war, de la Taille was invited to become a professor at the Gregorian University in Rome, participating in a newly inaugurated "*cursus magistri*" designed for those who would themselves become teachers of theology. Until his health declined in 1930, de la Taille taught at the Gregorianum alongside such eminent theologians as Cardinals Louis Billot and Francis Ehrle. He is reported to have been a most vivid and dynamic teacher, with a "challenging" and "oratorical" style.[11]

De la Taille's lectures on the philosophy and theology of Thomas Aquinas, delivered at the Angelicum, drew audiences of over two hundred, and from "all orders and ranks."[12] Early in his studies de la Taille had been seduced by the luminous and wide horizons of Thomas's thought; he would remain a faithful disciple of Thomas throughout his own theological writing.[13] Even so, as will become apparent in the course of this study, de la Taille does not fall easily into a neo-Scholastic school such

9. Rene de Maumigny was a well-known spiritual director and author of a two-volume work, *Le pratique d'oraison mentale:* vol. 1, *L'oraison ordinaire,* and vol. 2, *L'oraison extraordinaire,* first published in 1905–1907 (Paris: Beauchesne); cf. chap. 7 of this volume for a further discussion of de la Taille's relationship to Maumigny.

10. Maurice de la Taille, *Mysterium Fidei: De augustissimo corporis et sanguinis Christi sacrificio atque sacramento, Elucidationes L in tres libros distinctae* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1921, 1924, 1931). The first two volumes of the work have been translated into English: *The Mystery of Faith: Regarding the Most August Sacrament and Sacrifice of the Body and Blood of Christ,* book 1, *The Sacrifice of Our Lord* (New York: Sheed and Ward, 1940); and book 2, *The Sacrifice of the Church* (New York: Sheed and Ward, 1950). I shall be using the Latin text of 1921 in this study. My citations from the original Latin will be indicated by "*MF,*" followed only by the page number, whereas my use of the English translations will be indicated by "*MF*" followed by the volume number, then the page number (for instance: *MF* 1:viii; *MF* 2:14.)

11. Leeming, "Master Theologian," 38.

12. Leeming, "Master Theologian," 39.

13. Lebreton, "*In memoriam,*" 6.

as the one represented by the Dominican Garrigou-Lagrange, a leading figure of the *rigorissimi* interpreters of the Angelic Doctor. In fact, since Garrigou-Lagrange was professor at the Angelicum from 1909 until his death in 1965, these two Thomists no doubt had the opportunity to hear one another's lectures.[14] How they might have assessed each other's thought is thus far left to speculation only. In the first few decades of the twentieth century, there may well have been a fair dose of mutual respect and agreement between the Dominican and the Jesuit. However, the connection mentioned above between Rousselot and de la Taille is not without incident; as I shall suggest below, both of these thinkers share a desire and a capacity to read Thomas afresh—escaping from the standing influence of Suarez in Thomistic seminary teaching, an interpretive lens that synthesized Thomas and Scotus.[15] As will be apparent in our chapters on grace and contemplation, de la Taille retrieves an authentic Thomistic vision that refuses to sharply oppose nature and grace or the intellect and will.

De la Taille was a keen reader of Thomas and knew well the tradition of Thomist interpretation: John of Thomas, Cajetan, de Lugo, Suarez, and Franzelin appear frequently in his work, accompanied by words both of appreciation and critique. His own interaction with Thomas might be described best as loyal and independent.[16] Though an acute philosopher, he abhorred a *strictly* philosophical approach to Thomas, one eager to establish a "grand system" of Thomas's thought. Rather, de la Taille recognized the vitality of Thomistic theology, extol-

14. Without doubt, these two thinkers have deep common interest in spiritual theology, and particularly in synthesizing the work of Thomas and John of the Cross. De la Taille's first publication on the topic of contemplative prayer in 1919 (see chapter 7) already reveals the influence of John of the Cross. In 1923, Réginald Garrigou-Lagrange published *Le perfection chrétienne et contemplation selon S. Thomas d'Aquin et S. Jean de la Croix* (Var: Saint-Maximin), based upon lectures he had been delivering at the Angelicum in Rome; see Richard Peddicord, O.P., *The Sacred Monster of Thomism: An Introduction to the Life and Legacy of Réginald Garrigou-Lagrange, O.P.* (South Bend, Ind.: St Augustine's Press, 2005), 190–91. Garrigou-Lagrange would also become the director of Pope John Paul II's doctoral thesis on John of the Cross.

15. I am indebted here to the prescient comments of David Burrell, C.S.C., who suggested that the brighter Jesuits of the early twentieth century (including Rousselot, de la Taille, Maréchal, de Lubac, and Lonergan) could be understood as challenging the Suarezian curriculum in which they were trained. Suarez's work melded Scotus and Thomas, thus giving a skewed teaching of Thomas's thought.

16. Lebreton, "*In memoriam,*" 10.

ling the way it spoke meaningfully to the very real encounter of God's saving creation and redemption in the historical, liturgical, and spiritual life of human beings. Particularly, de la Taille took profound inspiration from Thomas's illuminating thought on the mysteries of the life of grace, of prayer, and of the sacraments as the creature's way to union with the Creator. It could be said that de la Taille, like his classmate Rousselot, was concerned to promote an "interiorized" scholasticism.

Furthermore, de la Taille's expertise—in the lecture hall and in journals—covered a broad spectrum of topics: e.g., grace, incarnation and the hypostatic union, the act of faith, contemplation, sacrifice, the sacraments, human and divine knowledge, and moral theology, specifically sin and the virtues.[17] A historian of the Gregorianum has observed that the "brilliant" French Jesuit was one of the last of the "old order" theologians at the University: the early 1920s witnessed the establishment of several specialized chairs in the faculty of religious sciences, an event that spurred the growth of distinct faculties in the last part of that decade. The era of great teachers whose erudition covered a wide range of topics was giving way to field specialists.[18] De la Taille's competency was immense indeed, and the varied subject matter and style of his writings reveals him to be a singular thinker—one difficult to classify neatly, much like the "liberal-conservative" Cardinal Newman a short generation before de la Taille.

In the first decade of the twentieth century, when Modernism and Combism were the chief theological crises facing the Jesuits in France and the Catholic Church at large, de la Taille's earliest publications in the Jesuit journal *Études* show a passionate intellectual engagement with

17. Cf. the bibliography for a list of de la Taille's published essays, which appeared predominantly, though not exclusively, in *Études* and *Récherches de science réligieuse*.

18. Philip Caraman, S.J., *University of the Nations: The History of the Gregorian University with Its Associated Institutes, the Biblical and Oriental* (New York: Paulist Press, 1981), cf. 122, 134–35. While Caraman praises de la Taille's *Mysterium Fidei* for its "width of vision," "erudition," "elegant Latin," and stimulus to "eucharistic piety," he goes on, in a way typical of most post-Vatican II assessments of de la Taille's work, to dismiss it: "Today it is thought to be based on a wrong interpretation of the Epistle to the Hebrews and finds few supporters" (135). Compare Henri de Lubac's more sympathetic—if uncommon and unverifiable—words: "The immense opposition he aroused [in *Mysterium Fidei*] is now only a memory, and the essence of what he taught is now commonly accepted"; de Lubac, *The Mystery of the Supernatural* (New York: Herder and Herder, 1967), 4).

these ecclesial concerns. In 1904 he wrote a piece on revelation and dogma directed obviously against Loisy and Tyrrell, though in the (sometimes annoying-to-us-later-readers) literary style of the day, no names are mentioned. In the following year he addressed the nature of religious belief in opposition to Ferdinand Brunetière and composed a "list of errors" that could be uncovered in Fogazzaro's *Il Santo*.[19] De la Taille's voice against Modernism was clear and trustworthy, so much so that he was asked by the Catholic Faculties of the West to give an opening-term address in support of the recently issued Encyclical *Pascendi gregis* (1907); the audience would have included bishops and dignitaries.[20] In a word, he joined many of his confrères in battling intellectual threats to the faith tradition, threats that seemed to crystallize in the first decade of the twentieth century.

With regard to the political situation facing the church in France, de la Taille vitally advocated the formation of a Catholic Party. His writings on the subject (1907–1908) must have been impressive, as they were later collected and printed under the title *En face du pouvoir* (1925).[21] Still, his biographer and friend Jules Lebreton insists that de la Taille was much more interested in theological study than in the controversies of the day. Given that he was able to research, write, and complete his massive and erudite study on the Eucharist by 1915, I suspect that Lebreton's judgment is accurate. The secondary status of de la Taille's interest in political Catholicism is also evident in the fact that he willingly retreated from his more impassioned position when Pius XI condemned the monarchist movement *Action Française* and its journal of the same name. This movement had a large base of intellectual and clerical sup-

19. De la Taille, "Quelque précisions sur la Révélation et le dogme dans leurs rélations avec le progress," *Études* 101 (1904): 507ff. Ferdinand Brunetière (1849–1906) was a member of the French Academy and a popular lecturer; he converted to Catholicism and, late in his life, attempted to reconcile the positivism of Auguste Comte to Catholicism. *Il Santo* was a novel published in 1905; its author, Fogazzaro, was sympathetic to positivist and evolutionary theories, and he urged the church to be open to these theories.

20. Leeming, "Master Theologian," 32–33. Unfortunately, I have not been able to find a copy of de la Taille's lecture.

21. Leeming, "Master Theologian," 32–33. It is also worth noting that de la Taille wrote a dense and lengthy article for the *Dictionnaire Apologétique de la Foi Catholique* on the topic "Insurrection" (Paris: Beauchesne, 1915), cc. 1056–66. This essay was later translated and reprinted as "Una opinión teológica," part of a book entitled *Catolicismo y república* (Madrid: Gráfica Universal, 1932), 140–60.

port, and the Pope's condemnation became a divisive one not only for the French Jesuits, but also for Catholic intellectuals across Europe. Cardinal Louis Billot, for whom de la Taille had great respect, voluntarily resigned from the Gregorianum over this issue.[22]

If the early writings of de la Taille reveal a robust and energetic thinker attentive to the theological and political defense of Catholicism, the postwar publication of *Mysterium Fidei* and essays on contemplation and grace give us a fuller, more serene picture of his intellectual and spiritual character. We turn our focus now to the theological method and the reception of de la Taille's *Mysterium Fidei,* for the two topics are related and help us to see what was new and striking about his major work. I shall argue that both the positive and negative reactions to his book are as much a consequence of his method as they are of the specific theses he proposes.

John Milbank has written that de Lubac and the *ressourcement* movement aimed at a new speculative theology that would be carried out "with a closeness to the exegetical, mystical and liturgical reading of the revealed signs."[23] De la Taille's *Mysterium Fidei* unquestionably stands as an early prototype of this "new" methodology. More accurately, perhaps, we can say that de la Taille is implementing the pedagogical and scholarly style promoted by his teacher Léonce Grandmaison. Grandmaison urged that lectures and written studies be grounded in a presentation of the historical sources: scripture, the Fathers, conciliar teaching. This, he argued, was the more helpful methodology for assessing truth in teaching—more helpful than a nakedly scholastic or speculative approach.[24] *Mysterium Fidei* exemplifies such pedagogy and method, embracing in fact a more extensive list of the sources of tradition. Beyond scripture and patristic authors, de la Taille consults and

22. Cf. Fergus Kerr, *Twentieth-Century Catholic Theologians* (Oxford: Blackwell, 2007), 10, 34–35; and Caraman, *University of the Nations*, 135.

23. John Milbank, *The Suspended Middle: Henri de Lubac and the Debate Concerning the Supernatural* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2005), 2.

24. Cf. Henri Rondet, *The Grace of Christ: A Brief History of the Theology of Grace,* trans. Tad Guzie, S.J. (Westminster: Newman Press, 1967); preface, v; originally published as *Gratia Christi* (1948). Rondet, roughly a contemporary of Maurice de la Taille, writes that Léonce Grandmaison, in urging such a method, was hoping both to "reconcile" positive and scholastic theology, and to give an adequate context to the "importune speculations" of theologians.

collects for his readers the testimony of the church's liturgies; the witness of Thomas and his (often conflicting) commentators; the writings of both medieval and contemporary theologians and spiritual writers; and both ancient and contemporary preaching. Indeed, he casts of the net of tradition *in altum*. De la Taille possessed a generosity of ear, a charity for listening deeply to and perceiving the conceptual vision of a particular text, allowing its illuminating voice to enrich the truth of a doctrine. Perhaps one of the highest compliments paid to his methodology comes from Karl Rahner, who appreciated de la Taille's keen sensibility and integrity in approaching the texts of the tradition:

> What is it that makes the properly historical in studies like those of de Lubac or de la Taille so stimulating and to the point? Surely it is the art of reading texts in such a way that they become not just votes cast in favour of or against our current positions (positions taken up long ago), but say something to us which we in our time have not considered at all or not closely enough, about reality itself.[25]

Indeed, it is this "art" of reading historical texts that engages and wins the trust of de la Taille's readers. *Mysterium Fidei* reveals, in a classic way, the virtue of retrieval.

De la Taille's sensitivity to the liturgies of the church as a source for doing theology caught the attention and fervent adulation of Dom Lambert Beauduin, the Belgian Benedictine considered by many to be the father of the liturgical movement in Europe. Beauduin hails *Mysterium Fidei* as a "new point of departure" for the explication of doctrine, noting that the title alone announces a new spirit and "program" for theology. In particular, Beauduin praises de la Taille for recognizing that the liturgy "*constitue un lieu théologie de grande valeur.*"[26] Yet beyond this approbation of the method de la Taille employs, Beauduin

25. Karl Rahner, "The Prospects for Dogmatic Theology," in *Theological Investigations* (Baltimore: Helicon Press, 1965), 1:9–10; cf. another significant compliment paid by Rahner to de la Taille's *Mysterium Fidei*: "If I were asked which theological work written in Latin within the past generation ought to have been read by every theologian in the field of the new and actively researching theology, then I know of only one really indisputable example, viz. *Mysterium fidei* by M. de la Taille"; Rahner, "Latin as a Church Language," *Theological Investigations* 5:397.

26. Lambert Beauduin, O.S.B. "Le Saint Sacrifice de la Messe: A propos d'un livre recent," *Les questions liturgiques et paroissiales* 6 (1921): 197–98. I think it worth noting that, like Beauduin, de la Taille shows no interest in *reforming* the liturgy, but rather only a deep interest in *renewing* the liturgy. Beauduin's approach, to restore Christian spirituality through the restoration of the high Mass on Sunday—with full participation—likely would have been de la Taille's as

also acknowledges that this study of eucharistic sacrifice marks a major turning point in theology. He claims that *Mysterium Fidei* is a "release (*soulagement*)" and "deliverance (*déliverance*)"[27] from the web of immolationist theories propounded since the Council of Trent, theories that located the "true and proper" sacrificial aspect of the Eucharist in the destruction of the victim.

Beauduin's review of *Mysterium Fidei* is a springboard for assessing de la Taille's significance in the liturgical movement, a significance inexplicably overlooked by historians of the movement and by contemporary eucharistic theologians. *Mysterium Fidei* witnesses to—indeed, advocates for—several concerns linked with the early project of liturgical renewal: e.g., an attentiveness to liturgical prayer texts; the renewal of a biblical fluency along with the retrieval of patristic sources; the desire for fuller lay participation in the offering of the sacrifice *and* in the reception of communion; and the deepening of liturgical prayer and spiritual practices *tout court*. Given de la Taille's rich argument for the frequent sacramental reception of communion (cf. chapter 9), the dedication of his tome to Pope Pius X is hardly surprising. Julio Jimenez, S.J., in his lengthy article celebrating the fiftieth anniversary of the publication of *Mysterium Fidei,* suggests that de la Taille's great work was seen by some as a "guide or teacher," by others as a kind of "catalyst" of the liturgical movement, and by almost all as a "determining" factor in the blossoming of liturgical studies.[28]

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well. Neither theologian openly advocated changing the received liturgical tradition. See Sonya Quitslund, *Beauduin: A Prophet Vindicated* (New York: Newman Press, 1973).

27. Beauduin, "Le Saint Sacrifice," 202.

28. Julio Jimenez Berguecio, S.J., "En el cincuentenario del *Mysterium Fidei* de Maurice de la Taille (1921–1971)," *Anales de la Facultad de Teologica* 22 (1971): 143–309, esp. 168n27. Jimenez also suggests that de la Taille was "ahead of his time" in his reflections on ecclesiology and the sacrament of penance (154–57, 158). The only recent study of de la Taille is a German dissertation by Maria Magdalena Elbl, *Eucharistie als Opfer der Kirche bei Maurice de la Taille* (Regensburg: Pustet, 2003), which focuses on de la Taille's ecclesiology, specifically, on the question of "the offering Church." Elbl's work is valuable for situating, historically and dogmatically, de la Taille's contribution on this topic. Elbl questions whether de la Taille's theology of sacrifice adequately illuminates the connection between the action of Christ and the action of the church in the Eucharist. Her retrieval, generally speaking, is a positive one, yet she ultimately critiques de la Taille's construal of Christ's heavenly action in the Eucharist, i.e., his argument that in the Eucharist the power is all Christ's, while the new action belongs to the church—*virtus tota ex parte Christi—novitas tota ex parte Ecclesiae;* see Elbl, *Eucharistie,* 233.

Apart from investing the budding liturgical movement with momentum, de la Taille participated in another distinctive feature of *ressourcement:* his retrieval of the Fathers, patristic and medieval, was significantly inclusive of the Eastern tradition. Here again, we could say that de la Taille was ahead of his time. It is quite likely that his embrace of Greek and Syriac authors was spurred by his reading of, and admiration for, the work of Matthias Joseph Scheeben, the German scholar of the nineteenth century who pioneered a retrieval of Eastern theologians.[29] Apart from a shared interest in Eastern theologians, de la Taille seems also to have been attracted to Scheeben's sense of theology as an organic knowledge directed to the spiritual life of humans and to Scheeben's focus on uncreated grace and God's indwelling—a topic to which we shall return in our later discussion of grace. I suspect that de la Taille deeply sympathized with the mystical temperament of this great German theologian.

At the turn of the century, it was still a *novum* to be using the Eastern tradition with the depth and confidence that de la Taille exhibits in *Mysterium Fidei*. That he is aware of doing something bold surfaces at several points—when, for instance, he expresses "surprise" at discovering harmony between certain Eastern and Western church fathers on a particular teaching, or when he defends his use of Cabasilas, whose *Commentary on the Divine Liturgy* de la Taille finds most appealing.[30] Further, beyond his methodological retrieval of Eastern theologians, de la Taille took a direct interest in the ecumenical movement, as would many who were later associated with *nouvelle théologie*.[31] In 1926 the

29. De la Taille references Matthias Scheeben's seven-volume *Handbuch der katholischen Dogmatik* (Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 1873–1903) with obvious appreciation in *Mysterium Fidei* (*MF,* 156, 179, 265). See Edgar Hocedez's treatment of Scheeben in *Histoire de la théologie aux XIXe siècle* (Paris: Desclée de Brouwer, 1947), 3:377–84.

30. Cf. *MF,* 602. De la Taille does not suggest that Nicholas Cabasalis and the other medieval Eastern fathers he cites are without the "taint" of upholding schism. However, he argues that these figures have witnessed accurately to the theology handed on to them by earlier thinkers. In regard to Cabasilas, he laments that he did not devote the same "care and skill" in dealing with church unity as he did with the "sacraments of the faith." De la Taille goes further in his advocacy of Cabasilas, exonerating theologians of earlier centuries who praised what they found in his writings: "they are to be commended, according to the phrase of Moses: *O that the people might prophesy,* provided, as St. Paul says, *Christ is announced*" (*MF* 1:viii).

31. This term does not seem to have been "in place" at the time of de la Taille's death. It was likely first introduced in public writing by Henri de Lubac, in his 1946 *Surnaturel: Études*

Pontifical Institute for Eastern Studies published an essay de la Taille wrote on the fruits of the eucharistic sacrifice for the separated Eastern churches.[32] In a footnote at the beginning of that text, de la Taille expresses gratitude for the warm reception of his "fraternal and sincere" essay by the Russian Orthodox, who heard him deliver it at The Week for the Union of Churches in Brussels (1925).

This ecclesial and intellectual generosity extended to developments in the field of the history of religions. In the explication of his theory of sacrifice, de la Taille shows his familiarity with the relatively new tide of anthropological and historical studies on the phenomenon of sacrifice in diverse human communities and cultures. He does not hesitate, especially in book 1 of his work, to cite such history-of-religion scholars as E.B. Taylor, J. Wellhausen, Robertson Smith, the Dominican M. J. Lagrange, and Hubert and Mauss. Likewise, in discussing (and dismissing) the "mythic" origins of the Last Supper in book 2, de la Taille exhibits a wise familiarity with the cultic theories of religious studies, including a reference to the Third International Congress for the History of Religions in 1908.[33] Clearly, de la Taille (like Rousselot and Grandmaison) attended to the findings of secular studies without a sense of fear or threat. But such openness is balanced by a firm *hierarchy* of knowledge in de la Taille's thought, a hierarchy for theology in general and for his theory of eucharistic sacrifice.[34] In the highest place is revelation, found in scripture and explicated in the sacred writings of the tradition: this dictates his method, which can best be described as "positive" theology, though undertaken by a thinker with both a keen sense for speculative argument and a mystical sensitivity. Also noteworthy, despite this receptivity to the broader intellectual discussions of his day, de la Taille's

historiques (Paris: Aubier), and then picked up and employed pejoratively by Garrigou-Lagrange in 1946; see Aidan Nichols, O.P., "Thomism and the Nouvelle Théologie," *The Thomist* 64 (2000): 7–11. Nichols speculates that the phrase "the new theology" was likely "fed" to Pope Pius XII by Garrigou-Lagrange. In any case, Garrigou-Lagrange's *Angelicum* article, "La nouvelle théologie, où va-t-elle?" (1946: 126–45), determined its negative associations, at least until the far side of Vatican II.

32. De la Taille, *L'oecumenicité du fruit de la messe: Intercession eucharistique et dissidence,* Orientalia Christiana Analecta 8, no. 30 (Roma: Pont. Institutum Orientalium Studiorum, 1926). This piece draws heavily upon his research presented in book 2 of *Mysterium Fidei.*

33. *MF* 2:14.

34. *MF* 1:7n9.

written work manifests a remarkable consistency of thought. We do not find him altering his positions in later work; rather, what appears is a more finely tuned and penetrating articulation of his fundamental insights.[35]

Finally, before we return to the topic of sacrifice, I want to grant to de la Taille the final word on his theological method, purpose, and sources. Theology, he rather pointedly describes in the Preface to *Mysterium Fidei,* is "for believers," and thus has "no place for anything which does not foster piety." He thereby envisions his own work as directed to the augmenting of "the knowledge of faith" so that believers are better able "to appreciate the full benefit of the gift of God."[36] It is partly to this end that he defends his choice of sources and his "prolix" quotations from both scripture and tradition. A theologian's task is not to promote his own "special findings," but rather that which has been gathered from tradition: "His purpose is to record them [the fathers and the doctors] honestly, co-ordinate and refine them, and, where necessary, set them down in detail."[37] With these words de la Taille aptly depicts the experience and pleasure of reading *Mysterium Fidei:* arguably, it is the most valuable encyclopedic collection of writings on sacrifice from scripture and tradition that has been produced.

More distinctively, de la Taille also reveals a sharp distaste for "systems of theology." He proposes instead that theology is an organic science, "resting on its own principles," with all its parts "connected and coherent among themselves." No single part of theology can be explored fully without reference to "its corresponding part and corresponding member (*sua comparte ac commembro*)."[38] I emphasize this point for two reasons. First, de la Taille's work is a marvelously complex body of integrated "Elucidations," and he himself cautions the reader about the organic articulation of his theology: "in my opinion, no part of the book could be completely understood (*plene perspectam*) by one

35. That said, I am yet curious to pursue a cryptic remark by Bernard Leeming, who acknowledges de la Taille's independent thinking and yet makes it a point to record that he "owned to having changed his opinion on reading an article by P. Guy de Broglie." Leeming, "A Master Theologian," 39.

36. *MF* 1:viii.

37. *MF* 1:viii.

38. *MF,* viii; *MF* 1:ix.

who had not read the whole."[39] If, as I am suggesting, much of the consternation pursuant to the publication of *Mysterium Fidei* indicates a resistance to his method of "doing theology" and reading Thomas (which pushed beyond—or rather behind—a narrowly defined scholastic system),[40] also evident is a failure to see how the work hangs together organically as a complex treatise on the Eucharist, inclusive of a number of interconnected topics: incarnation, sacrifice and gift theory, sin and redemption, grace and the virtues, mass stipends and Mariology, prayer and the ascetic life.

Second, I wonder if de la Taille's dismissal in later twentieth-century theology stems precisely from a curtailed reading of the whole.[41] In particular, this study proposes that de la Taille's thought on eucharistic sacrifice has been misrepresented because it is read and rehearsed *in isolation from* his teaching on grace and the life of prayer, most of which appears in the yet untranslated book 3. To fully appreciate his understanding of the church's ritual sacrifice, this plainly announced cumulative and interconnected method must be taken with due seriousness.[42] I shall proceed to show forth the synthetic exigency of his thought, even though his fundamental intuition linking sacrifice to grace and prayer is often more mystically suggested than lucidly spelled out in *Mysterium Fidei*. Drawing upon the full scope of his writings, our task will be to bring into

39. *MF* 1:ix–x; *MF,* ix.

40. In particular, two Dominicans (Vincent McNabb and Alfred Swaby) voice "shock" at de la Taille's "New Theory" of eucharistic sacrifice and at his interpretation of traditional sources (Thomas, in particular, but also the Council of Trent and some early fathers); see McNabb, "A New Theory of the Sacrifice of the Mass," *Irish Ecclesiastical Review* 23 (1924): 561–73; and Swaby, "A New Theory of the Eucharistic Sacrifice," *American Ecclesiastical Review* 69 (1923): 460–73.

41. Cf. Francis J. Wengier's *Eucharist-Sacrifice* (Milwaukee: Bruce, 1955) for a sampling of mid-twentieth-century manuals that badly misconstrue de la Taille's theory of sacrifice. Also, the following post-Vatican II eucharistic histories indicate the scant and incomplete depiction of de la Taille's work: Cesare Giraudo, S.J., *Eucaristia per la chiesa: Prospettive teologiche sull'eucaristia a partire dalla "lex orandi"* (Morcelliana: Gregorian University Press, 1989); Raymond Moloney, S.J., *The Eucharist* (Collegeville, Minn.: The Liturgical Press, 1995); Aidan Nichols, O.P., *The Holy Eucharist: From the New Testament to Pope John Paul II* (Dublin: Veritas, 1991). It is telling that in one of the most impressive end-of-the-century studies of the Eucharist, Edward Kilmartin's *The Eucharist in the West: History and Theology* (Collegeville, Minn.: The Liturgical Press, 1998), Maurice de la Taille's work is ignored altogether.

42. De la Taille refers to his method of gathering numerous testimonies from tradition as an example of "cumulative probability," a phrase used by Newman to identify a knowing that transcends opinion and is capable of begetting certainty; see *MF* 1:58.

sharp focus the connections de la Taille envisions between ecclesial oblation, grace, and prayer.

I have portrayed de la Taille as a theological figure who loosely fits into a number of twentieth-century characterizations: a defender of the faith against Modernism and a political activist against secular repression in France; an early *ressourcement* figure who gave full ear to the Eastern tradition; a scholar who provided a methodological and spiritual spark to the liturgical movement; a thinker who lent his support to ecumenical issues and was attentive to the findings of history-of-religions; a philosophical Thomist with a distaste for the systems of earlier neo-Scholasticism;[43] and, finally, an intellectual with a wide expertise and an attraction to mystical theology and contemplation. What does a theologian of this stature and temperament have to offer to a contemporary Christian doctrine of sacrifice?

Sacrifice: *Status Questionis* and de la Taille's Definition

As a signpost of the current theological writing on the subject of sacrifice,[44] we can attend to the recent work by Kevin Seasoltz, O.S.B., entitled *God's Gift Giving* (New York: Continuum, 2007). Favorably rehearsing the positions of major post-Vatican II thinkers on eucharistic sacrifice—Robert Daly, S.J., Edward Kilmartin, S.J., David Power, O.M.I., and Louis-Marie Chauvet—Seasoltz clarifies the issues and crystallizes the case against sacrifice—i.e., sacrifice understood in any way *except* as a metaphor of a relational self-gift or self-limitation, and

43. De Lubac reads *Mysterium Fidei* as a "liquidation of the over-complicated systems worked out" since Trent in regard to the sacrifice of the Mass; de Lubac, *The Mystery of the Supernatural* (New York: Herder and Herder, 1967), 4. The same may be said of de la Taille's position on God's knowledge and the freedom of the will. In his essay "Sur diverses classifications de la science divine," *Recherches de science réligieuse* 13 (1922): 7–23, de la Taille prescinds from the Molinist theory of "middle knowledge" and proposes a learned sort of agnosticism on the question; see Henri Rondet, *Essais sur la théologie de la grâce* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1964), 220–21n51.

44. A recent exception ought to be noted. Matthew Levering's book *Sacrifice and Community: Jewish Offering and Christian Eucharist* (Oxford: Blackwell, 2005) studies eucharistic sacrifice in the light of Hebrew sacrifice, suggesting that the sacrifice of the Mass achieves the end desired by the sacrifices of Israel, namely, perfect union with God. Levering's book, which relies upon Thomas's theology of the Eucharist, marks a step toward the regeneration of the notion of sacrifice in eucharistic theology.

this both in terms of divine and human "sacrifice."[45] Such a theological position on sacrifice seems problematic on at least two accounts: first, in that its "spiritualization" of sacrifice too frequently (and occasionally unapologetically) manifests an *anti-sacrifice* polemic—bracketing or rejecting any cultic sense of the word; and second, in its portrayal of sacrifice as *originating* in the Godhead, a position dubious on theological and soteriological grounds. Before I address these concerns at some length, the views of key theologians like Robert Daly and Louis-Marie Chauvet need fuller explication. Arguably, these two theologians set the context for theological discussion of eucharistic sacrifice today.

The writings of eucharistic theologian Robert Daly, himself influenced by the work of Edward Kilmartin and Réne Girard, have defined the contours of Catholic thought on sacrifice in the decades following the Second Vatican Council.[46] In his *Origins of the Christian Doctrine of Sacrifice* (1978), Daly develops an intricate argument from New Testament texts, from the self-understanding of Qumran community-as-temple, and from a close reading of early Greek and Latin fathers that, in the first centuries of Christianity, language and understanding of sacrifice was essentially *ethical,* not ritual:

> [Christian sacrifice] was centered not in a formal act of cultic or external ceremonial worship but rather in the everyday practical life of Christian virtue, in the apostolic and charitable work of being a good Christian, of being "for others" as Christ was "for us."[47]

45. R. Kevin Seasoltz, *God's Gift-Giving: In Christ and Through the Spirit* (New York: Continuum, 2007), 48ff. For the sake of clarity and distinction, I will be using the word *sacrifice* (without scare quotes) when I intend the word to be taken in a manner inclusive of its wide-ranging denotative, connotative, and metaphorical meanings. The reader will see "*sacrifice*" when the word is being employed in a manner that aims to curtail or jettison some of the more uncongenial associations of the word, e.g., temple ritual, immolation, violence, blood-letting, victimization.

46. Cf. Robert J. Daly, S.J., *The Origins of the Christian Doctrine of Sacrifice* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1978); Daly, *Christian Sacrifice: The Judeo-Christian Background before Origen* (Washington, D.C.: The Catholic University of America Press, 1978); Daly, "Robert Bellarmine and Post-Tridentine Eucharistic Theology," *Theological Studies* 61 (2000): 239–60; Daly, "Sacrifice Unveiled or Sacrifice Revisited: Trinitarian and Liturgical Perspectives," *Theological Studies* 64 (2003): 24–42. Daly gathers his research and arguments in *Sacrifice Unveiled: The True Meaning of Christian Sacrifice* (London: Continuum and T. and T. Clark, 2009).

47. Daly, *The Origins of Christian Doctrine of Sacrifice,* 140. Note that Daly does not deny that the Last Supper is interpreted as having a *sacrificial* meaning and context, whether that be located in the Passover context, in the language of "the new covenant," or of "the blood poured

Daly underscores that this "spiritualization" process reached a summit "incarnational" and practical phase. At this point, a focus on internal dispositions was replaced by "down-to-earth, practical" activities that reflected the self-giving ethic of Christianity.[48]

Daly's more recent writing directly reveals Girard's influence and offers a more trenchant critique of any "history-of-religion" remnants in regard to Christian eucharistic sacrifice. In blunt language, he argues that the Christ-event "did away with sacrifice in the history-of-religions sense."[49] Put differently, it is a "methodological mistake" to theologize about Jesus's death on the cross and about the eucharistic liturgy through the lens of Hebrew sacrifice or ancient ritual practices of sacrifice. Instead, Daly promotes a concept of sacrifice *as self-offering or self-gift*—an event not God-directed, but rather originating with the initiative of the Father in the gift of his Son, "whose 'response' is also a self-offering."[50] Consequently, it is not that a gift is being given to God in the eucharistic sacrifice, but rather that "persons, in full freedom, are giving/communicating themselves to one another." *Authentic* Christian sacrifice is defined as "a self-offering response."[51] Moreover, Daly identifies this vision of eucharistic sacrifice as the "consensus position" of contemporary liturgical theology and sharply regrets the persistent and "alarming divide" between this view and the current line of magisterial

out for many [you]" for the forgiveness of sins. He contends, however, that the primary interpretative key for the synoptic accounts and for 1 Cor. 11 is not the atoning sacrifice of Hebrew cultic system, but rather the thematic of the suffering servant of God, from the servant songs of Isaiah (especially the fourth). The early Christians were using "Servant Christology" to interpret Christ's death and the Eucharist (57–58). Daly likewise judges that the "slain Lamb" in Revelation (5:6, 9, 12; 13:8) is best interpreted in terms of this Servant Christology, as opposed to a sin-offering sacrificial context (80–81).

48. Daly, *The Origins of Christian Doctrine of Sacrifice,* 138.

49. Daly, "Sacrifice Unveiled or Sacrifice Revisited," 25–26. Daly roughly defines this "history-of-religions sense" in the following way: "Sacrifice is a gift presented to God in a ceremony in which the gift is destroyed or consumed. It symbolizes the internal offering of commitment and surrender to God. The purpose is primarily for the offerers to acknowledge the dominion of God, but also to bring about the reconciliation of themselves (and possibly others) with God, to render thanks for blessings received, and to petition for further blessings for oneself and others." To apply such a definition to the Eucharist, Daly argues, is "disastrously inadequate" (25). De la Taille, on the other hand, will nuance and expand this definition, finding sacrifice the central category for understanding the Eucharist and our ongoing baptismal transformation.

50. Daly, "Sacrifice Unveiled or Sacrifice Revisited," 28

51. Daly, "Sacrifice Unveiled or Sacrifice Revisited," 31.

teaching.[52] In sum, Daly's insistence, first, on the spiritualization of sacrifice as ethical activity, and second, on the re-scoping of "sacrifice" as a Trinitarian-based dynamic of self-offering, effectively dismisses the ritual-sacrificial context of the Eucharist.

Louis-Marie Chauvet's *Symbol and Sacrament,* in some ways more boldly anti-sacrifice and ethically driven than Daly's work, has further transformed contemporary thought on the Eucharist, shifting theological language away from "sacrifice" to "gift." In fact, in Seasoltz's new book, Chauvet stands as the principal theologian of the Eucharist *as gift*. Chauvet, who like Daly endorses the work of Girard, poses a complete "tear" between the ritual sacrifices of the Hebrew people and the Christian eucharistic rite. The death and resurrection of Jesus definitively breaks with sacrifice and priestly cultic worship.[53] Briefly, Chauvet argues for an understanding of the Eucharist based upon an anthropological notion of gift exchange. The Christian *receives* the gift of God in the Eucharist and *offers* a "return-gift" in his or her concrete ethical action in the world, which Chauvet also and intriguingly calls giving Christ a body in the world.[54]

Without a doubt, the work of Daly and Chauvet animates the late-twentieth-century shift in theology away from eucharistic sacrifice understood in any history-of-religions sense, to a recasting or replacing of sacrifice with *gift*—often parsed as self-offering, or self-limitation. Most theologians who follow this lead claim to want to retain "sacrifice" in some metaphorical sense, but I submit that such a domesticated or sanitized concept of sacrifice is questionable, and certainly not

52. Cf. n. 2 in this chapter.

53. Louis-Marie Chauvet, *Symbol and Sacrament (*Collegeville, Minn.: The Liturgical Press, 1995), cf. especially, 260; also 240–44, 248–49, 256–60, 298–99, 310–11 *et passim.* We should acknowledge here the work of a contemporary of Chauvet, Ghislain Lafont, whose work on the Eucharist also employs the anthropological category of gift exchange. Lafont, however, is refreshingly not anti-sacrifice (nor is he keen to repeat Girard or the postmodern anxieties about "onto-theology"). His poetic meditations on the concepts of gift, sacrifice, meal, storytelling, and death are a healthy complement to Chauvet's work. See Lafont, *Eucharist: The Meal and the Word,* trans. Jeremy Driscoll, O.S.B. (New York: Paulist Press, 2008), esp., 33–37, 96–107. For an in-depth comparison of the theological and philosophical approaches of Chauvet and Lafont, see Joy Harrell Blaylock, "Ghislain LaFont and Contemporary Sacramental Theology," *Theological Studies* 66 (2005): 841–61.

54. Chauvet, *Symbol and Sacrament,* 509.

fully inclusive of the Catholic tradition. For it seems clear that with thinkers like Daly, Chauvet, and now Seasoltz, a metaphorical or spiritualized understanding of sacrifice is inherently anti-sacrifice.

Jonathan Klawans, scripture scholar and Jewish historian, provides an additional angle on this anti-sacrifice question. He offers an illuminating critique of the recent tendency among some biblical and liturgical historians to cast the Last Supper (as well as Jesus's overturning of the temple tables) as a rejection of the temple cult, or as anti-sacrifice.[55] Klawans challenges the view that casts the early Eucharist as a dismissal of cult. His challenge focuses both on the comportment of Jesus's early disciples toward the temple cult and sacrificial worship and on the problematic way that New Testament sacrificial metaphors have been interpreted as a *negative* assessment of ritual sacrifice, negative even to the point of supersessionism. Klawans's argument warrants attention, for it reminds us that the "spiritualization" of sacrifice in Paul and the early fathers could be seen more fruitfully in another light. Indeed, he argues that sacrificial language in early Christianity is best understood in terms of metaphor: these *metaphors of sacrifice* attend to the context of temple sacrifice in a "positive and constructive" way, operating "on the assumption of the *efficacy* and *meaning* of sacrificial rituals."[56] In other words, the early Christians desired to "draw on" and "channel" the temple's sanctity and efficacy into their everyday practices. It is a "flawed exercise," writes Klawans, to align sacrificial metaphors "with cultic critiques, leaving temple ritual alone as the only thing that is *not* a 'spiritual' sacrifice."[57]

55. Jonathan Klawans, *Purity, Sacrifice, and the Temple* (Oxford University Press, 2006), 7–8, 213–20. Klawans notes that there are some scholars of the Last Supper who are clearly more sympathetic to the ancient Jewish sacrificial context; e.g., Bruce Chilton, *The Temple of Jesus: His Sacrificial Program within a Cultural History of Sacrifice* (University Park: Pennsylvania State University Press, 1992), and N.T. Wright, *Jesus and the Victory of God,* vol. 2. (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1996). According to Klawans, the most egregiously anti-temple interpretations belong to the Girardian-influenced Robert Hammerton-Kelly, *Gospel and the Sacred* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1994) and Gillian Feeley-Harnack's *The Lord's Table* (Washington, D.C.: Smithsonian Institution Press, 1994).

56. Klawans, *Purity,* 220–21 (emphasis mine).

57. Klawans, *Purity,* 220–21. Klawans does address the Epistle to the Hebrews as revealing a distinctly anti-temple polemic, showing the temple to be "inherently inferior" to the true sanctuary and high priest, Jesus. Interestingly enough, it is this same New Testament text that inspired de la Taille's theory of eucharistic sacrifice, which is not at all dismissive of cultic sac-

Klawans's stimulating critique helps to alert us to the problematic ubiquity in contemporary eucharistic theology of gift over sacrifice (again, understood in the cultic-ritual sense). Granted, it may or may not be the *specific aim* of much post-Vatican II eucharistic theology to dismiss entirely the cultic and sacrificial context of the Mass—though the more Girardian, the more this is true; but, in fact, this largely has been accomplished, and so much so that the polarization of sacrifice and gift, rooted in Luther's diatribe against the Mass as sacrifice, seems to be standard. Klawans's scholarship challenges this at its foundation in biblical sources. More to the point, Klawans's critique clears the way to retrieving a theory such as de la Taille's, which, I shall argue, distinctly "spiritualizes" (if you will) sacrifice without casting a negative interpretation on sacrificial ritual, without, that is, "cutting off" the history-of-religions approach to sacrifice as somehow inimical to Jesus's actions at the Last Supper *and* to the ecclesial participation in that sacrifice. As we shall see, de la Taille interprets the New Testament (and much patristic) employment of sacrifice metaphors as directly referring to the temple ritual context—and in a theologically positive and heuristic manner.

There is a second theological problematic posed by a "spiritualization" of sacrifice, related to the attempt to make sacrifice synonymous with gift. When theologians begin to speak of sacrifice as a "universal law," found even at the heart of the Trinity, it seems that (1) we have lost sight of a basic linguistic principle that some language is inappropriately used of the divine, and (2) that we are "fixing" upon a particular soteriology, namely, exemplarist. To say that sacrifice originates in God is not at all identical to proclaiming that God is the original Gift-Giver: Gift originates in the triune God; sacrifice is a response to, or a consequence of, the refusal of the presence and *caritas* of God.

Ian Bradley's poetically seductive book *The Power of Sacrifice* (1995) is perhaps the most complete expression of a theological endeavor to speak of sacrifice as divinely ordained. Indeed, Bradley stridently de-

rifice and its history. Perhaps de la Taille has something to teach biblical scholarship on the reading of Hebrews in light of Jesus's sacrifice and the ecclesial sacrifice. (In a conversation with Klawans, he admitted that he had not been as precise as he could have been in his assessment of Hebrews.)

picts sacrifice as a "cosmic law issuing from God," and even more, as an integral part of the Godhead. In a way that recalls the thought of Daly, Bradley contends that we misunderstand sacrifice when we look at it anthropocentrically, rather than seeing it as "at the heart and center of the life of the Holy Trinity."[58] What does Bradley intend by such "sacrifice" in the Godhead? How is the language being used? Sacrifice in God means that the very being of God is patterned upon "costly self-giving and the bringing about of life *through the agency of death*": "sacrifice" is the "supreme *opus Dei,*" Bradley asserts, "a universal principle of self-limitation and self-surrender that emanates from the very being of God."[59] Notice what obtains when sacrifice is seen as a "distinct characteristic" of God and as a pattern of surrender and self-limitation at the foundation of created life: sacrifice then becomes "life-affirming" and "life-enhancing." To be sure, such a position has its pastoral attraction. The suffering of creation and the pattern of self-surrender now become a reflection of the Godhead and part of a universal law in which death is the agency of life. Seasoltz finds Bradley's vision of "sacrifice" highly persuasive—and in tune with modern science in physics and biology.[60]

But is there not something very confused and ultimately *anthropocentric* about Bradley's thesis? His reasoning seems to evolve this way: because there is a death-into-life dynamic all about us in the created world, because self-limitation (always?) results in an enhancement of life, and because Jesus of Nazareth was put to death so that all might live, "sacrifice" thereby must be at the very heart and center of God. On the contrary, is it not rather the case that God (*in se*) is Gift, and *ex se* also only Gift—abundant and ecstatic? Is it not the case, in fact, that sacrifice originates in the human context of sin, of misdirected desire, of a failure in love? Perhaps no one has put this with greater insight and precision than Sarah Coakley, who articulates that it is only when the Gift of God "hits the time-line of sin" that we can speak of the origin of sacrifice. Coakley writes that "the demanding effects of the reception of divine, Trinitarian Gift, *while sin still reigns in the order*

58. Ian Bradley, *The Power of Sacrifice* (London: Darton, Longman, and Todd, 1995), 6, emphasis mine.

59. Bradley, *The Power of Sacrifice*, 10–11.

60. Seasoltz, *God's Gift-Giving,* 50–51.

of the world, are inevitably 'sacrificial,' morally and spiritually"—and I would want to add, "ritually."[61] Sacrifice, then, does not belong properly to the divine realm, to the inner Trinitarian life. There, all is Gift.[62] There, desire is pure. There, Gift exchange is spirit and truth. This is the Gift reality that John of the Cross so marvelously describes in *The Living Flame of Love* (3:78–79), a passage to which we shall return later: only the perfectly purified soul, in and through the Spirit, receives the divine Gift and offers the Gift *without sacrifice*.

Not surprisingly, the view of sacrifice as a principle of self-limitation in God and in creation correlates with a soteriology that links Jesus's sacrificial death not with propitiation or expiation, but with a kind of exemplarism. Bradley, for instance, deemphasizes the voluntary and willing character of Jesus's death in order to underscore Jesus's *passivity*—as opposed to a willing, priestly "self-immolation." Jesus obediently bears his death as "a submission to the dark and mysterious power of sacrifice … which the Son of God is destined to reveal and release."[63] A certain inevitability marks the passion and death of Jesus; Jesus dies to reveal that the way to the Father is through a surrender to the law of sacrifice.

Those influenced by Girard also tend to view the sacrifice of Jesus as essentially revelatory: the cross and resurrection reveal a God who "works by way of example, not substitution."[64] According to Seasoltz, the Girardian-understood exemplum in the victimal death of Jesus empowers and inspires the believer "to overcome both violence and victimization." In the gift of the Eucharist, the Christian becomes like God inasmuch as he or she "implements" the gift that Jesus came to

61. Sarah Coakley, Lecture 3, "Gift Retold: Spirals of Grace," and "Conclusion," *Flesh and Blood: The Eucharist, Desire and Fragmentation,* the Hensley Henson Lecture Series (Oxford: Oxford University, 2004–5).

62. Catherine Pickstock strikingly describes the self-giving flow between the persons of the Trinity: "As the Father gives Himself and glorifies the Son, and the Son glorifies and gives Himself to the Father, all by the Spirit, without lack, the Father 'gains' something from the Son and the Son 'gains' something from the Father, but the 'gain' in the donee does not correspond to any diminution or loss in the donor"; Pickstock, *After Writing: The Liturgical Consummation of Philosophy* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1998), 243. In other words, in the Trinitarian exchange, there is no "sacrifice" in terms of self-limitation and lack, but only the excess of Gift.

63. Bradley, *The Power of Sacrifice,* 112–13.

64. Seasoltz, *God's Gift-Giving,* 108.

reveal: the saving Love of God.[65] Seasoltz also praises the sharp critique of atonement theory given by Stephen Finlan in his recent *Problems with Atonement* (2005). Finlan's study is radically and unapologetically anti-sacrifice and anti-temple. Jesus, he writes, "rejected the whole mythology of sacrifice."[66] Atonement is not an "essential doctrine" of the Christian faith; rather, what is revelatory about God and God's generosity, what is significant for redemption, is found at the heart of doctrine of the incarnation. Redemption is fundamentally about *theôsis*, Finlan argues, about "*restoration and re-enabled participation in divinity,*" and such redivinization is precisely the goal of the incarnation.[67] While Finlan's retrieval of *theôsis* is attractive (and patristically rooted), he speaks as if such "spiritual maturation" is simply a gift to be received, as if such reception is viable without undergoing a *passio,* as if sinful human desire could be corrected by a moral lesson that remains outside the gates of the Garden of Gethsemane and the *via crucis*.

My intention here has been to outline the soteriological correlatives of recent efforts to either "translate" sacrifice into the Godhead or, on the contrary, to reject sacrifice altogether and to speak only of the cross and Eucharist in terms of gift. To summarize, we have seen that for Bradley and, differently, for Girard (as interpreted by Seasoltz), the voluntary character of Jesus's death on the cross is replaced by a kind of surrender to the inevitable law of sacrifice, a passive acceptance of death (and violence). In that very surrender, they argue, lies the revelatory key to redemption. Finally, for Seasoltz and Finlan, when sacrifice is "corrected" by a notion of God's generosity, the gift of the incarnation and Eucharist *saves* by being received, by being *cooperated with* and *implemented*. To be sure, this is one approach to a theology of eucharistic "sacrifice," and, perhaps, it even represents the current consensus position—as Daly contends. It is not, however, either the only possibility nor the most complete theological option, an option that would do justice both to the language in which the church prays

65. Seasoltz, *God's Gift-Giving,* 112.

66. Stephen Finlan, *Problems with Atonement: The Origins of, and Controversy about, the Atonement Doctrine* (Collegeville, Minn.: Liturgical Press, 2005), 119.

67. Finlan, *Problems with Atonement,* 120–24.

and to the long and full tradition of reflection upon the liturgy of the Eucharist.

We begin now to spell out de la Taille's theory of eucharistic sacrifice and to point to the ways that it suggestively engages the positions and concerns of contemporary liturgical theology. In short, de la Taille's discourse on sacrifice reveals a third way between Daly's perceived chasm between magisterial teaching and the "sacrifice-translated" theological majority. First and foremost, de la Taille's work eschews any facile dichotomy between sacrifice and gift; at the same time, neither does he conflate the two in such a way that "sacrifice" is subsumed by "gift," becoming indistinguishable from self-gift or self-limitation. Nor again does he see sacrifice as a universal natural law—having its origin in the uncreated. Unlike most current attempts to purge from the Eucharist any history-of-religions elements of sacrifice, de la Taille welcomes this context and its multiple associations, mining them for theological import and truth. In doing so, he is retrieving and imitating an approach found in much patristic material, to which he then supplements the corroborating voices of medieval theologians.

Indeed, de la Taille's receptivity to the ritual and temple context of sacrifice provides him with his central insight: a neat distinction between sacrificial *oblation* and *immolation*. In striking contrast to most post-Tridentine eucharistic theology, he places the essence of sacrifice in the act of oblation. Hence, the supper and the cross are *a single sacrifice*, with Jesus acting as priest of his death on the cross in the ritual offering of the Last Supper. The will, the love, the *devotio* underlying this oblation is central to Christ's redemptive sacrifice. Into this dynamic of Christ's offering, the church intimately and mystically enters when ritually offering the sacrifice at the Mass. This *oblatio-devotio* movement stands at the heart of de la Taille's thought on eucharistic sacrifice, and, as I shall argue, it points to a theology of desire pulsating throughout the pages of his monumental opus *Mysterium Fidei*. Surprisingly, this aspect of his work has not been given attention.

In addition, the full scope of what de la Taille intends by eucharistic sacrifice is frequently lost when his theory of sacrifice is isolated both from his dense thought on grace and from his treatment of prayer and

baptism. De la Taille possesses a sure instinct (one gleaned from his reading of the tradition) that sacrifice is essential to growth in the life of grace: the Christian must ritually offer the ecclesial sacrifice and receive the deifying grace that flows from the eternal victim. Further, he understands oblation and the movement of desire in eucharistic sacrifice to be not simply cognate to, but in fact *continuous with,* ascetic practice, including the practice of contemplative prayer. In the church's sacrifice, de la Taille sees a rite pregnant with transformational potency. In the eucharistic oblation—as in contemplation—human desire is made vulnerable to purification and intensification.

I have shown above that the supplanting of sacrifice by gift proffers a concomitant rejection of any propitiatory or expiatory understanding of Jesus's death on the cross. De la Taille, to the contrary, does not sidestep the propitiatory aspect of sacrifice. His theory of sacrifice-as-gift affirms that any gift directed to God by humans will have, of necessity, a propitiatory character. The nature of this necessity becomes even more evident when we attend to his discussion of contemplation, in which the soul longing for union with the divine "learns," in the light of contemplation, its own impurity before the all-pure love and holy goodness of God. Succinctly, the ecclesial offering of sacrifice, the ongoing mortification symbolically expressed in baptism, and the contemplative's willing vulnerability to God are analogous oblations, each manifesting a love that knows its sin and is animated by a desire for union to Christ and a share in the divine life. In de la Taille's thought, the Eucharist is the *fruit* of the sacrificial banquet; it is God's return gift, a gift bestowing grace according to the measure of the worshipper's devotion and participation in the sacrificial offering. This eucharistic fruit is the inflow of sanctifying grace and the delightful union between bride and bridegroom.

Hence, this study will attempt to demonstrate how de la Taille's theory of eucharistic sacrifice subtly negotiates the sacrifice/gift divide—and does so without sacrificing, so to speak, the historical-ritual aspects of sacrifice. His thought permits us to imagine a third alternative to the contemporary impasse between liturgical theology and the church's magisterial teaching. Part 1, comprising three chapters, is

devoted to a careful exposition of de la Taille's theory of eucharistic sacrifice. The first chapter provides a detailed analysis of de la Taille's concept of sacrifice-as-gift, defining its central features (*latria,* propitiation, oblation and immolation, *devotio,* and acceptance) and bringing them into conversation with current philosophy and theology regarding the dynamic of gift-giving. In chapter 2, we shall explore de la Taille's controversial understanding of the sacrificial unicity of the Last Supper and the cross. The harmony of this supper-cross unicity with his oblation-focused theory of sacrifice will be readily evident, yet we shall show that de la Taille's thesis is not contrived, but grounded in the strong testimony of scripture, of the church's liturgical prayer, and of the early fathers. Chapter 3 looks at the ramifications of this supper-cross sacrifice to a theology of the ecclesial sacrifice in the Mass. De la Taille explores the centrality of Christ's priesthood and argues for a nuanced concept of the celestial Victim, to the end of providing full and accurate answers to the questions: *who offers the sacrifice of the Mass?* and *how is the Mass properly thought to be a true sacrifice?* Throughout these initial three chapters, the concepts of oblation and of the offerer's *intentio*—the involvement of love and the will—shall emerge as absolutely central to the ecclesial eucharistic sacrifice.

Part 2 of our study turns to de la Taille's theology of grace. Chapters 4 and 5, based on the untranslated *Liber* III of *Mysterium Fidei,* focus on eucharistic grace, or the sanctifying grace of intimate and deifying union to Christ. In particular, chapter 4 sounds de la Taille's strong preference for Greek and Syriac thought on eucharistic grace, showing his desire to accentuate divine life as flowing from the flesh of Christ. Chapter 5 involves a more technical discussion of the grace of Christ and of the necessity of the Eucharist. Taken together, these two chapters provide vital indications of the topics de la Taille intended to explore at greater length in the unfinished (and apparently unrecoverable) treatise *de gratia.* Here again we shall attend to how the dynamic of desire figures centrally in the reception of the sacrificial, grace-bestowing food. For de la Taille, the Eucharist attracts desire, "straightens" it, and finally excites it further. Chapter 6 moves beyond the scriptural and patristic witness of *Mysterium Fidei* to an articulation of de la Taille's acute in-

sight into a metaphysical understanding of the union between uncreated grace and the created soul. This chapter may not be of strong interest to the reader who is fundamentally a liturgical or historical theologian. And, because the discussion in this chapter takes us beyond the pages of *Mysterium Fidei,* de la Taille would not fault the reader who chooses to bypass this chapter. In this chapter I shall explicate his provocative theory of "created actuation by uncreated Act," assessing its significance for twentieth-century theological discourse on grace and pointing to the way it originates from and illuminates de la Taille's thought on the grace of eucharistic union. Chapter 6 thus completes de la Taille's thought on grace and provides a valuable supplementary, if not essential, layer to the overall argument of the book.

Part 3 manifests the scope of de la Taille's theology on sacrifice and grace for the spiritual life. Chapters 7 and 8 take up his impressive treatment of contemplation and the numerous questions of debate concerning mystical theology. Contemplation, or passive prayer, is that purgative exercise through which all souls pass on their way to union with the divine. I shall argue that John of the Cross's influence vividly surfaces in de la Taille's portrayal of contemplation in terms of sacrifice and the purification of desire. What surfaces is a strong analogy between contemplative union and the grace of the Eucharist, both of which are dependent upon the food of the sacrificial victim.

Chapter 9 then gathers the various pieces of this study under the rubric of baptism, particularly of the ongoing purification and transformation signified by that rite. For de la Taille, the oblation of our mystical death in baptism is crucial to eucharistic sacrifice. Baptism is the image of Christ's willing oblation of his death, an oblation to which the believer is conformed in baptism and one that she is henceforth obliged to offer in the ecclesial community. Ongoing baptismal mortification—ascetic discipline, works of *caritas*, practices of liturgical and passive prayer—is oriented to and subsequently authenticates the ecclesial offering of the eucharistic sacrifice. All such purificatory practice has the same end: the grace of union to Christ and the influx of his divine life.

The Nature of Sacrifice 1

A first indication that *Mysterium Fidei* offers a decidedly different approach to eucharistic theology, different from that of the eucharistic treatises that populated the theological field from the early medieval period up to the manuals of de la Taille's own time, is his decision to treat "sacrifice" before "sacrament," thereby inverting what had become the classical structure for explicating the Eucharist. De la Taille defends this *bouleversement* as a rightful attending to the "natural order" or sequence of events: that is, dealing with what came first—the sacrifice offered by Christ—before considering the daily sacrifice of the church.[1] However, without accusing de la Taille of being disingenuous, sacrifice is much more than a temporal "first" in his eucharistic theology. Sacrifice, in fact, is the principal intellectual category in the whole of de la Taille's *Mysterium Fidei*—always implicit, and frequently coming rather explicitly to the surface throughout the various questions he treats. De la Taille likewise acknowledges that some readers will be disconcerted that a proof of "real presence" does not emerge as the "set purpose" of his work (also indicated by the reverse structuring of *Mysterium Fidei*). Still, though he professes not to address this apologetic question with direct intention, real presence is demonstrated, nonetheless, in the course of his focus upon sacrifice. We commence then with

1. *MF* 1:vii. Let me make two stylistic clarifications. First, I will be following the Latin text in making capitalization decisions; thus, for the sake of consistency, I will be amending the English translation when I quote from it directly. Second, de la Taille is profuse in his use of italics. Unless I claim the emphasis as my own, all other italics are directly from de la Taille's manuscript.

a detailed presentation of de la Taille's definition of sacrifice, precisely to the end of tracing the ways it shapes and illuminates his treatment of Christ's sacrifice and the sacrifice of the ecclesia.[2]

I shall not attempt here a full *apologia* for de la Taille's starting point in sacrifice, despite the protest of modern eucharistic theology. He maintains, and with reason, that a Christian theology of the Eucharist will, of necessity, attend to sacrifice "*in genere*." Scripture and tradition give ample evidence that the event of Christ's passion was interpreted in terms of sacrifice, and de la Taille would be puzzled indeed by the suggestion of some late-twentieth-century theologians (R. Daly, E. Kilmartin, and L-M. Chauvet) that beginning with sacrifice is a "methodological mistake." Of course, it is another question altogether to ask whether or not elements from his initial discussion of sacrifice *in genere* govern his eucharistic theology in too heavy-handed a way, to the point of straining revelation and official church tradition. I do not think so. Alternatively, we shall see that these elements of sacrifice enhance our understanding of the Eucharist in ways that corroborate church tradition and truths of Christian practice and formation.

In any event, de la Taille is not unaware that his theological approach leaves some angles on the Eucharist unexplored, or at least underexplored.[3] However, his express purpose is to shed greater light on the mystery of the Eucharist, striving for a systematic, coherent understanding that is both congruent with the truth of scripture and tradition and concerned to "foster piety."[4] The genus of sacrifice is that *archê* that allows for an "organic articulation" of the theological complexus of the Eucharist. Sacrifice responds to the central theological questions about the Eucharist, namely, "What properly is this?" and "What in its intrinsic essence is this matter with which our faith concerns itself?"[5]

2. Because de la Taille proves to be a consistent thinker, I shall be drawing upon the 1921 edition of *Mysterium Fidei,* the edition most widely available and the one that establishes the pagination for succeeding editions (1924 and 1931). In the 1931 edition, de la Taille has appended responses to critics; this material is found, in substance, in the English collection of his work: *The Mystery of Faith and Human Opinion Contrasted and Defined* (London: Sheed and Ward, 1930). I will refer to this material only when de la Taille's later argument appears more transparent than his initial articulation in *Mysterium Fidei.*

3. *MF* 1:vii.

4. *MF* 1:vii–ix.

5. "Proprie quaeritur quid sit, vel quomodo se habeat secundum se, illud circa quod est fides"; *MF* 1:ix.

For de la Taille, sacrifice is *the* theological key to a hermeneutic of the Eucharist. This chapter begins to outline why this is the case, while also revealing how *sacrifice* is intrinsically related to its frequently segregated relative: *gift*.

Sacrifice *In Genere*

De la Taille stipulates that his definition of sacrifice is founded upon "revelation" (contained in "sacred writings") and upon "reason"—reason that, in the Thomistic sense, understands that human nature demands (*"exigit"*) sacrifice. As he lays out his theory of sacrifice at the opening of *Mysterium Fidei,* it immediately becomes apparent that his definition rests on an amalgam of sources: scripture; liturgical texts; theological tradition (the fathers, mediaeval theologians, conciliar documents, sermons, and hymns); and history-of-religions research. In regard to the latter, he acknowledges that such studies fluctuate and contain more conjecture than well-established fact.[6] Even so, de la Taille displays an intellectual delight in correlating the findings of comparative religious studies with his strictly theological witness to sacrifice, welcoming the illuminating power that comes from such an approach. One may quibble with his broad methodological approach and observe that he has cast his net too widely in considering sacrifice *in genere.* But I would argue that de la Taille's creative synthesis, which gives evidence of a clear hierarchy among materials, is both theologically responsible and valuable.

The central features of de la Taille's definition of sacrifice will be identified and discussed in the following order: (1) a traditional, but presciently stipulated, doctrine of sacrifice as *latria* and propitiation; (2) a categorization of sacrifice as belonging to the species of sign and gift; (3) an instructive parsing of oblation and immolation in sacrifice; and (4) an understanding of sacrifice as gift and moral *pactum,* thereby involving divine acceptance and the subsequent flow of gifts "touched" by the divine (sacrificial banquet). During this exposition of de la Taille's thesis on sacrifice, I urge that three questions or concerns remain close to the surface. The prevailing sentiment against sacrifice in contem-

6. *MF* 1:7n9.

porary circles frequently contends that the only appropriate response toward a God who *requires* destructive blood sacrifice from human beings is repulsion. Thus the first question, "What picture of God emerges from de la Taille's definition of sacrifice?" needs to hold place in the context of this discussion. Precisely, what kind of a God is suggested in this treatment of sacrifice and the gift dynamic imbedded within it? Secondly, we do well in advance to point to the unrelenting tension between external sign and interior reality in de la Taille's construal of sacrifice. Does he, in fact, negotiate successfully this tension? This is a fair question, provided it is issued without an accompanying demand that the tension need be resolved. At any rate, acknowledging this tension in his definition of sacrifice forestalls a dismissal of his thought as purely objectivistic. Thirdly, and certainly related to the exterior/interior question of sacrifice, de la Taille's theory is marked by an emphasis upon the role of will (*intentio*) and *devotio* in the act of sacrifice, which emphasis, if overlooked, contributes both to a misconception of his unicist position on the supper and cross and to serious oversight in regard to the spirituality behind his eucharistic theology. In regard to these last two issues, we do well to recall the central inspiration for de la Taille's thought on eucharistic sacrifice—namely, the Epistle to the Hebrews. This New Testament text itself returns frequently to the themes of external rite/internal disposition and of the will's obedience and purity.[7] In short, I argue that de la Taille's understanding of sacrifice as laid out in the first Elucidation of *Mysterium Fidei* bears within it a theology that is neither crass in its concept of the divinity nor simplistic in its portrayal of the human act of oblation.

Sacrifice as *Latria* and Propitiation

De la Taille's exposition of sacrifice as latreutic and propitiatory reveals him to be a heedful disciple of Thomas on this question. Even so, his exposition holds out a few theological surprises of its own, particu-

7. Cf. Luke Timothy Johnson, *Hebrews: A Commentary* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press, 2006), 20–21. Johnson's work repeatedly calls attention to the Platonic tension of Hebrews. He rightly qualifies, however, that Hebrews displays a "softened" Platonic dualism, i.e., more historical than Philo's Platonism and more appreciative of corporeal existence in light of the incarnation and resurrection: "Only because Jesus had a body could he be a priest" (Heb 2:17; 10:5).

larly in regard to the portrayal of *latria* and propitiation as dual sources of the obligation to offer sacrifice. While arguing that *latria* is central to the act of sacrifice, de la Taille also demonstrates that the "second source" of obligation to offer sacrifice, propitiation, cannot, given the *de facto* condition of sin, be absolutely divorced from that of *latria*. This overlapping or conjoining of the reasons for offering sacrifice goes some way toward precluding a construal of de la Taille's position on sacrifice as either purely ethical offering or as an offering made only to placate—or change the disposition of—a justly angry God.

Let us carefully define *latria,* the "first and highest" duty of the human creature. *Latria* includes an obligation to surrender to, to submit to, and to entirely "hand oneself over" to God, who is the source and the Creator of all things.[8] Following Thomas,[9] de la Taille argues that sacrifice is the singular *exterior representation* of that interior, latreutic dedication of the mind and will to God; more, it is a worship that cannot be directed to any other being without the grave sin of idolatry. We shall return shortly to the emphasis on the necessity of the outward, sensible sign of *latria*. I first want to underscore both how de la Taille characterizes the God to whom this sacrifice is offered and how he delineates the elements peculiar to latreutic sacrifice.

De la Taille establishes his understanding of sacrifice in opposition to theologians like Cardinal de Lugo, who, holding that latreutic sacrifice worships God as the omnipotent "lord of life and death," thereby sees a destruction of the self (or a substitute) as inevitably demanded by sacrifice. De la Taille, to the contrary, insists that latreutic sacrifice honors God "as our *end,* or as the highest Good, the perfecting of all things (ut *finis* nostra, seu ut summa Bonitas, perfectiva rerum omnium)." As such, latreutic sacrifice must signify the *perfecting* of the creature; it cannot be a diminution ("*inimicam*"), but only an enrichment ("*amicam*") to the life of a human being.[10] Even more, de la Taille

8. "Quod igitur se totum Deo dedat, mancipet atque submittat, primum est hominis maximumque officium, cui nomen imponitur latria"; *MF,* 4.

9. *SCG* III, c. 120.

10. *MF* 1n1; 3n1. De la Taille cites Thomas (*SCG* III, c. 119), arguing that sensible worship is required not that by loss of life one is further removed from God, but rather, that through sacrifice we come nearer to God ("quia per hujusmodi actus proficimus in Deum").

stipulates that this office of *latria* is referred not to God's omnipotence, by which he holds all things in being, but to his "goodness and lovableness (*bonitatem seu amabilitatem*)," by which he calls all beings to himself ("*quae omnia vocat ad se*").[11] God moves and draws human beings to participate in God, and it is in accordance with this Supreme Good that the believer offers latreutic sacrifice to the creator and provider of beatitude. In other words, it is God's "loveableness"—which is love itself ("*ipse amor*") and which alone moves and inclines the rational will—that elicits from humans the cult of *latria*.[12]

Latreutic sacrifice likewise includes aspects of both *eucharistia* and *impetratio*. As God is the diffusive origin of all goods, *latria* fittingly and explicitly acknowledges these gifts by thanksgiving. Concomitantly, as God will not be outdone in generosity, the securing of divine favors by petition is also involved in latreutic sacrifice. What can be expected by the worshipper who devotes herself to the first Good, to the *fons* from which every created thing comes forth and to which every good leads? Quoting Ignatius of Loyola, de la Taille suggests that the more generous one is in *latria,* the closer one is to God and the more generous will be the response of the divine majesty. Between God and the worshipper there exist robust intimacy and mutual generosity. In asking for help and specific goods, *latria* appropriately gives expression to a desire for God.[13] Hence, thanksgiving and petition are layered realities of latreutic sacrifice.

If latreutic sacrifice is a submission to God, God as attracting love and the end of human happiness, how can one reconcile to this the second source of obligation for offering sacrifice—propitiation? In a word, de la Taille weaves propitiation into *latria* without a seam. Propitiation, in fact, becomes a form of *latria* that best accords with the fallen state of humankind. This move may be de la Taille's *novum* in regard to Christian sacrifice. His argument unfolds first by questioning what relationally ought to obtain in sacrifice between the worshipper and God, and then, secondly, by more precisely demonstrating that propitiation and *latria* inherently coalesce as twin obligations in the genuine

11. *MF* 1:2n2; *MF,* 4n1.
12. *MF,* 4n1.
13. *MF* 1:3.

offering of sacrifice. Does de la Taille here too readily unite two distinct forms of Hebrew sacrifice?[14] Perhaps, but some scholars have noted that issues of purity and impurity and harmony and disorder underlie the entire sacrificial system in ancient Israel.[15] As far as the history of Hebrew sacrifice is concerned, it is certainly not clear that the peace or communion sacrifice (sometimes translated as "completion" offering), which typically ends in a shared meal among participants, is ever offered without an accompanying recognition of human impurity before an all-holy Lord. In fact, the communion meal or feasting of the peace sacrifice is often the final ritual moment *after* a purification sacrifice has removed what could hinder harmony with the divine.[16] Once one admits that sin or impurity is inevitably involved whenever the creature comes before the Creator in the worship of sacrifice, de la Taille's logic is difficult to controvert. To be sure, while the two obligations of *latria* and expiation are always conjoined in a single liturgy of sacrifice, there is no difficulty in acknowledging that, most frequently, one of the two aspects will predominate.[17]

De la Taille construes the propitiatory aspect of sacrifice in the following attractive way. Because human beings are sinners, every honor or gift given to God must also ("*prius*") give testimony of sorrow and exhibit some kind of compensation or reparation. This requirement is based on the sacrificial dynamic of gift giving that calls for genuine goodwill and friendship. Without the element of penitential acknowledgement, along with an expression of the desire to make reparation, the offering in sacrifice of gifts or thanksgiving to God would bear the

14. Cf. how Michael McGuckian, S.J., parses the holocaust, the communion sacrifice, and the sin-offering as different forms of sacrifice in Levitical tradition in *The Holy Sacrifice of the Mass: A Search for an Acceptable Notion of Sacrifice* (Chicago: Hillenbrand, 2005), 28–31. But it is likely that McGuckian's distinctions are far too tidy. In any event, McGuckian is less interested in the different types of sacrifice than in discerning a general Temple model that contains the three movements of *offering, priestly mediation*, and *meal*. Philip Jenson's essay on Old Testament sacrifices suggests greater overlapping among not three, but five different kinds of sacrifice: the holocaust, the sin offering, the reparation or guilt offering, the grain offering, and the peace or communion offering; Jenson, "The Levitical Sacrificial System," in *Sacrifice in the Bible,* edited by R. Beckwith and M. Selman (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Baker Book House, 1995), 25–32.

15. Jenson, "The Levitical," 30–35; Robert Daly, S.J., *The Origins of the Christian Doctrine of Sacrifice (*Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1978), 25–27.

16. *MF* 1:31.

17. *MF* 1:11–13.

"savour" of coming from one "both unworthy and unfriendly (*ab indigno et inimico*)."[18] To be a friend of God, to be one who offers gifts to God—be it in praise, thanksgiving, impetration, or all three—necessarily involves a testimony to sorrow for sin. Note that de la Taille does not specify here some process of penance and purification necessary *before* offering sacrifice to God. Rather, an element of propitiation pertains to the act of sacrificial oblation proper, such that the purification is embedded in the offering, a reality to which we shall return. More forcibly still, de la Taille asks us to see the inherently overlapping religious posture in the two obligations. If propitiation includes the concept of "compensation" for the injured "right" of God, then that very acknowledgment of divine excellence reveals an unmistakably latreutic attitude toward God's majesty.[19] The latreutic friend of God offers sacrifice knowing the need and desire for reconciliation; the repentant offerer of sacrifice acknowledges that the one to be "compensated" is the creator and lord of the universe—i.e., the only being worthy of *latria*.

This conflation of the double obligation to offer sacrifice can be promoted from yet another angle: de la Taille posits that propitiation, like *latria,* includes *eucharistia* and *impetratio.* Thanksgiving is proper to propitiatory offering because such action expresses gratitude for mercy shown to the unworthy and undeserving. On a similar note, the propitiatory aspect of sacrifice includes not only the obvious petition for forgiveness and reconciliation, but also, pardon being granted and "obstacles" removed, petitions for other benefits flowing from divine goodness.[20] De la Taille so parses propitiation as to argue that *latria* and propitiation cannot be absolutely distinct *in genere sacrificii.*

Two final observations about propitiatory sacrifice may curtail later confusion. De la Taille does not hesitate to show that real or metaphorical death and mortification are *conveniens* to propitiatory sacrifice. At the same time, however, he argues that love plays an essential role in propitiatory oblation (as it does in latreutic sacrifice). Invoking scripture, and particularly Paul, de la Taille draws his conclusions about the relationship between death and propitiation. Because the subjection of

18. *MF* 1:10; *MF,* 9.
19. *MF* 1:12.
20. *MF* 1:12.

the spirit to the flesh is a "natural consequence" of sin, mortification of the flesh is appropriate in the "undoing" of sin.[21] He acknowledges with Paul that eternal death is the "wage" of sin, and that this death begins with a temporal dying. In chapters 8 and 9 we shall have occasion to look precisely at how this "mortification" is entwined with baptismal life and the practice of prayer. For now I merely intend to highlight de la Taille's unflinching recognition of death as a fitting component to propitiatory sacrifice. "*Sine sanguinis effusione non fit remissio*" (Heb. 9:22). Quoting the author of the epistle that so penetrates his eucharistic theology, de la Taille argues that when a propitiatory end is preeminent, sacrificial action most congruently exhibits the reality of alienating sin through some *sensible* sign of death. Significantly, however, this sign of blood and death is not efficacious without *amor.* Indeed, love is and must be the central motive in the pain and death that accompany sacrifice. Suffering and death are so naturally repugnant to the human appetite that love must lead the way in any propitiatory offering: there is no *ampliorem aut nobiliorem* "field of victory open to love" than that of propitiatory sacrifice (cf. John 5:13; Phil. 2:8). De la Taille states frankly the law of efficacy in propitiatory sacrifice: "The greater the intensity of love in the person converted to God and turned away from sin, the more adequate (*condignior*) will be the compensation."[22] This principle, which will be crucially important in its application to the church's sacrifice, clearly announces the key issue in his doctrine of sacrifice—namely, the relation between the external sign and the internal reality of *devotio,* to which we now turn.

Sacrifice as Belonging to the Genus of "Signum" and "Donum"

Sacrifice is that exclusive form of worship that, in a sensible way, shows reverence, obedience, and the natural inclination (*tendentia*) of human beings toward God. The final clause of this definition ought not to be too quickly overlooked, for sacrifice is being set within a broader context of the creature's—the *viator's*—return to God. Sacrifice is a form of worship that moves the human toward his or her fi-

21. *MF* 1:11.

22. *MF* 1: 10; *MF,* 9.

nal end. Still, should the duty of *latria,* the submission of the mind and will to God, and (as we have shown) concomitantly propitiation, demand an external manifestation? Is it not possible for the worshipper to "hand himself over to God" without displaying some outward sign of that oblation? Why offer this gift of self *in sacrificio,* i.e., *in signo, in sacramento?* And what is the relationship between the "sign" and the interior dedication to which this sign points? De la Taille's definition of sacrifice invites such questions, the answers to which take us more deeply into the heart of his theory.

Acknowledging the teaching of Augustine and Thomas, de la Taille concurs that sacrifice would not have been needed in the integral state of human being—that is, in the innocence and "primeval elevation" before the Fall. Unfallen humanity could offer themselves to God as pure, guiltless victims, "without the assistance of signs (*sine signorum ope*)."[23] The spirit yet held sway over the flesh. In postlapsarian creation, however, sensible signs are a provision to human knowing and worship: sacrifice is a divinely provided means for the human mind to be elevated to God. With Thomas, de la Taille argues that it is through external signs that "the will of man is more greatly recalled to the divine (*hominis intentio magis revocatur ad divina*)."[24] Visible sacrifice is divinely instituted to meet the epistemological and psychological needs of fallen human creatures. Furthermore, the sensible aspect of sacrifice is traced to the social nature of worship: our *latria* ought to bear the social impress of being manifest, publicly, by external "testimony" and witness.[25] In short, given the parameters of human sinfulness, the mode of human knowing that moves *through the sensible,* and the essentially social character of worship, sacrifice does not exist properly without an external sign. Sacrifice is not a Gnostic exercise; body and soul together share in the fallen condition. An "incarnate" sign is demanded by sacrificial worship in order to signify the internal surrender and *devotio* of the offerer, and this sign is the gift made sacred in being handed over to God.

We could question how strict an interpretation ought to be rendered to de la Taille's definition of sacrifice. A community of Quakers

23. *MF* 1:5n6; *ME,* 5n2.
24. *ME,* 5; *SCG* III, c. 119.
25. *MF* 1:4.

gathered in silent prayer in a spare building might be said to be manifesting a "sign" of internal devotion to God. But could such a worship scenario be called sacrifice? De la Taille would answer negatively, because sacrifice belongs properly to the category of "gift," or, more precisely, *gift giving.*[26] This placement of sacrifice under the genus of gift is a critical feature of de la Taille's theory, one that we shall be unpacking in the course of this chapter and the next. At present, I wish to underscore the sharp riposte that this coalescing of sacrifice and gift proffers: de la Taille reverses the prevailing tendency, inaugurated theologically by Luther, to segregate "sacrifice" and "gift," aligning them on different conceptual and phenomenological axes. To return to our example of the Quaker meeting, for de la Taille such worship could not be called sacrifice, *properly* speaking, for it lacks that external sign that is determinative of sacrifice—*the handing over of a gift to God,* an action that occurs *ritually* over, with, or about that which is to be made sacred. "Since sacrifice belongs *to the category of gift,* it is necessary that some action be sensibly enacted in the presentation or rendering of the gift (Cum sit sacrificium *in genere donationis,* necesse est ut sensibiliter peragatur aliqua activa doni praesentatio seu redditio)."[27] It is the gift-giving action that, in sacrifice, signifies "internal surrender." De la Taille translates this dynamic of sacrifice into the classical language of sacramental theology. The ritual handing over of the gift is *res et signum:* it is real giving *and* it is a sign of internal devotion and obedience. But it does not constitute the *res tantum,* the reality itself of the interior gift.[28] For reasons that will be most evident when we consider the supper and mass oblation, de la Taille absolutely insists that the ritual *donatio* of the gift in sacrifice be regarded as a *real* giving.

We can press de la Taille further. In this delineating of the sign and reality of sacrifice, which takes precedence—the external ritual sign

26. De la Taille offers a list of New Testament passages in which sacrifice is the clear reference, although the word or words used to indicate that reality connote "gift"—*donum* or *munus* in the Latin, δῶρον in the Greek. For instance, Matthew 5:23 ("If therefore thou offerest thy gift at the altar," etc.); Matthew 8:4 ("Offer the gift which Moses commanded"); and Hebrews 6:1 ("Every high priest is ordained … that he may offer up gifts"); see *MF* 1:6n1.

27. *MF,* 11 (emphasis mine).

28. *MF* 1:9.

(real giving that signifies), or the interior reality (what is signified)? This is no trivial question, and the answer must be pursued with caution to avoid misunderstanding. *Both* elements, de la Taille argues, are necessary for the integrity of true sacrifice, for without the internal surrender, the sacrifice offered is "fictitious (*ficte*)," an empty show, while without the external *signum,* the sacrifice is *improprie,* for the essential exterior element is absent.[29] Put otherwise, there is no *res tantum* without the *res et signum.*

If both elements are necessary for sacrifice, de la Taille nonetheless summons a number of witnesses from tradition to indicate that the aspect of "interior immolation" ought to be underlined in genuine sacrifice. He offers a rich array of citations from Augustine, Cyril of Alexandria, Gregory the Great, Leo the Great, Procopius, Eusebius of Caesarea, and William of Paris, all of which suggest that no sacrifice is pleasing to God without the invisible, interior offering of the self that gives authenticity to the ritual sacrifice.[30] In each of these passages, de la Taille highlights that the offering of the gift to God must be imaged in the oblation of the worshipper's heart. Cyril of Alexandria's vivid voice will stand as representative for the others, and as expository of de la Taille's own thought. In this passage, Cyril links the exterior rite of the ecclesial sacrifice to interior, spiritual mortification and the surrender to God's will:

> For in our sacrifices, we to a certain extent immolate and offer our own soul, *as in an image,* to God, when we die to the world and to the wisdom of the flesh, when we mortify our vices and are, so to speak, crucified with Christ; and thus we spend our days in holy submission to his holy will.[31]

Indeed, "our sacrifices," the sacrifices of the church, are intended as *signum* of an interior handing-over. We have noted de la Taille's reluctance to include as sacrifice *proper* acts of devotion unaccompanied by the visible, ritual sign of giving something unto God. Still, this delimitation is balanced by his unqualified affirmation of the voice of tradition (beginning with Jesus's echo of the prophets) that accentuates the invisible element in ritual sacrifice.

29. *MF* 1:8; *MF,* 7.
30. Cf. *MF* 1:7–9.
31. Cyril of Alexandria, *De adoratione in spiritu et veritate* 1; *MF* 1:8–9.

Sacrifice: *"Oblatio et Immolatio"*

We now have before us two essential features of de la Taille's understanding of sacrifice: that sacrifice is a sensible sign of interior devotion to God, and that this sign is a visible action of gift giving to God. These defining characteristics ground the more complex features of de la Taille's theory of sacrifice and are particularly crucial to his careful and constant distinction between oblation and immolation. It is no exaggeration to say that much theological entanglement over sacrifice has been caused by a failure to attend adequately to the difference between oblation and immolation. In the course of tradition—in the writings of the fathers and subsequent theologians, in the liturgies and even in conciliar and papal documents (*vide* Trent!)—the conflation of the two terms, both linguistically and conceptually, has generated significant confusion. De la Taille sharply observes that writers have often employed the words "offering" and "immolation" rather "indiscriminately," substituting one for the other, and often simply using one to encompass the whole action of sacrifice.[32] While forgiving of this rather "natural" occurrence in historical theology—"natural" because oblation and immolation are so integral one to the other—de la Taille announces that he will be relentless in his distinct use of *oblatio* and *immolatio.* Strictly speaking, *immolation* refers to the destruction of a victim—even though it must have some reference as well to the act of offering that victim. *Oblation,* or *offering,* though it cannot suffice of itself to confer victimhood, is the central, gift-oriented action of sacrifice. De la Taille constructs his argument for the centrality of oblation largely from history-of-religions materials. His proposal, moreover, distinguishes his project from that of sixteenth- and seventeenth-century efforts to cast immolation as determinative of ritual sacrifice.[33]

32. MF 1:14. De la Taille's critics frequently challenge him on his interpretation of sources, which are themselves fraught with ambiguity on the meaning of immolation and oblation. We shall address this challenge further in chapter 3.

33. At the same time, however, de la Taille's emphasis on oblation often leads to his being too quickly and completely associated with the French Oblationist School (Bérulle, de Condren, Olier, Lepin). As we shall see in the next chapter, de la Taille is careful to articulate his differences with that school of thought.

De la Taille points to evidence in anthropological research that humans, from "the dawn of creation," have been led by natural law, or taught by God,[34] to offer gifts or presents to God/gods, and for "this one end only": "as a witness and sign of one's interior dedication (*testificationem atque significationem internae suae dedicationis*)."[35] Thus does he confirm that the primary end of sacrifice is to signify internal *devotio*—and not to influence or change God's mind. De la Taille underscores, relying largely on the work of M. J. Lagrange (*Études sur les religions sémitiques,* 1903), that the concept of *offering* unites a myriad of ancient sacrifices, bloody and unbloody. Even in the Egyptian sacrifices, some 4,000 years before Christ, the practice of preparing banquets for the gods, however realistic, likely had a *signifying* meaning beyond the wish to feed the divinity.[36] Further, drawing upon sacrifices described in Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy, de la Taille points to scriptural evidence for distinguishing oblation and immolation. The actual rite of slaying the victim not only could be carried out by someone besides the priest, but also was frequently an action prior to the more significant act of the priest *offering* that victim to God, particularly identified as the sprinkling of the victim's blood upon and around the altar.[37]

Hence, when setting forth the defining sacrificial actions of immolation and oblation, de la Taille argues that immolation—destruction

34. De la Taille does not think it necessary to settle the question of whether the human inclination to offer gifts to a divinity derives from natural or revealed law. Tradition has not settled the issue definitively. Cassian, for example, thought that ancient peoples were led by nature to offer sacrifices; Chrysostom argues that it was both natural law and the authority of revelation that prompted humans to offer their gifts to God. See *MF* 1:6n8.

35. *MF,* 6. De la Taille's insistence upon this "*one end only*" is in direct response to a controversy unleashed by Alfred Loisy's book, *Essai historique sur le sacrifice* (Paris: Nourry, 1920). Loisy argues that the origins of religious worship are tied to the more or less "magical" practices that attempt to influence invisible, *impersonal* powers. De la Taille takes issues with Loisy's interpretation of historical research, and particularly with his conclusion that Jesus did not offer up his death (Loisy thinks this to be Paul's fabrication). See *MF* 1:22–23, n34.

36. *MF* 1:6n7. For de la Taille, it is purely an interpretive matter, and not one of fact, as to whether or not any symbolic meaning can be denied to these banquets. Such "uncertainty" is largely why de la Taille approaches the "findings" of history-of-religion research only tentatively; *MF*, 7n9.

37. *MF* 1:13. De la Taille invokes evidence from Wellhausen, Robertson Smith, and J.A. McCullagh to show that similar rites involving the blood of victims were prevalent in semitic, Egyptian, and ancient Celtic sacrifice; MF 1:n19.

or change in the gift—cannot be the integrating element of sacrifice. Immolation *in itself* neither signifies internal devotion nor ritually represents the dedication of the gift; rather, an *offering* to God of the thing changed or destroyed constitutes the essential act of sacrifice. De la Taille defines this offering as a ritual gesture, and one that requires a "*liturgus*": without a publicly recognized "sacrificer" and some action indicating the transference of the gift into the hands of God, there is no sacrifice.[38] The verb *sacrificare* specifically highlights the activity of the liturgus, as it indicates a "making sacred" and the handing over of a gift to God. As such, sacrifice suggests the ritual oblation directly ("*in recto*") and the immolation only indirectly ("*in obliquo*"). In sum, we can conclude with de la Taille's own words: "It will suffice, then, for true sacrifice, that something *be offered either as to be immolated, or as immolated.*"[39]

The relationship between immolation and oblation is more sharply illuminated by two distinctions that surface at a later point in volume 1 of *Mysterium Fidei*. The first distinction calls attention to the difference between a "vow" and a sacrificial offering, with the offering of sacrifice constituting an obligation of much greater magnitude. Making a vow to God, de la Taille suggests, is more intrinsically related to the genus of verbal prayer: it is the offering and enunciation of a promise to God, and one that refers to the future. In the oblation of sacrifice, however, what is offered in ritual action is *now* handed over to God, requiring that the victim be consecrated by immolation—either in the past or subsequently. The obligation of sacrificial oblation is thus "far more sacred," "for what is not only promised but actually given over into the ownership of God, cannot be withdrawn from his altars without dreadful sacrilege."[40] Showing the magnitude of sacrifice in comparison to vow making, de la Taille unfolds how the distinct actions of *oblatio* and *immolatio* are inextricably bound together, even co-present, though the former is elevated over the latter.

38. *MF* 1:13.

39. *MF* 1:15. "Ad verum igitur sacrificium sufficiet ut *offeratur* aliquid *aut tanquam immolandum aut tanquam immolatum*"; *MF,* 12.

40. *MF* 1:135.

This tight correlation, or union in distinction, can be measured, secondly, by de la Taille's analogy to form and matter. He aligns *oblatio* with the "determining form" of sacrifice and *immolatio* with "matter." The offering and immolation of sacrifice cannot be construed as "integrating parts" after the manner of parts of the body that together make a whole. Rather, they are "constitutive parts": "[O]ne of which, the oblation, is akin to the mode of a determining form, whilst the other, immolation, is related to the material element, which carries and underlies the formal reality (quarum una, oblatio scilicet, se habet per modum formae determinantis, altera autem, scilicet immolatio, per modum materiae se habet, portans atque subjectans rationem formalem)."[41] In other words, in an action that we call sacrifice, it is through the offering that the "*sacrificial essence (esse sacrificiale)*" is determined; the immolation *sustains* it and is the subject of that determining form.[42] The context of this form/matter discussion in volume 1 is not insignificant. De la Taille is in the midst of proving his central thesis about the unity of the supper-cross sacrifice, a thesis that we shall address shortly. My immediate purpose in presenting his scholastic analogy here is to more fully elucidate the dynamic of oblation-immolation in eucharistic sacrifice. We can and must consider offering and immolation as essential, constitutive elements of sacrifice. This double aspect granted, de la Taille stresses (1) that oblation is central to recognizing sacrifice, and (2) that in the substantial reality of sacrificial action, the separation of immolation and oblation is rather more notional than real, just as the human is a substantial reality of soul and body.

Divine Acceptance of the "Gift", Moral *Pactum,* and Sacrificial Banquet

Three aspects of de la Taille's definition of sacrifice remain to be set forth, all of which are explicated against the background of sacrifice belonging to the genus of gift. Apart from oblation and immolation,

41. *MF*, 102.

42. Lest it be thought that de la Taille sounds far too Platonic in giving precedence to the form over matter/subject, he later notes that while the formal element of sacrifice is most apparent in the offering, the immolation gives that form its absolute "substantial reality"; *MF* 1:141–42.

sacrifice involves a further twofold "consummation." The first consummation depends upon the divine—namely, it depends upon God's *acceptance* of the sacrifice; the second pertains to those offering the sacrifice, focusing upon a *participation* in that sacrifice through the "return" of the gift offered.[43] De la Taille lays considerable emphasis upon the role that divine acceptance holds in the concept of sacrifice, reiterating the dynamic of gift giving and its moral implications. Undoubtedly, his discussion here will prove theologically surprising, if not offensive, to the postmodern ear. Therefore I shall provide both description and analysis of his thought on divine acceptance before turning to a more abbreviated discussion of "partaking" in the sacrificial banquet.

In construing the transaction that occurs in sacrifice between humans and the divine, de la Taille unapologetically employs the category of gift giving. We offer a gift to another in the hope that it might be accepted; in the phenomenology of gift giving, the *finis* is acceptance. When a community of worshippers offers a gift, a victim, to God, the intended end is divine acceptance. A gift rejected by God is null and void: it does not pass into divine "ownership" and thereby remains "profane." (It is not for nothing that the church fervently prays for the acceptance of its eucharistic victim—even though, as we shall explore in chapter 2, that victim has been accepted eternally.) Only when God accepts a gift does it pass into the "*condition and dignity of things divine*."[44] We do not, as it were, "hurl" victims into heaven. The ratification of a sacrificial victim is achieved only at the moment when it is "*a Deo suscepta*." Yet, if acceptance is what we intend in offering sacrifice, we also recognize, implicitly or explicitly, that divine acceptance secures a kind of bilateral contract ("pactum") between the offerer and God. If, for example, a sacrifice is offered as propitiatory or impetratory, God's acceptance morally "obliges" God to grant pardon or confer benefits. Divine acceptance indicates the intervention of a *pactum,* and the offerer will "certainly and necessarily (*certo necessarioque*) obtain that for which the sacrifice was ordained."[45]

De la Taille takes this sacrificial "contract" a step further by argu-

43. *MF* 1:15.
44. *MF* 1:15.
45. *MF* 1:16; *MF,* 13.

ing that such a bilateral engagement must exhibit itself in some sign of mutual giving and receiving (just as in "ordinary" social contracts). The more perfect signification comes through a divine act, such as fire sent down from heaven upon the victim.[46] A second, though clearly deficient sign of divine acceptance is expressed by a human action, a ritual act such as the pouring of victimal blood on an altar, the altar representing divine presence: what the altar "receives" is accepted or "taken up" by God. Or, in the case of a holocaust fire, the fire signals God's consuming of the victim. De la Taille acknowledges that human-generated signs of divine acceptance *could* be false—signs lacking reality—for the divine in fact may have found the gift loathsome. Yet, even in the Hebrew sacrifices where fire descends from God, the acceptance remains "only figurative." The "perfect victim," Christ, was alone "truly borne into the sanctuary of divine holiness," becoming, as it were, "food for the divine glory."[47] Christ's sacrifice and the Father's acceptance: this divine *pactum* is the perfection of gift giving.

While de la Taille does not shrink from insisting on the divine obligation incurred by the acceptance of sacrifice, I suspect that most contemporary readers would. Is it not presumptuous (at best) to suggest that, on account of a human action, God is "bound" to give in return? Certainly, the thrust of much recent philosophical and theological interest in "gift" militates against such a proposal. For example, Derrida and Levinas have promoted a notion of "pure gift" as *unilateral,* a giving in which the giver expects nothing in return and in which the receiver incurs no obligation (the offering of one's own death stands as the optimum—and perhaps only—pure gift). Jean-Luc Marion (*God Without Being* [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1991]), on the other hand, argues for a phenomenological understanding of God as *Gift,* precisely to shatter the idols constructed by classical onto-theology and to leave God utterly free to give—and often in ways that shock (apocalyptically) and defy human measure. Similarly, we could point also to the work of Louis-Marie Chauvet, for whom the gift exchange theory seems to

46. Cf. the Old Testament narratives of sacrifice in Genesis 15:17; Judges 6:19–20; 1 Kings 18:38 (*MF* 1:17).

47. *MF* 1:16–17.

oblige only humans, who have already received from God. God gives and thereby implicates the one who receives to offer a return gift.[48] Chauvet, who excludes sacrifice from the Christian dispensation, could not allow a gift coming from the human that would somehow implicate or oblige God.

Why forge such a divinely implicating notion of sacrifice? First, de la Taille obviously envisions God as a real player, so to speak, in the "marvelous exchange (*admirabile commercium*)" of sacrifice. If the offering of a sacrifice does indeed entail desire and an act of *devotio,* is it not fitting that the acceptance of this true sign include a response from the God who inclines the human soul to offer *latria* and who enflames the very *devotio* that accompanies the sacrifice? As de la Taille specifies later, and perhaps in more palatable terms, offering sacrifice "opens" the fountain of divine giving: "when by sacrifice we give praise to God, or offer him just compensation, *the way is opened for the mercy of God towards us,* either to justify us or to keep us good and make us better."[49] In other words, the giving of an acceptable sacrifice to God establishes a way for God to shower his gifts upon worshippers, according as they are individually "fit" to receive these gifts.[50] At one point, while providing "evidence" from the early fathers, de la Taille favorably cites a passage from Origen's Commentary on Luke 19:24, which I repeat here for the light it sheds on the gift-dynamic aspect of sacrifice:

> And in this manner those things which we shall have given to God (*dederimus Deo*), he will give back to us (*nobis ea ipsa restituet*), and with them other things which we did not have before. God asks and requires gifts from us, *so to have an occasion of giving to us,* to give to the one who gave to him (Exigit et postulat a nobis Deus, ut habeat occasionem donandi, ut ipsi tribuat qui erogavit.).[51]

Eliciting sacrifices from human beings, God freely "obligates" himself in the dynamic of gift exchange. What is striking in Origen and in de la

48. Louis-Marie Chauvet, *Symbol and Sacrament*, 277ff. For a marvelous *theological* grammar of gift, see Paul J. Griffiths' *Intellectual Appetite: A Theological Grammar* (Washington, D.C.: The Catholic University of America Press, 2009), especially 50–75.

49. *MF* 2:226. "dum, pia laude Deo reddita, vel justa compensatione exhibita, *misericordiae divinae recluditur aditus ad nos,* sive justificandos, sive custodiendos in bono atque in melius promovendos"; *MF,* 320–21.

50. *MF* 2:226. To this subject we shall return at length in chapter 3.

51. *MF* 2:52–55; *MF,* 213 (emphasis mine).

Taille's vision of sacrifice is that both human and divine giving is *real giving,* though clearly giving that is not symmetrical.[52]

Perhaps we could say further that de la Taille's theory of sacrifice is cognate to what John Milbank has called "asymmetrical giving." In Milbank's riposte to the Derridean ethical paradigm of the "pure gift" of death, he counters that the *good* that marks giving is not essentially unilateral, but rather mutual; not essentially indifferent, but rather a kind of *interested* interaction. Milbank perceives that genuine gift exchange is most frequently reciprocal, if asymmetrical, and often with a significant period of time intervening in the exchange. For example, consider the "returned" dinner invitation: the menu, the time of year, and atmosphere will likely be, and even predictably be, quite different. The original invitation might have been to a formal, six-course, holiday-season dinner; the "return" might be a casual backyard barbecue in the middle of July. The contractual-sounding nature of gift exchange is precisely overridden by this asymmetry and "non-identical repetition" of the gift. Such asymmetry provides for an element of "freedom" not found in the "contract."[53] Additionally, Milbank demonstrates that the gift given inevitably *alters* once it passes into the hands of the recipient: it will come to reflect the character and being of its new owner/user, even as the degree of mutuality between the givers must shift in the exchange (trust, love, and understanding either augmenting or falling off).[54] Granted, Milbank is not considering here interaction between creatures and God. Nonetheless, I propose that his model of gift exchange elucidates well what de la Taille is driving at in the gift-dynamic operative in sacrifice. The reciprocal exchange set in motion by sacrifice *does morally* bind, but the pact, as it were, is between two free agents: the gift offered and accepted, therefore, will be returned differently and perhaps *surprisingly*, and always bearing the "mark" of the divinity. Finally, in asymmetri-

52. Some, no doubt, will want to press here what they perceive as *the* pertinent question: who gives *first?* De la Taille does not address such a question because, in his Thomistic framework, it is not a question. The nonnegotiable, taken-for-granted, first principle of Christian theology is that God is Giver: we but participate in that perfection, and do so incompletely. The point to underscore is that in ritual sacrifice human beings can truly *give* to the divine, and this giving is not unilateral.

53. John Milbank, "The Ethics of Self-Sacrifice," *First Things* 91 (March 1999): 35.

54. Milbank, "The Ethics of Self-Sacrifice," 35, 36.

cal giving, the ecstatic *devotio* of the giver emerges as significant. The good will with which the holiday dinner host bestows the feast upon her guests in some way measures her worthiness and capacity to receive a return invitation. For de la Taille, the *devotio* of the one offering can never be discounted; in fact, it is the element that gauges the fittingness of the worshipper, who looks expectantly for a return gift.

Now if sacrifice aims *maxime* at opening a path to give to and receive from God, it follows that the perfection of sacrifice is achieved in the partaking of the gift returned by the divinity.[55] This aspect of sacrifice especially reveals de la Taille's rich interweaving of history-of-religion materials, scripture, and theological tradition. Three features of his sacrificial banquet discussion are noteworthy: familiarity or communion with the divinity; present and future sanctification through the gift received; and the necessity of sacrifice to *get to* the banquet. First, de la Taille argues that the communication of divine goods is "appropriately" signified by a banquet. God, pleased with the victim offered in sacrifice, becomes *host,* preparing the feast and granting the offerers communion with himself and one another.[56] De la Taille here draws upon William of Paris's "fifth cause" of sacrifice to explicate the familial effect of *convivium* at the sacred banquet, an effect that construes God's very presence at the feast:

> The fifth cause [of sacrifice] is familiarity and nearness to God. For the offering of gifts and the partaking of the sacred table beget the greatest confidence of nearness to God, and make us partakers with the family of God, for one is a member of the family of the person from whom he receives nutriment, and by whose table he lives. Clearly, then, these sacrifices impressed on the partakers the sense of familiarity and nearness to God, since by partaking of the same table they became in a manner sitters at the table with God. Now apart from the union of the father and mother as cause of our being, this is the most effective bond of familiarity. For this reason, seeing that God could not be in their presence to eat with them, he sometimes sent fire from heaven to consume his share of the sacrifice, and, so to speak, to take his place.[57]

55. Those sacrifices not ending with the banquet (e.g., the pouring of oil on an altar, burning incense, a holocaust) are real sacrifices. De la Taille insists that the communication of divine gifts is "*merited and secured*" by the "actual offering of the sacrifice accepted by God," even lacking the sign of divine bestowal of gifts; *MF* 1:18n26. Still, a certain *perfection* accrues to sacrifices that end in the consuming of divine favors.

56. *MF* 1:17–18. De la Taille offers a series of references to comparative religious studies research on feasting, union of a common table, the divinity as host, etc., cf. *MF* 1:18–19, nn27–30.

57. William of Paris, *De Legibus,* c. 2, cited in *MF* 1:18–19. De la Taille also draws attention to

The exchange of sacrifice thus concludes to a banquet of human-divine intimacy.

This symbol of divine familiarity points both to a future and a present *sanctification*—a second aspect of the sacrificial banquet. The banquet figures a future attaining of divine favors, since the eating of a victim consecrated to God "initiates" and "prepares" one for the reception of celestial gifts, just as the prior offering of the "sacrifice of justice" readies the worshipper for a more intimate union with God. But if partaking of the sacrificial banquet is preparation for a heavenly one, it is likewise *present* sanctification. Here de la Taille cuts a creative path through traditional sources and contemporary history-of-religions studies in order to demonstrate how the banquet signifies sanctification in the present. Participating in the sacrificial meal is an immediate "making holy" through the *contagion* of the sacrificed gift, which has been sanctified by being taken into the hand of God. The sacrificial, gift-offering action itself is a sanctification: what passes into the property of God passes into the nature of a divine thing, becoming "clothed as it were with the sanction and the unction of divinity itself."[58] Therefore, among those assembled at the banquet table, the gift returned by God diffuses its sacredness.

Even prior to the feasting at the banquet table, this contagion ("*invadere*") of holiness may be cast in terms of union with the victim. I quote the following in full, as it reveals vividly de la Taille's mind concerning a spiritual participation in the sacrifice (a subject more fully explored in a later chapter):

> For the man who ate of the sacrifice, by communion with the victim sacrificed to God, became himself, so to speak, a victim sacrificed to God; and the signification was in the highest degree perfected by the fact that nothing else was indicated but that man consecrated and dedicated himself interiorly to God, and consequently became united to him also.[59]

De la Taille points to the reality that the sacrifice offered, a sign of the internal *devotio* of the worshipper, reaches its perfection in the achievement of desired union, of which the banquet is sacrament.

1 Cor. 10:18–22, a Pauline depiction of what partaking of a sacrifice entails: union with the one who accepted the sacrificed gift (*MF* 1:18).

58. *MF* 1:19.

59. *MF* 1:19.

In a third assertion about the sacrificial banquet, de la Taille accentuates the priority of sacrifice over banquet, a priority that can be relearned in contemporary eucharistic theology. The evident trend in post-Vatican II eucharistic theology to underscore *commensality* as opposed to sacrifice has been critiqued in rather reactionary and (often) shallow terms, often with little depth of thought in regard to the nature of sacrifice itself. In the early twentieth century, de la Taille found himself in a position of giving answer to theologians of his own day[60] who were proposing that the Eucharist is essentially a *banquet*—food placed before us without the sacrificial offering of the body and blood of Christ. De la Taille refuses a Christian supercessionist presumption that would consider Christian sacrifice as *sui generis,* a sacrifice explicable apart from the reality of sacrifice in Hebrew scripture and in the history of religions. Such an approach, he believes, is not only counterfactual, but also elusive of natural reason. Put simply, "sacred banquet" cannot be delineated apart from sacrifice, any more than sacrifice can be captured entirely by the notion of a sacred feast: "The banquet is not sacred unless it is consecrated to God by the *sacrificial offering and the divine acceptance.*"[61] Any assertion that the church "possesses" the body and blood of Christ in the eucharistic banquet *without* also presupposing that she *offers* that sacrifice simply lacks sense. Citing J. J. von Döllinger's study of sacrifice in Greek and Persian cultures, de la Taille shows that the feast and the sacrifice were so intimately connected that the names were often "interchangeable."[62] To be sure, de la Taille acknowledges that it is through *one* ecclesial action that the sacrifice is offered to God and given back to the worshippers. Even so, oblation and banquet are formally distinct. The sacrifice and banquet have opposite subject references: the sacrifice is offered to God, the banquet is prepared for us.[63] We could say this more straightforwardly in terms of the directionality of the *donum:* the gift offered to God in

60. E.g., Franz Ser Renz in *Die Geschichte des Messopfer-Begriffs* (1901), and Bishop J. Bellord in "The Sacrifice of the New Law," *Ecclesiastical Review* (July 1905): 258–73.

61. *MF* 1:20–21 (emphasis mine).

62. Johann Joseph von Döllinger, *Heidenthum und Judenthum* (Regensburg: Verlag von G. Joseph Manz 1857), 209–10, 371–73; see *MF* 1:21n32.

63. *MF* 1:21.

sacrifice is returned in the banquet. The "preparation" of the banquet proceeds only *per modum oblationis*.

I have outlined in this first chapter the central features of de la Taille's definition of sacrifice. To summarize, we have noted that sacrifice is first and foremost the *sensible oblation* of a gift to God, a gift that is a sign of the worshipper's internal devotion to a God whose creative and attractive love sustains the universe. The gift offered is a manifestation of the desire and the duty of nature to give praise and thanksgiving to God. At the same time, the worshipper may, legitimately, petition for favors of God without adulterating the gift. For de la Taille, this movement of the (fallen) will toward God is simultaneously propelled by propitiation, or a sense of sorrow for one's lack of *genuine* friendship with the Holy One. Thus the oblation manifests a desire for reconciliation, a desire for one's gift to be found pleasing. Because the dynamic of sacrifice is that of gift giving, divine acceptance "morally" binds God to distribute his gifts, though in a time and (asymmetrical) measure that, as we will soon address, is limited only by the *capacitas* of the one receiving. The perfection of sacrifice is achieved when the gift, the victim sanctified by the receiving hand of God, is partaken of by the worshippers, thereby indicating union with the divine and a communication of holiness.[64] Such are the salient features of de la Taille's understanding of sacrifice *in genere*. How these defining components of sacrifice shape de la Taille's eucharistic theology will unfold in the chapters ahead.

64. I should note that in the Latin text de la Taille shows consistency in using the word "*hostia*" for victim, and "*donum*" and "*munus*" for gift. I have attempted to maintain his linguistic precision throughout the course of this study.

Christ's Sacrifice 2

Having explicated the key components of de la Taille's definition of sacrifice, we can begin to trace these formative lines in the whole of his eucharistic theology. Much of the controversy surrounding the publication of *Mysterium Fidei,* controversy that perpetrated its later dismissal, stems from a failure to see accurately the shaping nuances of sacrifice in his depiction both of Christ's passion and of the church's sacrificial offering. This chapter attends specifically to the events of the Last Supper and the passion, noting how de la Taille illuminates them in terms of the theory of sacrifice outlined above. Two crucial and contested aspects of his thought shall be our focus: (1) the connection between the supper and the cross, construed as a *single* sacrifice; and (2) the concept of an eternal and celestial victim. These two theological points prove to be the pillars of de la Taille's understanding of the sacrifice of the Mass, and when we turn to that topic in the next chapter, it will be evident how intricate and tightly interwoven is his thought on the eucharistic sacrifice. For in reflecting on ecclesial sacrifice, de la Taille's inner eye seems fixed on the Last Supper and the victim there offered to the Father. It is thus important that these two foundational concepts be portrayed distinctly, taking note of de la Taille's response to his critics.

The Supper-Cross: A Unified Sacrifice

At the heart of de la Taille's eucharistic theology stands the disputed claim that the supper and cross *together* comprise the sacrifice

of Christ's passion, an assertion that he discovers in scripture and the fathers, and one consonant with his notion of sacrificial oblation. De la Taille's position on the supper-cross sacrifice was attacked from various angles: by adversaries who argued that connecting the supper and cross in such a way was contrary to, even a heretical interpretation of, the pronouncement of Trent; by thinkers who faulted his "confusion" of the sacramental and real; and by more sympathetic "oblationists" who argued that Christ's offering could not be relegated only to the Last Supper. To delineate de la Taille's theory of the *unicity* of Christ's sacrifice, and to show how he meets the objections addressed to it, will be the scope of this first part of the chapter.

No space will be devoted here to rehearsing de la Taille's "evidence" that the early church understood the passion of Christ as a "true sacrifice."[1] Still, in his amassing of scriptural passages and citations from the early fathers, two distinct features ought to be noted. First, a perception of Christ as *priest* (largely taken from the Epistle to the Hebrews) figures prominently in the "witness" he brings forth. Secondly, a preference for Eastern fathers, especially Ephraem and Cyril of Alexandria, comes to the fore rather quickly. De la Taille is less concerned with establishing *that* Christ's passion is understood as sacrifice (to deny this, he argues, is "to deny or doubt the Catholic faith") than with the theological task of giving reasons for that faith.[2] If Christ's passion is a sacrifice, and the superlative sacrifice, then it is incumbent upon the eucharistic theologian to show in what way all the central elements of sacrifice are found and perfected in that salvific event. De la Taille thereby purposes in *Elucidatio* II to show that Christ's sacrifice is a sacrifice *proprie dictum,* for it lacks no aspect of a true sacrifice, "*aut invisi-*

1. De la Taille appears intent to dismiss any implication that the early tradition viewed Christ's sacrifice only in a "metaphorical," "wide," or "improper" sense. To this end he brings forth a number of passages from Augustine; see *MF* 1:30–31. He concludes that Christ's passion and death gather "in plenitude all the latreutic and propitiatory signification and efficacy of all sacrifice." Note that he does not intimate (even slightly) that Christ's sacrifice was thereby a dismissal or condemnation of all previous sacrifices. Interestingly, at the time of his writing de la Taille can boldly claim that no one—"apart from the Socinians, a few Protestants and rationalists"—has "called into question" the dogma that Christ's death was an "expiatory sacrifice" (MF 1:32).

2. *MF* 1:27 and 33n6.

bili aut visibili." Before turning in detail to the supper, where de la Taille locates the crucial moment of sacrificial oblation, his telling discussion of the *invisible* element of sacrifice in Christ's passion must be noted briefly. For it is from this discussion that we can discern de la Taille's soteriological concern, as well as his peculiar urgency in regard to sacrifice and the purgation of desire.

When de la Taille pursues the question of the invisible element in Christ's sacrifice, he first contextualizes the discussion by considering, at some length, the signification of Christ's sacrifice *ad nos*. What is signified by the Lord's passion? De la Taille's answer echoes both Gregory the Great and Thomas,[3] but is most strikingly rooted in 1 Peter 3 and 4. The passion of Christ is a sign of the dedication—the *oblation*—of human beings to the worship of God, along with an indication of our "alienation" from sin ("est humani generis dedicatio in cultum Dei et abalienatio a peccatis").[4] De la Taille finds appealing the language of Gregory the Great, who sees the cross as "sacrament" of that altar "on which the offering of human nature should be celebrated." And, just so, 1 Peter 3:18 attests that Christ died, "the just for the unjust, *that he might offer us to God*."[5] For his part, Thomas construes the "sign" of the passion in terms of 1 Peter 4:1: "Christ therefore having suffered in the flesh, be you also armed with the same thought: for he that hath suffered in the flesh hath ceased from sins, that now he may live the rest of his time in the flesh, not after the *desire of men, but according to the will of God*" (emphasis mine). More to the point, then, Christ's sacrifice is *sign* to Christians of their own intended mortification, the conversion of desire from the worldly to the godly. Christ's passion thus signifies the "death" involved in turning away from sinful desire and the "immolation" of fallen human nature.[6] De la Taille's choice of sources and texts is a valuable indication, quite early in *Mysterium Fidei,* of

3. In *Sermo* 55 and *ST* III, q. 48, a. 3, ad 2, respectively.

4. *MF,* 23.

5. *MF* 1:34.

6. De la Taille remarks upon a significant difference between ancient sacrifices and Christ's: in ancient sacrifices, the invisible element—human obedience and inclination to God—was signified by the visible, but not *effected.* In other words, the invisible was a kind of *praeambula* to the visible sacrifice. With Christ's sacrifice, however, the invisible is *achieved,* not presupposed: human alienation from sin is a consequence, not a "precondition," of Christ's sacrifice; see *MF* 1:34 and *MF,* 24.

what I argue is an implicit theology of desire running throughout his exposition on sacrifice. As we shall see in the course of this study, the passage from 1 Peter 3 and 4 punctuates key movements in de la Taille's thinking.

Shifting to a consideration of the visible and invisible elements of Christ's sacrifice as it pertains to Christ himself, de la Taille reflects upon the latreutric, eucharistic, and propitiatory aspects of sacrifice. Obviously, the passion and death signify Christ's "*dedicatio interna*," his praise and worship of God the Father, and his willingness to "compensate" the divine honor violated by human sin. De la Taille's language has an Anselmian ring here. Even so, the full picture of his soteriology situates itself in a nuanced reading of Thomas's treatise on Christ in the *Tertia Pars* of the *Summa*. With Thomas, de la Taille stresses Christ's sacrifice as originating in *love*. Let us explore this briefly to clear away any ambiguities about de la Taille's theology of sacrifice and salvation.[7]

Addressing the dynamic between the visible and invisible signification of Christ's sacrifice, de la Taille underscores that the victim of the sacrifice was "rational," a term that he parses as "a willing and loving victim, in heart's desire one with the priest," and thereby one "in value and acceptability."[8] This union of desire in the victim and priest is critical to understanding the perfection of Christ's sacrifice. Christ might have offered something *other* than himself to the Father, which "other" would have sufficed to atone for sin because of Christ's divinity and the power of his love. But the self-oblation exhibited more potently his love and desire to "make satisfaction" to the Father.[9] Put differently, the visible element in Christ's sacrifice is without doubt a "sacrament" of his love and dedication to Father. De la Taille assiduously avoids a "penal" understanding in the vicarious satisfaction offered to the Father. He argues that Christ, "under the impulse of love," willingly took the burden of human sin to the cross (it was not placed upon him by the

7. Equally revealing in this discussion is de la Taille's understanding of human sin, sharply articulated as the *incapacity to offer adequate love* to God, or to order human desires in a holy way; see *MF* 1:37n13. We shall return to this in chapter 5, where we treat of de la Taille's theology of sin and grace.

8. *MF* 1:37.

9. Cf. *ST* III, q. 46, a. 6.

Father): Christ desired to act as "our priest" and to "surrender" himself as our victim.[10]

This emphasis on the willingness of Christ to suffer leads to the question inevitably posed by de la Taille's notion of sacrifice: *ubi et quando*. Where and when does Christ give clear sign of his intention to offer sacrifice? Where and when does he offer his death to the Father? If internal *devotio* is essential to sacrifice, nonetheless it is incomplete without the exterior, ritual sign of that affect and desire. Willingness alone does not suffice. Specifically, as we have noted, the *ratio* of sacrifice requires that the direction of the gift to God be "outwardly manifested (*manifestata externe*)," for oblation is "the active tender of a gift."[11] According to de la Taille, that external sign of Christ's interior will occurs at the supper in the ritual offering of his body and blood. The supper *is* the oblation of the passion. I shall chart how this is argued and defended, and then articulate the more significant ramifications of such a thesis.

De la Taille attests that the voluntariety of Christ's sacrifice, an "all-embracing and continuous" willingness that extended through his death on the cross, is solidly founded in tradition: Christ could have prevented his passion and death—had he willed it otherwise.[12] Here there is no argument. De la Taille goes on to praise "modern theologians" (e.g., Franzelin, C. Pesch, and Gihr) for "very wisely" laying stress on the necessity of an outward act manifesting this internal will and desire of Christ.[13] He parts company with these theologians, however, in determining where Christ performs ("*peracta*") the "active dedication of himself to the worship of God as victim."[14] With care, de la Taille en-

10. *MF* 1:39. De la Taille stands by Bernard of Clairvaux's "splendidly traditional formula": *Deus filii sanguinem non requisivit, sed acceptavit oblatum;* see de la Taille, *The Mystery of Faith and Human Opinion,* 45.

11. *MF* 1:42. "At voluntarietas … non sufficit qualiscumque, sed requiritur involvens directionem doni in Deum, et quidem, ut talis, manifestata externe. Oblatio enim est quaedam activa doni exhibitio; oblatio autem sacrificalis oportet ut sit sensibilis"; *ME,* 29.

12. *MF* 1:41–42.

13. De la Taille appreciates Pesch's explicit language in *De Verbo Incarnato* (2n545): "In the sacrifice of Christ we have a sensible offering made to God.… For Christ offered himself immaculate. This offering is not merely an inward intention, it is also external and sensible"; see *MF* 1: 42–43.

14. "By what *external act*," de la Taille asks, "did Christ *assume the bearing of a priest* towards his passion, by what *rite* did he offer the sacrifice?"; see *MF* 1:43.

tertains other "solutions" propounded by thinkers who have looked for sacrificial indications in the words and actions of Christ, from Gethsemane to the cross. While he concedes that the complexus of actions and words *ab horto ad crucem* reveals signs of Christ's self-surrender to the passion, what remains lacking is a *definitive* indication of Christ as a victim, ritually handed over to God's ownership as a latreutic and propitiatory gift. In unambiguous terms, de la Taille reiterates that sacrifice must be "*plainly evident* as sacrifice":

> Now *sacrifice in itself must be plainly evident as sacrifice,* because sacrifice is in the nature of a sign—a pragmatic locution signifying an invisible thing; before all else therefore it should be self-evident. (Porro *sacrificium debet ex sese clarere ut tale:* cujus ratio est, quia sacrificium est in genere signi, tanquam locutio quaedam pragmatica notificans rem invisibilem; proindeque debet esse per se notum primo.)[15]

To those who would argue that the whole of Christ's life, indeed his very incarnation (cf. Hebrews 10:5–7), constitutes a sacerdotal, sacrificial offering, de la Taille counters with the suggestion that whatever the will and affect of Jesus's mind from his birth to the cross, the sacrificial dedication remained "invisible" until the gift was given "in actual fact (*in re*)": "No actual contract (*foedus*) was made with God for the expiation of sin, it was desired merely, and (if an outward intimation was at any time given) foretold."[16] De la Taille seems to be responding here to the French School oblationists and to the prevalent *libelli pii* of his day, both of which proclaimed the entire earthly life of Jesus to be sacrificial. Some contemporary eucharistic theologians, L-M. Chauvet, for example, have argued in a similar vein.[17] Without rejecting that the incarnate life of the Son can be considered as a "sacrifice" in a broad or metaphorical way, de la Taille is seeking for a true and proper sacrifice, one in which "an actual giving *de praesenti* is required … and not in words only but in action."[18]

15. *MF* 1:46; *MF,* 31. The gift-character intrinsic to sacrifice is absolutely determinative for de la Taille. In a footnote, he distinguishes the "giving of oneself to death" of, say, soldiers and martyrs, from that giving of oneself to death "*by way of sacrifice to God.*" While the former may be called sacrifice in a metaphorical way, only the latter, which demands a gift be presented to God (as sign of internal *devotio*), can be properly called sacrifice; see *MF* 1:46n19.

16. *MF* 1:46n20; *MF,* 31n2.

17. Chauvet, *Symbol and Sacrament,* 310–15. For Chauvet, "sacrifice" means obedience to God and mercy toward others.

18. *MF* 1:46n20; *MF,* 31n2.

Having dismissed inadequate suggestions about the actual "sacrificial dedication" of Christ's death to the Father, de la Taille reexamines scripture and "the early theologians," finding therein that the dedication is located in the *coena*. In a cumulatively convincing argument, he demonstrates that Christ sacerdotally, enacting the image (*effigies*) of his passion at the supper, offered to God "the reality (*veritatem*) of his death."[19] I shall outline the central steps in de la Taille's thesis, focusing particularly on his portrayal of the oblation of the supper as a "real and present" giving, sacrificially continuous with the immolation on the cross. For it is here that his opponents took him to task both for "confusing the sacramental and the real" and for "misinterpreting" the Council of Trent.

The Last Supper: Scripture, the Fathers, and Liturgical Witness

The Gospel accounts of the supper, as well as John 6 and 17 and the Epistle to the Hebrews, figure strongly in de la Taille's theological explication of Christ's words and actions in the upper room; secondarily, but rather more persuasively, the early fathers and liturgical sources give credence to his interpretation of those events. These sources allow him to make the following mutually implicating assertions, which we shall unpack: (1) Christ offers himself really in the "representative immolation" of the bread and wine; (2) at the supper, Christ becomes victim—*hic et nunc*—and the new covenant is made; (3) Christ is here "obligated" to death, and, offering in the eternal Spirit, God's acceptance is likewise secured; and (4) the supper is causally important to redemption, thereby precluding any sharp division between the supper and the cross.

As we begin to look at the Last Supper, prudence dictates that we treat, preemptively, a question readily brought against de la Taille's theory: does it not stand or fall upon the assumption that the supper actually, historically occurred? And is not such an assumption a shaky foundation for an entire theology of eucharistic sacrifice? De la Taille

19. *MF* 1:49; *ME,* 33.

was not unaware of this possible challenge to his work. At the opening of book 2 in Mysterium *Fidei,* he addresses recent challenges to the historicity of Christ's supper and the dominical command to repeat the ritual sacrifice, for instance, those coming from German liberal Protestant theologians and critics of the mythic school.[20] But de la Taille contends that the liberal Protestants, modern rationalists, or critics of the mythic school, fall prey to "lapses" of logic and of the laws of criticism—"demonstrating a constant predilection for subjective invention against objective testimony." He proceeds to give a response to such critics by arguing from Paul that the supper must have happened and that Christ did indeed give the command to repeat that sacrificial meal.[21]

20. *MF* 2:5–13. De la Taille acknowledges that German theologians such as Adolf Jülicher (1892), J. Hoffmann (1903), and Friedrich Spitta (1893) argue, from the fact that Jesus was fully human and could not have had any clear foreknowledge of his death and resurrection, that the supper accounts are not meant to be interpreted as instituting the eucharistic sacrifice. De la Taille also presents the widely varying proposals (popular in the 1890s to 1915) that the supper derives from pagan myths, or totemistic rites; see *MF* 2:14–16.

21. *MF* 2:6, cf. n. 2. Turning to the central question—"Did [Christ] or did he not command the supper to be renewed in the Church?"—de la Taille states his case for an affirmative answer on 1 Cor. 11:23, where Paul testifies that he is handing on a received teaching about the supper. De la Taille surmises that this teaching was not Paul's invention, for how could such a transformation occur in a mere twenty years after Christ's death: that the supper would evolve "from a primitive nothingness into a true action concerning the body slain for us and the blood of the new testament," and that Christians would believe that Christ himself "celebrated the supper in this ritual fashion"? Paul, who was not at the supper, could not have the force of such authority unless it rested upon the Lord's own command. De la Taille further suggests that the "uniformity" of rite and belief in the New Testament period can be attributed only to Christ's own authority—for such a "concordant" development would otherwise have to be counted one of the more "stupendous miracles of the scriptures"; see MF 2:17–18. Neither does de la Taille consider John's Gospel an exception to the historical institution of the eucharistic sacrifice: throughout the sixth chapter, Christ insists that no one will obtain life "without eating the body and drinking the blood"—a possibility that he intended to be available for all, throughout the ages; see MF 2:21–22.

However, the work of a scholar like Bruce Chilton (*A Feast of Meanings: Eucharistic Theologies from Jesus through the Johannine Circles* [New York: E.J. Brill, 1994]) calls into question de la Taille's simplistic vision of the uniformity of eucharistic rite and interpretation among the New Testament Christian communities. Chilton argues for six different types of eucharistic ritual and understanding in the New Testament. For a helpful assessment of current literature and trends, see Robert Daly's "Eucharistic Origins: From the New Testament to the Liturgies of the Golden Age," *TS* 66 (2005): 3–22. In the end, Daly wonders if we need to worry excessively about tracing "eucharistic praxis back to the historical Jesus or even to the New Testament in order to legitimate it" (17). Perhaps not; but de la Taille's theory of eucharistic sacrifice does depend upon the historical truth of certain actions and words of Jesus at that supper before his death on the cross. For another fascinating study of the supper as a sacrifice, see Mary Douglas's essay, "The Eucharist: Its Continuity with the Bread Sacrifice of Leviticus," in which she suggests that

To be sure, the debate about the historicity of the supper and the institution of the Eucharist continues in the twenty-first century. What in the Last Supper accounts is historically accurate and what is literary or cultic fabrication? The bulk of today's New Questers for the historical Jesus, led by John Dominic Crossan, would deny the historicity of the Last Supper—even though the sources for it are early and multiple.[22] A persuasive and sympathetic account of the historicity of the Last Supper is presented by John Meier, who insists that the onus of proof is upon those who deny that the supper occurred. De la Taille no doubt would applaud Meier's conclusion:

> [T]he prophetic words and actions of Jesus over the bread and wine were not simply predictions with stage props. The words and actions … set in motion and revealed the deepest meaning of what was about to take place, while at the same time they *already communicated something of the saving* reality to those who shared the bread and one cup of Jesus.[23]

In sum, I would argue not only that de la Taille responded adequately to his contemporaries on this question, but also that today's scholarly challenges are far from decisive and fail to delegitimize his project.

Aligning the three Gospel accounts of the Last Supper, along with 1 Cor. 11, de la Taille argues that the texts put before us a bloody death—both in words (the separate mentioning of the body "as given" and blood "as shed") and in the things themselves, which designate the body and blood. The propitiatory intent in these narratives is not to be discounted: "shed for many unto the remission of sins" (Matt 26:28); "which shall be shed for you" (Mark 14:24); "which shall be delivered for you" (1 Cor. 11:24). De la Taille thus concludes that something sacrificial is being *accomplished* in the supper. The passion is "put before us (*in medio est*)," "implied in the bloodless rite, with some kind of propitiatory benefit."[24]

Jesus was aware of the Levitical tradition of bread sacrifice for sin offerings, and that he and the disciples would have been clear about the associations for the word "body": temple, tabernacle, and God's creation (*Catholicism and Catholicity: Eucharistic Communities in Historical and Contemporary Perspectives,* edited by Sarah Beckwith, 97–112 [Oxford: Blackwell, 1999]).

22. Cf. John Dominic Crossan, *The Historical Jesus* (San Francisco: HarperCollins, 1991).

23. John Meier, "The Eucharist at the Last Supper: Did It Happen?" *Theology Digest* 42 (1995): 350 (emphasis mine).

24. *MF* 1:51; *MF,* 35.

To be sure, one can allow that these scriptural words indicate a propitiatory intent without seeing that something sacrificial is thereby *done,* but that would be to overlook the dynamic of sacrifice that we have explored above. Given that sacrifice belongs to the category of sign and gift, the supper reveals Christ *offering* himself as victim through the sign and image of that immolation to occur on the cross. In this representation of "future mactation" there is a "real and present" oblation of Christ, an offering achieved through the symbolic power of Christ's *dicta*—declaring the bread to be his body handed over, and the wine, his blood flowing from that body.[25] What is offered "apparently" is the bread and the wine; what Christ indicated was actually there, is offered in truth. In short, the words of Christ are effective of the *presence* of that offered-up body on the cross, even though the slaying is not effected.

De la Taille denies that this liturgical offering is merely a sign of some more secret giving ("*donationis secretioris*"), as if the offering simply "foretold" of a "real" oblation to happen at a later point. On the contrary, at the supper Christ actually delivers himself into the hands and possession of God. In the representative, symbolic, sacramental, mystical (de la Taille accepts the rough equivalency of all these adjectives) immolation of the supper, Christ is "dedicated to the passion" and the oblation of the victim is "actually made (*perficitur*)."[26] More, the different verb tenses of the Greek (present: "is given"/διδόμενον) and the Vulgate (future: "shall be shed"/*effundetur*) hand us a felicitous discrepancy. Indeed, the discrepancy is theologically complementary: the present tense indicates the "present representative immolation," through which is made the oblation of an immolation that will occur later, as "denoted by the future tense."[27]

If we grant that the victim is handed over to God at the supper through a sacramental immolation, the question may yet be posed as to whether the interior devotion and will, directive of the gift to God, is adequately expressed by Christ's words and actions at the supper. De la Taille gives three reasons for affirming this to be the case. First,

25. *MF* 1:52.
26. *MF* 1:56; *MF,* 39.
27. *MF* 1:56n9; *MF,* 39n2.

Christ's free will is indicated by his renewal of the covenant ("this is the blood of the new testament" [Mark 14:24]), an act that must always be engaged *freely.* Standing with the witness of "ancient teaching," de la Taille affirms that the new testament was indeed "founded (*conditor*)" at the supper and celebrated by Christ the priest, even as Moses sprinkled blood on the people, saying, "This is the blood of the covenant which the Lord hath made with you" (Exodus 24:8). Christ, giving clear and external evidence of his will, makes the new covenant, which is later "sealed" with his death on the cross.[28] Secondly, in the previous giving of thanks and blessing over the bread and wine, Christ exhibits the directionality of the gift—returned and surrendered to God ("*munera Dei Deo reddenda*"). Both his words of thanks and his gestures are revelatory of his intention to offer his life in the gifts of the bread and wine.[29] Thirdly, the intent of Christ is sensibly manifest in the body and blood given not so much *to* the disciples, but *for* them—and for the many, unto the remission of sins and reconciliation with God.[30]

Based on the New Testament narratives (and his definition of sacrifice), de la Taille perceives that the supper places before us a gritty reality. We are not looking at a supper easily sentimentalized as a poignant farewell meal between Jesus and his friends, a meal that would be a kind of "monument" to his memory. In the offering of his body and blood, Christ is *deputing* himself to his passion and death: here is the sign of Christ's interior devotion; here is the oblation of himself as victim for the remission of sins.

As we turn to the powerfully invoked witness of the fathers and liturgies, we are confronted with the underlying assumption of Christ

28. *MF* 1:75–76. In the course of demonstrating that Christ's words and actions indicate the establishment of a new testament, de la Taille unapologetically looks to a history-of-religions tradition. He cites Wellhausen and Smend for evidence of the ancient custom of "ratifying" a contract/compact with blood; see *MF* 1:75n3.

29. De la Taille here cites Moses Bar Kepha's *Explanatio mysteriorum oblationis,* a passage that discerns Christ's will in the offering of thanks at the supper: "By that phrase *he gave thanks,* [Christ] declared to us . . . that he assents to the will of the Father—for *thanksgiving is assent*—as though he said: I assent to thy will, O Father, that I receive suffering and death for the human race"; *MF* 1:52n2. Though de la Taille does not develop this further, the suggestion that the very giving of thanks and praise over the bread and wine already engages the determination of the will is worthy of greater liturgical reflection.

30. *MF* 1:51–53.

as *liturgus*—that is, Christ acting as priest in the offering of his death to the Father. Incorporating the Epistle to the Hebrews 5–7, de la Taille insists the sacrifice offered by Christ be understood in Melchisedechian terms,[31] which, he avers, would require a unity between the cross and the supper. How so? De la Taille proposes, with a consensus of exegesis on his side ("all exegetes," he rather too boldly says), that Hebrews quite plainly declares Christ to be a priest "according to the order of Melchisedech *in respect of the sacrifice of his passion and death,* whereby as the eternal Redeemer he opened the way to heaven for us (*per respectum ad sacrificium suae passsionis ac mortis,* quo aperuit nobis viam coeli redemptor aeternus)."[32] So we say that it is in respect to the cross that Christ carries out this priesthood; *and* we say that the *preeminent resemblance* between Christ and Melchisedech lies in the ritual form and mode of offering the sacrifice, namely the material of bread and wine.[33] How do these two affirmations square? For de la Taille, the coupling of these two assertions leads inevitably to the inference "that Christ offered the sacrifice of his passion in the consecration of the bread and wine." Indeed, unless we admit the oneness of the supper and cross, the Epistle's relentless association of Christ's Melchisedechian priesthood to the sacrifice of redemption presents an "insoluble exegetic difficulty."[34] Thus, both on the basis of the Gospels and the Epistle to the Hebrews, de la Taille secures his claim that the offering of the passion at the supper is real, *pragmatic* sacrifice.

A short sampling of the literature called forth to substantiate the unicity of the supper and cross is worthwhile, if only to render a sense

31. De la Taille rejects decidedly the suggestion of Christ's "dual" sacrifice—Melchisdechian at the supper, and Aaronic on the cross. This question of Christ fulfilling an Aaronic priesthood on the cross was raised at the Council of Trent, even included in the first draft of the decree, but firmly "corrected" and excised from the final draft; see de la Taille's discussion of this theological "correction" in *MF* 1:155–57.

32. *MF* 1:94; *MF,* 67.

33. De la Taille admits that Hebrews points to other similarities between Christ and Melchisedech (e.g., Heb. 7:1–3), but he thinks that these are merely "superficial" likenesses; see *MF* 1:94. Still, de la Taille would have abetted his own position on Christ's eternal priesthood had he underscored what Luke Timothy Johnson takes to be the central likeness between Melchisedech and Christ: Melchisedech does not know an "end of life" (Heb 7:3); Jesus's life and priesthood is "indestructible" (Heb 7:16, *passim*); see Johnson, *Hebrews: A Commentary* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox, 2006), 175–81, 186–89.

34. *MF* 1:95.

of the theological fruit and the surprising implications of this doctrine. As mentioned earlier, the Eastern fathers seem the most fertile source for the eucharistic theology that de la Taille is reclaiming. We shall hear from two Syrians, Ephraem and Aphraates, and the Cappadocian Gregory of Nyssa, all of whom vividly articulate the supper-cross sacrifice. Ephraem, in his second "Hymn of Unleavened Bread," realistically overlays the offering at the supper and on the cross:

He broke the bread in his hands for the sacrifice of his body; *he filled the chalice* in the sacrament of the offering of his blood. Priest of our propitiation *he offered the sacrifice for himself.*[35]

Ephraem evocatively depicts Christ as priest of his own sacrifice, offering *and* effecting the immolation in the dedication and ritual gestures with the bread and wine. Aphraates, in a passage reckoning the counting of "the three days," similarly understands the sacrifice as beginning, and radically so, at the supper:

He who took his own body in food, and his own blood in drink, *is reputed with the dead.* Before he was crucified, the Lord with his own hands gave his own body to be eaten and his own blood to be drunk.… From the time when he gave his body in food and his blood in drink, three days and three nights elapse.[36]

The suggestion that the supper oblation casts Jesus as among the dead patently coincides with de la Taille's view that the offering of his body and blood at the supper is indeed *real* and *obligating.*[37] Gregory of Nyssa gives an even more startling interpretation in his *Oratio* I *in resurrectionem,* establishing that Christ commenced and disposed everything in relation to the great sacrifice of redemption. Not waiting for betrayal and arrest, Christ "*opens the way by a sacrifice ineffable and invisible to men*":

and he offered himself for us an oblation and a victim, priest and at the same time that lamb of God who taketh away the sin of the world. When did he do this? *At the very*

35. Ephraem, *Hymni Azymorum,* Hymn 2,"Hymn of Unleavened Bread," Str. 7, in *Sancti Ephraem Syri hymni et sermones,* edited by Thomas Josephus Lamy, 1:576–78 *(Mechlinae: H. Dessein, Summi Pontificis, 1882–1902)*; *MF* 1:58–59.

36. Aphraates, *Demonstratio* XII, *De Paschate,* n. 6 and 7, PS 1.1.517, 520; *MF* 1:62.

37. See also *MF* 1:123–24. The absolute underscoring of the freedom of Christ in offering his death at the supper inevitably includes—given the *pactum* of sacrifice—an obligation to actually give the gift offered. In other words, after the ritual offering, Christ is not free to withhold the gift.

moment when he openly showed that his own body was to be received as food, because the sacrifice of the lamb was now perfected.[38]

According to Nyssa, the supper is the "ineffable" oblation and the "invisible" immolation of sacrifice. In a word, after the oblation of his body and blood at the supper, Christ is, so to speak, a "dead man walking."

If the fathers provide de la Taille with significant testimony to the sacrificial unicity of the supper and cross, the church's *lex orandi* is similarly suggestive. The anaphora of the Liturgy of St. James, for example, underscores the willing salvific action of Christ at the supper with these words: "on the night in which he was given up, nay on the night on *which he gave himself up for the life and salvation of the world,* taking bread into his holy and immaculate hands, etc." The ancient Egyptian liturgy of St. Mark proclaims the same: "Jesus Christ *on the night which he gave himself over* for our sins, *and submitted to death for all*, reclining in the flesh with his holy disciples and apostles, taking bread, etc."[39] These liturgical examples exhibit the sacrificial intention and action of Christ at the Last Supper. De la Taille also provides a Holy Thursday proper from the early Western Ambrosian rite that indicates the sacramental immolation at the supper:

> Can we despair of thy mercy, we who have been considered worthy to receive the high office of offering this great victim to thee, that is the body and blood of our Lord Jesus, *who for the salvation of the world gave himself to that holy and venerable passion? Who instituting the form of the sacrament of salvation, first offered himself as victim?*[40]

Such early texts from the church at prayer (only a brief sampling of those gathered by de la Taille) convey an understanding of the passion as beginning and actually offered by Christ at the Last Supper.

More radically, de la Taille argues for the sacrificial union of the supper and cross by showing that the fathers not only speak of the fruits of redemption *beginning* at the supper, but that they conceive as well that the new covenant is both "announced" and "entered into" at the

38. PG 46, 612; *MF* 1:62–63. De la Taille also provides at length what he calls "direct" evidence from Hesychius of Jerusalem, whom he deems to have written more on the explanation of the supper than the "other Fathers"; see *MF* 1:67–69.

39. *MF* 1:70–71.

40. Canon antiquus missae ambrosianae in coena Domini, in L. A. Muratori, *De rebus liturgicis dissertatio,* c. 10; PL 74, 914; *MF* 1:70–71.

supper.[41] He is quick to add, however, that this teaching is put forward without any suggestion of a dismissal of the cross. Gregory of Nazianzus, for example, preaches that the remission of sins is accomplished at the evening sacrifice of the supper.[42] Sharper examples of this doctrine are collected from medieval theologians who contest that the old law, which does not take away sin, came to an end at the supper, when Christ inaugurated the new order and "took away sin." John of Rouen robustly articulates this in describing the work the supper:

> *He decreed that a mystery be celebrated wherein the wounded by sin,* and the weakened in virtue, *would be restored to eternal salvation,* and the darkness of sin dispelled, those having true peace in their hearts would be illuminated with the light of faith. For on that day he brought the old law, which punished sin, to an end, and instituted the first sacrifice of his body and blood, whereby sins are taken away.[43]

For de la Taille, the implication of such writing leaves little room for doubt: the sacrifice of the cross is "already being enacted" in the supper ("Sacrificium igitur crucis in coena jam agitur").[44]

The patristic teaching that the ancient Pasch is fulfilled *both* by the supper and the passion provides further proof for this sacrificial unity. Here, Ephraem is again quoted at length, this time from his second and third *Sermo in hebdomadam sanctam.* De la Taille spotlights how Ephraem links the old Pasch to the new in terms of what is being fulfilled at the supper and on the cross. At the supper, the disciples were "witnesses" of the new Pasch—"they gazed in wonder at the sacrifice; for they had never partaken of the like." The Pasch of Egypt, offered so that "the first-born might not be slain," was brought to a close: "This [new] Pasch was offered because of the slaying of the first-born."[45] De la Taille corroborates Ephraem's poetic theology with another liturgical witness, here drawing from a Chaldean eucharistic prayer:

41. *MF* 1:60, 82ff.

42. Gregory of Nazianzus, *Oratio* 45 *in sanctum Pascha,* n.16, PG 36, 644; *MF* 1:59. "The lamb will be eaten by us. And it will be eaten towards evening, because in the end of ages is the passion of Christ: seeing that he too *towards the evening is partaker of the sacrament with his disciples, dispelling the darkness of sin.*"

43. John of Rouen, *De officiis ecclesiasticis*, PL 147, 49; *MF* 1:60n12.

44. *MF* 1:60n12; *MF,* 41n1.

45. *Sermo* 2, n. 6–10, in *Sancti Ephraem Syri hymni et sermones,* ed. Lamy, 1:380–90; *MF* 1:82–83. Tertullian and Paschasius Radbertus are also cited as conclusive examples of the teaching that the Pasch of the Lord is fulfilled indivisibly in the supper-cross; see *MF* 1:84–86, 90–91.

for when the time arrived when he was to suffer and come to his death … having in obedience to the law of Moses made the Pasch with his disciples, he then in place of this Pasch *introduced his own Pasch before his death,* the memorial of which we now make, as he gave us to do, until his return from heaven: *for our Pasch is Christ who was immolated for us. After he had supped therefore in the legal Pasch of Moses he took bread,* etc.[46]

The meaning is plain. The new Pasch begins in the supper and carries forward to the cross: "that is, the sacrifice of the one Lamb, commenced in the supper, is completed on the cross—as he hastens on from the offering to the immolation."[47]

Though a painfully condensed presentation of de la Taille's scriptural, patristic, and liturgical evidence, I have attempted to indicate that this teaching about the supper-cross sacrifice posits no "*new* theory" in theological tradition, as some of his adversaries maintained. To be fair, de la Taille himself admits that it is a doctrine "not well known in the schools today" (though he points to recent ecclesial preaching where it may be found).[48] But current obscurity does not denote innovation. If de la Taille succeeds in demonstrating the traditional tenor of his thought, and I believe he does, the more heated concern among his contemporaries that such a supper-cross unicity conflicts with Tridentine teaching proves more difficult to answer. To this topic we now turn.

Council of Trent: One Sacrifice or Two?

Shortly after the publication of *Mysterium Fidei,* Dominicans Vincent McNabb and Alfred Swaby acerbically argued against understanding the supper and cross as a single sacrifice: de la Taille's unicist theory was declared fundamentally "irreconcilable" with the declaration of the Council, a "denial of the mind of the Church."[49] McNabb adds to the

46. Max Saxonia, *Missa Chaldaica,* 32–33; *MF* 1:92.

47. *MF* 1:92–93.

48. Most notably in Henry Edward Cardinal Manning's *The Glories of the Sacred Heart* (London: Burns and Oates, 1877), 130–40, from which de la Taille cites a remarkable passage (*MF* 1:93). He must have appreciated the irony of finding the words of contemporary preaching to be "ahead" of, or rather more accurate than, the theological textbooks.

49. Vincent McNabb, O.P., "A New Theory of the Eucharistic Sacrifice," *Blackfriars* 4 (1923), 1086–1100, esp. 1095; Alfred Swaby, O.P., "A New Theory of the Eucharistic Sacrifice," *American Ecclesiastical Review* 69 (November 1923): 460–73, esp. 467; see also Dom Anscar Vonier, O.S.B., *A Key to the Doctrine of the Eucharist* (Westminster: Newman Press, 1956), 156.

theological stakes by accusing de la Taille's theory of being "nothing short of an *evacuatio crucis*."[50] Critique came from within de la Taille's own religious order as well, and from his esteemed colleague at the Gregorianum, Cardinal L. Billot.[51] In 1929 Spanish Jesuit M. Alonso, wanting to reiterate a defense of Billot and the doctrine of Trent, issued a trenchant attack against de la Taille's theory in *El sacrificio eucaristico de la Ultima Cena del Señor según el Concilio Tridentino.*[52] *In nuce,* the heart of the disagreement revolves upon the question of a numerical distinction between the sacrifice of the supper and the cross, and then upon the consequent configuring of the relationship between the Mass and the sacrifice of the cross. De la Taille's critics hold to a dual understanding of the sacrificial offering in the supper and Christ's death on the cross, a position that de la Taille assesses as highly problematic and a "mainly post-mediaeval" assumption. The fathers and the liturgies say nothing of a "dual sacrificial action" between the supper and the cross. The dualist position is a false inference "*based on the numerical distinction, which on the admission of all must exist between the sacrificial activities repeated by the Church and the sacrificial action whereby Christ redeemed the world.*"[53] The crux of the difference between our author and his adversaries may be captured in this question: where does one place numerical distinctness? Are there three sacrifices (supper, cross, and Mass—each with oblation and immolation), or are there but two

50. McNabb, "A New Theory of the Eucharistic Sacrifice," 1095.

51. For an intricate treatment of the defining differences in thought between Billot and de la Taille, see Julio Jimenez Berguecio, S.J., "A proposito de la controversia entre Billot y de la Taille sobre un texto Tridentino," *Archivum Historicum Societatis Jesu* 49 (1980): 219–41.

52. Scholarly assessment of Alonso's work is not laudatory; he frequently and egregiously misinterprets de la Taille, accusing him variously of denying the doctrine of real presence and of taking his teaching from such thinkers as Renz and Wieland (whom de la Taille soundly critiques in *Mysterium Fidei*), and of encouraging the faithful to "forget the letter" of the church's teaching on sacrifice; cf. Jimenez Berguecio, "En el Cincuentario del *Mysterium Fidei,*" 258–59, 273n182; Jimenez Berguecio, "A proposito de la controversia," 220n3; Emile Jamoulle, "L'unité sacrificielle de la cène, la croix et l'autel au Concile de Trente," *Ephermerides theologicae Lovanienses* 22 (1946): 61–62. De la Taille, in a lengthy *Gregorianum* article, "A propos d'un livre sur la Cène" 11 (1930): 194–263, responds to Alonso's sustained attack. I find this article poignant: it betrays a certain weariness in de la Taille with the unjust and ongoing misinterpretations of his theory of eucharistic sacrifice. At a time when his health was already beginning to fail, it seems as if de la Taille is both at pains to "clear" his name and to finally move beyond the defensive position in which he finds himself locked; see especially 260–63.

53. *MF* 1:106.

(supper-cross and the Mass)? De la Taille argues for the latter, and we shall now investigate how he constructs a case that the oneness of the supper and the cross is at least *implied* in the official text of Session 22, and even quite explicitly discerned in the well-documented controversies among the bishops and theologians gathered for the Council (collected in the *Acta genuina Concilii Tridentini*).[54]

Simply put, the Council does not *explicitly* declare a sacrificial unity between the supper and the cross; in fact, it is difficult to fault an interpretation that reads the sticky "although … nevertheless" wording in chapter 1 (Session 22) as suggesting two distinct sacrifices.[55] Here is the key phrase upon which the debate centers:

> Although (*etsi*) [Christ] by his death was to offer himself once to God the Father on the altar of the cross, in order to redeem us there.… Nevertheless (*tamen*) in the last supper … declaring that he was a priest forever according to the order of Melchisedech, he offered his body and blood to God the Father under the appearance of bread and wine.[56]

Does the language of the Council envision two "true, proper, and complete sacrifices" (as McNabb defends)? The *Acta* reveals that there was a large contingent at the Council who viewed the supper as a sacrifice "before" that of the cross, most of whom thereby believed it better *not* to declare anything specific about the sacrifice of the supper, given the context of responding to the reformers. De la Taille's tactic in dealing with the Tridentine declaration is twofold: first, he shows that the teaching of the *oneness* of the sacrifice of Christ proves more crucial in the final shaping and framing of the Decree—even if it does not appear openly; and secondly, he argues inversely from what *is* expressly said about the Mass (chapter 2, Session 22) to what must logically be concluded about the supper.

De la Taille grants a "common" dualist supposition among the Tridentine fathers, especially early in their debates; but precisely because

54. Augustin Theiner, *Acta genuina Concilii Tridentini* (Zagrabiae: Typis et sumptibus Societatis bibliophiae, 1874), 79ff. De la Taille also cites from *Historia Concilii Tridentini,* Pietro Sforza Cardinale Pallavicini (1690), 1:18, cc. 2 and 9.

55. A most impressively thorough treatment of the Council debates on this question can be read in Jamoulle's "L'Unité sacrificielle de la cène," 50–61.

56. Council of Trent, Session 22, c. 1; *MF* 1:159n12.

of this situation, it became the task of those who upheld the oneness of the sacrifice to more fervently defend it (as de la Taille's documentation convincingly attests).[57] He avers that those who *opposed* the more popular dualist notion ultimately had the greater hand in the final wording of the decree, and that their thought is more "akin" to that final definition.[58] This is not indubitable logic—that is, the proposal that a minority opinion, which effects change to an original draft, has the ultimate hermeneutical clout. However, neither is such a dynamic improbable.

The question remains whether or not de la Taille is justified in arguing that the tenor of the "although … nevertheless" phrase need *not* be read as setting up numerical opposition between the supper and the cross. De la Taille contends that the sentence could be read in the following way: although Christ could have enacted the sacrifice of the cross without the supper—perhaps by some other rite—he nevertheless desired that through the supper the cross "should be Melchisedechian." To further shore up this interpretation, de la Taille recalls the "scope" of the Council: it was not an attempt at constructive theology, but fundamentally a response to Protestant "error." Thus the passage in question can be understood quite likely as saying that "although the cross is a most true sacrifice (this we all believe), *nevertheless* we must believe that Christ, as priest according to the order of Melchisedech, willed that the supper should be also a sacrifice."[59] If the final text of Session 22 does not openly declare the unicity of the supper-cross sacrifice, neither does it require a two-sacrifice understanding.

Secondly, de la Taille argues that the Council undoubtedly asserted a unity—even a *sameness*—between the Mass and the cross ("for the victim is one and the same, the same now offering by the ministry of the priests, who once offered himself in the cross, the manner of offer-

57. *MF* 1:155–56. Perhaps the most fiery—and indeed *ad hominem*—critique of de la Taille's reading of Trent can be found in M.D. Forrest's *The Clean Oblation* (St Paul: Radio Replies Press, 1945). Forrest essentially argues that de la Taille sees "unicism" in the Council fathers where, in fact, a dualist position is being declared (74–103). De la Taille, he insists, slants the evidence in his favor. On the other hand, Jamoulle's careful study, "L'Unité," demonstrates that the majority of Council fathers were actually inclined to de la Taille's unicist position, even though the language employed is not identical (49ff).

58. *MF* 1:155.

59. *MF* 1:159–60n12.

ing alone being different").[60] To be in accord with the Council on this teaching about the Mass is to admit that Christ offered himself as victim to be immolated *at the supper.* The difference between the Mass and the cross, given that the victim is identical, is linked only to the modality of offering. Thus, "arguing from the Mass back to the supper," we can conclude that if in the Mass the faithful "offer the death as having happened, [Christ] must have offered his death as impending" at the supper: we "cannot teach the one in the Mass without concluding to the other in the supper."[61]

Does de la Taille have his opponents here? Even though NcNabb and Swaby agree that the Mass and the cross are "substantially" the same sacrifice, they are not asserting the kind of numerical oneness between the Mass and the cross that de la Taille thinks to obtain between the supper and the cross. The question remains whether de la Taille's unicist position or that of his adversaries is more logically convincing in forging a connection between the Mass and the cross. That is a matter to which we shall return in the next chapter. In sum, looking *only* at the language of the Council declaration itself, it seems that de la Taille cannot persuade fully about the sacrificial unicity of the supper-cross. But in fact de la Taille does not seek definitive support—only a possible line for his own interpretation. The wording of chapter 1 of Session 22 does not *confirm* absolutely the unicity of the supper and the cross. Taking into account the historical records of the Council and the strongly decisive minority voice, and factoring in the doctrinal connections affirmed about the Mass at Trent, de la Taille finds good "*probable*" support for his thesis in the Council's statement, which is all that he ever claims to find therein.

We can close this section by analyzing more precisely the nature of

60. "Una enim eademque est hostia, idem nunc offerens sacerdotum ministerio, qui se ipsum tunc cruce obtulit, sola offerendi ratione diversa"; Session 22, c. 2.

61. *MF* 1:158. De la Taille would have us recall that the Council wished not only to refute Luther's conclusion that the Mass is not a sacrifice, but also to disengage the premises of that conclusion, namely that Christ did not offer a sacrifice in the supper. For, if we understand the Protestant argument in terms of a syllogism, it would proceed in the following way: "In the mass we do what Christ did at the supper; Christ did not sacrifice at the supper, therefore neither do we offer sacrifice in the mass"; De la Taille, "Coena et Passio in theologia apologetica contra pseudo-reformatores," *Gregorianum* 9 (1928): 180.

the sacrificial unity between the supper and cross, and by noting a singular consequence of that conjoining, *viz.*, the striking sacramental realism to which the doctrine gives rise. The nature of the union between the supper and the cross is spelled out with care. De la Taille insists that the supper not be construed as a "*petite*" or preliminary or subordinate sacrifice to the bloody sacrifice on the cross; rather, the supper is "co-ordinated and co-numerated" with the cross. As noted in the previous chapter, the relationship between oblation and immolation in sacrifice is integral, like that of soul and body; there exists a union of constitutive parts. It is this very notion and analogy of unity that elicited the vehement opposition of Vincent McNabb, leading to his denunciation of de la Taille's thought as emptying the cross of meaning. He protests that if we see the Last Supper as the formal element of the sacrifice and passion and death as the "material element," then we cannot also say that they are the *same* sacrifice—any more than one could say that "the soul is the body," or that "the body is the soul," or that "the body is the man," or that "the soul is the man." With such a parsing of de la Taille's analogy, the cross becomes a mere "part" of the sacrifice of redemption, which, McNabb concludes, directly opposes the church's belief about "the redemptive sacrifice of Calvary."[62]

De la Taille's thought on the supper-cross unity is a good deal more subtle than McNabb portrays. We can make three clarifying points. First, de la Taille specifies that this unity between the eucharistic oblation and the bloody immolation need not be—and *is not*—a unity *in genere rei.* However, it is a unity "*in genere signi*—for it is *oneness as sacrifice;* and sacrifice as such is a sign, an actually existing sign of invisible and internal dedication."[63] Put differently, de la Taille does not argue that "x" is "y," that the supper is the cross; he purports that the supper and the cross are one as parts of a single signifying act. Against the dualist position, de la Taille engages an argument from the ontology of a sacrament or a sign. Because unity is derived from being, the unity

62. McNabb, "A New Theory of Eucharistic Sacrifice," 1094–95.

63. *MF* 1:137 (emphasis mine). "Unitas illa ex oblatione eucharista et immolatione cruenta, non est, neque oportet ut sit unitas in genere rei; sed profecto est unitas in genere signi; siquidem est unitas in genere sacrificii, et sacrificium, ut tale, inter signi recensetur: signum existens invisibilis internaeque dedicationis"; *MF,* 102.

of a sacrament belongs naturally to its signifying components. In the case of sacrifice, belonging by definition to the category of signs, every sacrifice seeks its unity in the reciprocal and composite signifying elements. From these premises, one may conclude the following:

> If the supper and the cross intrinsically and indissolubly concur in signifying the donation of Jesus as Victim to the Father for the salvation of the world, then the supper and the cross are a single sacrifice—even though sacrifice is found in the supper—thanks to the signifying influx from the cross, and sacrifice is found in the cross, thanks to the signification already established in the supper.[64]

To better explicate what is intended by this *in genere signi,* de la Taille suggests an analogy to the unity between the form of the consecration and the eucharistic species: they are not one *in genere rei,* but they are indivisible *in genere sacramenti* or *signi.* In the sacrament of the Eucharist, the form is "identical with the matter, and surely one sacrament with it."[65]

De la Taille wisely raises two caveats about the analogies he has offered. First, he distinguishes that the unity of form and matter cannot be transferred so absolutely from physical things/substances (e.g., body and soul) to that of sacraments and sacrifices. Secondly, and this is crucial to getting at the heart of de la Taille's concept of the sacrificial unity, he limits the analogy to sacramental form and matter in a further way: the unity of the sacrifice is "*multo strictior*" than that of the eucharistic sacrament. In the sacrament, the words of consecration, which determine the bread and wine as significative of the presence of Christ, are transient. By contrast, in the Christ's sacrifice the supper oblation not only determines the passion to be *sacrificial,* but as an oblation begun in the rite it *continues* throughout the passion, up until the death of the Lord:

> [I]n the sacrifice of Christ, the whole passion up to the death is determined to the *sacrificial essence* by the eucharistic offering of Christ, and having received this formal determination, it actually is, and is called, the sacrifice of the redemption, going on uninterruptedly in the process of completion (*fieri*), until with the occurrence of death it is complete (in *facto esse*).[66]

64. De la Taille, "A propos d'un livre sur la Cène," 196n1.

65. See de la Taille's direct response to McNabb in *The Mystery of Faith and Human Opinion,* 239–40n1.

66. *MF* 1:138; *MF,* 102. "In sacrificio Christi passio tota, ad mortem usque, determinatur *ad esse sacrificale* per oblationem eucharisticam Christi, unde, accepta ratione formali, habet ut sit

This statement about the continuity of the supper oblation cannot be overlooked. If taken seriously, de la Taille is invulnerable to the accusation that he denies any sense of offering upon the "altar of the cross" (which would, as he himself admits, be contrary to the mind of Trent).[67] Put most plainly, the formal and determining element of oblation, while *clearly evident* in the ritual action of Christ at the supper, does not *cease* with the end of the eucharistic meal. On the contrary, the offering of the gift, the pledge of the victim, is "kept up" by a perseverance of the will of Christ, "revealed in so many acts and words" until his death on the cross.[68]

More can be said to obviate the *evacuatio crucis* allegation. De la Taille invokes philosophical and scholastic reasoning to demonstrate that his position does not demean the cross. In order to show that the "material element" of the sacrifice, the cross, gives the sacrifice its "absolute substantial reality," he appeals to a philosophy of actual existing material things, which tends to more "justly" and "properly" attribute actual substance to the material element, "assuming that it is endowed with form." Two further examples are marshaled to exonerate his theory, one concerned with Thomistic "rational psychology" and the other with moral order. According to Thomas, choice is formally in the reason, but materially and substantially in the will. Presupposing the will to be directed by reason, we do not hesitate to say that choice is located where it is materially. Analogously, de la Taille suggests that we may say of the sacrifice of Christ that it substantially *is* where it is materially, namely on the cross, notwithstanding the determining aspect of the supper. So, too, in the moral order. The work of the sacrifice will appear to be more "luminous" and "heroic" on the cross than in the offering "under a symbol." The "moral value" of the ritual oblation at the supper is secured, as it were, by the suffering on the cross.[69] If somewhat

et dicatur sacrificium ipsum redemptionis, in quodam continuo *fieri* decurrens, usquedam, intercedente morte, consistat in *facto esse*."

67. Cf. McNabb, "A New Theory of Eucharistic Sacrifice," 1099; Swaby, "A New Theory," 467; Forrest, *The Clean Oblation,* 78ff; and de la Taille, *Mystery of Faith and Human Opinion,* 257.

68. *MF* 1:138–39.

69. *MF* 1:141–42. Yet, even while admitting this point, de la Taille again stresses that the supper is of great moral significance: for it is there that the obligation to hand himself over to God for the salvation of all was *willingly* assumed; see *MF* 1:143n14.

strained, these examples do allay suspicion that de la Taille's theory detracts from the sacrifice of the cross. We bring this discussion to a close by underscoring that de la Taille intends the supper-cross sacrifice to be conceived fully as a *union;* the juxtaposition and moral weighing of one action against the other is, *ipso facto,* artificial and beside the point.

To summarize what has been argued thus far in this chapter, de la Taille exposes that the very nature of sacrifice entails the strict unity of supper and cross. This unity is not only depicted in scripture and the tradition, but it is also (at least) permitted in the Tridentine teaching about sacrifice. In fact, we have seen that de la Taille finds ample support for his position among the Council fathers, even if the final wording of Session 22 remains ambiguous. Two neat consequences obtain in construing the sacrificial unicity between supper and cross, consequences worthy of further elaboration. First, the sacrificial dynamic of gift-offering seen in the supper-cross surfaces a robust sacramental realism and doctrine of real presence (though de la Taille confesses not to be concerned with proving real presence). Secondly, in his theory we discover a remarkable vision of the supper-oblation as trinitarian.

Sacramental Realism and Oblation in the Eternal Spirit

If in the supper Christ's death is truly offered in sacrifice, the presence of his body and blood *must* be postulated, that is to say, the ritual offering of Christ cannot be merely a kind of "prophetic adumbration" of an offering *yet to be made,* a "parable" of the approaching death, or a figural "anticipation" of messianic joy.[70] For sacrifice, recall, includes both *sign* and *reality.* As sign it indicates interior consecration, but it likewise must include the actual handing-over of a gift to God. If Christ held only bread and wine in his hands, there would have been "no sacrifice of his death; the flesh and blood of the victim to be immolated would not have been offered," or at most, it would have been "*offered in figure.*"[71] Accordingly, there would be no "sacramental im-

70. *MF* 1:151. De la Taille addresses and fully refutes these propositions (attributed to Adolph Jülicher and Spitta, respectively) in book 2 of *Mysterium Fidei* (6–7).

71. *MF* 1:150. De la Taille clarifies that this would be a figural sacrifice of the "ancient" sort: bread and wine "sacrificed" as a type to the cross. But Christ's sacrifice, fulfilling every sacrifice, could only be an offering of himself as *res*.

molation" at the supper and no victim offered unless the "symbol or sacrament contains the true body and blood."[72] Likewise, no new covenant is made in the cenacle unless the chalice is the cup of blood. In a word, de la Taille's argument for the sacrificial reality of the supper necessarily includes the teaching of real presence; Christ's *dicta* must be efficacious in reference to the bread and wine. Does it not follow from this that the disciples would have received the flesh of the victim *yet* to be immolated in blood? How is this to be conceived? De la Taille here invokes the *modus oblationis* as the decisively operative theological principle:

> [T]he Lord could have given himself in the banquet previous to the immolation in blood for this reason: that the victim once constituted under the symbols of immolation, not only was destined for immolation, but was then made apt to be received as food and drink. The *very nature of the offering,* therefore, made possible for the banquet to anticipate the immolation. (Hoc est, quia is fuit modus oblationis, ut hostia, sub symbolis immolationis semel constituta, non solum in immolationem destinaretur, sed jam aptatur ad comestionem et potationem. *Ex genere igitur oblationis* factum est ut convivium posset anticipare immolationem.)[73]

Hence, the reality of the act of oblation, absolutely central to de la Taille's concept of sacrifice, concludes to the disciples having partaken of the victim of the sacrificial banquet—even prior to Christ's death on the cross. As we shall see vividly when examining de la Taille's concept of the ecclesial sacrifice, much depends on this *modus oblationis*. It is the bearer of sacramental reality and it is the act that unites events of different temporalities.

But to this phenomenology of oblation we must add the gift-dynamic of sacrifice, specifically as it would apply to Christ's offering at the supper, both as man and God. While divine acceptance of the victim was not made manifest until the resurrection, de la Taille argues that the Father's acceptance was, in some sense, assured at the supper—"invisibly indeed but nevertheless infallibly."[74] This "secured" acceptance derives from the fact that Christ, "being God," offered himself through the Spirit (by that same power that the church would later invoke in her own eucharistic oblation): "*The blood of Christ, who by the eternal Spirit*

72. *MF* 1:151.
73. *MF* 1:81; *MF,* 57 (emphasis mine).
74. *MF* 1:201.

offered himself unspotted to God, shall cleanse etc." (Hebrews 9:14). God was "of obligation," in the "bond of moral union" implicated by sacrifice, to take up into glory the flesh offered by the Son in the eternal Spirit.[75] In short, the sacrifice of the supper was already ratified by divine acceptance, so that, even if the flesh of Christ was not yet glorified by the resurrection, it was nevertheless that accepted and ratified victim that was "returned" in the banquet, and that he and his disciples ate and drank.[76] Put somewhat differently, in Jesus's oblation both as human being and God, all three mysteries converged: supper, death, and resurrection.[77] In virtue of the obligating dynamic established in sacrifice and engaged by the divine persons, de la Taille theologically asserts that "even at the supper, the Eucharist could signify the fruit of the death and resurrection and *hence cause it.*"[78] This is a profound contribution to a trinitarian understanding of Christ's sacrifice, one that raises theological consciousness about the presence and power of the entire Godhead at the ritual offering in the upper room.

De la Taille's unique sacramental realism emerges from his concept of sacrifice. If his understanding of the reality of sacrificial oblation at the supper has been labeled "confused" (a confusion of the sacramental and the real/natural, as Vonier and others repeating Vonier would have it),[79] that so-called confusion appears only (and especially) if the dynamic of oblation-immolation and the concomitant unicity of the supper-cross sacrifice have been denied *a priori*. Quite apart from empha-

75. *MF* 2:181.

76. De la Taille rather persuasively demonstrates, largely from the "perfection of sacrifice" and from tradition, that Christ partook of the banquet with the disciples; see *MF* 1:165–80. We shall address this in chapter 5.

77. In Benedict XVI's Apostolic Exhortation *Sacramentum caritatis,* we hear something surprisingly similar: "In instituting the sacrament of the Eucharist, Jesus anticipates and makes present the sacrifice of the Cross and the victory of the resurrection" (§10).

78. "Et vi illius vincula moralis, poterat jam eucharistia in coena significare fructus mortis et resurrectionis, proindeque et *causare*"; *MF,* 291; *MF* 2:182; emphasis mine.

79. This designation of de la Taille's position as "confused" actually comes from Michael McGuckian, S.J., *The Holy Sacrifice of the Mass,* 100, although the tenor of Vonier's writing is strikingly similar. Vonier's complaint is that in treating the supper or the Mass, one cannot invoke anything suggestive of a natural or real sacrifice, for the Mass and supper are both thoroughly sacramental—belonging to "another order" entirely; Vonier, *A Key to the Doctrine of the Eucharist,* 87–91, *passim*; cf. Raymond Moloney, S.J., *The Eucharist* (Collegeville, Minn.: The Liturgical Press, 1995), 208–9.

sizing the will and desire of Christ operative in sacrifice—which, as we shall show later, configures our own participation in that sacrifice—the oblation of the passion at the supper, and the truth of the gift there offered, proves instrumental to making theological sense of the ecclesial Eucharist as sacrifice. Before turning to that topic, we need yet to delineate de la Taille's concept of the *sacrificium coeleste*. The "heavenly sacrifice" is a corroborating thesis of oblation and acceptance, and is perhaps the second-most-controversial and misconstrued aspect of de la Taille's eucharistic theology. A correct interpretation of Christ as eternal and celestial victim critically marks the sacrificial nature of the Mass.

The Eternal and Celestial Sacrifice: "Hostia Illa Perpetua Est" (4 Sent. 12, *In Lit.*)

> He never ceases to offer himself for us
> But defends us and ever pleads our cause before you:
> He is the sacrificial Victim who dies no more,
> The Lamb, once slain, who lives forever.
>
> *Preface III of Easter*

The notion of an eternal sacrifice and victim is the second pillar to de la Taille's theory of eucharistic sacrifice, and one about which theological debate circled. Again, only by a disciplined attention to the defining elements of sacrifice does the proper understanding of de la Taille's "eternal sacrifice" emerge. The central question can be posed thusly: with death on the cross, does the sacrifice of Christ thereby reach an end? De la Taille answers that, indeed, in terms of oblation and immolation, nothing more could be added, no further act on the part of priest or victim is needed. However, recall that sacrifice, by definition, is perfected by its acceptance. From the early fathers of the church, de la Taille recaptures the *poesis* in sacrifice: God's acceptance of the gift of Christ, exhibited in the resurrection and ascension, *consummates* the offering and immolation of the victim with a glory that endures eternally. God, as it were, "crowns" the "work of man" by this perfecting acceptance.[80] To demonstrate the *sacrificium coeleste,* de la Taille carefully navigates through scriptural and patristic sources, showing this teaching to be

80. *MF* 1:183.

embedded in notions of Christ as "eternal victim," "eternal altar," and "eternal intercessor." Equally important, he stipulates how this "heavenly sacrifice" must be conceived in order to avoid suggestion of a new and different sacrifice, other than the one made "once for all" at the supper-cross. (De la Taille remains loyal to the inspiration of his theology—the Epistle to the Hebrews.) On this question, he is particularly at pains to distinguish his own position from that of the German and French School oblationists. Let us first go right to the heart of the matter and spell out what our author means by the "eternity of the sacrifice."

De la Taille is quick to offer two clarifying principles about his doctrine of an eternal celestial sacrifice: the "sacrifice" cannot be considered in an *active* sense; nor, on the other hand, is the "celestial sacrifice and victim" simply metaphor or sign. To substantiate both assertions requires forefronting the genus of sacrifice. If oblation and immolation (when it occurs) constitute the two external acts of sacrificing, then once these acts are accomplished, the sacrifice may be said to be at an end. Yet, considering the matter from the aspect of the victim and its acceptance, that closure expands. True enough, when the acts of oblation and immolation are completed, the "victimal condition" perdures only as long as the victim remains incorrupt. With Christ, however, resurrection and ascension intervene; the flesh of victim becomes "inviolate" and utterly sanctified, living eternally in glory. "Must we then say that there is no sacrifice in heaven?" de la Taille asks.[81] To be sure, there is no sacrifice of the risen Christ in an *active* sense, nothing repeated or in a state of coming to completion (*in fieri*). Instead, the sacrifice "continues (*perseverat*)" as the "passive sacrifice," that is, in the state "of which it has been the purpose of the sacred rite to bring the victim." The victim "perdures (*durat*)" in the state of being (*esse*) as "accepted victim."[82] De la Taille's "passive sacrifice" reiterates that sacrifice is *donum:*

> Christ is in heaven, in the quality of gift, offered once, accepted and kept by God for ever. This is what is meant by designating Christ as eternal victim, or celestial sacrifice.[83]

81. De la Taille, *The Mystery of Faith and Human Opinion,* 70.
82. *MF* 1:202; *MF,* 143.
83. De la Taille, *The Mystery of Faith and Human Opinion,* 70–71.

When de la Taille speaks in terms of "celestial sacrifice" and "eternal victim," he indicates that the victim offered at the supper and immolated on the cross remains as gift in the Father's presence, eternally exhibiting himself in his humanity that suffered for the sins of the world.

This "passive" sacrifice, however, cannot be reduced to a mere metaphor or sign. De la Taille is adamant to curb any temptation to rank the celestial sacrifice as a metaphor, and here again we have a glimpse of his constant and careful negotiation between the external and internal dimensions of sacrifice. The passive sacrifice in heaven is not to be understood as some continuing internal devotion of Christ (*"quasi denominet affectum Christi internum duntaxat"*). Rather, the celestial sacrifice *is* sacrifice "in a strict sense," "denominating" some external condition (*proprietatem externam*) in the humanity of Christ, specifically, the glory obtained in the sacrifice that was eternally ratified by God.[84] If not metaphor, neither is the celestial sacrifice a *sign*—a clarification that might seem odd, given de la Taille's frequent reminder that sacrifice belongs to the nature of a sign. That the celestial sacrifice is no longer a sign derives both from the fact that in Christ's sacrifice there is a closure between sign and signified—"*in quo signum aequaret rem*"—and also from the belief that in heaven all is "resplendent truth" (there is no longer need for figure or veil). Can one say, then, that the celestial sacrifice signifies the *devotio* of the sacrificer? Well, the celestial sacrifice does signify Christ's love, but in a way that collapses the distinction between sign and signified. In Christ's sacrifice, the offerer and the gift have become the same: the Priest offers himself as victim.[85] Christ is the "sacrament" of himself in the earthly sacrifice; in the celestial sacrifice there is pure transparency. This closure between sign and signified is far from trivial, for from it "flows the efficacy of that sacrifice to sanctify us" through the church's sacraments. The ecclesial signs are neither "vain" nor "empty," only because they signify that full sacrifice that remains eternally held as gift and thereby eternally sanctifying of those now participating in it.[86] Therefore, de la Taille's "passive sacrifice" is neither a metaphor nor

84. *MF* 1:202; *MF,* 143.

85. *MF* 1:202; *MF,* 143. "Hence his was a full (*plenum*) sacrifice in which the sign was equated with the thing signified (*in quo signum aequaret rem*)."

86. *MF* 1:203.

a sign pointing to some other reality; rather it is the fulfillment of the signifying potency of sacrifice.

But how does de la Taille claim support for his thesis from scripture and tradition? His approach is to argue that what is taught in "sacred writings" about Christ as eternal victim, eternal altar, and eternal priest indirectly lends credence to the notion of a celestial sacrifice. Again, from a wealth of material I shall select a few central witnesses, those that reveal most sharply the theological and spiritual depth of de la Taille's thought on the perpetual heavenly sacrifice.

De la Taille calls attention, first and foremost, to the rich patristic vision of Christ's resurrection and ascension as constituting the eternal ratification of his sacrifice. The sacrificial dynamic of offering/immolation/acceptance is vividly preached among the fathers, most pronounced in their penchant for seeing the resurrection and ascension as the *integral third element,* or fulfillment, of the paschal sacrifice. Citing a number of patristic and medieval witnesses, resurrection and ascension are portrayed variously: as the "perfection of immolational dignity"; as the consummate sanctification of the victim; as the final purification of the gift; as the divinization of the human condition of the victim, transferred into the hands of God; as the gift transformed and "beautified by the light of eternal glory"; and as the ratification of the efficacy of Christ's priesthood.[87] Perhaps Augustine can be allowed to speak for the many witnesses that de la Taille brings forward. In a single phrase Augustine captures the sacrificial completion in the resurrection: "This [self-oblation] then is the evening sacrifice, the passion of the Lord, the cross of the Lord, the offering of the saving victim, the holocaust accepted by God. *In the resurrection, he made this evening sacrifice a morning gift.*"[88] It is a gift, we should add, of that eschatological morning that has no end, a gift transformed by eternal glory.

De la Taille likewise rehearses how the fathers would interweave images from Hebrew sacrifices to indicate the perfection of Christ's sacrifice in the resurrection and ascension. The resurrection was frequently portrayed as the descent of God upon the victim, a holocaust

87. *MF* 1:185–96.
88. Augustine, *In Psalm* 140.5; *MF* 1:191.

fire signifying God's communion *ad sacrificium Christi.* On the other hand, the ascension was seen as the raising up of the victim to God—or the sweet odor of the holocaust smoke taking flight for heaven.[89] Divine acceptance is found in either case. In the tradition of patristic thought, de la Taille shows that resurrection and ascension confer on the sacrifice an "excellence" beyond other sacrifices and an excellence that is as eternal as the victim's existence in God's presence.

Concomitant to this understanding of eternal divine acceptance, and flowing quite naturally from it, both scripture and the fathers give expression to doctrines of Christ as eternal victim, altar, and intercessor. Not surprisingly, de la Taille interprets the Hebrews passage (9:1–24) about Christ's entrance into the "inner sanctuary" as depicting the sanctification of his flesh "by celestial glory."[90] In other words, the Epistle to the Hebrews presents us with a belief that Christ, having made his sacrifice once only "at the end of ages," nonetheless remains an "eternal gift," an oblation always *coram Deo.* De la Taille insists repeatedly that the gift offered by Christ in sacrifice is never retracted; nor is acceptance by God limited or conditional.[91] The liturgical passages sprinkled throughout the book of Revelation (see 5:2, 5:6, 5:12; 8:3–5; 9:13, 9:15) are also brought forward as suggestive of some kind of heavenly, continuing worship. Still, de la Taille stipulates that this worship consists of Christ's "presentation" of himself to the Father as one "once slain" but abiding forever "unto the praise of God and the glory of the saints."[92] This subtle question of the nature of Christ's heavenly "liturgy" and the cleverly negotiated distinction between "presentation (*exhibitio*)" and oblation will be taken up again at the close of this chapter.

In addressing Christ as eternal altar ("We have an altar whereof they have no power to eat who serve the tabernacle" [Heb. 13:10]), de la Taille exposes the traditional notion of Christ being the altar of his

89. *MF* 1:194–200.

90. *MF* 1:184; cf. the interesting note (n. 1), where de la Taille advocates an exposition of Hebrews 8:5 which understands that the slaying did not take place in the holy of holies, but it was there that the sacrificial blood was offered.

91. *MF* 1:209.

92. *MF* 1:185.

own sacrifice. Specifically, Christ's body, sacramentally "splashed with blood" in the chalice of the supper and then really so upon the cross, *is* the altar. Hesychius, in his commentaries on Leviticus, expresses this teaching in robust language:

> He shed his intelligible blood … on the altar, that is to say, on his own body.… For Christ himself, by the sprinkling of his own blood offered his passion for us unto our salvation.… For Christ was made the whole of his sacrifice—priest, sacrifice, and altar. He is himself the *man made ready* (Lev. 16:21), made ready for the passion for us.[93]

Recalling that the altar in ancient sacrifices represented the place of divine dwelling and the *locus* of sanctification for the gift, de la Taille also argues that the altar and victim must therefore be the same in Christ's sacrifice: only Christ himself could sanctify himself, for only in the body of Christ did God dwell in an "absolutely physical and substantial way."[94]

Yet these suggestions that Christ was the altar of his sacrifice do not necessarily compute to an eternal celestial altar. De la Taille moves forward in his argument to present a substantial sampling of commentaries upon the eternal "golden altar" of Revelation 6:9, commentaries that interpret the symbol as referring to the celestial victim, and in particular to the humanity of Christ.[95] Moreover, he highlights the traditional liturgical perception of the church's liturgy as directed to, even *celebrated upon,* a celestial altar. If, in ancient sacrifices, a gift needed to be offered through an altar, Christ approached God through himself and now remains as the altar through which the faithful offer sacrifice. Irenaeus's well-known passage from *Adversus haereses* articulates pointedly this liturgical and Christological teaching: "The Word of God desires that we too should offer a gift *at the altar* frequently and without intermission. *The altar therefore is in heaven for thither our prayers*

93. Hesychius, *In Levit*. 1.2 and 5, PG 93, cc. 883, 885, 1001; *MF* 1:219.

94. *MF* 1:220. De la Taille draws upon the following Aristotelean principle: "what produces any perfection in another, has more perfection in itself than that which it produces on the other"; *MF* 1:215. Cf. also Matthew 23:19: "Ye blind, for whether is greater, the gift, or the altar that sanctifieth the gift?"

95. Perhaps the most interesting of these examples, from the *Glossia Ordinaria* in Apoc. 6.9, 8.3, claims that Christ, according to his humanity, is both his own "golden altar" and the "altar of trinity"; *MF* 1:221n12.

and offerings are directed."[96] Interestingly, the fathers cited by de la Taille all refer to this heavenly altar as the *humanity* of Christ, an association I would argue that stresses the image of Christ as victim, whose humanity is present eternally (in passive propitiation) before the Father.[97] Not coincidentally, this accent upon the humanity of Christ is likewise central in de la Taille's theology of grace.

Patristic and medieval thought on the perpetual intercession and mediation of Christ corroborates what de la Taille wants to say about the celestial sacrifice. That the heavenly Christ offers prayers and supplications and petitions before the Father is a teaching intimately related to his condition as eternal victim. That is, the role of Christ as our advocate indicates his eternal presence "ante conspectum Dei, in carne quam ex nobis assumptam obtulit pro nobis."[98] According to de la Taille, Gregory Nazianzen is the "great champion" of this interpretation: in Christ's heavenly intercession and advocacy for us, there is no sense of "humiliation," no prostration at the Father's feet. Rather, "as Word and counsellor of the Father, [Christ] persuades him to bear with me, because of all that as man he suffered. This, I think, is what advocacy means here."[99] Gregory the Great puts this even more pointedly, articulating that the prayer of Christ before the Father is his assumed human nature, an intercession less by word than by mercy.

> In this way he speaks to the Father for us, that he presents himself to the Father in our likeness. His words, his petition consists precisely in this: he presents himself to the Father as man for mankind. Because interceding for sinners, he presents himself as the just man who merits indulgence for others.[100]

It seems important for de la Taille that the celestial intercession be seen in terms of Christ's eternal victimhood, for it is through that condition that the Son continues to make his latreutic and propitiatory will known.[101]

96. *Adversus haereses,* I, 4, 18.6; *MF* 1:222.

97. Cf. a passage from Gregory the Great (*Moralia* I, 24.32) in which he envisions Christ as unceasingly presenting "incarnation" to the Father. De la Taille draws attention as well as to some medieval witnesses in St. Bruno of Segni and Gerhoh of Reichersberg; see *MF* 1:206, 226.

98. *MF,* 167.

99. Gregory of Nazianzus, *Or.* 30n14; *MF* 1:236.

100. Gregory the Great, *Moral.* l.22, 17n43; *MF* 1:237.

101. De la Taille draws upon two sermons of Thomas, *In Hebr.* 7, lect. 4, and *In Rom.* 8, lect. 7,

However, Christ does this not as "a suppliant," but as the Son, "using the power of God as his own power."[102] With Hebrews 5:6–10 in mind, de la Taille frames this from another angle: while in the flesh, Christ offered prayers and supplications; now, in lieu of "prayer," there is the blessing of "the pontiff": namely, the eternal Sacrifice sends the Holy Spirit.[103] More impressive still, and in words harmonious with de la Taille's thought on grace (to be explored ahead in chapter 4), Nicholas Cabasilas construes Christ's continuing mediation in terms of an *act of union:*

> *For having once been our mediator* … he did not withdraw, rather he is ever interceding, *not by some form of words and prayers*, as ambassadors do, *but by an act. What is this act?* He unites himself to us, and through himself imparts to us his own graces.[104]

Christ's heavenly intercession and supplication thus assume the form of a divine sending of himself, his Spirit and grace, so that he might unite the needy human believer to himself and the Father. This eternal intercession rests upon the reality of Christ having entered the heavenly sanctuary with his own blood, as victim and priest. By the efficacy of his priesthood and gift, he has forever gained access to God for believers.

Greater precision is still called for in exposing de la Taille's thought on the "passive" heavenly sacrifice of Christ, largely because this notion is, I think, at the root of controversy about the nature of Christ's activity in the earthly, ecclesial sacrifice.[105] What one determines about

in which Thomas acknowledges that the heavenly Christ intercedes as victim by continuing to make manifest "the *desire* of his most holy soul for our salvation"; *MF* 1:238–39, emphasis mine.

102. *MF* 1:240. De la Taille notes that this is the "principal distinction" between the intercession of Mary and Christ: Christ intercedes as one of the Godhead; Mary is rightly called "omnipotentia *supplex*"; see 240n5.

103. *MF* 1:241. "Clamor scilicet nostrae hostiae exauditus est a Deo, penetrans coelos, ubi consummatus Christus non incumbit reconciliationi quasi adipiscendae, sed inventam nobis impertit, *factus obtemperantibus sibi causa salutis aeternae*. Pro precibus enim quas litans olim noster sacerdos obtulit Deo, superest jam pontificis benedictio, missio scilicet Spiritus Sancti"; *Hebr.* 5.6–10; *MF,* 170–71.

104. Nicholas Cabasilas, *Liturgiae expositio*, c. 45; *MF* 1:236.

105. In an illuminating passage, de la Taille himself entertains and then rejects the suggestion that the phrase "celestial sacrifice" is so misleading theologically that it ought to be "withdrawn." He offers four reasons it ought to be retained in theological discourse: (1) There are a number of traditional phrases in the church, e.g., "participation in the sacrifice" and "consum-

the *sacrificium coeleste* inevitably bears upon ecclesial sacrifice, a wager that we shall substantiate shortly. It remains for us now to observe how de la Taille distinguishes his own view from the popular German and French School teachings on Christ's continued sacrifice in heaven, a task that leads us to examine his nuanced distinction between "oblation" and "presentation." For de la Taille, there are two ways to "err" in considering the teaching of the eternal sacrifice: (1) the error by *defect,* which "overlooks" or denies the celestial sacrifice;[106] and (2) the error by *excess,* which considers the heavenly sacrifice in an *active* manner. In regard to the second error, de la Taille identifies "two schools" of Catholic theologians—German and French; he attends to these schools in detail in order to clarify his own position in contradistinction to these "oblationist" thinkers.[107]

In brief, the German school of thought conceives of the celestial sacrifice in heaven as an "internal" act of obedience on the part of Christ, repeatedly renewed in heaven until the day of judgment. De la Taille finds this theology problematic in a twofold way. First and obviously, it perceives the sacrifice of redemption as ongoing, as if the once-for-all sacrifice of Christ were insufficient. (This critique applies to the French School as well—and all theological proposals of an *active* sacrifice in heaven.) Secondly, construing the sacrifice as "internal" ignores that sacrificial action is properly *signifying*—that is, there is no sign unless the sacrifice has an external *esse* ("Perit autem signum, nisi habeat esse externum").[108]

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mation of the sacrifice," that would have no meaning without the concept of a "passive" sacrifice; (2) Eliminating the phrase would be "deviating" from the fathers, who rather frequently referred to Christ as still being a sacrifice, quite apart and independent of the ecclesial sacrifice; (3) It would depart from the medieval practice of referring to eucharistic reservation with the word *sacrificium*—which can only be understood in the *passive* sense; and (4) To withdraw the phrase would also encourage a "forgetfulness" about where all prayers and sacrifices have their end, namely, in the temple or house of God, wherein all gifts of God's faithful are received; de la Taille, *Mystery of Faith and Human Opinion,* 74.

106. De la Taille claims that Cardinal Lugo (*De Mysterio incarnationis,* dip. 28, n. 35) is a prime example of this "error by defect" (*MF* 1:247).

107. The primary German theologians considered by de la Taille are Albert Stoeckel, J.T. Franz, Pell, Thalhofer, and Max T. Hompel. Among the French school, de la Taille identifies Charles de Condren, Jean-Jacques Olier, and M. Lepin.

108. *MF* 1:248, 252–53; *MF,* 176. Some of these German theologians suggest that this internal sacrifice "happens" to be "outwardly manifest" in the wounds of Christ's glorified body. De

The French School, on the other hand, has a comparatively more robust external sacrifice occurring in heaven. De la Taille cites passages from the leading French oblationists Charles de Condren and Jean-Jacques Olier. This school of thought purports that Christ's sacrifice began here on earth only "*in order to be continued in heaven,* where we find the perfection of sacrifice." How is the sacrifice in heaven envisioned by these French thinkers? As de la Taille understands the French School,[109] there is, beyond the presentation of Christ's humanity before the Father, some active oblation of his body (accompanied by sacerdotal prayer). Even more surprising, the oblationists assert a kind of self-immolation or "annihilation" that occurs in the very process of glorification: the divine consuming fire annihilating all that is mortal in the humanity of Christ.[110] De la Taille strongly objects to the proposal that there be anything of immolation or destruction in the divine glorification. The glorifying of Christ is the Father's act of acceptance; that is pure consummation. Needless to say, he notes that such entangled theological positions—"immolation or destruction by Christ's own glory"—are given scope only because some "new" immolation is seen as necessary to maintaining a concept of celestial sacrifice.[111] Rejecting the teaching of these two schools, de la Taille opts for what he calls a "middle course." There is no "formal continuation or renewal" of active offering in the celestial sacrifice, but there is a "virtual duration" of that one active oblation in the perpetual victim, which remains eternally sacred to God. Though offered once in time, the gift is eternal, for Christ gives "irrevocably" and God accepts eternally.[112] In short, the

la Taille finds this too weak of a connection between the internal and external element of oblative sacrifice; *MF* 1:248n6.

109. Cf. also the work of M. Lepin, *L'idée du sacrifice dans la religion chrétienne* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1897), 187 *passim*.

110. *MF* 1:249–50.

111. *MF* 1:250–51.

112. "Quare medii inter duos scopulos incedentes, nullam formalem oblationis activae continuationem aut instaurationem fingimus, virtualem autem oblationis durationem, profitemur, in hoc consistentem, quod ex oblatione sua temporali una, valida in aeternum (cum ex parte donantis irrevocabiliter, tum ex parte acceptantis aeternaliter) manet Christus Deo in perpetuum sacer, seu theothytus" (*MF* 1:254; *MF,* 179). De la Taille persuasively cites Matthias J. Scheeben as giving the "best" account of this teaching in his *Handbuch der katholischen Dogmatik* (Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 1873–1903), vol. 3, 1882, 445n1496; see *MF* 1:254n15.

celestial sacrifice perdures on the basis of the eternal and formal state of Christ as victim once offered, immolated, and forever accepted. De la Taille states this truth even more elegantly in a letter of response to a missionary priest confused about the manner of Christ's offering and intervention in heaven. The celestial sacrifice of Christ, he writes,

> is intercession which is no longer in the process of going on (*fieri*); it is mediation whose function no longer is to draw opposites closer together, but to keep them welded into unity. One only activity remains to Christ, and it is to cause life to circulate from the divine summits to the lower regions of our fallen humanity, from the Father to all his children.[113]

But de la Taille is prescient enough to acknowledge that the language of the fathers and the liturgies is at times ambiguous, open to the interpretation that Christ *offers* in heaven.[114] He asserts that his notion of "passive sacrifice" adequately covers these difficult passages from the fathers and, at the same time, desires to underscore that the heavenly sacrifice is best understood as more cognate to *presentation* than *oblation* (though he notes that the two are "closely akin"). There is a difference, he argues, between Christ's eternal manifestation of himself to God, in an abiding presence to the one who received him, and an actual handing-over of a gift in sacrificial oblation. This seems to me a terribly important allowance in de la Taille's eucharistic theology, one that significantly discourages any suggestion of active sacrifice on the part of the glorified Christ. It is not insignificant that de la Taille is once again showing himself to be influenced by, or faithful to, his prime scriptural inspiration (cf. Hebrews 9:24–26). Those who objected most vehemently to de la Taille's subtle notion of the "passive" celestial sacrifice[115] were loath to accept any concept intimating that Christ was not involved in the mass-sacrifice by a *new and personal act of oblation.* We are now prepared to see how this "passive" yet eternal sacrifice significantly structures de la Taille's theology of the ecclesial Mass-sacrifice, lending it a coherence rarely found in the thought of his detractors.

113. De la Taille, *Mystery of Faith and Human Opinion,* 54.

114. Gregory the Great will further complicate the issue by using immolation and oblation interchangeably when speaking of the heavenly sacrifice; *MF* 1:253n13.

115. Cf. Forrest, *The Clean Oblation,* 137–40. Vonier seems entirely to miss the point about a *passive* celestial sacrifice; Vonier, *Key to the Doctrine of the Eucharist,* 262–68.

The Ecclesial Sacrifice 3

We have thus far detailed how de la Taille's theory of sacrifice shapes his doctrine about the unicity of the supper-cross sacrifice and how it founds the concept of a celestial victim—eternally accepted and sanctified and held by God. In forging a response to the contentious question of how the Mass is "true and proper sacrifice," de la Taille unfolds the logic already advanced in these two principles. This chapter on the church's sacrifice divides in a threefold way. First, we shall explicate de la Taille's theology of ecclesial sacrifice, showing how it undercuts post-Tridentine assumptions and theories about the Mass-sacrifice, "inventions" still held dear by some of de la Taille's contemporaries, and showing how it "resolves" many of the difficulties posed by the teaching of Trent. Secondly, the question of *who* offers the Mass-sacrifice and *how* that offering is enacted will need to be treated in some detail. A discussion of *immolatio symbolica* and of the nature of the consecratory prayer is essential to apprehending de la Taille's unique sense of the ritual mode of oblation. Thirdly, and most significantly in terms of this study, we will look at de la Taille's rather striking approach to the question of the efficacy and fruits of the Mass-sacrifice, a largely overlooked aspect of de la Taille's eucharistic theology but one critical to his integration of sacrifice, grace, and prayer. He relentlessly construes the fruits of the eucharistic sacrifice in terms of the internal devotion of those who *offer:* sacrifice is much less an abstract theory than a real act and practice.[1] At

1. In this "subjective" emphasis to ecclesial sacrifice, de la Taille can be seen as a precursor to later twentieth-century theologians like Schillebeeckx and Rahner, who, though very

the end of this chapter, we shall thereby have a much clearer picture of the essential link between sacrifice and *devotio*.

The Mass as a Sacrifice: *Unitas Ex Parte Rei Oblatae*

Recall that de la Taille's strongest critics were those who argued (ostensibly on the basis of Session 22 of Trent) that the supper and the cross are each "true and complete" sacrifices: the supper being a "sacramental" sacrifice, a sacrifice *in specie aliena,* the cross being a "physical" sacrifice, or a sacrifice *in specie propria*.[2] But how, then, is the Mass-sacrifice, which the catechism of Trent identifies as "one and the same sacrifice as that of the cross," to be theologically construed? This is precisely the difficulty for theologians who maintain the (allegedly) Tridentine "dualist" position about the supper and cross, a difficulty overcome by some through stressing a "real immolation" in the Mass or by others in proposing that communion is in fact constitutive of the ecclesial sacrifice. De la Taille, not surprisingly, rejects both proposals—"errors" attributed to the absence of any profound sense of the nature of sacrifice.

His own approach to the Mass-sacrifice emerges lucidly when both the strict unity of supper-cross sacrifice and the reality of a passive heavenly sacrifice are admitted. *In nuce,* the Mass gains entrance, as it were, to the supper-cross sacrifice primarily by way of *what* is offered: namely, the same victim offered *to be immolated* at the supper is now offered *as immolated and glorified* in the ecclesial sacrifice of the Mass.[3] Obviously, this unity formed by the identity of what is offered ("*unitas ex parte rei oblatae*") is made possible by the theology of an eternal victim, and, perhaps less obviously, by a concept of the *subordinate* and derivative oblation that permits the church to participate in the offering

differently, would give attention to the subjective side of the church's sacraments. In fact, as David Burrell suggests in "Many Masses and One Sacrifice," *Yearbook of Liturgical Studies* (1964): 103–17, Rahner is indebted to de la Taille for his own approach to the question of the value of one-and-many masses.

2. Cf., McNabb, "A New Theory," 1093, 1096, 1099, and M.D. Forrest, *A Clean Oblation,* 160ff; cf. also Eugène Masure's treatment of Billot, who upheld that the Mass and the cross were not the same sacrifice—either in number or in species—"*non idem numero neque specie*"; Masure, *The Sacrifice of the Mystical Body* (London: Burns and Oates, 1954), 17–19 (main text and notes).

3. *MF* 2:24–25.

of Christ at the supper—a participation that makes that action truly, *formally*, the church's (a point we shall press shortly). If in the Mass a "new" victim were offered, the Mass would be an additional sacrifice to that of the cross, which is precisely what the reformers feared to be the case in the Catholic denomination of the Mass as "a sacrifice." On the same note, any suggestion that Christ intervenes by way of a new, personal sacrificial action in the ecclesial sacrifice indicates that a supplemental act on Christ's part is needed in the redemption of humanity. In order to better illuminate de la Taille's own position, we shall examine how he responds to those theories inimical to his view of the Mass-sacrifice.

Perhaps the easiest of the sacrificial theories for de la Taille to dismiss is the one that locates, for a variety of reasons, the constitutive element of sacrifice in *communion*. Renz, for example, argues that the Mass is not formally an offering of the body and blood of Christ, but rather the "preparation" and "setting forth" of a banquet.[4] Such a thesis, de la Taille argues, clearly runs counter to Trent's affirmation about the *oblation* of the Mass. A more complex theory, advanced by theologians such as Dominic Soto, Melchior Cano, and Robert Bellarmine, does not deny that the Mass is the offering of the body and blood of Christ, yet it does locate the necessary component of sacrificial immolation in communion—that is to say, the consumption of the species causes either a symbolic (Cano, Soto) or real (Bellarmine) destruction of the victim. Predictably, de la Taille's initial rejoinder to such theories is a sharp reminder about the dynamic of sacrifice. Communion is neither the oblation nor the immolation: it is rather the *reception* of the gift, sanctified and returned by God as food.[5] He also appeals to the tradition that places the offering of the sacrificial gift on a separate axis from that of receiving the sacrificial food. For example, my offering and prayer might "save" you, but my eating cannot. The reason for this

4. *MF* 2:199. Pope John Paul II, in his 2003 Encyclical Letter *Ecclesia de eucharistia,* seems to be rejecting this same theological position with the following statement: "By virtue of its close relationship to the sacrifice of Golgotha, the Eucharist is *a sacrifice in the strict sense,* and not only in a general way, as if it were simply a matter of Christ's offering himself to the faithful as their spiritual food" (§13).

5. Thomas, in fact, confirms that the sacrifice is indeed complete *before* communion (*ST* III, q. 83, a. 4); see *MF* 2:200.

is "plain (*in promptu*)": through offering and prayer something may be impetrated for another, but the reception of the divine gift is neither prayer nor oblation.[6] De la Taille likewise denies the sort of realistic immolation-destruction that Bellarmine is seeking in the Mass-sacrifice. His counterpoint may be vividly captured in this felicitous phrase: if one looks in the Mass for the crucifixion or immolation—instead of looking for the *crucified*—then one seeks the Mass-sacrifice in vain.[7]

Another set of proposals about the ecclesial sacrifice focuses on the status of the victim. Is a new "state" of victimhood induced by the Mass? Or, on the contrary, is Christ no longer victim at all? De la Taille categorizes as an "error by excess" those theories that see the consecration of the Mass as victimizing Christ anew, specifically, placing Christ *in statu decliviori* (Cardinal de Lugo, Cardinal Franzelin, T. Raynaud). Though not a "bloody immolation," this induced state of victimhood is a kind of "death" in which Christ is deprived of his connatural life. De la Taille confesses that a teaching of Christ "suffering" anew in the Mass may be found "scattered" in books and sermons (predominantly from the "modern period"); nonetheless, he soundly rejects as "ignoble" and "inconsistent with Christian piety" any suggestion that a new state of victimhood is produced in the Mass.[8]

By contrast, the teaching of tradition most evident in the Scholastic fathers speaks of an immolation *in sacramento.* Language that refers to Christ's immolation in the Mass must be understood as indicating only this immolation *in signo*—just as Augustine suggests that we may call something according to what it is an image of, or what it resembles, without thereby speaking falsely.[9] De la Taille appeals directly to Thomas (*ST* III, q. 83, a. 1) for the classic expression of how to conceive of the Mass as an immolation: "But the celebration of this sacrament is an image representative of the passion of Christ, which is true immola-

6. *MF* 2:200; *MF,* 305.

7. Wengier, *The Eucharist-Sacrifice,* 271.

8. Cardinal de Lugo is here cited as an example of this school of thought: "Although the body of Christ is not substantially destroyed in the act of consecration, *still it is destroyed in a human* manner, in as much as it is given a lower status, and as such *it is rendered useless for the human services of the human body*" (*De venerabili eucharistiae sacramento,* disp. 19, sect. 5, n. 67–68); *MF* 2:202–3.

9. Augustine, *Ep.* 98, n. 9; *MF* 2:211–12.

tion. *And for this reason (ideo)* the celebration of this sacrament is called the immolation of Christ." To de la Taille's mind, the tradition solidly refuses to entertain in the Mass "any real blood-shedding in Christ… any detrition (*detritio*) or lessening (*diminutio*) or lowering (*extenuatio*) of any kind, or change (*immutatio*) whatever, *even bloodless*."[10] Not only does such a rejection safeguard the doctrine of Christ's incorruptibility as resurrected and glorified victim, but it also underscores that the Mass cannot stand apart from the cross: the Mass is sacrifice *relative* to that of the cross.[11] We shall return to this question of sacramental immolation in explicating the ecclesial oblation, in which the truth of the representative *immolatio* is manifest.

De la Taille's most interesting and challenging interlocutor on the ecclesial sacrifice is his former mentor and contemporary colleague at the Gregorian University, Cardinal L. Billot. I attend at greater length to their disagreement, for it reveals the distinctiveness of de la Taille's thought and provides critical insight into the question of the internal "immolation" of the offerers. Billot (along with Vasquez) dismisses the necessity of any thesis about an eternal, celestial victim; instead, he focuses the sacrificial explanation of the Mass on the eucharistic species themselves. Above and beyond the commemorative character of the eucharistic species, Billot maintains that they sacramentally constitute a true sacrifice because they "fittingly represent the internal and invisible" *devotio* of those offering themselves in worship of God.[12] For Billot, then, the Mass is a sacrifice *sub species aliena;* it is neither numerically the same as the sacrifice of the cross, nor is it the same as that of the supper.[13]

If de la Taille appreciates the subtlety of Billot's position, and we should note that Billot's theory is also a fresh break from immolationist theories, he challenges its insufficient account of sacrifice. Sacrifice, de la Taille reiterates, must include both *res et signum* and *res tantum*. The "reality and sign" are the giving over to God of a victim (immo-

10. *MF* 2:212; *MF*, 312 (emphasis mine).

11. *MF* 2:213.

12. Louis Cardinal Billot, *De Ecclesiae sacramentis: Commenatarius in tertiam partem S. Thomae* (Romae: Typographia Polyglotta S.C. de Propaganda Fide, 1897), 1:611, 616; 568–72; *MF* 2:216.

13. Cf. Masure, *The Sacrifice of the Mystical Body*, 17–19.

lated, to be immolated, or now being immolated) and by an action apparent to the senses. The "reality only" is the internal immolation of the one offering. If the oblation is to be a sign of internal *devotio,* then it must be the case that the gift being handed over *bears the reality or condition of immolation*. Such immolational reality, de la Taille argues, is found in the church's offering of the flesh and blood of Christ—a victim already immolated to God and ratified. The upshot of de la Taille's response to Billot might be put in this way: it is not *any* external signification of the worshipper's desire to be immolated to God that suffices for proper sacrifice, but only that *res et signum* that links internal *devotio* to that of a true victim. In other words, a thing is not sacrificed merely on the basis that a sign "professedly sacrificial is employed in connection with it"; rather, the latreutic signification of sacrifice both "arises from and has its foundation in the oblation of an *external thing truly immolated*."[14] Billot, it seems, has gotten the sacrificial signification backwards.

> The immolative reality, therefore, is not to be proved by the sign, but, on the contrary, the sign is to be regarded as dependent on the immolative reality, as presupposed and underlying that sign.[15]

Two important points can be gleaned from de la Taille's rejoinder to Cardinal Billot. First, immolation or the immolative reality of the victim stands ontologically prior to the ecclesial sacrifice, a truth that is foundational to the church's action. Secondly, and correlatively, the sacrificial signification and real giving of the believer's internal immolation to God depend upon the victim, Christ, even as a kind of mediating reality. In de la Taille's theological framework, the worshipper's internal *devotio* does not take flight for heaven, as it were, without the offering of a true victim. The devotion of the offering church is *participative* in the victim's, so that the Christian might be offered to God and henceforth live "*not after the desire of men, but according to the will of God*" (1 Pet. 4:1). As noted earlier, de la Taille walks neither as an extrinsicist nor as one who acknowledges only the internal reality of sacrifice. He prudently insists upon a theory of sacrifice and sacrament

14. *MF* 2:218–19.
15. *MF* 2:219.

that honors and indeed demands *truth* both of the exterior sign and of the interior reality.

If Cardinal Louis Billot's theory misperceives the signifying dynamic of sacrifice, his position is problematic also in refusing any concept of the *sacrificium coeleste*. Without a celestial victim, the intrinsic oneness of the Mass and the supper-cross sacrifice is imperiled. More, the absence of an eternal victim leaves significant difficulties in explaining the propitiatory value of the Mass, upon which Trent is unambiguously firm. For de la Taille, these rival theories about the Mass-sacrifice ultimately are inadequate to the Tridentine doctrine. The unity of the ecclesial sacrifice with the supper-cross sacrifice stands squarely upon the identity of the victim offered. Let us turn then to the second critical feature of de la Taille's theory of the Mass: the subordinate and derivative nature of the church's sacrificial oblation.

The Ecclesial Oblation: *Subordinatio Ex Parte Oblationis Activae*

We have seen de la Taille answer the question of *what* is offered at the sacrifice of the Mass, and how that what—the eternal victim immolated and ratified—grants sacrificial status to the Mass. Next we examine the contentious issue of *who* offers the ecclesial sacrifice and *how* that offering is accomplished in the church's ritual action. To theologize about "who offers?" opens onto the debate about whether each Mass includes a personal and formal act of offering on the part of Christ, or, as de la Taille maintains, only a "virtual" act of offering by Christ. De la Taille's core position demands a careful delineation of the church's subordinate, yet participative, power in the offering of sacrifice. Additionally, our explication of how the ecclesial ritual accomplishes this sacrificial oblation shall include both de la Taille's curious and not unpersuasive depiction of the consecration *as* oblation and his logical, though infelicitous, conclusion about the role of the epiclesis in eucharistic sacrifice.

Christ's Offering at the Ecclesial Sacrifice

The same critics who decried de la Taille's unicist perception of the supper and cross as contrary to Trent also take issue with his proposal

that Christ does not *formally* offer at each ecclesial sacrifice.[16] However, de la Taille's position on Christ's activity at the ecclesial sacrifice is utterly consistent with his theology of eucharistic sacrifice as we have expounded it thus far. Is Christ the offerer and priest of the church's sacrifices? "Yes," *if* one understands that Christ, the high priest, offers now *through* the oblation of his mystical body, the church, whose sacrifice he has made his own. As was clear in the concept of Christ's continued sacrifice and intercession in heaven, there is no new, active role of Christ as *liturgus*. Instead, Christ gives to the offering church "the power of presenting" his body and blood to God *as its own victim*.[17] All that is "new," then, derives from the particular activity of the church, even though all the power comes from Christ who communicates his sacerdotal power to the church: "Novitas tota est ex parte ecclesiae, quanquam virtus tota est ex parte Christi."[18]

De la Taille couches this crucial principle in terms both of causality and of virtual and formal offering. Christ, in effect, is the principal and universal cause of the church's sacrificial oblation; the ecclesia is the particular or subordinate cause under the priesthood of Christ—*sub sacerdote Christi*. The ecclesial priesthood is derivative of Christ's—"*sicut ex fonte rivulus et a sole radius*."[19] The church now sacrifices only

16. Forrest, *A Clean Oblation,* 137–40, for example, suggests that de la Taille's position is indubitably counter to the Tridentine declaration: "For the victim is one and the same, and the same person (*idem*) now offers by the ministry of his priests who then offered himself on the cross, only the manner of offering being different" (Session 22, c. 2).

This question of Christ's role in the offering of each sacrifice did not simply "go away" in the decades following the publication of *Mysterium Fidei*. For example, we can note in addresses given by Pius XII in the mid-1950s an attempt to respond to the new "personal sacramentalism" being introduced by theologians like Karl Rahner, who, I contend, was clearly influenced by de la Taille; see, for example, the numerous footnotes to Maurice de la Taille in his and A. Häussling's *The Celebration of the Eucharist* (New York: Herder and Herder, 1968). Pius XII, wanting to uphold an objective sense to the Mass-sacrifice, announces that Christ is intimately and "separately" active in each offering of the Mass: "With regard to the offering of the Eucharistic sacrifice, the actions of Christ, the High Priest, are as many as are the priests celebrating"; see David Burrell, "Many Masses and One Sacrifice," 113. It may be argued, in fact, that the question has not been definitively settled in this new century.

17. *MF* 2:187. The church's offering proceeds *virtually,* "in quantum oblatio ejus, firma in saecula, supereminet nostris, *quas incorporat sibi,* influens in eas vim exhibendi Deo corpus et sanguinem Christi *tanquam hostiam nostrum*"; *MF,* 295, emphasis mine.

18. *MF,* 296.

19. In the strictest manner of speaking, the ecclesial sacrifice is not sacrifice *in se*, but sacrifice *per participationem; MF,* 195.

"by virtue of that one sacrificial act carried out long ago by Christ." The principal power and act of sacrificing pass (*transit*) from the head to the body, thereby allowing the church to make its own the one offering of Christ at the supper and on the cross.[20] In fact, unless the present offering is conceived as subordinate and participatory of the Lord's, then the oneness of the two sacrifices would "fall to the ground." If Trent does indicate that Christ offers anew in his own person (à la McNabb, Swaby, Forrest, Vonier) through the ministry of the ecclesial priesthood, then a *multiplicity* of redeeming sacrifices must obtain. For Christ, who is "not subordinate to himself," could not offer again without offering something "perfectly equal" to the first sacrifice.[21]

De la Taille presents an alternative vision, explicating that Christ offers *virtually* at the Mass, rather than *formally*, which is to say that the power—*virtus*—of the church's offering is Christ's, but that the concrete, specific action is properly the church's. Allowing his definition of sacrifice to seal the question, de la Taille concludes that "he alone formally offers sacrifice who offers visibly."[22] Christ remains a priest forever offering through the ecclesia: his one oblation at the supper-cross "incorporates" the church's derivative and sensible oblation, which oblation renews the sacrifice.

The Mode of Oblation

Granted that the church is the formal offerer of the sacrifice, though this offering is participatory in Christ's past and only ritual oblation, still we might press de la Taille to say more about the relationship between this oblation of the once-immolated and eternally accepted victim and the *immolatio symbolica*—that is, the representation of the passion. How are (real) oblation and immolation *in sacramento* related? And does the fact that the church immolates in symbol *only* thereby detract from the Mass being a true sacrifice—the nagging fear of many post-Tridentine

20. Even should one argue that the consecration implies some new causative power on the part of Christ, de la Taille shows that this causality does not require that Christ be formal offerer as well: the efficient cause and the offerer are related in distinct ways to the sacrifice; see *MF* 2:194, esp. n. 1.

21. *MF* 2:191–93.

22. *MF* 2:196.

theologians? This latter concern is not difficult to answer, for such diminishment to the sacrificial reality of the Mass would be the case only if immolation were the "same thing" as sacrifice.[23] But according to de la Taille's theory, we know that sacrifice is essentially the oblation of a victim (immolated, or to be immolated). So how does one correlate the oblation and symbolic immolation of the ecclesial sacrifice?

De la Taille hangs much on Peter Canisius's definition of the Mass (in fact, it is the epitaph to *Mysterium Fidei*):

> The sacrifice of the Mass, carefully considered in all its bearings, is the holy and living representation, and at the same time the bloodless and effective offering of the passion of our Lord, and of the bloody sacrifice which was offered for us on the cross.[24]

Canisius leads the way by both *distinguishing* and *linking* the representation and the oblation: the Mass-sacrifice is a representation of the bloody death on the cross; the oblation is the offering of that passion and death. More explicitly put: "the representative rite is oblative of, or such that it offers, the reality represented by it."[25] Whether or not de la Taille has accurately captured the sense of Canisius's definition, and there were challenges to his reading,[26] I would contend that he has expressed well what *he* wants to say of the oblation and immolation of the ecclesial sacrifice. Not surprisingly, our attention is drawn relentlessly back to the supper: at the supper, Christ offered his passion and death in symbolic immolation; we do the same at the Mass. The offering in the Mass, as in the supper, is *realis et praesens*—unlike the immolation, "represented as past or future." De la Taille goes on to make a most striking claim about the genus of oblation, a claim about the collapse of time and signification in sacrificial oblation:

> For it is one and the same thing to offer the body of Christ as having suffered and died in the passion, as to offer the passion and death of the body; it is the same to offer the blood as shed, as to offer its shedding; the same to offer Christ as victim of a past immolation, as to offer that immolation itself. (Idem est enim offerre corpus Christi in quantum passi et mortui, ac offerre ejus mortem et passionem;

23. *MF* 2:211–12.
24. Peter Canisius, *Opus catechisticum, De sacramentis*, q. 7; *MF* 2:94.
25. *MF* 2:94.
26. Forrest, *The Clean Oblation,* 57.

idem, offerre sanguinem prout effusum, ac offerre ejus effusionem; idem, offere Christum ut hostiam ex praemissa immolatione exsistentem, ac offerre ipsam immolationem.)[27]

These words announce a distinctive feature of de la Taille's eucharistic theology, a certain mysticism of sacramental action: the Mass is a sacrifice because, *sub actu oblationis,* it is the same to offer the past occurrence of a thing as to offer the thing itself. One could, no doubt, protest this transgression of the historical-temporal and of an ordinary phenomenology of gift-giving. Still, we must acknowledge that, for de la Taille, the mystery of the identity of the Mass and Christ's sacrifice is realized through this *modus oblationis*.[28]

Consecration and Petition

When de la Taille considers what is required on the part of the church to accomplish the sacrifice, oblation and immolation coalesce even more securely, and the external-internal tension of sacrifice again comes to the fore. Explicating the sacrificial actions of the church, de la Taille makes two rather arresting claims: (1) the consecration accomplishes the sacrifice—but Christ's *dicta* alone do not suffice; and (2) though a petition for transubstantiation (in the "epiclesis" or *Supplices te*) is eminently fitting to the eucharistic sacrifice, such a petition is not a necessary condition or cause of the consecration. In each of these arguments, the definitional components of sacrifice are clearly operative, as is de la Taille's attentiveness to the Last Supper.[29]

Consecration and Sacrificial Oblation

De la Taille holds that the eucharistic consecration effects the sacrifice. This is so not only because of the efficacy of Christ's words, re-

27. *MF* 2:23–24; *MF,* 195.

28. Moloney (*Eucharist,* 209) misrepresents de la Taille, suggesting that he locates the unity of the Eucharist and the cross only in the victim. To the contrary, de la Taille proposes that the Mass and the supper-cross are united also under the ritual action of oblation.

29. Joseph Cardinal Ratzinger (Benedict XVI) would not be alone in casting suspicion on the practice of looking to the Last Supper for ritual suggestion or verification of what is now done in the eucharistic liturgy; see Ratzinger, *The Feast of Faith: Approaches to a Theology of the Liturgy,* trans. Graham Harrison (San Francisco: Ignatius Press, 1981), 59–60n1.

peated by the officiating priest *in persona Christi,* but also because of the fact that the consecration and the oblation are *simultaneous*. By insisting that the consecration accomplishes the sacrifice, de la Taille is first of all reacting to two other extant teachings about the church's sacrifice: one that claims that the sacrifice is *perficitur* in the communion, while the other posits its completion in the breaking of the bread.[30] More interestingly, however, he is intent also to make sense of what the early fathers meant by indicating that the sacrifice is accomplished *per precem*. Combing through early sources (here particularly Justin, Ignatius, Tertullian, and Clement of Rome), de la Taille surmises that the word "sacrifice" most frequently refers to the *sacrificial action,* to the prayers of thanksgiving over the bread and wine (prayers that include the consecratory words of Christ). Even so, it does not follow that the eucharistic prayer is thereby the *reality offered,* instead of that which terminates the sacrificial action—the body and blood of Christ.[31] In fact, the contrary is suggested:

> For if the giving of thanks is here to offer sacrifice, evidently that over which thanks is given is offered in sacrifice. Hence we conclude, naturally, that what is consecrated by the thanksgiving is offered in sacrifice.[32]

30. De la Taille rejects the suggestion that the banquet is the sacrifice proper, a question already treated in chapters 1 and 2. As for the teaching that the breaking of the bread is central to the sacrifice—as the perfect symbol ("*absolutum exemplar*") of Christ's death—de la Taille traces its emergence in the early medieval church and cites Cano as a proponent of the view. He denies that this teaching has foundation in Scripture or in the fathers; see *MF* 2:402–6. If, hypothetically, there were no fraction of the bread, the sacrifice would yet be complete.

31. De la Taille is here responding directly to the work of Franz Wieland, *Mensa und Confessio* (Munich: J. J. Lenter, 1906), 49, 52–53; and Wieland, *Der vorirenäische Opferbegriff* (Munich: J. J. Lenter, 1909), xxii, 132–33, 145–49, who ostensibly argued that in the early church (at least before Irenaeus, and in some cases after Irenaeus) there existed no perception of an *offering* of the body and blood of Christ; see *MF* 2:42ff; 60ff. De la Taille's reading of the sources here is impressive in scope and detail. Throughout the footnotes of this Elucidation XVIII ("The Fathers of the first two centuries knew that we offer to God in our celebration of the Eucharist the body and blood of Christ"), de la Taille presents to his defense, or respectfully challenges, the translations and interpretations of such contemporary figures as Renz, Battifol, Harnack, Edmund Bishop, and Dom Leclercq. In other words, though de la Taille's own interpretations may be questioned—and perhaps there may never be a definitive interpretation of the early fathers on this question of eucharistic sacrifice—he demonstrates an astute engagement with the historical texts and with contemporary scholarship upon those texts.

32. "Nam si το εὐχαριστεῖν est sacrificare, videtur sacrificari idipsum quod dicitur εὐχαριστεῖσθαι; proindeque satis naturaliter existimabitur in sacrificium offerri res per gratiarum actionem consecrata"; *MF* 2:73; *MF,* 225.

De la Taille thus maintains that *what* is accomplished through the prayer of consecration—an oral action enunciating and pragmatically effecting the presence of the body and blood of Christ—is the reality offered.

Affirming what "all admit," that the words of Christ ("This is my body, This is the chalice of my blood") are the essential form of the consecration,[33] de la Taille yet wants to ask if anything *else* is necessary for the efficacy of this form. On the basis of the nature of sacrifice, he concludes that *verba formalia* require two contextualizing additions: (1) some words that indicate a clear *sacrificial intention;* and (2) some words that provide the sacramental form with a power both *recitative* and *significative*. In addressing both of these points, he underscores that the full dynamic of sacrifice cannot be overlooked when we reflect theologically on the ritual action of the Eucharist.

Against those who deny that the consecratory words need any further determination, de la Taille argues that Christ's sacrificial intention cannot be indicated sufficiently by the verbal formula alone. As at the supper, the ecclesial sacrifice must plainly express both Christ's desire to offer a sacrifice of propitiation and the directionality of the gift offered to God. Looking to the testimony of ancient liturgies, as well as to what Christ in fact plainly willed at the supper (namely, to offer sacrifice for the forgiveness of sins), he insists upon the necessity of words that determine that what is done in symbol is done *pro nobis: in remissionem peccatorum* (words most appropriately found in reference to the chalice).[34] What is at stake here is not the issue of real presence, which Christ might have effected without sacrifice, without the oblation of a victim to God. Rather, it is a question of the ecclesial eucharistic form *fully signifying* what Christ willed to accomplish: "by transubstantiation he willed to offer sacrifice, he willed to offer the transubstantiation sacrificially."[35] Hence, because the sacramental form effects what

33. A contemporary challenge could be made by arguing that there are early examples of eucharistic prayers that (apparently) lack the institution narrative (e.g., the Liturgy of Addai and Mari); see, for example, Robert Taft, S.J., "Mass Without a Consecration," *Worship* 77 (2003): 482–509.

34. *MF* 2:440–44.

35. *MF* 2:442, 446.

it signifies,[36] it must express all that it is meant to express and accomplish—namely, the sacrificial intent of Christ to offer a victim pleasing to God for sinners. The sign character of sacrifice demands that inner intention be signified by an external "visible word." Sharply put, had Christ's intention remained "secret" or hidden at the supper, there would be no eucharistic sacrifice. The ecclesiastical sacrifice must *signify* as Christ did.

On the same note, de la Taille adds a further and more controversial thesis: necessary also to the signifying efficacy of the consecratory formula is a narrative preamble "putting" these words "on the lips of Christ," thereby designating the bread as *Christ's* body. Thomas does not require any such introduction to Christ's *dicta* (cf. *ST* III, q. 78, a. 1, ad 4). I suspect that the controversy that erupted over de la Taille's proposal (on this "still freely discussed" question, he qualifies), derives largely from his assertion that Scotus's opinion here is not only "solidly" more probable than Thomas's, but *more harmonious with* Thomas's own thought on sacrifice and the sacraments.[37] De la Taille cannot follow Thomas obsequiously here, for the signifying exigencies of sacrifice and sacrament demand that the words be uttered in such a way that they "ritually signify their effect."[38] Unless it is clear that the words "This is my body" refer to Christ's body (and not the priest's), then they lack their properly signifying sense. That is, if the narrative preamble identifying the words as spoken by Christ is not part of the consecratory form *per se,* nevertheless, it is a *condition* for that form, as it is prayed in the eucharistic sacrifice, to be efficacious.[39] Scotus lucidly puts it this way:

36. "[E]st enim indivisibilis in re effectus ille et significatum"; *MF,* 456. In other words, in sacramental action, one cannot divide what the formula signifies from what is achieved in reality.

37. Forrest, for example, takes great umbrage at de la Taille's audacity: "It is rather amusing, after deserting the opinion of St. Thomas in this matter … and adopting that of Scotus, to tell the Angelic Doctor that his own principles are better served by the opinion of Scotus. St. Thomas should be the best judge of what 'satisfies his own principles'"; Forrest, *The Clean Oblation,* 247.

38. *MF* 2:449, 455. "Verba formae non producent suum effectum, nisi ita prolate, ut suum effectum rite significent"; *MF*, 459.

39. In a footnote (*MF* 2:450n1) de la Taille also offers the neat suggestion that the narrative introduction is rather like a *disposition* to the truth of the form.

The sacramental words must signify by virtue of the words (*ex vi verborum*) that which is effected by virtue of the sacrament. But by virtue of this consecration the effect is that the true body of Christ is there; therefore the words, sufficient by their own proper virtue, must signify that the true body of Christ is contained there.[40]

Those who follow Thomas on this question argue that the priest's intention to utter the words as belonging to Christ suffices. De la Taille reminds us, however, that in the dynamic of sacrifice, and so too in the church's sacramental sacrifice, private intention alone has no signifying power. An intention not evident to the senses can never supply what is lacking to the form, any more than a hidden desire to give a gift to God is accomplished without the actual (ritual) handing-over of the gift. We must say that in the realm of sacrifice, which is *in genere signi,* external manifestation is intimately tied to efficacy.

Epiclesis and Sacrifice

If de la Taille does not hesitate to insist upon the necessity of sacrificial intention and a narrative preamble (the *Qui pridie*),[41] it may be surprising to learn that he denies such necessity to the epiclesis, a denial that we cannot attribute simply to an underdeveloped pneumatology. The epiclesis, he argues, though having an apt place ("*locus aptus*") in the eucharistic sacrifice, is neither causally nor conditionally essential to the consecratory form, which would be complete and efficacious without it. It is worthwhile attending to how he articulates the *appropriateness* of the epiclesis, for this tells us something critical about eucharistic oblation and the externalization of desire. In the end, we may ask justifiably whether or not de la Taille's position on the epiclesis squares with his own theory of sacrificial action.

De la Taille casts the epiclesis (and the *Supplices te rogamus*)[42] as

40. John Duns Scotus, *Commentaria oxoniensia ad IV libros magistri sententiarum* (Quaracchi: Collegii S. Bonaventurae, 1912), 4. D. 8.2.n4; *MF* 2:457.

41. It should be remembered that when de la Taille wrote, the Roman Canon (now Eucharistic Prayer I) was the only eucharistic prayer in use in the Roman rite. The current translation of the *Qui pridie* is: "On the day before he was to suffer, he took bread in his holy and venerable hands, and with eyes raised to heaven, to you, O God, his almighty Father, giving you thanks, he said the blessing, broke the bread and gave it to his disciples, saying . . . ."

42. The current English translation of the *Supplices* reads: "In humble prayer we ask you, almighty God, command that these gifts be borne by the hands of your holy Angel to your altar on high in the sight of your divine majesty, so that all of us, who through this participation at

a petition for transubstantiation—which in turn, he specifies, is likewise a prayer for divine acceptance. Without rehearsing de la Taille's complete argument for the *Supplices te* as a Roman epiclesis,[43] I want to underscore his interpretation of this petition. In the *Supplices te,* the church invokes divine assistance for the transferral of the gifts on the ecclesial altar to the celestial altar, an invocation equivalent to asking that they "be changed into the heavenly victim of the body and blood of Christ." Insofar as a transformation of the bread and wine into the celestial victim is effected by the transubstantiation, that transubstantiation is the *acceptance* by God of our ecclesial offering. A prayer for acceptance is interchangeable with a prayer for transubstantiation; in effect, they are the same.[44] If the epiclesis is so construed (as a prayer

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the altar receive the most holy Body and Blood of your Son, may be filled with every grace and heavenly blessing."

43. De la Taille's position is detailed in an appendix to Elucidation 21 ("The Mass in relation to the heavenly sacrifice"). He proceeds impressively by way of comparing the *Supplices te* to Eastern epicleses in a variety of early liturgies, analyzing place and meaning of the prayers; *MF* 2:154ff. He provides good reason for thinking that the formula can be traced back to "subapostolic" times, when the faithful would find little strange in this prayer, so imbued were they with Ignatius's Epistles, the Letter to the Hebrews, and St. John's Apocalypse. Moreover, while he prefers to think of the angel as Christ, which is questionable (cf. Joseph Jungmann, S.J., *The Mass of the Roman Rite: Its Origins and Development* [Westminster: Christian Classics, 1950], 2:234), he is correct in pointing out that, if this is an epiclesis calling upon the Divine Word (not the Spirit) to descend, then such an invocation is indeed quite early; see *MF* 2:167–69; 426 ff. He cites at length two medieval thinkers, Paschasius from the West and Nicolas Cabasilas from the East, who both interpret this part of the Canon as an epiclesis; *MF* 2:158–61. Interestingly, de la Taille suggests that an ascensional epiclesis—a prayer that the gift be taken to the heavenly altar—is essentially equivalent to a descensional epiclesis, in which the petition invokes the descent of the Holy Spirit upon the offering that it may be transubstantiated; *MF* 2:161n1. The bearing of the gifts from the earthly altar to the heavenly "means the same thing as their sanctification or consecration because the sacrifice derives its sanctity from the altar"; MF 2:159. De la Taille draws upon a wealth of sources to demonstrate that this celestial altar is the body of Christ. Because the altar on high is Christ, what is on that sublime altar and what is received from that altar can only be the glorified body of Christ (*MF* 2:154). In fact, the *ex hac altaris* of the *Supplices te* is understood to be the celestial, not the earthly altar. As Jungmann would later expound, there is in the *Supplices* only one altar, not two: "it must be said that in the metaphorical language of our prayer the earthly altar wholly disappears from view and is absorbed, so to say, in the heavenly one which alone has validity"; *The Mass,* 236.

44. *MF* 2:154, 422 *passim.* De la Taille points to the *Quam oblationem* (which has "crept into a place before the consecration") as an example of the conflation of a prayer for acceptance and transubstantiation: "we beg that our offering be ratified and accepted by the fact of its passing into, becoming the body and blood of Christ" (MF 2:422n1). The *Quam oblationem* of the Canon today reads: "Be pleased, O God, we pray, to bless, acknowledge, and approve this offering in every respect; make it spiritual and acceptable, so that it may become for us the body and blood of your most beloved Son, our Lord Jesus Christ."

for transubstantiation and/or acceptance), is it not both redundant and "useless," given that the consecration has been accomplished in the words of institution?

Apart from acknowledging that the epiclesis has been "solemnized" and "sanctioned" by centuries of use in the church, de la Taille locates the *congruitas* of the epiclesis under the liturgical principle of "distension," by which he means that what is solemnized in one indivisible moment in the liturgy, needs to be "distributed," "diffused and expanded" over a series of words and ritual actions.[45] The *ratio* of this "distension" is to engage the faith and affections of the worshippers in a salutary way. The epiclesis constitutes such ritual expansion: it distends and opens up the essential action of consecration, achieved in the *dicta* of Christ. In other words, the epiclesis (or the *Supplices*) has a declarative and elucidating function in regard to the oblation and consecration, while also—and importantly—giving expression to the desire of those offering that the transubstantiation and acceptance indeed occur. Given this principle of ceremonial expansion (*principio caerimoniarae expansionis*), as well as the understanding that acceptance comprises the *finis* of sacrifice, de la Taille supports a post-consecratory position of the epiclesis.

Yet, does de la Taille's diminishment of the *epiclesis* (that is, as having a ceremonial, but not necessary function) best serve his own argument about the dynamic of sacramental sacrifice? We may grant that the consecration in effect accomplishes the sacrifice, for there one finds oblation, immolation in symbol, the presence of a victim, and divine acceptance. Still, if propitiatory intent and a narrative preamble are essential for the sacrificially signifying power of the consecration, would it not be consistent to require as well an oral expression of ecclesial desire, especially since de la Taille has argued that the church formally offers the sacrifice?

I invoke a passage that seems to reveal de la Taille's own ambivalence in regard to the epiclesis. He favorably cites, but ultimately steps

45. *MF* 2:419. The sacerdotal prayer of Jesus in John's Gospel (c. 17) provides an example of this ritual elucidation and extension of time. De la Taille also sees in this Johannine passage (esp. 17:19) a "model" for the structure of the church's epicletic prayer; see *MF* 2:425.

away from, the position of Dom Touttée, who holds that two things are necessary in the eucharistic sacrifice: (1) the recitation of the words of Christ, which effects the conversion of the bread and wine; and (2) the expression of the church's desire that Christ, according to his promise, not be wanting in the sacrament (*viz.,* the epiclesis). These two elements are one action, though separated in ritual time. Touttée suggests that it does not matter which comes first—the consecration or the epiclesis—though he finds it more apt (and I agree) that the desire ("impetratory cause") be expressed before the recitation of Christ's words ("efficient cause").[46] While de la Taille seems to find Toutée's thought appealing, he nonetheless fears that it makes of the epiclesis a *condition* of the consecration—a possibility that, unlike the narrative component of the consecration, de la Taille rejects. Dom Toutée's position, I argue, is significantly more attuned to de la Taille's own emphasis upon the external manifestation of internal *devotio* in sacrificial action. If, beyond the simple verbal formula, some words are needed to indicate Christ's intent to make of himself a victim, it would follow that the desire of the church to make that victim her own would also demand signifying clarity (supplied by the petition/epiclesis).

But de la Taille is rather puzzlingly averse to this possibility. Instead he prefers to rest with the (weak) reply that our petition for transubstantiation is "implicitly contained" in the words of consecration. How so? De la Taille's answer is evidently circular. The petition for transubstantiation is in the words of consecration because they themselves are an oblative action, which oblation *pragmatically* seeks acceptance (the end of all sacrificial offering), and acceptance consists in the transubstantiation itself.[47] Even if de la Taille's logic obtains, it is worth questioning whether or not the church's desire is adequately *manifest* in the oral action of the consecration. In the ecclesial sacrifice, the epicletic prayer appears to make most plain the desire of the *formal* offerer of

46. Dom Touttée, *De doctrina Cyrili, dissert.* 3.c2n97, PG 33, 283; *MF* 2:416–17.

47. *MF* 2:437. "Postulatio enim transsubstantiationis implicite continetur in nostro sermone consecratorio, etiam nulla postulatione enuntiata. Continetur scilicet in nostro sermone: quatenus is rationem habet actionis oblativae, oblativa autem actio est ex sese quaedam pragmatica petitio acceptationis, acceptatio autem nostri sacrificii in transsubstantiatione sita est"; *MF*, 453.

the sacrifice. The discussion that now follows, on the relationship between the *devotio* of the offerers and the fruits of the sacrifice, would seem only to strengthen our suggestion that de la Taille misfires on the question of the necessity of the epiclesis.

"De Fructu Sacrificii et de Devotione"

Curiously, de la Taille's teaching on the relationship between sacrifice and the *devotio* of the offerer did not attract much attention at the time of the book's publication; nor, save the striking exception of Karl Rahner,[48] did it find a hearing among theologians writing in the mid-twentieth century. Given that de la Taille underscores the intentionality of the worshipping community, a principle loudly promoted in much post-Vatican II liturgical theology, it is odd that this feature of de la Taille's erudite work continues to be ignored. Apart from the possibility that de la Taille's book is widely known only through the reading of volume 1, I also suspect his teaching on *devotio* might be offensive precisely because it is inextricably tied up with his theory of sacrifice. De la Taille's proposal about *devotio* is not a *novum;* it is at least as old as Thomas: the fruit of the sacrifice is proportioned to the intensity of devotion in the one offering.[49] More comprehensively, though the Mass-sacrifice is of infinite value, though the fruits of the sacrifice are without limit, those fruits are "restricted" by the *affectus* of the church offering in common, as well as by the devotion of individuals (in an accumulative way). These two elements of de la Taille's thesis—the nature of the sacrificial fruits and the role of *devotio* within the offerers—must be more fully delineated.

In pursuing the topic of the fruits of the sacrifice, de la Taille iden-

48. Rahner and Häussling's *The Celebration of the Eucharist* was keen to answer the question about Mass frequency and the value of many masses over a single Mass. Building upon de la Taille's work, Rahner establishes the following principle: "mass must be celebrated as often as its repetition increases the *fides* and *devotio* of those taking part" (*Celebration,* 91–106, at 92). Would de la Taille have agreed with Rahner's thesis? Not without considerable qualification, I am inclined to think. De la Taille would encourage Rahner not to forget the central *directionality* of sacrificial action—something given to God; and, while de la Taille underscores the principle of *the offering church* (*totius Ecclesiae*), Rahner, for his part, finds such a notion unsatisfying—philosophically and theologically; see Burrell, "Many Masses and One Sacrifice," 107–8, 116.

49. *ST* III, q. 79, a. 5, c.

tifies what is meant by these fruits, from whence these fruits derive, and how they are distinct from the fruits of the "sacrament." These distinctions, typically ignored in contemporary eucharistic theology, are not, I submit, without value. Given what we have seen about the nature of sacrifice, de la Taille's assertion marking the difference between the fruits of "the sacrifice" and that of "the sacrament" might be expected. For the sacrifice of the Mass does not consist in receiving some good from God "*sed in offerendo*"; the sacrament pertains not to offering but to *receiving something* from God (the returned gift of the sacrifice). Activity and passivity (perhaps too rigidly) enter into de la Taille's distinctions: "With respect to the sacrament we are passive; with respect to the sacrifice, active. In the sacrament God acts among us; whereas in the sacrifice we are engaged in an activity directed towards God."[50]

Reflection upon the fruits of the sacrifice thus attends to the *directionality* of the liturgical action. If the fruits of the sacrament are best spoken of in terms of our sanctification by God, the fruits of the sacrifice are, properly speaking, best understood in terms of propitiation—that is, reconciliation and atonement. Yet, wanting to adhere to an "organic notion" of the sacrificial fruits,[51] de la Taille also recalls that every sacrifice is, by definition, *pragmatic impetration* (and this by way of *latria* and *eucharistia*): the one offering may ask and expect other goods, as well.[52] By saying that it "suffices" to place the fruits of the sacrifice in the propitiatory effect, de la Taille is less rigorous than he appears at first glance. To clarify, the fruits of the sacrifice primarily reconcile humans to God, but from the same love of the Priest and Victim flows "relief from every possible need."[53] The *whence* of this fruit derives from the "thanksgiving and adoration which Christ exhibits towards God," a worship that the believer makes her own in the mass oblation, and that "opens" (in God's generosity) the fount of all benefits.

Two theological points follow upon de la Taille's concept of the

50. "Passivi sumus respectu sacramenti, activi respectu sacrificii. Agit circa nos Deus in sacramento; agimus nos erga Deum in sacrificio"; *MF,* 320–21.

51. Suarez, apparently, denied impetratory fruit to the sacrificial action of the ecclesial sacrifice; *MF* 2:227.

52. Cf. this volume, chapter 1, 36.

53. *MF* 2:224n1.

fruits of the sacrifice, both of them linked to the dynamic of sacrifice and the nature of the gift offered at the Mass ("*ratione rei oblatae*"). First, because God has accepted eternally Christ's impetration, an acceptance made known in the resurrection, that effective impetration is "infallibly" won when the church offers Christ the victim to God. This infallibility is not attributed to a kind of efficient causality, but rather to a "moral cause" implied by the sacrifice itself. In other words, the fruit of the sacrifice *ex opere operato* does not indicate the "immediate infusion" or production in the offerer of grace or some other specific divine gift.

> [T]he sacrifice intervenes merely as a moral cause, in so far that, when by way of sacrifice we give praise to God, or offer … just compensation, *the way is opened for the mercy of God towards us,* either to justify us or to keep us good and make us better. ([S]ed intercedit sacrificium per modum causae mere moralis, dum, pia laude Deo reddita, vel justa compensatione exhibita, *misericordiae divinae recluditur aditus ad nos*, sive justificandos, sive custodiendos in bono atque in melius promovendos.)[54]

By way of the dynamic of sacrifice, God is hence "prepared (*paratus*)" and "bound (*obligatus*)" to respond and bestow his mercy—in a "way suitable to our own individual state and condition." Again we hear the possibly dissonant suggestion of sacrifice placing God under some obligation.[55] But de la Taille encourages us to view this not in a mechanical way, but as a *pactum* between a giver manifesting her *devotio* and a receiver who, if he accepts the gift, is in a morally obliging position to bestow a return gift. If, however, God has eternally accepted the gift once offered by Christ, ostensibly this places the offering church in the position of being assured of the fruits of the Mass-sacrifice. After all, the sacrifice is a "done deal." Or is it?

The eucharistic Gift, infinitely pleasing to God, ought thereby to make the Mass-sacrifice abundantly and infinitely fruitful. The victim of the passion has "infinite propitiatory power." Even so, de la Taille argues that the fruits of ecclesial sacrifice are limited or restricted by the offerers themselves, in particular by the measure of their *affect* in offering the gift.[56] Favorably citing both Bellarmine and Scotus, he takes

54. *MF* 2:226; *MF,* 321.
55. Cf. discussion in this volume, chapter 1, 47–51.
56. *MF* 2:228ff.

seriously the fact that sacrifice is an *action*—not an object. If Christ's sacrifice is an accomplished act, we might say that the sacrifice of the offerers is *in fieri*. In the following passage, Scotus makes the point neatly in pointing out the difference between the *offering* of the Eucharist and the Eucharist reserved in the pyx:

> [The fruit] does not correspond precisely to the good contained in the Eucharist, for that good is exactly the same when the Eucharist is reserved in the pyx, and nevertheless, it is not of the same efficacy for the church as when it is offered in the mass.… Clearly then, just as the Eucharist is *not fully acceptable precisely by reason of what is contained therein,* but it must be offered, so, too, the offering is not fully acceptable, except by reason of the *good will of some offerer.*[57]

To reiterate, the *oblatio* of sacrifice is an action inseparable from the internal affect of the one offering.

If the will of the offerer is crucial in "measuring" the fruit of the Mass-sacrifice, can it ever be the case that an utter lack of devotion—in the offering priest, the assistants, and the attending faithful—would curtail entirely the efficacy of the sacrifice? Even were such an extreme case to obtain, de la Taille answers negatively: the church *as a whole* is always the principal offerer and "wins without fail" acceptance for the oblation of the Christ-victim.[58] Invoking an Augustinian teaching, de la Taille confirms that the intervention of the entire church in the oblation is congruent with the nature of the sacrifice-sacrament. For, just as the body of the church is the *res tantum* of the eucharistic sacrament, so the oblation of this whole body is competently and sincerely offered only by the "whole Church (*totius Ecclesiae*)."[59] This *totius Ecclesiae* principle does not negate that my intention and *devotio* as an individual worshipper "count" in the offering of the sacrifice of the Mass. It does establish that the action of offering and the gift offered are not exclusively mine, but rather the common action and victim of the entire church. To be sure, the *devotio* of the church is not a constant reality: it is subject to both increase and diminishment. However, though it may

57. John Duns Scotus, *Quodlibeta quaestionum,* n. 20. For a modern translation, see Scotus, *God and Creatures: The Quodlibetal Questions by John Duns Scotus* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1975). The reference to Bellarmine is from *De missa,* bk. 2, c. 4, which can be found in Bellarmine, *De Controversiis Christianae Fidei,* vol. 3 (Rome: 1840); see *MF* 2:230–31.

58. *MF* 2:233.

59. *MF* 2:237; *MF,* 330.

be greater at one time than another, the sanctity granted it by the presence of Holy Spirit never perishes altogether.[60]

De la Taille pursues this question of the *devotio* further: is the *devotio* of the church members offering sacrifice rightly thought to be a mere *oblatio interna*? Obviously not, for this would not be sacrifice at all. De la Taille proposes that the desire of the faithful is "external" or outward in a twofold way. First and principally, it is externalized both in the public initiation of baptism, whereby every Christian is ordained (*ordinatur*) to offer the sacrifice of the church, by the ministry of priests, and in the rite of ordination, in which a baptized Christian is "publicly deputed" to present the sacrifice on behalf of the church.[61] We shall look with much greater depth in chapter 9 at the question of baptism and pragmatic, immolational participation in the ecclesial sacrifice. Let it suffice here to acknowledge that de la Taille highlights the *sacerdotal* character of baptism, insisting that baptism is a sharing in the priestly power of Christ, whereby Christ dedicated himself to God. He argues that this baptismal character means, at the very least, that every baptized Christian has the "habitual desire of being conformed to Christ in offering to God the unique victim of our salvation."[62] The priest, on the other hand, is ritually deputed to *give expression* to the desire and intention of the faithful. As the Syrian Narsai seems to have coined, the priest is the "tongue of the Church."[63] There is a second way that the desire of the worshipper is externalized: the liturgical formulae themselves give "open expression" to the desire of the offering community. De la Taille suggests, for instance, that the eucharistic dialogue, the *Amen,* and the kiss of peace are all manifestations of the offerers' *votum* in the Mass-sacrifice.[64]

60. *MF* 2:239. This concept of the "offering Church," though not new with de la Taille, has not gained unanimous theological support. As mentioned above, in note 48, Rahner, in the interest of "a more personal sacramentalism," denies that the concept has validity; see David Burrell, "Many Masses," 116.

61. *MF* 2:237.

62. *MF* 2:236.

63. *MF* 2:237n2.

64. *MF* 2:260–66. See Thomas's discussion of the "formation" of that desire by the liturgical rite itself in *ST* III, q. 83, a. 4. Catherine Pickstock provocatively unfolds this liturgical shaping of desire in her article "St. Thomas and the Quest for the Eucharist," *Modern Theology* 15, no. 2 (1999): 159–80.

To sum up, from the perspective of the gift offered in the ecclesial sacrifice, the fruit of the sacrifice *ex opere operato* is of infinite value. However, the church's actual oblation at a particular eucharistic liturgy does determine "accidentally" the fruit of that sacrifice, according to the fervor of the offerers themselves. The limitation of the fruit is thus by way of potentiality and capacity. An analogy to sacramental disposition is illuminative here. Just as sacraments sanctify "by the virtue of the sacrament itself," this sanctification is effected in proportion to one's disposition to *receive* that grace. So, too, the sacrifice: though an "inexhaustible fount of benefit," its fruits are proportioned to the devotion of the offerers. Put differently, and with an emphasis upon participation in Christ's oblation, each offerer, according to his desire, his capacity ("*suo captu*"), can exhibit to God as his own that gift of infinite proportion.

Conclusion

This chapter and the previous have displayed how de la Taille's eucharistic theology, shaped by a theory of sacrifice, both distinguishes and unites the acts of oblation and immolation, setting the former in a new and essential light. The supper and cross are thereby seen as a single unified sacrifice; the Mass becomes a *commemoratio* and *repraesentatio* not simply of the crucifixion (immolation, strictly speaking), but of the *supper-cross sacrifice*. The externalized intention or will of Christ in offering himself as victim to the Father takes a central place. Concomitantly, *devotio* is underscored as crucial to the ecclesial oblation, as well. We likewise explored how the eternity of the accepted victim figures in de la Taille's way of construing the unity of the Mass and the supper-cross sacrifice: the victim offered is the same, and Christ, who offered once, now offers virtually through the church; he permits the ecclesial oblation to participate in his own.

De la Taille uniquely develops that the *modus oblationis* mystically closes the "gap" between Christ's sacrifice and that of the church, making of both a "true and proper" sacrifice. Moreover, we have noted that the nature of sacrifice as sign and gift elucidates de la Taille's theology

of the eucharistic prayer. For de la Taille, the external/internal tension endemic to sacrifice demands that the words of consecration be fully signifying—of Christ's intention at the supper, and of the church's intention at the Mass. I argued, further, that de la Taille's own theory would be better served by granting a fuller scope and role to the epiclesis, precisely as exhibiting the desire of the church in its eucharistic offering. Finally, we began to demonstrate how the affect of the offerer *measures* the fruits of the sacrifice.

We can now turn to de la Taille's theology of grace, which, I maintain, resonates profoundly with his theology of eucharistic sacrifice. The resonance is not merely accidental, but decidedly organic. His understanding of sanctifying grace, the reality of deifying union with God, does not stand apart from the *oblatio* and *devotio* of the worshipper. We shall see, in other words, that sacrifice rightly precedes and is correlative to the sanctifying grace of eucharistic union.

4 Eucharistic Union and Divinization

In the first three chapters on eucharistic sacrifice, I have elucidated de la Taille's theory of sacrifice, highlighting his nuanced use of the dynamic aspects of gift: oblation and *devotio*. I have intended to diffuse a crude view of his thought and to reveal that his theology of sacrifice is solidly rooted both in scripture and in the patristic literature of the East and West. The second part of this study retrieves de la Taille's thought on sanctifying grace, an aspect of his eucharistic treatise that contributes crucially to a proper understanding sacrifice. This integral connection between sacrifice and grace should not surprise. In the church's oblation of the acceptable victim (immolated now *in mysterio*), God accepts the offerers as his table guests in a divinizing banquet: a theology of grace is anticipated—even patent—here.

It is the burden of these next three chapters to explicate de la Taille's intricately elaborated and profound reflections on the topic of grace. I shall suggest that de la Taille, without contesting a Thomistic understanding of sanctifying grace, is nonetheless inclined to the Greek patristic point of departure, one that underscores *uncreated*—rather than created—grace. That is to say, de la Taille is more interested in exploring divine indwelling, more interested in beginning with the intimate presence and initiative of the holy Trinity uniting itself to the human soul, than he is with a focus upon habitual grace and the created gifts. I shall nuance this thesis as we proceed. For now, I simply note that this

shift in approach,[1] if not in doctrine, commands attention in our effort to give a genuine interpretation of de la Taille's theology of eucharistic sacrifice.

Historical Context: The Controversy concerning Nature and the Supernatural

Before proceeding with an explication of book 3, we pause to make some historically situating observations about de la Taille's work on grace. The first half of the twentieth century gives witness to a renewed exploration of the theological topic of grace, a discourse that becomes intensely focused on the correct interpretation of Thomas on the relationship between nature and grace. Controversy among interpreters of Thomas reached an apex with the publication of Henri de Lubac's *Surnaturel* (1946) and the responsive encyclical of Pius XII, *Humani Generis* (1950). At the core of the grace controversy lies this question: is it indeed the case that a human (and humans in community) can arrive at happiness and *completion* in and through the power and goodness of created natural capacities, thereby construing grace and supernatural existence as something extrinsic to—added to—the nature and destiny of man? Or, rather, are human beings so created with a defining supernatural destiny (*visio Dei*) that grace is intrinsic—and indeed *necessary*—for all human flourishing and perfection? If grace is so intrinsically conceived, is the divine bestowal of grace really *gift?* The former possibility,[2] often affixed with the name "pure nature theology," allows,

1. P. Edgar Hocedez, *Histoire de la Théologie au XIXe Siècle,* vol. 3, *Le Règne de Léon XIII, 1878–1903,* provides an engaging account of the nineteenth-century theological "*problem*" concerning sanctifying grace and the question of filial adoption (254–259). Hocedez details the importance of Scheeben's work (*Handbuch der katholischen Dogmatik,* 1882), which insists upon a close reading of the Greek fathers on the question of the *consortium divinae naturae.* While Scheeben was attacked for suggesting that participation in the divine nature (and filial adoption) was, above all, an effect of the substantial presence of the Holy Spirit in the soul (instead of a special supernatural assimilation of the soul by created grace), his retrieval of the Greek fathers opened up new possibilities for considering the relationship between created and uncreated grace. De la Taille favorably cites the work of Scheeben's *Handbuch* in book 1 of *Mysterium Fidei,* particularly when considering questions of the celestial sacrifice and teachings on Christ as altar and priest (*MF* 1:156, 179, 265). Although he does not refer specifically to Scheeben when he is writing on the topic of grace, I strongly suspect de la Taille's familiarity and sympathy with Scheeben's thought on grace and his retrieval of Eastern patristic thought.

2. This reading is frequently attributed initially to Cajetan, the influential sixteenth-century

at least hypothetically, for a natural human end that can be achieved through capacities natural to rational beings (surely a just Aristotelian reading of Thomas)—even if that end is finally imperfect (theologically speaking). Such a perspective seems to *secure* the utter gratuity of grace, a gratuity that Pius XII sought to safeguard in *Humani Generis*. The second position, advocated by *nouvelle théologie* and articulated authoritatively by de Lubac, dismantles any sharp divorce between the natural and the supernatural in rational creatures; it embraces the Thomistic paradox that humans have been created with a *genuinely* natural desire for the vision of God, a vision that nonetheless cannot be attained without the supernatural elevation of the human (through grace) to a participation in the divine. Put differently, God intends this end of divine union for all, God instills the desire for this end as part of the makeup of every human creature, and God grants this end only by raising human nature through his own divine assistance.

De Lubac's argument generated a good deal of theological anxiety.[3] Does it not collapse the proper distinction between the natural and the supernatural? Does it not somehow "bind" God to fulfilling the natural propensity of the human soul? Does not grace thereby become something pedantic—unsurprising and a "right" for all rational creatures? And does this not vitiate a genuine realm of human autonomy, an autonomy that Thomas advocates in his ethical and sociopolitical reflections? As later twentieth-century theology reveals (especially the work of Karl Rahner and Bernard Lonergan),[4] de Lubac and *nouvelle théologie*

interpreter of Thomas. Yet it had equally strong proponents among Suarez and the Dominican theologians of Salamanca, who understood Thomas's *desiderium naturale* as a vague, if innate "velleity," and then in Bellarmine, who crystallized the notion of two tiers: natural and the supernatural; see Fergus Kerr's discussion of the grace "quarrels" in *After Aquinas: Versions of Thomism* (Oxford: Blackwell, 2002), 134–38. Stephen A. Long's recent publication, *Natura pura: On the Recovery of Nature in the Doctrine of Grace* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2010) retrieves this line of interpretation, claiming that Thomas did indeed have a notion of a proportionate natural end for human creatures; cf. footnote 5, below.

3. And a good deal of personal offense, as Fergus Kerr notes in *After Aquinas* (136–37)! De Lubac audaciously attacked almost every revered interpreter of Thomas, including his magisterial contemporaries Garrigou-Lagrange, George Tyrell, and A.-D. Sertillanges.

4. See Brian Shanley's *The Thomistic Tradition* (Dordrecht: Kluwer Academic, 2002), 166–78, for a prescient exposition of Rahner's struggle with the nature/grace question. Bernard Lonergan, S.J., would also wrestle with the *nouvelle théologie* proposal in *Grace and Freedom: Operative Grace in the Thought of St. Thomas Aquinas,* edited by Frederick Crowe and Robert Doran (Toron-

did not adequately answer these difficulties—if indeed such a paradox is ultimately "answerable." Even so, I think Fergus Kerr neatly summarizes the enduring influence of de Lubac's critique of *natura pura* with the following words: "Few now doubt that when Thomas taught that human beings have a natural desire for the vision of God he meant what he said."[5]

Granted, I have oversimplified a very complex debate of the 1940s and 1950s. However, my intent in setting up clearly defined boundaries in this controversy is to imagine where de la Taille might have declared his own mind had he lived a decade longer and entered the debate in a direct way. Earlier, in the Introduction, I labeled de la Taille a forerunner of the *nouvelle théologie* movement, yet also pointed out that he repeatedly shows his independence as a thinker and interpreter of Thomas. The question remains whether we have any clear evidence that de la Taille would align himself with de Lubac in this "quarrel" over grace. Can anything be said definitively *sans* his manuscript *De gratia, sans* his own careful analysis of key texts from the Thomistic corpus?

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to: University of Toronto Press, 2000). Contemporary attention to this question is exemplified, *inter alia,* by John Milbank's recent book on de Lubac: *The Suspended Middle: Henri de Lubac and the Debate Concerning the Supernatural* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2005), which is critical of Lawrence Feingold's *The Natural Desire to See God According to St. Thomas Aquinas and His Interpreters,* 2nd ed. (Ave Maria, Fla.: Ave Maria Press, 2010), and by the recent issue of *Nova et Vetera* 5, no. 1 (English ed., 2007).

5. Kerr, *After Aquinas,* 137. We must note, however, that Feingold's *The Natural Desire to See God* and Reinhard Hütter's essay "*Desiderium Naturale Visionis Dei—Est autem duplex hominis beatitudo sive felicitas:* Some Observations about Lawrence Feingold's and John Milbanks's Recent Interventions in the Debate over the Natural Desire to See God," *Nova et Vetera* 5, no. 1 (2007): 81–131, remarkably nuance this question of a natural desire in the creature to see God. Feingold and Hütter want to emphasize that Thomas allows, hypothetically, for a notion of pure nature—that is, a notion that the human being, given its constitution as a spiritual being, does enjoy natural desires (*naturalia desideria*—desires given by the creator of human nature) for earthly or connatural happiness, including, for example, the natural desire for the body and soul to be always united, as well as the natural capacities to achieve that happiness. All creatures naturally desire their cause, the source of all created perfections. But the desire to see God face-to-face, the desire for a union to God that is also a participation in the divine nature, is *not innate,* and so surpasses the nature of the rational creature that it must be given by God. Specifically, the human is moved to this supernatural end by the Holy Spirit. To summarize, both natural and supernatural desires are God-given, and the latter builds upon the former, as it were. Still, considering the *de facto* reality of sin, the natural desires of the human being—any more than the supernatural desires—cannot be achieved without divine assistance, without the superadded gifts of grace. The notion of "pure nature" allows us to distinguish between the human condition as created, and human nature *sub conditione peccati;* see Hütter's illuminating discussion, 98–118.

Perhaps a telling clue to de la Taille's sympathies appears in de Lubac's own *Mémoires*. In a set of diary notes, recorded to assist his recollection of the unfolding events of 1946–1947 (when his *Surnaturel* was under close scrutiny and his teaching career in jeopardy), de Lubac mentions a meeting with Père de Boynes, a congenial if theologically conservative Vicar General at Rome. The September 26, 1946 entry reveals this significant reference to de la Taille:

> A visit to Père de Boynes. I know that he had distrusted me for a long time. Very kind,—though it was he who directed the interview. He amicably signaled to me that Père Maurice de la Taille, in his projected work on grace, had sent walking the idea of "pure nature."[6]

If we accept the suspicious de Boynes's statement as accurate, de la Taille's reading of Thomas on grace and the natural desire for union with God might well have resonated with de Lubac's.[7]

Yet, quite apart from this diary entry, de la Taille's extant writings leave strong hints about the inclination of his mind on the nature/grace question. In the course of this chapter, it will become evident, first, that de la Taille's eucharistically rooted theory of grace denies a strictly two-tiered understanding of nature and grace. To underscore the movement of the will in eucharistic oblation already points to the reality that grace and sanctification are not a *creatio de novo* in human nature: the worshipper brings something of her "own"—desires natural and supernatural—to the altar, even if the intention of the heart to offer is itself elicited by God. Secondly, de la Taille casts desire for union with the divine as dependent upon the prior gift of grace won, possessed, and dispensed through the sacrificial victim (chapter 5). Eucharistic grace is the very source of the desire for transformative union with God, a point advocated by his assertion of the presence of, and indeed the efficacy of, a desire for the Eucharist in worshipping communities *antecedent* to the Christian sacrifice. We shall see, thirdly, that "created actuation by uncreated Act" (chapter 6), based on a vision of divine

6. I am very grateful to Philip McCosker for discovering this reference in Henri de Lubac, *Mémoires sur l'occasion de mes écrits* (Brussels: Culture et Véritée, 1989), 254 (my translation).

7. This Roman reference to de la Taille's "lost" treatise, aligning it with de Lubac's condemned book, may well suggest why this treatise-in-the-making seems to have disappeared without a trace.

self-donation as foundational to the union of sanctifying grace, sheds a surprising light on de la Taille's concept of supernatural elevation. I propose that de la Taille, like de Lubac himself, welcomed the kind of mystery and paradox posed by the reality of a *desiderium naturale* for God, an inherent created desire that nevertheless must be granted a gratuitous and supernatural assistance to achieve its end of union.[8] We turn now to an exposition of eucharistic grace in *Mysterium Fidei*.

Grace in *Mysterium Fidei*

In the yet untranslated *Liber* III ("De sacramento") of *Mysterium Fidei,* de la Taille takes up the theological questions surrounding the Eucharist *as sacrament* (as opposed to, but surely not disconnected with, the Eucharist *as sacrifice*).[9] Elucidations XXXVI–L treat such topics as the nature of the Eucharist as a sacrament; the relationship of the various levels of the sacrament (*sacramentum tantum, res et sacramentum, res tantum*); the question of concomitance; the mystery of incorporation to Christ; desire in baptism and in the Eucharist; the necessity of the Eucharist and its position vis-à-vis the other sacraments; and the question of transubstantiation. It is here, in this third part of his work, that a theology of grace explicitly surfaces. In fact, in a series of appendices attached to his treatment of the *res tantum* of the Eucharist, de la Taille writes a veritable mini-treatise *de gratia*. Given that his projected treatise on this topic will likely remain undiscovered, our exposition of de la Taille's theory of grace depends preponderantly upon *Liber* III of *Mysterium Fidei*.[10]

8. Cf. Hans Boersma's significant discussion of *nouvelle théologie* and de Lubac in "'*Néoplatonisme belgo-français*': *Nouvelle théologie* and the Search for a Sacramental Ontology," *Louvain Studies* 32 (2007): 333–60. Boersma describes De Lubac's "neo-Platonic mindset" and openness to mystery as something especially acquired from his deep reading of the fathers and medieval theologians. More, he identifies de Lubac's theological vision as "*sacramental in character*" (338; 352–53). It is not difficult to project an intellectual sympathy between de la Taille and de Lubac.

9. Recall, as we recognized at the beginning of this study, that de la Taille has departed from the typical theological pedagogy of scholastic and post-Tridentine theology, opting to present the Eucharist as sacrifice *before* considering the Eucharist as sacrament.

10. De la Taille himself distinctly mentions the purported manuscript *De gratia* four times in book 3 of *Mysterium Fidei* (*MF,* 491; 522n2; 575n1; 600n1), making a total of six references throughout the whole of *Mysterium Fidei*. The appendices in book 3 prove especially valuable, not only for supplying us with his theology of grace in relationship to the Eucharist, but also for indicating how de la Taille's thought on grace was taking shape systematically before 1920.

Fortunately, however, de la Taille would return to the topic of grace in another forum: two journal articles written in the 1920s. In 1928 (seven years after the first edition of *Mysterium Fidei*), de la Taille published an article entitled "*Actuation créée par acte incréé*" in the journal *Recherches de science religieuse.* This article was followed in 1929 by an amplifying and clarifying piece written after the fashion of a Platonic dialogue, "*Entretien amical d'Eudoxe et de Palamède sur la grâce d'union,*" which appeared in *Revue apologétique.*[11] These two essays provide a crucial and more explicitly metaphysical articulation of de la Taille's theology of grace, which will be taken up in chapter 6. If the eucharistic scope of *Mysterium Fidei* treats divine indwelling primarily in terms of scripture, tradition, and sacramental signification, the point of departure in these later writings is, decidedly, a Thomistic metaphysics of act and potency. Within these two different articulations, however, the common denominator is a keenness for the uncreated gift of divine union to the soul.

Whether or not de la Taille's later metaphysical formulation constitutes any genuine shift in his central insights on grace will be a question addressed fully in due course. Let two observations suffice for now. First, the two different articulations pose no contradiction; in fact, "created actuation by uncreated Act" is a theory de la Taille applies *to* sanctifying grace (as well as to the beatific vision and the incarnation). As I shall suggest, the journal essays reveal a certain genetic dependence upon his understanding of grace in the eucharistic context. Secondly, the metaphysical articulation of these later journal articles undeniably accounts for de la Taille's enduring theological contribution. A set of essays in the 1940s and 1950s (primarily in the journal *Theological Studies*) amply witnesses to the generativity of the concept of created actuation.[12] It not only spawned a renewed interest in considering the

11. These two de la Taille essays, "Created Actuation by Uncreated Act" and "Dialogue on the Grace of Union," along with a third entitled "The Schoolmen" (originally a conference paper given at the University of Cambridge in 1925), were translated and published in book form: *The Hypostatic Union and Created Actuation by Uncreated Act* (West Baden Springs, Ind.: West Baden College, 1952). I will be using this English translation, except where de la Taille's native French proves illuminating.

12. What follows is a partial list of the essays written in response to de la Taille's theory of created actuation. Note that the majority of these articles were written several years after de

metaphysics of the hypostatic union, but also percolated new questions about the Trinitarian structure of grace in the souls of the just. The "after life" of this seminal concept of creative actuation in the mid-twentieth-century *risorgimento* of Catholic thought on grace is a theological story worth tracing.[13] That narrative, unfortunately, is outside the scope of this study. However, I do want to draw attention to what the expositors of de la Taille's metaphysical articulation of grace have all failed to note: the *connection* between his published articles on grace and his eucharistic reflection on grace in *Mysterium Fidei*.[14]

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la Taille's death in 1933. For the most part (I will note a few exceptions), these articles largely applaud de la Taille's "new" construal of grace and the supernatural. I refer the reader to this literature for an appreciation of de la Taille's significance and the widespread interest in this topic during in the first half of the twentieth century. Prudence de Letter, "Sanctifying Grace and our Union with the Holy Trinity," *TS* 13, no. 1 (1952): 33–38; de Letter, "Created Actuation by the Uncreated Act: Difficulties and Answers," *TS* 18, no. 1 (1957): 60–92; de Letter, "Grace, Incorporation, Inhabitation," *TS* 19, no. 1 (1958): 1–31; de Letter, "The Theology of God's Self-Gift," *TS* 24 (1963): 402–22; Malachai Donnelly, S.J., "The Theory of R.P. Maurice de la Taille, S.J., on the Hypostatic Union," *TS* 2 (1941): 510–26; Donnelly, "The Inhabitation of the Holy Spirit: A Solution According to de la Taille," *TS* 8 (1947): 445–70; Donnelly, "Sanctifying Grace and our Union with the Holy Trinity. A Reply," *TS* 13 (1952): 190–204. In a more skeptical vein, William O'Connor, "New Concept of Grace and the Supernatural," *American Ecclesiastical Review* 98 (1938): 401–13; and O'Connor, "The Theory of the Supernatural: A Critique of P. de la Taille," *TS* 3 (1942): 403–12. Perhaps the most strident criticism of de la Taille's theory was written by the Dominican Thomas U. Mullaney in "The Incarnation: De la Taille vs. the Thomistic Tradition," *The Thomist* 17 (1954): 1–42. Lonergan also had reservations about de la Taille's theory; see especially *De Verbo Incarnato* (Rome: Gregorian University Press, 1960), 336–53. Both Guy Mansini, O.S.B., and Matthew Lamb repeat Lonergan's view: Mansini in *The Word Dwelt Among Us* (Ave Maria, Fla.: Sapientia Press, 2008, 15–26); and Matthew L. Lamb, in "An Analogy for the Divine Self-Gift," *Lonergan Workshop* 14 (1998): 115–54. Most recently, Matthew Sutton has favorably retrieved de la Taille's theory of created actuation, suggesting that his thought supplies a needed supplement to the Christology of Karl Rahner: Sutton, "*Mysterium Christi:* The Christologies of Maurice de la Taille and Karl Rahner," *International Journal of Systematic Theology* 10, no. 4 (2008): 416–30.

13. This "after life" is primarily due to an inter-Jesuit conversation between the relative value of the approaches of de la Taille, Karl Rahner, and Bernard Lonergan. While Prudence de Letter attempts to bring together the thought of these three thinkers ("The Theology of Self-Gift"), accenting how each is similar and complementary, Matthew Lamb and Guy Mansini (see note 12, above) take a much less irenic approach, underlining the significant difference between de la Taille and Lonergan, and elevating Lonergan's construal of grace as the more adequate—philosophically and theologically.

14. I imagine that de la Taille's treatise *De gratia* would have reflected the structure and method of *Mysterium Fidei*—that is, it would have been a synthetically written account of grace, one that pointedly integrated the various questions falling under the genus of grace (e.g., sin, hypostatic union, sanctifying grace and sacramental grace, eucharistic union with Christ, divinization, the necessity of the Eucharist, divine indwelling, contemplative union). Such an integrated approach does not seem to have been the model for treatments of grace among the generation of theologians that followed de la Taille.

Consequently, this first chapter devoted to de la Taille's thought on grace will explicate substantially the contours of his theology of grace as gleaned from *Liber* III of *Mysterium Fidei,* that is, from his treatment of the Eucharist as sacrament. Eucharistic union with Christ clearly frames the *topos* of grace in *Mysterium Fidei*. More particularly, de la Taille's ordered schema indicates that a theology of grace properly begins with the grace of Christ, for all grace is a *participation* in Christ's grace, a participation granted through the flesh of the God-Man. We shall attend at some length to de la Taille's scriptural and patristic reflection on union with Christ and the church—the proper effect of the sacrament of the Eucharist. In the course of this presentation, I shall argue for the significant role that Cyril of Alexandria plays in shaping de la Taille's understanding of the flow of grace to human beings.

Chapter 5 follows with de la Taille's more systematic treatment of the nature of grace, detailing the topics of grace in Christ, of sin and sanctifying grace, and of sacramental grace as it intersects the dynamic of desire within the economy of the church. De la Taille reflects carefully upon the relationship in Christ between the grace of union and habitual grace, providing unmistakable intimations of his later writing on created actuation.

Our third chapter on grace (chapter 6) goes beyond the foundational material found in *Mysterium Fidei* and explores de la Taille's theory of "Created Actuation by Uncreated Act," with its illuminating analogy between sanctifying grace, *lumen gloriae*, and hypostatic union (the grace of union). Created actuation, I shall submit, is an insight shaped *by his eucharistic theology,* as well as by a Thomistic metaphysics of knowledge, act, and potency. I thus hope to add to previous expositions of de la Taille what generally has been overlooked—namely, that his "scholastic" thought on grace emerges from a context of eucharistic sacrifice. The question of divine indwelling cannot be conceived fully apart from an acknowledgment of the eucharistic grace bestowed in partaking of the flesh and blood of Christ.

My presentation thus will be alert particularly to the relationship between de la Taille's thought on grace and eucharistic sacrifice, an approach corroborated by an unpublished letter written in 1921. In this

letter, he owns that his treatment of the Eucharist in book 3 focuses less upon the sacrament's "*rapports*" with the incarnation and more upon its "*rapports*" with "*le sacrifice de la redemption*." Why? De la Taille does not adopt this method simply because it harmonizes with the sacrificial concept that shapes the whole of *Mysterium Fidei*. Rather, he focuses on the fundamental link between redemption and the Eucharist because both the church's prolongation of the incarnation in the sacraments and the believer's incorporation to Christ *depend* upon a participation in the sacrificial victim. After all, the grace and glory into which we are led by the Eucharist is, "in the present economy," "the crowning of the sacrifice (*le couronnement du sacrifice*)."[15] The point may seem overly obvious. However, de la Taille is here stepping off the theological track that prevailed in his era. True enough, Thomas in the *Tertia Pars* of the *Summa* treats the sacraments as (instrumental) extensions of the incarnation; yet, he likewise delineates that the entire sacramental life of the church flows from the side of Christ upon the Cross (see, for example, *ST* III, q. 61, a. 1, ad 3; q. 64, a. 5, c). De la Taille finds this second sacrificial and concorporative perspective most "urgent," noting that the incarnation-sacramental view can be found in "other places (*ailleurs*)"—indeed, "everywhere (*partout*)." The sacrificial angle, on the other hand, is infrequently accented, *even though* it sustains that approach to the sacraments that departs from the incarnation.[16]

Thus, to anticipate the material ahead in these three chapters on grace, two underlying *idées* give substance and shape to de la Taille's treatment of grace and the sacraments in book 3 of *Mysterium Fidei*. First, Christ is the Head and Source of the grace of redemption as the victim of the sacrificial banquet, thereby making our participation in that saving grace dependent upon the Eucharist. There is no other ac-

15. I am quoting here from a letter dated "29 août 1921, Villa du Sacré-Coeur," which is collected at the Jesuit Archives in Vanves, outside of Paris. I am grateful to Père Robert Bonfils, S.J., for granting me permission to look through the letters of Maurice de la Taille. (The addressee is uncertain, but the letter leaves clues that its recipient might have been the writer of a review of *Mysterium Fidei* published in the journal *Études*.) "Pour ce qui est du troisième livre, sur le Sacrement, il est parfaitement vrai que j'ai eu pour objet l'étude de sacrement dans les rapports avec le sacrifice de la rédemption.… Il importe donc de bien montrer que le prolongement de l'incarnation dans l'Eglise doit se concevoir en dépendence de la participation de l'Eglise à l'hostie du sacrifice. C'est ce que j'ai eu l'intention de montrer un peu partout dans le 3° livre."

16. De la Taille, letter, 29 août 1921, Villa du Sacré-Coeur.

cess to the redeeming grace of Christ apart from his eucharistic flesh. Second, I shall demonstrate that a salient theology of *intentio* undergirds his discussion of the sacrament of the Eucharist—as it did his theory of sacrifice. In effect, *desire for* the Eucharist is grace itself, and thereby effective of that intimate union to Christ the victim.

For the most part, our discussion of de la Taille's thought on grace follows the outline suggested by his own structured exposition in book 3 of *Mysterium Fidei* (Elucidations XXXVI–L). The book is divided into four chapters, the first of which takes up the basic question of *whether* the Eucharist is a sacrament, and if so, what kind of sacrament (Elucidations XXXVI–XXXVIII). The second, and for our purposes most critical chapter, addresses the different levels of the sacrament (*sacramentum tantum, res et sacramentum, res tantum*), the relationship between these realities and their causal power, and how the Eucharist compares with the other six sacraments (Elucidations XXXIX–XLVIII). As mentioned above, a discussion of the *res tantum* of the Eucharist provides the springboard for de la Taille's "treatise" on grace. A third chapter (Elucidation XLIX) follows with an examination of the question of the *necessity of the Eucharist* (is it an absolute necessity or a necessity of means?), exploring the critical role of desire in the Eucharist and the distinction between spiritual and corporeal eating. This Elucidation, particularly rich in reflection upon the dynamic of desire in both baptism and the Eucharist, will figure prominently at the end of this study, where baptism and sacrifice are compared and correlated. In the final and lengthy Elucidation L (chapter 4), de la Taille addresses "the conditions of eucharistic presence"—various theories of eucharistic conversion, the duration of eucharistic presence, the relationship between the accidents of the species, and the substantial reality of Christ's presence. I shall not incorporate de la Taille's extensive philosophical arguments against "erroneous" conversion theories (e.g., theories of adduction and reproduction); we need only note that his defense of transubstantiation is—by his own admission—driven by a concern to protect the unity between the historical and eucharistic body, so that the body received in the Eucharist be the same victimal body offered to God for our salvation, the same body that is the fountain of grace.

In the remaining pages of this chapter, we shall attend to de la Taille's telling slant on how the Eucharist is *sacrament,* and then look closely at his "demonstration" of the believer's union to Christ in the sacrament of the Eucharist. This demonstration, largely *ex scriptura et traditione,* reveals the centrality of deifying union and the gift of uncreated grace. Here, the sharp influence of Cyril of Alexandria emerges in a striking manner.

Of What Is the Eucharist a Sacrament?

De la Taille begins with a traditional reminder, taken from Thomas (*ST* III, q. 60, a. 2 and 3) who himself looks to Augustine, that a sacrament is generally understood to be "the sign of a sacred thing that sanctifies man."[17] Given this point of departure, de la Taille proceeds to inquire about the cause and end of sanctification. That which ultimately sanctifies is the passion of Christ, and this sanctification occurs through the "form" of sanctifying grace and for the purpose of heavenly glory. Hence the Eucharist properly can be called a sacrament if it signifies these three things: passion, grace, glory. Because he has dealt earlier in the work with the sacrificial signification of the Eucharist,[18] de la Taille moves quickly to the central subject of book 3—namely, how the Eucharist is *a sacrament of grace and glory.* To the point, the sacramental signification of grace and glory coincides with "partaking in the sacrifice itself of our salvation through the Eucharist."[19]

This partaking in the sacrificial banquet of the Eucharist has a double aspect: a distinction between *sign* and *signified* leads de la Taille's reflection here. What is the *sign* of partaking in this redeeming sacrificial feast? Simply enough, it is the eating of the victim in the Eucharist. But more interesting to de la Taille is the question of *what is signified* by the believer's partaking of the sacrificial banquet. And the answer is more complex. First, that which is signified pertains to "future life, namely

17. *MF,* 475.

18. For de la Taille, the separate species of bread and wine, along with the signifying words indicating body and blood, bear forth the image of Christ's immolation in the passion. Thus the consecrated bread and cup is the sign of the Lord's passion (see Elucidations XVII, XX, XXII).

19. *MF,* 475.

sharing in the divine goods of heaven" (glory); the second signification (grace), however, refers to the present time and is again twofold. Partaking of the Eucharist signifies (1) a present spiritual union with God, or "a sanctification of those eating, who are led, as it were, into divine holiness through the victim who himself possesses divine sanctity"; and (2) a present spiritual union between those who have eaten, as they become "sharers (*consortes*) in the one divine food"—or, in other and rather more startling words, those who have partaken become "one in substance," *consubstantiales,* in and through their eating of the divine victim.[20] In the first signified communion with God, partaking of the eucharistic body and blood indicates a share in the holiness and gifts achieved in the acceptance of the victim. There is, so to speak, a contagion of divinity spreading from the victim that effects the union to God. Ecclesial union, on the other hand, is signified both in the commensality of the eucharistic sacrifice and, more importantly, de la Taille suggests, by partaking of the one divine food that transforms believers into a single substance or body. Hence the Eucharist is a threefold *sacrament of union* in which incorporation to Christ is perfected: partaking of the Eucharist signifies union to Christ—and thereby to the Father, it signifies union to one another, and it signifies union to "the glorious resurrection."[21]

Because the Eucharist is a particular kind of sign, a *practical* sign, it *causes* these three effects by signifying them. In regard to the present effect—union with Christ and with the ecclesial body—the sacrament of the Eucharist clearly indicates and thereby causes this union by indicating it (*demonstrando inferens*); in regard to the future effect of resurrection, that resurrection is procured in the promising.[22] That the effects of grace and glory are caused by the efficacy of the eucharistic food and not, for example, by the *affect* of the one receiving,[23] is a truth

20. *MF,* 475.

21. *MF,* 475.

22. "Est enim signum practicum, id est significando causans significatum: effectum quidem praesentem demonstrans, at demonstrando inferens; effectum autem futurum spondens, et spondendo procurans"; *MF,* 475–76.

23. De la Taille acknowledges this sixteenth-century-inaugurated debate over the causality of the Eucharist. His tone is one that suggests that the *ex opere operato* debate is put to rest by

that de la Taille supports from scripture and the early teaching of the church. In fact, he finds it "more surprising" that the causal power of the eucharistic bread and wine could be *denied* on the basis of scripture.

In a section substantial in length, he proceeds to unfold the mind of Paul, the Gospel of John, and the thought of the early fathers on the question of sacramental causality and eucharistic incorporation. Beyond his desire to establish "proof" that the Eucharist effects such incorporation, we can discern here de la Taille's predilection both for discoursing on the Eucharist as the *sacramentum communionis ad Christum* and for identifying the intimacy of that union in terms of a sanctifying participation (grace) in the divine *through the flesh of Christ*. It is illuminating to observe the theological texts and images that he employs for eucharistic union, for they critically frame his later systematic presentation on grace. Given de la Taille's principal lens of sacrifice, the key scriptural and patristic passages brought forward speak, somewhat predictably, to the following matters: the importance of the altar, the divinizing effect of eating the victim's flesh, the intimacy of the communion achieved in the Eucharist, and the beginning of resurrected life through union to Christ. Once again, we note that a preference for the eastern fathers shapes his discussion of these topics.

Deifying Union (Grace), Ecclesial Union, Resurrecting Union

De la Taille's teaching about eucharistic union *ad Christum* is fundamentally rooted in two New Testament passages: 1 Cor. 10:16–21, in which a sacrificial perspective regarding participation in the altar emerges, and John 6:56–57, in which de la Taille considers the indwelling promised by Christ in Eucharist. His profound exposition of these passages manifests the divinizing intimacy of eucharistic union. After beginning with scripture, de la Taille gathers patristic as well as medieval sources to further underline that this union is achieved only through the flesh of the assumed humanity.

scripture and tradition; *MF,* 476. But lest the reader jump to the erroneous conclusion that de la Taille has a strictly mechanical view of the sacraments, recall the distinction—and tight connection—that de la Taille holds concerning the *active* offering of the sacrifice and the *passive* reception of the eucharistic fruits of grace; see *MF,* 616–17, and chapter 3 of this volume.

The cup of blessing that we bless, is it not a participation in the blood of Christ? The bread that we break, is it not a participation in the body of Christ? Because the loaf of bread is one, we, though many, are one body, for we all partake of the one loaf. Look at Israel according to the flesh; are not those who eat the sacrifices participants in the altar? So what am I saying? That meat sacrificed to idols is anything? Or that an idol is anything? No, I mean that what they sacrifice, [they sacrifice] to demons, not to God, and I do not want you to become participants with demons. You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and also the cup of demons. You cannot partake of the table of the Lord and of the table of demons (1 Cor. 10:16–21).[24]

I quote this Corinthian passage in full because de la Taille's distinctive reflection relies heavily upon Paul's manner of linking sacrifice and altar with the concept of κοινωνία ("participation"). At this point in his exposition, de la Taille is less interested in Paul's notion of the ecclesial bond between members of the body, a bond effected by the partaking of the one cup and loaf. Rather, he wants to urge that the word κοινωνία points to something more profound yet—namely, that in those eating there is a "sharing (*consortium*)" in "the sanctity inhering in Christ as victim."[25] De la Taille demonstrates this by rehearsing the anatomy of sacrifice. In every sacrifice, the gift (*hostiam*) is made holy *through* the altar of the divine, the altar that stands as the "vicarious seat" of God, the holy "fountain" of sanctity. Therefore, as the victim is "sanctified and sanctifying" through the altar, so those who partake of the victim "acquire some share of the sanctification from God," derived from the victim by way of the altar.

But the sanctity of the victim is not distinct from the sanctity of the altar, which is not distinct from the holiness of God. In fact, the one who is sharer of the first [the holiness of the victim], also is partaker of the second [the altar] and of the third [God]. More, unless there is an altar—sanctified and sanctifying, no victim is desired; neither is the altar required except on account of the holiness of God. Just so, one does not come into the holiness of God unless made to pass through the altar, to which the way is opened through the victim.[26]

24. It should be noted that de la Taille is citing, both here and with his exposition of John 6, the Greek New Testament texts, which no doubt makes a difference to how he imagines union and participation.

25. "Attamen voce κοινωνία aliquid plus enuntiatur quam ipsa demum manducatio corporis ac sanguinis Christi; sed asseritur inesse manducantibus quodam consortium sanctitatis inhaerentis Christo ut hostiae"; *ME,* 476.

26. "Sanctitas autem hostiae non est alia a sanctitate altaris, quae non est alia a sanctitate

De la Taille's point in connecting God's holiness to the sanctity of the altar and victim is this: Paul's κοινωνία refers to a participation in divine sanctity that is the worshipper's by partaking of the victim. It is the worshipper's *through* the altar upon which the victim is sacrificed, and it is the worshipper's *from* the God to whom the victim is sacrificed. Such is Paul's objective in likening Christian communion in the body and blood of Christ to Jewish communion with the altars of sacrifice, as well as to Gentile communion with the demons to whom they sacrifice. But this analogy requires two stipulations. The idol worship of the pagans "acquires and transfers" only "execration and pollution," for that is the nature of the demons to whom sacrifice is offered. The Jewish tradition offered sacrifices to God, but since the victims were "figural," so too the sanctity transferred through the flesh and blood of the victims was but a "shadowy" sanctity. Whereas when Christ offered himself as a victim, a gift received into glory by God, he truly obtained divine sanctity and bestows it upon those who partake of his flesh and blood.[27]

De la Taille underscores that this Pauline κοινωνία is a true, not figural, union with the divine; it is an ontological and not merely physical sharing in the victim. Why else would Paul conclude, "*You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons; you cannot partake of the Lord's table and the table of demons*"? To be sure, if κοινωνία is taken only as "physical eating or sharing," one could partake of disparate altars. But if this partaking and union are understood "rightly," as producing in themselves a communion or *consortium* of divine sanctity, then obviously no worshipper could participate in both cups and tables, "because in fact divine sanctity cannot be experienced along with demonic pollution."[28] Paul, de la Taille summarizes, could not have "more vividly preached the reality of the sanctity in us granted through the eucharistic banquet." The transference of sanctity to the worshipper from God through the sacrificed victim and altar: what can strike the mind

Dei. Sed qui consors est primae, consors est alterius et tertiae. Nec nisi propter alteram requiritur prima, aut altera nisi propter tertiam; sicut nec pervenitur ad tertiam nisi transitu facto per alteram, ad quam per primam aperitur via"; *MF,* 476.

27. *MF,* 476–77.

28. *MF,* 477.

as more realistic? What more profound communion can be imagined than this participation in the very holiness of God through Christ—altar and victim?

"*Whoever eats my flesh and drinks my blood remains in me and I in him. Just as the living Father sent me and I have life because of the Father, so also the one who feeds on me will have life because of me.*" John 6:56–57 supplies de la Taille with his second "demonstration" of, or reflection upon, the union to Christ effected by eucharistic eating. His exposition takes us into the heart of divine indwelling. Interpreting the words of Christ in verse 56, de la Taille describes eucharistic union with Christ as a kind of "mutual penetration of two things and in a single mingling (*duorum penetratio mutua atque in unum commixtio*)."[29] Importantly, this mingling is not of two corporeal things, but rather is proposed as a union in the divine life of Christ, a union that is a participation in that common divine life flowing within the Trinity.

For de la Taille, the mutual abiding promised by Christ in the Eucharist is best perceived in light of Christ's own "guiding example"—namely, of the "community of life flourishing between himself and the Father."[30] The life that the Father communicates to the Son is the life that Christ communicates to those who receive the Eucharist; it is a vitality that conjoins at the deepest level of existence. Yet de la Taille points to this theological qualification: the divine life from the Father is consubstantial in the Son, whereas in the believer it is possessed by a participation that cannot achieve a "perfect similitude" or "equality" to that divine life shared between Father and Son. Even so, de la Taille confirms that the "by no means obscurely proclaimed effect of the eucharistic food is the life of Christ, which is divine, enlivening us."[31]

This Johannine insight about mutual presence and sharing in the divine life leads de la Taille to clarify further aspects concerning our *consortium* in divine sanctity and dominical life. Is this effect of eucharistic union a permanent one? Is it a union with Christ according to his divine nature only, or also according his human nature? In dealing with these more precise questions, de la Taille not only provides a first

29. *MF,* 477.
30. *MF,* 477.
31. *MF,* 478.

definition of sanctifying grace, but also depicts what he calls "the order of deifying life," an order that begins *with the flesh of Christ*. Liturgical texts, as well as theological discourses from the tradition, amplify what he intends to convey about eucharistic *consortium* with Christ.

De la Taille argues that this sharing in the sanctity and life of the divine is a *permanent* and *dynamic* union, flowing both from Christ's divine and human nature, though principally through the Lord's flesh. He again reminds us of how Paul conceives this spiritual consortium with Christ:[32] first, this eucharistic union is with the "flesh of the immolated Christ" (in partaking of the Eucharist); then, the union is also with Christ "as altar, according to his human nature"; and lastly, it is a union with Christ "as he is (in) himself, according to the divine nature, to which sacrifice is offered."[33] This threefold Pauline vision of eucharistic union does not, however, suggest three kinds of communion with Christ. Even if the believer's participation can be considered under these three aspects, the reality is "one and indivisible." But de la Taille's central agenda here is to establish a truth proclaimed in John's Gospel: divinization commences in a eucharistic union to the flesh of Christ, "[a]nd therefore, so long as we remain conjoined spiritually with the human nature of Christ, with the flesh of Christ, so long do we also remain united with the divinity of Christ."[34]

Thus we arrive at de la Taille's first identification of "sanctifying grace" as something (*aliquid*) that "really inheres" in the Christian, that really *remains,* in and through a *consortium* in Christ. De la Taille is quick to clarify how this sanctifying grace is ordered to the two natures of Christ and how the quality of its permanence is to be understood properly. While it is the case that sanctifying grace is related both to the divine and human natures of Christ, the relation is not an equal but an ordinate one: "for, not unless life is flowing into us continually from the Lord's flesh are we conjoined to the divinity; so too, our flesh is vivified only through the flow of the divine life."[35] In other words, sancti-

32. Perhaps one should write "Paul," as I suspect that de la Taille is also thinking here of The Epistle to the Hebrews.

33. *MF*, 478.

34. *MF*, 478.

35. *MF,* 479.

fying grace, a share in divinizing life, is bestowed through a union with the flesh of Christ in the sacrificial banquet.

Concerning this order of divinizing life, de la Taille adds a further theological note asserted by "several Doctors" of the church, and distinctly by Thomas. True enough, the human body shares in divine life through the humanity of Christ; the union between the Lord's flesh and the believer's, however, is "accomplished *mediantly by the soul,* which is vivified constantly by the flesh of Christ, the proximate source of life (*principium vitale*) in the order of deiform existence (*vitae deiformis*)." We are not imagining, he cautions, "some immediate sanctification of our flesh"—one that is "permanent and inhering"—apart from the mediation of the soul.[36] Sketched out, the order of deifying life would appear this way:

Christ's divine life shared with
the Father and Spirit
↓
Christ's flesh
↓
divine life flows into the soul
↓
vivification of our flesh

Depicted with equal care is the nature of a "permanent" union of sanctifying grace. The abiding presence of Christ through eucharistic union is far from instrumental and static:

> For, in so far as we participate in the holiness of Christ, under so great a stream which pours into us from Christ, that far can we and ought we also aptly to say that Christ is, according to his humanity, spiritually conjoined to us, and even intimately united to us through an enduring touch (*contactum*) of power.[37]

This intimate bond or contagion of *virtus* is the bestowal of sanctifying grace, a bestowal not to be conceived as initiatory only. De la Taille's comment is a remarkable one. He specifies that Christ's permanent pres-

36. De la Taille refers the reader to *ST* III, q. 8, a. 2, c: "The whole humanity of Christ, which is to say the body and the soul, flows into humans, as much into the soul as into the body; but principally it flows into our soul, and secondarily into the body"; *MF,* 479n2.

37. "Quatenus autem sub tali influxu Christi participamus Christi sanctitatem, eatenus etiam apte dici potest et debet Christus nobis secundum humanitatem suam spiritualiter conjunctus atque unitus intime per permanentem contactum virtutis"; *MF,* 479.

ence is not a "substantial" one; nonetheless, it is one "continually infused" according to Christ's "spiritual efficacy." Thus Christ's presence and power not only cause grace but also sustain that grace in being: "For the Lord's flesh is not the cause *in fieri* only of our grace, but also the cause *in esse;* that is, as long as he is causing grace, that long is the reality of grace present."[38] In other words, sanctifying grace is Christ's abiding and life-giving power within the believer; it is an intimate and dynamic union forged and sustained in the reception of his eucharistic flesh and blood.

The Eastern fathers provide potent articulations of this eucharistic reality. I shall give two shorter examples, the first of which is from a liturgical text. De la Taille cites a post-communion prayer *super populum* from the liturgy of Bishop Serapion that underscores the life-giving union of the Eucharist:

> O God of Truth, Lover of Humanity, *may the communion of your body and blood* (κοινωνία τοῦ σώματοσ καὶ τοῦ αἵματος) *remain* (συνπαραμεινάτω) with this people. May their bodies be living bodies [which is to say enlivened spiritually through the source of deiform life taken up within them], and may their souls be cleansed souls. Grant that this blessing, effected by the union of the Eucharist, be enduring (τήρησιν) and unharmed (ἀσφάλειαν).[39]

The power flowing from Christ's eucharistic body is likewise sounded in Canon 13 of Ephraem's *Necrosima,* in which the Syriac father describes eucharistic union as a "co-mingling" of the Lord's body with that of the believer, to the end that Christ's body abides in the believer's as its source of life: "*Your body, the source of our life, remains in us.* In us, O Lord, your body *is* the greater part."[40] For de la Taille, these patristic voices capture the nature of that union *ad Christum* that derives from the eucharistic flesh of the Lord: through that sacrificial flesh, the divinizing life of grace resides and presides in the life of the Christian—soul and body.

But it is two other sources from tradition, Hilary of Poitiers's *De Trinitate* and Cyril of Alexandria's *Commentary on the Gospel of John,*

38. *MF,* 479n1.

39. Bishop Serapion, *Sacramentarium Serapionis* 18, in *Didascalia et Constituitones Apostolicae,* edited by F.X. Funk (Paderbornae: Libraria Ferdinandi Schoeningh, 1905); *MF,* 479. De la Taille provides the parenthetical Greek, and the bracketed interpolations.

40. Ephrem the Syrian, *Necrosima,* can. 13, Opera omnia, v. 3 (Rome: Typographia Vaticana, 1743), 247; *MF,* 479.

upon which de la Taille leans most heavily to depict ever more sharply the nature of our intimate, life-giving union to Christ in the Eucharist. He brings forth these texts from the storeroom of tradition largely, I suspect, because they emphasize that the entrée into divine life is realized through a sharing in Christ's human nature, a participation attained through his eucharistic flesh and blood. De la Taille quotes, very nearly *in toto,* four chapters from book 8 of Hilary's *De Trinitate,* chapters that refute the erroneous suggestion that Christ was united to the Father according to a union of wills, rather than a union of natures. De la Taille is especially attracted to Hilary's lengthy analogy between the "natural" union of the Father to the Son and the "natural" union of the human being to Christ in the Eucharist. He highlights the striking *commercium carnis* in Hilary's depiction of eucharistic union. I shall only summarize enough of this rich passage from Hilary's *De Trinitate* to suggest its appeal and significance to de la Taille.

Employing eucharistic imagery and the Gospel of John, Hilary develops an analogy between eucharistic eating and the union of the Son and the Father. This analogy from "the sacrament of perfect union (*perfectae sacramentum unitatis*)" unfolds in this way: the Word has truly become flesh, and Christians receive this flesh as food; this union between Christ and the believer in the Eucharist is a *natural* one—i.e., a union according to human nature (and not according to any mere conjoining of wills). Now, Christ has announced that those who eat his flesh enjoy not only the kind of union that he has with the Father, but enjoy also that very Life that is the union. Christ's union with the Father is also a "natural" one—according to the divine nature of the Father, from whom Christ receives life in the Spirit. The believer is hence joined to Christ and to the life of the entire Godhead in the "perfect union" of the sacrament. Hilary brings his reflection to a close with these words: "We are to proclaim the mystery of the true and natural unity since both through the glory of the Son granted to us and through the Son's abiding presence in us carnally [understand: according to the exchange of flesh (*commercium carnis*)], we are united to him corporeally and inseparably."[41]

41. *De Trinitate* 8.17; *MF,* 479–80.

De la Taille underscores Hilary's view that divinizing union is consequent upon the "commerce" of flesh that occurs in the Eucharist. Without this corporeal exchange, the human does not know divine life, which is to say, does not live the supernatural life of grace:

> Hilary assigns a double *commercium carnis* between us and Christ. First, the Word remains in us carnally because of his flesh; and second, we remain in the incarnate Word according to that dominical taking up of our flesh. In both cases (doubtless with the incarnation presupposed), the effect is placed in the sacrament—ordinately however, even as from the first the second proceeds: "For no one shall be in Christ, unless he himself were dwelling in that one; for the only flesh he has taken to himself is the flesh of those which have taken his flesh." This is considered a mutual immanence because we live through Christ: "In the manner that he lives through the Father, *in the same way we live through his flesh*." We exist in him "inseparably united," and he himself is in us "dwelling naturally and enduringly."[42]

In other words, contemplating the reality of our "mutual dwelling" with Christ, and thus with the entire Trinity, de la Taille emphasizes both divine prerogative and the gift of the flesh of Christ in the Eucharist. In the reception of his eucharistic flesh and blood, Christ *takes up* the believer's flesh to himself (an intimate union of like and like) and fills it with his own divine life. Such is the *commercium carnis* that Hilary envisions in eucharistic union—and that de la Taille finds so theologically attractive.

De la Taille also seizes upon Cyril's Commentary on John 15, a passage treating the image of adherence between vine and branches, for it provides further doctrinal pedagogy on the eucharistic union of natures and the permanence of that union. Cyril does not doubt that the discourse in John 15 identifies Christians as participants in Christ's human nature; nor does he equivocate upon the truth that the believer draws from Christ the life that vivifies her own flesh. Here is a short segment of the much longer passage cited in *Mysterium Fidei:*

> In what way may it be thought ambiguous, or who of sound mind would doubt it, that when we refer to the image of the branches, we understand Christ to be the vine according to the flesh, whilst we, being branches draw upon his very life from the vine itself? As Paul says: *For we are all one body in Christ, seeing that we who are many are one bread, for we all partake of the one bread.* Let anyone speak

42. *MF,* 480. De la Taille is pulling together lines from book 8 of Hilary's *De Trinitate*, which he has already quoted in context (emphasis mine).

who can account for this, who can provide a reason other than the power of the mystical *eulogia*. Why do we receive it within us? Is it not that it may make Christ to dwell in us corporeally through a participation and communion of his sanctified flesh?… And the Savior himself says: *He that eats my flesh and drinks my blood abides in me and I in him.* By which words we should especially observe that Christ did not only say that he would be in us according to a certain relation only, as it is thought by some to be through a disposition in the soul, but also by a natural participation (κατὰ μέθεξιν φυσιχήν). For just as if one were to melt wax with wax entwining them by the fire, which makes two things one, so through the reception of the body and of precious blood of Christ we are conjoined—he in us and we again in him.… For if we do not eat of his flesh, nor drink of his blood, we shall not possess eternal life within us, that is, in our own flesh. For eternal life is rightly judged to derive from the flesh of Life, that is, the flesh of the only-begotten.[43]

De la Taille spins out three eucharistic insights prompted by Cyril's vision of a participation of natures between the vine (Christ) and the branches (those initiated into Christ). First, this union to Christ is indeed a permanent one through the Eucharist, so long as the believer clings to the Life of the vine, received through Christ's flesh. Secondly, Cyril's image of participation in immortal life is linked to the Eucharist "as effect to cause," which is to say, the way to sharing in the divine life is through a participation in Christ's eucharistic flesh.[44] Thirdly, the vine-branches image potently suggests that Christians depend upon union to Christ for their existence, formally speaking. In brief then, intimate and enduring union to Christ through the eucharistic flesh and blood, which bestows grace and divine life, is achieved "through [Christ] because of his assumed nature, to which we are conjoined."[45]

Bringing to a close his theological reflection on eucharistic union *ad Christum,* de la Taille underlines Christ's humanity and the necessity of the believer's desire for his flesh. In the Eucharist, the Christian is granted a participation in the holiness of God and is made capable of

43. PG 74, col. 341–44; *MF,* 481.

44. De la Taille here raises the distinction that an effect is always taken to be something *other than* its cause, a distinction made to show to that our participation by nature in the Lord's flesh, about which Cyril preaches, is in fact something different than the sacramental communion itself, posited as its cause. "However," de la Taille clarifies, "apart from the sacramental communion, no union with Christ—except a spiritual one—can be conceived"; see *MF,* 481n1.

45. *MF,* 481. De la Taille reinforces this point with a short citation from Leo the Great on the eucharistic union: "This is imparted, this is taken up in that mystical distribution of spiritual food in the Eucharist: receiving the power of this heavenly food, we pass *into the flesh of him* who became our flesh" (*Ep.* 59, c. 2; *MF,* 482).

divine life "not only in Christ as he is God, but also as he is human"—a humanity that is "immediate and very near." This life of the divine nature is extended to the believer through Christ's assumed flesh:

> To this life we adhere; to him we cling; to this life we remain connected, and in an unbroken union not only held by the soul, but also by the body.… Thus it is that *we would be nothing in the order of grace* without some addition of the Lord's humanity; for the Lord, through the exchange of one life, assumes to his very self those who receive that divinizing life into themselves with a *full and avid heart.*[46]

Such is the transformative *commercium* of the Eucharist. Christ "takes up" into his own flesh those who, desiring a share in his own divine life, eagerly "take up" the eucharistic flesh of his (now glorified) human nature—that "altar" through which one participates in the life of the Godhead. This permanent union of branches and vine, through which a single divine life flows, is, for de la Taille, the reality of divine indwelling and sanctifying grace.

De la Taille's discussion of ecclesial union through the Eucharist follows readily from the preceding treatment of union to Christ. I shall focus on only two salient features of his presentation: first, the union formed at the altar between Christ and the church, and between the church's members; and second, the reality of fraternal charity flowing within and from the ecclesial body. De la Taille's scriptural point of departure here is 1 Cor. 10:17, which he interprets in a straightforward manner. Paul claims that ecclesial unity is caused by the eating of the eucharistic bread, for in that bread Christians are all concorporate in the one living body of Christ: "For if we all are incorporated into the one Christ, we are also made one body (*concorporamur*). If we all participate (*communicamus*) in Christ, we also participate in one another (*ad invicem*)."[47] De la Taille heralds John Chrysostom's preaching on Paul, appreciating Chrysostom's description of how all live by the same divine life communicated through the one sacrificed body of Christ.

> What is the union which Paul mentions? That we are the body itself. For what is the bread? The body of Christ. And what are they receiving? The body of Christ; and not many bodies, but one body.… For you do not live by a different body,

46. *MF,* 482 (emphasis mine)
47. *MF,* 485.

nor are you nourished by a different body, but all exist by the very same body of Christ.[48]

De la Taille underscores that the reception of the one eucharistic bread inseparably determines union to Christ and to the body of the church. There is no union to Christ without union to all who have partaken from the altar. The head does not exist apart from the body any more than the members exist distinct from the head and from one another: "*One* is the incorporation to Christ, head of the ecclesiastical body, just as there is *one* sacrament of that incorporation."[49] De la Taille cites the now famous passage from Augustine's Commentary on the Gospel of Saint John, a passage in which Augustine meditates on the mystery of unity through the creative divine life flowing from the Eucharist:

O sacrament of piety! O sign of unity! O bond of charity! He who wishes to live has where he may live, has from whence he may live. Let him approach; let him believe; let him be incorporated that he may be given life. Let him not recoil from the joining the limbs.… Let him cling to the body, let him live unto God from God (*Deo de Deo*).[50]

In addressing this shared divine life of the ecclesial body, de la Taille does not hesitate to speak of the union between the church and Christ in terms of Genesis 1 and the union proclaimed between male and female. In fact, he seems to favor this nuptial image (also Pauline) as aptly expressive of the intimacy and permanence of eucharistic unity to Christ.[51] In partaking of Christ's flesh, the church becomes the body of Christ, just as it written, "Let the two become as one flesh."

If the unity and love between the Christ and the church are thought of in terms of the sexual union between bride and bridegroom, the *caritas* of the members united by the divine life of the body is equally intimate and powerful. The ecclesial bond forged in the Eucharist must not be thought a communion *only* with those in the church militant, but rather with all those who are in Christ.

The power to be joined most intimately to the Blessed Virgin or to one of the saints: this belongs to the Eucharist. And behold, these who are clinging together,

48. PG 61, 200; *MF*, 485.
49. *MF,* 485.
50. Augustine, *In Joan*. 26.13; *MF*, 485.
51. Cf. two telling citations from the tradition in *MF,* 486, 495.

this tight bond is neither just ideal or fictitious, but *a real and vital spiritual bond of mutual immanence in Christ*. The power to restore the original and indispensable relationship with your deceased loved ones: this belongs to the Eucharist. And whether they are in heaven or in purgatory, behold they are so close to you, and so truly spiritually one with you, just as you yourself are spiritually one with Christ, in whom they dwell. Therefore, who partakes of the Eucharist participates in the universal Church of Christ—those of the church militant, the church being perfected, and the church in triumph.[52]

With these pastorally eloquent words, de la Taille affirms the power of the Eucharist to unite all those "alive to God" through the flesh that incorporates and gives life.

Another characteristic of this fraternal union pertains to the intimacy of the charity shared among the living members of the body, a charity of which Christ is the *arché*. De la Taille acknowledges that a certain distinction obtains between love of God and love of neighbor in the pilgrimage of salvation—even if, ideally, they are united in the economy of grace. More, the Eucharist bestows upon the church the hope and strength to realize this unity of love, for the love of God and neighbor is "more fully ours inasmuch as there exists the one body of Christ and of the faithful." "Whether we are loving Christ or our brothers, what we love is one indivisible thing, which is the fullness (πλήρωμα) of Christ (Eph. 1:23)."[53] We belong—through a single incorporation—to both. With a single love does the believer love head and members.[54]

De la Taille goes further, envisioning this *caritas* of the body to extend beyond those who directly partake of Christ's flesh. Is eucharistic love, engendered by union to the body, the same as a love attentive to all human beings? De la Taille suggests that eucharistic love regards all people, even those outside of the church, on the *ut sint* principle—that is, on the principle that they *might* become members of the one body

52. *MF,* 487 (emphasis mine)

53. *MF,* 488.

54. The converse of this twofold love of Christ and neighbor is articulated by Augustine, who questions how, in sinning against a brother, one can claim guiltlessness before Christ: "No one is innocent when he sins against his brothers. For it was said by the Apostle, *If however sinning against your brothers, wounding their conscience, you sin against Christ* (1 Cor. 8:12), and this because we are made members of Christ. In what way do you not sin against Christ when you sin against his members?" (*Sermo* 82, c.3.n.4); *MF,* 488.

of Christ. Quoting from Augustine's *Commentary on the Epistle of John,* de la Taille is eager to show that eucharistic love is universal: it is directed toward, as well as streaming from, the body of Christ:

> May you always be enflamed with brotherly love, whether towards those who are your brothers already, or towards your enemies, so that they *may be made a brother by your loving.* Wherever you love a [Christian] brother, you love a friend, who is with you already, who is even already conjoined to you in catholic unity.… And you love the other who does not yet believe in Christ … but you therefore love that he might be a brother. Thus *all our fraternal love is towards Christians, directed towards all of Christ's members.*[55]

In other words, eucharistic charity is not exclusive to fellow partakers of Christ's flesh. Christ's sacrificial love extends to all who might—by the desire of God—become members of his body.

Significantly, the reason a believer's love is thoroughly rooted in the eucharistic body rests on Christ's explicit *mandatum.* After instituting the supper, Christ takes to himself and makes new the commandment of loving one's neighbor. He does so, de la Taille explains, because he who *is* love "is himself in the Eucharist," "both as the generative new principle of fraternal charity (as building up all into the unity of his body) and as the new obligating reason (inasmuch by incorporation he demands a single love for himself and for his members) (John 13:34–35; 15:12; 17:21–23)."[56] The one divine life, through and in which the eucharistic body exists, requires the fraternal love newly envisioned by Christ on the eve of his sacrifice. De la Taille sums up the matter neatly:

> If you strike against charity, you offend the Eucharist; if you seek charity, you discover it in the Eucharist. Look upon the law of the New Testament, built upon the blood of the New Covenant, and upon the body of the victim made sacred to God in the last supper and imparted to the disciples![57]

By partaking of Christ's body and blood believers become one life and one concorporate sacrifice of love.

Indeed, the Eucharist is the very fountain of Christian love. In partaking of the eucharistic food, every possibility of love is augmented. For de la Taille, this sacrament is the "fountain of ascetical theology,"

55. Augustine, *In Epist. Johan.* tract, 10.7; *MF,* 488.
56. *MF,* 488.
57. *MF,* 488.

just as he maintained earlier that this was true also of the Eucharist as sacrifice. "Every virtue whatsoever" depends upon union with God, and the one who frequents the Eucharist with genuine devotion will be a testament to the growth of the spiritual life and the strengthening of *caritas*.[58]

We now have seen how de la Taille explicates the intimacy and vitality of eucharistic union to Christ and to the church (even its potential members). It remains to be seen how this unifying and divinizing grace also promises and realizes the resurrection. As the great sacrament of incorporation, the Eucharist is the best "spiritual proof" of bodily resurrection. We can capture the kernel of de la Taille's thought in this way: if one is incorporated through the Eucharist into Christ's heavenly and glorified flesh, that one likewise shares *corporeally* in immortality. In order to hear the tenor of de la Taille's argument, and particularly to identify the role of sanctifying grace in bodily resurrection, we shall note a few key moments in his scriptural and patristic exposition of this eucharistic truth. The question again hinges upon the exchange of flesh in the Eucharist. *In nuce,* the sacrificial food of Christ's now divinized body is the "yeast" of resurrection within the believer's own corporeality.

De la Taille draws our attention to John 6:54 and 6:58–63 as the primary locus for establishing the causal, resurrecting power of the Eucharist. In these verses, Christ is doing three things: (1) declaring that those who eat and drink of the sacrament will enjoy eternal life and be raised up by him ("*Who eats my flesh and drinks my blood has life eternal, and I will resurrect him on the last day*"); (2) manifesting the godly providence of the bread and his own heavenly origin ("*This is the bread which has descended from heaven*"); and (3) "most especially," pointing to his "glorious ascension" ("*This scandalizes you? What if you were to see the Son of man ascending to where he was before?*"). According to de la Taille, Christ's discourse intends both to meet the likely scandal caused by his

58. "For when the virtues are exercised, the work and reality (*opus et res*) of the Eucharist is actualized and eucharistic life is passed on." Such is the gift of God, who not only desires that Christians may understand and preach the virtuous life of charity, "but also that we may be filled with the strength to live such a life"; see *MF,* 488.

words *and* to elicit faith from his disciples. Given these verses in John 6, can anyone think it "incredible that, when [Christ's] flesh is translated into the divine condition of God, that he would pass on to his friends (*consortes*) his divine life—both incorruptible and glorified?"[59] Surely it is in full accord with nature and reason to judge in this way: because the Christian is made one with Christ in the Eucharist, he or she shall also "be united to him in the resurrection of the body."[60] The head of an eternally incorruptible body will not be found corruptible in any part.

Christ's post-supper words in the synoptic Gospels (Matthew 26:20, Mark 14:25, and Luke 22:29–30), allow de la Taille to show that Christ connects eucharistic eating and drinking to the promise of a future spiritual banquet in heaven. These passages may be understood in a twofold way: either that Christ sees the ritual supper as a sort of *figure* of one to be celebrated in the kingdom, or that he connects the meal now being instituted with the heavenly banquet as "an incomplete thing to its fulfillment," rather like a seedling to its mature growth. This latter possibility demands that we see the fruit of vine now being drunk as *one and the same* with that which shall be later enjoyed (Matthew 26:20)—if in a new way.[61] Drawing upon a number of patristic and medieval sources,[62] de la Taille provides cumulative evidence of the doctrine that "we eat the same bread that we shall eat," and that "the Lord promised the same thing that he in fact gave." The future banquet refers not only to Christ's resurrection, but also to the bodily resurrection of believers by a future shared condition ("*I will bestow it upon you, just as the Father bestows it to me*").[63] The supper, therefore, was instituted "as symbol and cause" of future resurrection to an eternal life of glory, a life in which the Pascha would be fulfilled.

Still, the words "seed" and "cause" evidently imply that this bodily immortality has *already begun* in eucharistic union to Christ. How can Christians fathom that resurrection is "thus pledged, and thus acquired

59. *MF,* 491.

60. *MF,* 491, cf. n1.

61. *MF,* 495.

62. E.g., Irenaeus (*Adv. Haer.* 5. 36. 3); Athanasius (*Epist. Heortast.* 7, 8); Gregory of Nazianzus (*Or. 45 in Pasch,* c. 23); Nicolas Cabasilas (*Liturgiae Expositio* 45).

63. *MF,* 496.

and procured through the Eucharist"?[64] De la Taille suggests that the answer lies in the power of sanctifying grace. While he refers the reader to his treatise *De gratia* for a fuller treatment of this question, he does give here a valuable shorthand description of how sanctifying grace "modifies" *both* soul and body. In doing so, he appears to be much more explicit than his "master," Thomas, about the effect of *gratia sanctificans* upon the body. To secure this efficacious connection between the Eucharist and resurrection, de la Taille relies upon a number of theologically demonstrative images from the fathers.

As the first and proper effect of eucharistic union, sanctifying grace "modifies" not only the powers of the soul (where the virtues reside), but also "the substantial *esse* itself" of the soul, by which the body is informed. This means that "our bodies are already now temples of the Holy Spirit, sanctified, as it were, by being brought into *consortium* with the sanctity of the Lord's body." Through the soul's intimate contact with the flesh of Christ, the body likewise, by its most "intrinsic element," is now "anointed with divine grace."[65] The very *esse* of the soul is affected by eucharistic grace: the Spirit dwells in the soul and body. We shall return to a fuller description of these remarkable realities in chapter 6. For now, we simply note de la Taille's scriptural reference to Romans 8:10–14, Paul's assertion about the indwelling of the Spirit in our mortal bodies, an indwelling that bestows a share in the resurrection of Christ. These verses are not forthrightly eucharistic, but de la Taille encourages us to read them so, for it is through the eucharistic flesh that the Spirit comes to dwell in the soul and in the body.[66]

De la Taille reflects more profoundly yet on this mystery of the power of sanctifying grace in the soul and in the body. He urges the reader to think in terms of the interconnected perfection of the soul in this life and in the next. While existing on earth, conjoined to the body, the soul's informative *esse* is perfected *through grace;* in heaven, this power is perfected *through glory.* Consequently, the soul's informative *esse,* perfected entirely in glory, "demands"—"desires with its entire being"—union to the glorified human body.[67] Here our author

64. *MF,* 491.
65. *MF,* 491–92.
66. *MF,* 492.
67. "Sed et anima separata, ut per gratiam in terris, sic in coelis per gloriam perficitur, quoad

turns to Denys the pseudo-Areopagite's *Ecclesiastical Hierarchy* for a vivid articulation of this shared destiny of perfection between the soul and body. In the following passage (*EH,* c. 7.1–2), Denys is discussing the funeral rites of the dead. He boldly asserts the single perfection of body and soul in the life of grace and glory:

> These pure bodies, conjoined and persevering with the holy souls, since they are yoke-fellows and conjoined combatants *in their divine labors,* they also shall receive their due resurrection in the steadfast strength of the soul's divine life [grace]. For being made one (*copulata*) with the holy souls to which they were conjoined in this life, they will receive both deiform and incorruptible immortality, and also a blessed repose, since they were made members of Christ.… Now some among the profane think that this body, linked to its proper soul, is severed perpetually, as much as it is little fitting for these bodies to be constituted in a life of deiformity and blessed rest. They are by no means understanding (not yet sufficiently learned in divine knowledge) *that life most deiform in Christ has already begun for us*.[68]

Since the body and soul "sweated" together in this earthly life of spiritual growth in divine likeness, and since the body along with the soul becomes a member of Christ in the Eucharist, the body will fittingly share in the soul's life of glory. De la Taille is clear that this reality of resurrection begins now in sanctifying grace, the chief effect of eucharistic union to Christ.

Listening to the fathers, again with a preference to those from the East,[69] de la Taille finds support for the theological claim that sanctifying grace, this "*energia radicalis*" and seminal cause of the resurrection, is attributed to the Eucharist. We shall hear briefly from two passages, the first from Gregory of Nyssa, the second from Cyril of Alexandria—both of which underscore that the eucharistic flesh of Christ works the immortality of a believer's body. In Gregory's *Catechetical Oration,* the chapter devoted to the Eucharist communicates above all that the Eucharist is the great antidote to the mortality of human flesh, poisoned

esse informativum; et pro tanto se tota postulat unionem ad corpus gloria perfundendum"; *MF,* 492.

68. Denys the pseudo-Areopagite, *De Eccles. Hier.* 7. 1–2, PG 3, 553; *MF,* 492n1. De la Taille is here quoting from the Latin, as opposed to the Greek. My translation is based upon his Latin citation.

69. This list of the sources cited by de la Taille indicates this preference: Ignatius (*Ad Eph.* 20.2); Irenaeus (*Adv. Haer.* 4, 15.5); Clement of Alexandria (*Pedag.* 2.2); Athanasius (*Ep. 4 ad Serap.,* n19); Gregory of Nyssa (*Orat. Catech.* c.37); John Chrysostom (*In 1 Cor.,* hom. 24); Cyril of Alexandria (*In Joannem* 6.55); Dionysius Bar Salibi (*Commentarii in Evangelica*, Introduction, c. 28).

as it is. If the soul, remaining united to Christ through faith, has the possibility of salvation, the body comes to participate in the Savior's life "by another mode." The body's capacity for immortality relies upon the Eucharist—that is, upon union to the flesh of Christ, the "medicine of healing":

> For just as if you would mix something deadly with something healthy, what is combined is rendered harmless, so also Christ's *immortal body, when it is within him who eats, changes the whole mortal body into its own nature*.... Now, since only that body which is taken up into God can receive this grace, it is clear that *otherwise it is impossible that our body be immortal, unless it is made to participate in incorruption through a communion with what is immortal.*[70]

The "mixing" of Christ's immortal flesh with ours in the Eucharist dispenses grace, the divinizing power that works incorruption within mortal bodies.

"In preference to others," de la Taille again cites Cyril (*In Joannem.* 6.55), who similarly reflects upon the causal connection between partaking of Christ's flesh and the reversal of the sinner's corporeal death sentence. Because the Word was united to his flesh in such a way that he imparted to it the "whole of divinity," he thus banished death from our nature:

> Now death, which through the lie invaded us, may subject the body to corruption; however, *because Christ is in us through his very flesh, we shall be altogether resurrected. For it is incredible, indeed truly impossible, that he should not give eternal life to those in whom he dwells.* For consider how it is that we put many husks in the fire in order to maintain the spark of the flame; so also our Lord Jesus Christ through his flesh puts life within us, or, as it were, plants the spark of immortality, which spark abolishes every corruption that is within us.[71]

Without question, for Cyril and for de la Taille the Eucharist initiates—sparks—bodily resurrection. Within the partaker, a seminal power or grace is released by the presence of Christ's life-giving flesh. If Cyril employs the metaphor of husks and fire, the Syrian fathers supply de la Taille with perhaps his favorite image in regard to the eucharistic promise of resurrection: Christ's flesh within the believer works as a kind of yeast, fermenting the whole mass of dough, drawing it up to himself.[72]

70. Gregory of Nyssa, *Orat. Catech.* 37; *MF,* 492–93.

71. *MF,* 493.

72. Cf. de la Taille's citation of Dionysius Bar Salibi, *Commentarii in Evangelica,* Introduction, c. 28 (MF, 494).

Through the sacred mystery of the Eucharist, Christians are "fermented" into resurrection, their bodies elevated by the life-bestowing yeast of Christ's immortal flesh.

To summarize, we have seen in this chapter how, through scripture and tradition, de la Taille gives an account of the flow of divinizing grace through the sacrificial banquet. In the Eucharist, the believer comes to share in the divine life of Christ in a communion that reflects and shares in the very trinitarian union of Father, Son, and Spirit. With the skill of a careful craftsman and the rhetorical mastery of a great preacher, de la Taille sets before the reader a rich array of New Testament, liturgical, and patristic passages that, in their cumulative effect, overwhelm in their witness to the efficacy of eucharistic grace. If my exposition of de la Taille on eucharistic grace here seems excessive, I plead guilty of desiring to convey but a hint of the heady effect of his methodology of teaching and elevating through a retrieval of texts from the tradition. Recall that one of his primary goals in *Mysterium Fidei* was to foster piety and spiritual enrichment. To be spare here, in this yet untranslated volume of his work, could only have been a disservice to his theological and methodological intent.

As we have noted, de la Taille's (Cyrillian) emphasis is upon the flesh of Christ, which constitutes the key to understanding the intimacy of eucharistic union.[73] The dynamism and permanency of this graced

73. I have been suggesting that the thought of Cyril of Alexandria significantly influences de la Taille's understanding of the life-giving grace that comes through partaking in the Eucharist. While Cyril does not employ the theological language of sanctifying grace in his treatment of the incarnation and Eucharist, his perception of the tight unity between the Logos and the flesh of Christ is a unity that endures in the Eucharist and is the reason for its life-giving, divinizing power. The scope of this study does not permit me either (1) to look in detail at the various debates over Cyril's Christology and its connection to his eucharistic theology, or (2) to then assess where de la Taille's own reading of Cyril falls in this interpretive spectrum. For instance, one contested question is whether, for Cyril, Christ's presence in the Eucharist is somatic, pneumatic, or emphatically both (a question that is extended to "Is divine indwelling through the Holy Spirit or through Christ's flesh in the Eucharist?"). I think the evidence supports those scholars who argue the third position—*emphatically both*—and I suspect that de la Taille also supports such an approach. Some good sources to consult on this topic (as well as for a general understanding of Cyril's eucharistic theology) are Lawrence J. Welch, *Christology and Eucharist in the Early Thought of Cyril of Alexandria* (San Francisco: Catholic Scholars Press, 1994); Ezra Gebremedhin, *Life-Giving Blessing: An Inquiry into the Eucharistic Doctrine of Cyril of Alexandria* (Uppsala, Sweden; Uppsala, 1977), esp. 77–85; and Daniel A. Keating, *The Appropriation of Divine Life in Cyril of Alexandria* (Oxford, 2004), 64–104.

Still, we can assert at the very least the following four important points of intersection

union, as well as the *caritas* both bestowed and elicited by the believer's incorporation, flows from the sacrificed and glorified flesh. Eucharistic incorporation, de la Taille demonstrated, is ordered to resurrection, for it is "impossible" that the intimacy of eucharistic union with Christ—with life and grace itself—should not acquire a participation in his divine glorification. We are now in a position to consider de la Taille's more "scholastic" treatment of sanctifying grace in *Mysterium Fidei*, a treatment that gives extensive and principal attention to *the grace of Christ*. This topic is not incidental, for we have taken care to identify that a share in grace through eucharistic union *ad Christum* flows directly from the flesh assumed by the incarnate Word.

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between Cyril's and de la Taille's thought. First, in harmony with this Eastern patriarch, though certainly in different terms, de la Taille's notion of the incarnation maintains a powerful sense of the Word's—and indeed of the whole Trinity's—actuation of the very *esse* of the human nature and body of Christ, so that the human nature lives *by* the divine nature (cf. discussion of this below). Secondly, de la Taille robustly affirms that we must eat the flesh of Christ in order to have divine life within us; the Logos-sarx (to borrow Cyril's language) *vivifies*. Thirdly, divine indwelling is a matter of our being spiritually "taken up" into the divine body of Christ. This occurs most ostensibly in our participation in the Lord's sacrificial banquet, after which we bear a "natural" relationship to Christ—as branches on a single vine—and become united with Christ to the Father, in the Spirit. Consonant then with Cyril, de la Taille underscores both pneumatic and somatic aspects of our appropriation of divine life in the Eucharist. In spite of these strong notes of concord, we must acknowledge that de la Taille's Christology and eucharistic theology place a distinct emphasis upon the redeeming oblation of Christ as sacrificial victim.

The Grace of the Redeemer 5

How does the preceding discussion of the grace of union to Christ in the Eucharist fit into a broader theory of grace? In book 3 of *Mysterium Fidei,* de la Taille plunges into the depths of eucharistic grace, providing a treatment of sin and the salvific power of grace. We turn now to a more technical discussion of grace, sin, and soteriology, a discussion that commences with a careful analysis of *grace in Christ* and that concludes with a reflection on Christ's headship and the necessity of the Eucharist. For it is Christ's grace that permits the theologian to conceive and speak of the power of grace in believers, including that grace of union that flows from the Eucharist. If, as de la Taille proposes, the grace of Christ is the *princeps analogum* for the whole genus of created grace, and if Christ is indeed the fountain of all grace, a serious discourse on grace in the Redeemer is foundational to a theology of grace *tout court*. The discussion in this chapter confirms our view of de la Taille as a synthetic thinker, providing evidence of his conviction about the organic nature of theology.

Grace in General

Following an explication of the *sacramentum tantum* and the *res et sacramentum* of the Eucharist, de la Taille defines the *res tantum* as that invisible reality into which the Eucharist leads the believer—namely, into a participation in the grace of Christ: "According to the testimony of tradition, the grace we derive from incorporation to Christ in the Eucharist is a participation in the Lord's own grace, imparted to us

through the living power of the Lord's flesh."[1] At this point in *Mysterium Fidei,* de la Taille begins a full discourse on the nature of grace, seeking not only a general definition of grace and a more particular delimitation of eucharistic grace, but also focusing *extensively* upon the grace of the Redeemer, for he aims to show that all grace flows "mediantly" from Christ's humanity. That Christ is the mediant cause of grace is clear from his previous discussion of eucharistic union; yet de la Taille now sets forth a more classically structured and scholastic presentation, one that anticipates the style and content of his later journal articles. To reiterate, I contend that the context of eucharistic union must not to be forgotten—neither here, as de la Taille proceeds with his mini-treatise *de gratia* in *Mysterium Fidei,* nor in the reading and interpretation of his subsequent essays on grace.

All grace, establishes de la Taille, can be understood by its single purpose (*ratio*), which is the ordering of all rational creatures to seeing God *sicut est*.[2] Put differently, grace has the same form in all those being drawn to God: it prepares (*coaptat*) the created intellect for the beatific vision. In a rather theologically packed statement, de la Taille writes that grace "resides" in the souls of the just "by nature (*per modum naturae*)," building upon and radically transforming that nature—"directly affecting of itself not the operation or faculty, but the substance of nature."[3] Two striking ideas emerge in this general description of grace in creatures, both of which intimate de la Taille's position on the question of the supernatural, which would come to the fore in the decade after his death. First, if grace elevates and adapts the intellect for seeing God fully, it does so not by an extrinsic mode or alien imposition, but, as it were, from *within* nature, and by transforming that nature. Secondly, this "species" of grace is more than a polishing-up of a capacity to see God; it does not "speed up" a process of perfection obtainable without grace. Rather, this grace influences the very essence of human nature. This note of intrinsicism is sounded more unmistakably in his discus-

1. *MF,* 513.

2. De la Taille acknowledges that all creatures—and not just rational creatures—have a "species" of grace proportioned according to their nature, by which they tend toward their end, an end which is itself "specified" by the ordering mind of the creator God; see *MF,* 513.

3. *MF,* 513.

sion of the sanctifying grace of the Eucharist, which we shall address shortly. But at this juncture, de la Taille focuses our attention upon the single *ratio* of grace in order to explore the relationship between the grace of the just (angels or humans) and the grace of Christ.

The Grace of Christ

Given that the "species" of grace is the same in Christ and in other rational creatures, de la Taille desires to expose the causal power and perfection of Christ's grace. In short, he argues that in the order of grace, Christ's grace is highest *absolutely* (and not just *relatively*); consequently, all other grace is a *participated* grace in that of Christ's. The proposal that Christ's grace is *summa* leads to a detailed analysis of created grace in Christ, a grace that is highest on account of the hypostatic union. We shall follow the central points of de la Taille's explication of the relationship between the grace of union (the hypostatic union) and habitual (sanctifying) grace in Christ, both to discern his thought on these questions at the time of the publication of *Mysterium Fidei* and to inquire how his construal may be informed by a eucharistic context.

Christ's grace is highest absolutely, that is to say, not simply greater than all other graces, but greater insofar as there cannot be a higher grace. This unsurpassable magnitude results naturally (*naturaliter*) from the hypostatic union, as some "perfect disposition" to that union—but consequent and not antecedent to it.[4] The unpacking of this dense statement moves us into the first three appendices in book 3. Appendix E investigates how sanctifying grace is *connatural* to the hypostatic union. Appendix F explicates the problem of "perfect disposition" in regard to sanctifying grace in Christ, while Appendix G enumerates the ways that Christ's grace is highest, marveling at the consequences of this truth within the order of grace.

Appendix E: Sanctifying Grace as Connatural to the Assumed Humanity of Christ—to the Hypostatic Union (the Grace of Union)

De la Taille is eager to forestall misunderstanding on this question. He immediately clarifies that sanctifying grace is *not* connatural to

4. *MF,* 513.

Christ's humanity when considered *in and of itself,* but only insofar as that nature is *assumed* in the incarnation.[5] From the standpoint of the incarnation, however, one can say that sanctifying grace is in fact owed (is a *debitum*)—morally and physically—to the human nature of Christ. Moreover, created grace "naturally" accompanies the uncreated grace of the incarnation. As we shall see, de la Taille's demonstration of the connaturality of grace in Christ builds upon statements about the intimacy of the divine-human union, about the agency of the Trinity, and about divine indwelling. Such conceptual pillars prove revelatory of his larger theological vision of grace.

De la Taille spells out the "moral debt" of grace in Christ with the following logic. The "natural" Son of God, having assumed human nature and existing as a human being, nonetheless clings to the glory of the Father. Hence that paternal glory is owed to the human nature in which the Son now exists. In other words, the possession of divine glory "rightfully belongs to Christ in his human nature."[6] However, the capacity of human nature for the divine leads to a further assertion. Because human nature can possess divine glory only "by means of participation (*secundum participationem*)," which is to say, through the grace that "fits" the natural capacity of the soul for such glory, habitual grace was necessarily owed to Christ's human nature. Still, any suggestion about this moral necessity presupposes the grace of union (hypostatic union), for which there could be no preceding merit or disposition.[7]

With much greater detail, and with a depth of reflection and articulation that looks forward to his later work on grace, de la Taille treats the "physical" necessity of grace in Christ as consequent to the creat-

5. Grace is only *debitum* to Jesus's human nature because of the incarnation, because the Word joins himself to that nature. We can be sure that de la Taille would reject the suggestion that grace is in any way owed to humanity: Grace remains grace—gratuitous—to human nature. See *MF,* 514.

6. De la Taille's Latin composition is clever here, playing upon *haerere/haereditas:* "Debitum quidem morale: nam Filius Dei naturalis in humana natura, est Dei in humana natura naturalis haeres. Haeredi autem paternae gloriae debetur gloria paterna in ea natura, in qua est haeres. Debetur igitur Christo in humana natura haereditas gloriae divinae"; *MF,* 514.

7. De la Taille's point on this moral *debitum* concludes with a citation from Thomas's *Commentary on The Sentences* (3 D., q.1, a.1, 5m): "From this itself, that he was God, glory was due to him; still it is right that something be formally perfecting the soul itself to the act of glory. And this was grace"; *MF,* 514, my translation.

ed grace of union. Three important assertions emerge in this focused question upon the grace of union and its relationship to habitual grace in Christ: (1) the grace of union is a personal actuation of the human nature by the *Esse* of the Word; (2) *operation* follows *being,* and therefore habitual grace was necessary to Christ; and (3) the intimacy of this union was such that Christ lived *through the divine life.* Each of these assertions lends a further "thickness" of description to de la Taille's understanding of sanctifying grace in Christ.

I find it helpful to locate de la Taille's discourse on the grace of union squarely in Thomas Aquinas's own exploration in Question 2 of the *Tertia Pars* of the *Summa.* These preliminary remarks will clarify what our author assumes of his reader. In article 10 of this question, Thomas asks whether or not the incarnation, the union of the two natures in Christ, "took place by grace." For Thomas, the answer must be yes, since human nature cannot be united to the divine, "lifted up to God," without grace. But to be more precise and illuminating, Thomas distinguishes between two notions of grace, and between two ways of being lifted up to a participation in the divine life. Grace, he reminds us, can mean either the "will of God freely granting something"—and certainly the incarnation can be among the many things said to occur by God's good will—or grace can mean the "gratuitous gift itself of God," by which the union of the human nature to the divine is also said to be a grace, as it occurred without any preceding merit. Thomas, however, prefers to identify the "grace of union" in a stricter manner, demanding a further distinction between two ways in which humans are granted a share (by the gracious will of God) in what lies beyond their natural capabilities. The first way is *by operation:* habitual grace adapts the soul "to know and love God," and this is how the saints are united to God. The second way is *by personal being,* and this way belongs exclusively to Christ, whose human nature is taken up into "the Person of the Son of God" by this *grace of union.*[8]

De la Taille, I suggest, carries forward the Thomistic denotation of "grace of union." In the created grace of union, the Word "immediately touches" the very substance of the assumed humanity, *actuating* the

8. *ST* III, q. 2, a. 10, c.

human nature through "its obediential potency" and according to the personal *Esse* of the Word, which is pure act of being.[9] De la Taille is quick to stipulate that this grace of union does not indicate that the human nature thereby exists as uncreated: remaining created, "it none the less exists, not as we do, by a natural mode, but in a divine mode, and supernaturally." The actuation of the hypostatic union is "created" and "supernatural." It is "the communication of the divine *Esse* to the human nature, or conversely, the union of the human nature to the *Esse* of the Word."[10]

But de la Taille's intention in this section of *Mysterium Fidei* is not to give a fully delineated account of the hypostatic union; rather, he wishes to demonstrate that sanctifying grace in Christ is indeed both connatural and a physical necessity because of the grace of union. To this end, he introduces a metaphysical principle regarding the proportional relationship between *being* and *operation*. He asserts that the actuation of being in regard to *esse* "connaturally determines the actuation of an agent in regard to operation (*operari*)." If the human nature of Christ has been personally actuated by the divine *Esse* of the Son, then concomitantly the intellective operation of the assumed soul—though, again, remaining created—would be "actuated through *the pure act of intelligibility* (*per actum purum intelligibilitatis*)," i.e., by the divine essence itself.[11] The middle term, so to speak, of de la Taille's argument is that such intellective activity transcends the natural capacity of the human mind, thereby leading to the conclusion that habitual grace *must* elevate Christ's mental agency to operate in proportion to its existence by divine *Esse*. In other words, the grace of union "connaturally carries

9. *MF,* 514. De la Taille does not articulate here the precise phrase he would come to be remembered for—"created actuation by uncreated Act"—though the seeds of his later thought have no doubt begun to sprout.

10. *MF,* 514–15. Interestingly enough, in considering the mystery of this supernatural actuation, de la Taille's mind turns analogically to the eucharistic accidents. He proposes that he knows of only two occurrences in which something becomes divine, existing supernaturally, i.e., according to an *esse* not commensurate to its nature, but superior to it: the first, as we have seen, is the incarnation, in which the human nature exists by the uncreated *Esse* of the Word; and the second is the accidents of the converted eucharistic species, which exist not so much through the *esse* of another subject, but possess *esse* as if they were a substance; see *MF,* 515n1.

11. *MF,* 515.

with it" habitual grace; the hypostatic union "physically" calls for sanctifying grace.

De la Taille makes a final and far from insignificant observation about the *debitum* of habitual grace from the incarnation. The origin of this created grace is, "like the cause of the (hypostatic) union," the "work of the entire Trinity, and also both are rightly attributed to the work of the Holy Spirit."[12] He later qualifies that the hypostatic union, though caused by the Trinity, is a *relation* to the Word alone (a distinction Thomas makes in *ST* III, q. 2, a. 7, c); but presently his point is to signify the intimacy of the divine-human union, to signal the agency of the entire Godhead and divine indwelling: in a word, to signal uncreated grace.

The doctrines of the grace of union and of sanctifying grace indicate that Christ lived a human and natural life, yet he lived this existence *through* the divinity, and consequently "supernaturally and divinely." The grace of union does not suggest a "remote" divinity, affixed in some way to the humanity so that the divine lives through another—and specifically through a "created *esse*." Instead, the divinity "was and is so intimate to the humanity" that "the man lives by that divinity, just as he exists through the divine *esse*."[13] Does this not sound familiar? The echo of his earlier excursus on the intimacy and efficacy of eucharistic union is surely intentional.[14] De la Taille caps his point about the grace of union by rehearsing the words of sixteenth-century Jesuit Francesco Toletus:

> Christ was God and man: insofar as he was God, he lived because of the Father, since he had with him essence and life from the Father. So also as man, he lived because of the Father, because he received life as a man. For since that man was God and the Son of God, *he lived a natural life of grace and glory because of the union to the divinity. For this divinity communicated all things to the humanity*.[15]

12. *MF,* 515.

13. *MF,* 515–16.

14. In contrast to his later essays, de la Taille here makes this point about divine indwelling and the natural/supernatural life of Christ with significant accent and elegance. I suggest that this is the case because of the eucharistic context. After all, he has just finished discoursing on the eucharistic passages in John 6, particularly those referring to the Father's intimate indwelling in Christ.

15. Francesco Toletus, *In Johan.* 6.57; *MF,* 516.

The italics in this quote belong to de la Taille. Clearly, he is keen to stress Christ's possession of both created grace and divine glory—gifts that Christ now imparts to those who partake of his flesh. The divine-human intimacy in the grace of union is the analogue to the intimacy of eucharistic union *ad Christum,* the singular cause in believers of sanctifying grace.

Apart from the moral and physical exigency of sanctifying grace in Christ, de la Taille desires to show that uncreated grace naturally draws along (*trahit*) created grace. Unmistakably, we see here his theological interest in bringing divine indwelling into the forefront of his discourse on grace—that is, we see his inclination to begin with the reality of divine indwelling, with the gift of God himself, rather than with the created gifts.[16] It is true, de la Taille writes, that the Holy Spirit cannot dwell within us "without created grace arising in us," just as a "participation in brightness derives from the presence of the sun." Therefore, the same holds—and to an even greater extent—when the uncreated Gift is not just *accidentally* but *substantially* united to human nature: created grace "will radiate from the uncreated brilliance of the sun."[17] The sun image derives from Thomas, as does the following passage, which supports an understanding of habitual grace as an "effect of the incarnation":

> For grace is caused in man by the presence of the divinity, just as light in the air is caused by the presence of the sun. However, the presence of God in Christ is understood according to the union of the human nature to the divine person. Wherefore the habitual grace of Christ is seen as a consequence of that union, as splendor accompanies the sun.[18]

16. Prudence de Letter has suggested that, even before Rahner, de la Taille had introduced a shift within the theological approach to grace: a shift away from the Thomistic and scholastic approach, which began with the created graces and moved to reflection upon God's self-gift, to a theology beginning from the divine indwelling and then moving to created grace; see de Letter, "Created Actuation … Difficulties and Answers," 61 and 84. I would add the following two observations. First, it is very likely that de la Taille's theological attraction to divine indwelling derives from his reading of Scheeben and the Eastern fathers. Secondly, and perhaps unexpectedly, the Thomistic passages here employed by de la Taille do not represent a Thomas focused primarily upon created gifts. In other words, it seems that de la Taille interprets Thomas as fundamentally concerned with divine indwelling!

17. *MF,* 516.

18. *MF,* 516; *ST* III, q. 7, a. 13, c. De la Taille likewise argues that the fathers give an account of sanctifying grace as flowing from the incarnation; he refers the reader to Petavius's work, *De Incarnatione Verbi* l.11.c.7.n. 5–7, for the patristic witness.

That habitual grace accompanies the hypostatic union was not an undisputed theological question.[19] In fact, de la Taille introduces and responds to a possible objection in positing this created grace in Christ. The objection counters that the grace of union takes the place and role of sanctifying grace in Christ, since the grace of union is itself "ordered to the beatific vision (*visionem intuitivam*)."[20] If habitual grace is understood to perfect the "substance itself" of the soul, bestowing upon it a habitual being (and not just a power/*virtus*) that is supernatural, then such a grace is unnecessary when one concedes that the grace of union "abundantly perfects" the substantial *esse* of the soul, now actuated by the personal *Esse* of the Word. Habitual grace in Christ thereby appears superfluous.

De la Taille's response to such an objection is informative, for he again underscores a trinitarian agency and the *end* of habitual grace. In every created substance, two aspects of existence can be identified: "a passive potency in regard to existence" and a "radically active principle in regard to operation." The grace of union actuates the soul of Christ in relation to its passive potency (obediential potency) toward existence, and, in fact, perfects that passive potency, for nothing could more completely put that soul formally into existence. The entire Trinity causes this grace of union, even though the union terminates in a relation to the Word alone. On the other hand, the perfection of the radically active principle of the soul is "not only caused by the whole Trinity, but it looks to and is joined to the enjoyment and knowledge of the whole Trinity." The root principle of the soul's operation is destined, de la Taille suggests, for union to and enjoyment of the Trinity. He thus concludes that it is fitting for that operating principle of the soul to be perfected by—divinized by—another grace, namely habitual grace, "a grace attributed to the whole Trinity and specifically to the indwelling of the Spirit."[21] Put otherwise, the grace of union terminates in a personal relation of the Word to the soul's very potential for exis-

19. De la Taille mentions that Suarez and the seventeenth-century French theologian Louis Thomassin had argued to the contrary; see *MF,* 516.

20. *MF,* 516.

21. *MF,* 516.

tence, whereas sanctifying grace in Christ is necessary to elevate and fit the soul for beatific vision and union with the entire Trinity.

Having demonstrated that habitual grace is connatural to the grace of union, both morally and physically necessary in Christ, and that habitual grace is an apt theological consequence of the incarnation (and of Trinitarian causality), de la Taille takes up the thorny theological question of *disposition* and grace. Again, brief attention to this next appendix will be salutary in understanding his later articulation of created actuation.

Appendix F: Sanctifying Grace as Perfect, Consequent Disposition to the Hypostatic Union

This appendix probes more deeply into the relationship between the grace of union and sanctifying grace in Christ. Eager to exclude any temptation to think of sanctifying grace in Christ as an antecedent disposition to the hypostatic union, de la Taille explores that paradoxical Thomistic position of mutual priority and causality. One can pose the dilemma in this way: what comes first, a disposition to the reception of grace, or grace itself? As Thomas suggests in his Treatise on Grace in the *Prima Secundae,* we may indeed speak of a disposition in the soul toward grace, but that disposition itself *is* the effect of grace (*ST* Ia-IIae, q. 112, a. 2, c and ad 1; q. 113, a. 7). The disposition to grace seems to be grace itself.

De la Taille delineates his position by distinguishing disposition considered *actively* and *passively.* Active disposition is that which *prepares* the material for the reception of the form—in which view the disposition is understood as *praevia*—that is, as coming before the form. The soul recollecting itself, for example, is an active disposition to receiving the graces of contemplative prayer. Furthermore, this active, prevenient disposition can be either necessary or congruent—the first of which is ruled out in regard to the incarnation, while the second (congruent disposition) may be allowed in a limited sense. For instance, human nature possessed of grace would indeed be fitting to the incarnation ("as beauty is a kind of disposition to marriage"). Nevertheless, since there is no existence of Christ's human nature apart from, or

prior to, the incarnation, this actively construed congruent disposition is likewise eliminated. De la Taille here echoes Thomas (*De Veritatis* 29, 2): only when something is perfected gradually can any place be given to antecedent disposition—whether necessary or congruent.[22]

Disposition taken in a *passive* sense implies a much different relation to the form. Passive disposition does not "previously adapt the material to the form," but, once the form is presupposed and the matter is in relation to it, this consequent disposition adapts the material more fully to the form. De la Taille qualifies—and here the paradox emerges—that this "perfective" disposition has itself *already been* perfected by the form. Thomas supplies the example (*ST* Ia-IIae, q. 113, a. 8; *Veri.* 28, 8, c. and ad 5): love and contrition are perfective dispositions to grace, but they can flow only if "first infused by habitual grace."[23] That is to say, love and contrition make the soul visited by grace to be ever more pliant to that gift; but the movement of desire and sorrow is itself caused by grace. In addition, the order of nature teaches that what is thought to be perfected by the form, i.e., "perfected to the form (*ad formam*)," must *follow* that form:

> Consequently, neither is it necessary to *attract* the form or to *prepare* for it in order to be congruent with its arrival. Rather, the disposition is itself fashioned, originated, and necessitated through the form.[24]

De la Taille is restating here what amounts in Thomas to a kind of mutual priority and causality. Sanctifying grace in Christ is considered passive, consequent, and perfective disposition of the hypostatic union. Put conclusively and suggestively in terms of the incarnation, *disposition is grace.* Not only does disposition naturally follow the perfection of the grace of union, but consequently, "it cannot exist without existing in due proportion to the union itself"—so that, we might say, disposition is the adaptation by grace.[25] Again borrowing an image from Thomas, de la Taille suggests that we think of the relationship between sanctifying grace and the grace of union as that of heat to fire; if heat

22. *MF,* 517.
23. *MF,* 517.
24. *MF,* 517.
25. "Hujusmodi autem dispositio est gratia: nam et consequitur, ut dictum est, ad gratiam unionis connaturaliter; nec proinde potest quin exsistat in debita proportione ad ipsam"; *MF,* 517.

is a disposition to fire, it nonetheless is an effect of the form of the fire (*ST* III, q. 7, a. 13, ad 2).

De la Taille readily acknowledges the different articulations of this relationship in theologians like Cajetan and de Lugo, both of whom suggest that habitual grace in Christ is not a disposition, but rather a "natural property," related to the personal union *as to an end*. In this view, sanctifying grace "emanates" from the grace of union, and is thus ordered to that union as to an end, just as creatures made by God are ordered to that end because God exists and made them. While de la Taille has no particular quarrel with this approach to habitual grace in Christ, he prefers to call this ordination and relationship to an end "after the style of St Thomas," namely, as "consequent and perfect disposition."[26] This stylistic preference, if you will, is not without consequence.

Recall that de la Taille is here building a case for understanding grace in Christ as the source and prime *analogum* for grace *tout court*. His predilection exalts "perfective disposition" as a more salutary category for considering the question of nature and grace than that of a "natural property" ordained to a *finis*. In view of his preceding discussion of eucharistic union, "perfective disposition" nicely augments two facets of the dynamic of sanctifying grace in the Eucharist. First, consequent and perfective disposition rightly implies that reception of the Eucharist depends not upon a preparatory grace, but upon Christ taking up the believer's flesh to himself when the Eucharist is received (as the fathers cited earlier attest). The Eucharist *forms* and *perfects* participation in the grace of Christ. Secondly, eucharistic desire, shortly to be discussed in full, seems better served by this articulation of "grace as congruent disposition." The ardor, the heat of love and desire for the Eucharist is certainly *disposition* to the Eucharist itself, and de la Taille has insisted upon this *devotio* in the offering of sacrifice.[27] However, as the heat-fire metaphor signifies, this disposition of desire is also, and perhaps primarily, a consequence—an effect—of the eucharistic union. Graced union to the body of Christ generatively fashions and perfects this love.

26. *MF,* 518.
27. Cf. chapters 2 and 3.

Appendix G: Grace in Christ Is the Highest Absolutely

Having demonstrated that habitual grace in Christ is both *debitum* and connatural from the incarnation, and having shown that it is only consequent and duly proportionate to the grace of union, de la Taille lastly considers the ways in which Christ's grace is highest absolutely. There is no controversy about this point: de la Taille asserts that the fathers, Thomas, and "even" Scotus and his followers all agree upon this theological teaching. Apart from a short note clarifying the apparent contradiction of Christ's grace being both finite and highest, de la Taille here eschews any complex metaphysical instruction. I strongly suspect that the significance of this appendix (G) lies in the opportunity it affords de la Taille to further meditate upon the height, depth, and breadth of grace in Christ. The reader of *Mysterium Fidei* cannot fail to note the real pleasure—if one is allowed to say so—that de la Taille takes in theologically expounding the immensity of grace in Christ. I shall mention only those elements not raised in the preceding appendices, and then underscore his illuminating treatment of the "contradiction" in denominating Christ's grace as highest absolutely.

De la Taille begins with a citation from Petavius's *De incarnatione Verbi* (11, c. 6, n. 6; c. 12, n. 6–7), an attractive passage set forth as representative of the fathers and Scholastics:

> Since it is said by the ancient Fathers that Christ not only received grace and sanctity as a gratuitous gift, but that he also bestowed it upon himself, grace was to him the same as nature, established in being by him—not communicated extrinsically, but according to being (οἴκοθεν), and present and flowing into himself from himself. This reality *shows the immensity of the grace, circumscribed by no end or terminus*.[28]

These words reflect the absolute quality of Christ's grace: he who is alpha and omega receives and confers grace upon himself, and does so in accord with the eternal and infinite *Esse* of the Word. De la Taille proceeds to probe the truth of this paradoxical teaching in five ways, the

28. "Quoniam Christus non solum gratiam et sanctitatem tanquam donum gratuitum accepisse, sed etiam sibi ipse contulisse ab antiquis Patribus dicitur: eo fit ut naturalis eadem, illi esse statuatur, nec extrinsecus communicata, sed οἴκοθεν, et de suo sibi praesens et affluens. Quae res *immensam et nullo fine ac termino circumscriptam eam esse demonstrate*"; *MF,* 518.

first three of which are obvious from the preceding discussion—namely, (1) whatever is held "naturally" is held in the highest possible way (habitual grace *naturally* follows from the personal union); (2) a cause measures its effect (the grace of union is the highest possible union for a creature, thus its effect, habitual grace, will be the highest); and (3) perfect disposition is "fitted" to the resident form or end, which, being the *Esse* of God himself, cannot but be *summa*. But there are two newly articulated and significant reflections in this section, a discourse on divine filiation and on the beatific vision. To these we now turn.

A proof of the unsurpassibility of Christ's grace is gleaned from considering the question of filial adoption. Providing a traditional Western theological position, de la Taille writes that grace is purposed for divine adoption in creatures being drawn to God. Because of the hypostatic union, however, the soul of Christ enjoys a "permanent union (*unio schetica*)" to the Holy Spirit and the entire Trinity, thereby making grace a "*proper consequence and gift*" of Christ's "natural Filiation."[29] This grace of Christ's natural and substantial filiation cannot be surpassed, *simpliciter*. In fact, the gifts that accompany the Christian's adoptive filiation—a sharing in grace and divine glory—only "deficiently imitate" that which is proper to natural filiation.

To expand upon this doctrine of the Son's filiation, de la Taille draws from his Greek father of choice, from Cyril of Alexandria's *Commentary on the Gospel of John* (11, c.12). Explicating verse 22 from chapter 17, "*And the glory which you gave to me I have given to them, so that they may be one as we are one,*" Cyril teaches the following: in the incarnation, the natural, unbegotten Son of the Father becomes man, and in this taking on of human flesh by the Word, Christ is the true and natural *Filius*. Christ *receives and is* the glory of the Son, a glory and sonship in which the baptized share through his own self-Gift. The only way to adoption and union with the Father is through Christ.[30] In short, the union of the assumed humanity of Christ with the entire Trinity re-

29. "In anima autem Christi, ubi ex unione hypostatica ad Verbum resultat unio schetica ad Spiritum Sanctum et totam Trinitatem, gratia est *sequela et dos proprie* Filiationis naturalis"; *MF,* 519.

30. Cyril of Alexandria, *Commentary on the Gospel of John,* PG 74, 561–65; *MF,* 519.

sults in a grace of filiation that cannot but be highest, a grace and union in which adoptive filiation *participates*.

In a similar way, de la Taille demonstrates the *summa* of Christ's grace through a consideration of the *visio Dei*. Grace, he writes, is "proportioned to vision." Since Christ's soul was conjoined to the *Esse* of the Word of God, and since there is no "greater conjunction of the intelligible to the one thinking" than what is "seen" according to *esse,* there can be no greater vision than that which Christ enjoyed. The conclusion is obvious: grace proportioned to the highest vision will be highest grace. De la Taille expands this rather simple "proof" with a passage from the sixteenth-century Dominican Melchior Cano, whose text again directs us to the sub-discourse in these appendices—namely, the exploration of divinizing union to Christ through the Eucharist. Cano focuses on the relationship between the grace of union and the light of glory through which the blessed see God:

> The union of the soul of Christ with the Word is greater than the union of the blessed with the Word. In fact, from this union of Christ's soul with the Word exists the light (*claritas*) in the mind of the blessed, the light which allows them to see God. Hence much greater is that union by which such light arises.[31]

Through Cano's words, de la Taille reiterates the central principle in these appendices: it is from the hypostatic union that Christ's grace is highest, and it is from that fullness that believers may participate in the divine light and life.

De la Taille's "five ways" convincingly show Christ's grace to be highest. Still, he willing entertains and engages the following objection in order to explore the mystery further: *The concept of absolute highest grace suggests a contradiction: For first, if God's nature, life, beatitude, and proper operation are infinite, a sharing in that divine nature by grace ought to be open to infinite growth and increase for any created nature. Therefore, one can always conceive of a greater grace, in the same way that any creature can be created by God to be a better creature. More, is it not a contradiction to think of Christ's grace as finite and yet absolutely highest?*[32] De la Taille's extensive response to this contrived objection gives

31. Melchior Cano, *De locis theologicis* 12, c.13, fol. 440; *MF,* 519–20.
32. *MF,* 520; cf. *ST* I, q. 25, a. 6, c.

occasion to highlight some of the important aspects of his theology of grace: the supernatural; "mixed" and "pure" perfection; and union and divinization as the terminus of grace. I suggest that the ensuing discussion yields the clearest perspective of de la Taille's position within the debate that emerged over the supernatural in the 1940s.

To begin, de la Taille reinforces that union with the divine nature is "intrinsically supernatural" to every created (and creatable) nature. As such, it is not *owed* to creatures, and is formally closed to the "freedom or observation" of the subject. De la Taille names this grace of union a "mixed" perfection, i.e., the kind of perfection that has its *summum* in God (*infra Deum*). By contrast, a pure perfection (like the perfection of being, or the perfection of the intellect) is not closed, by definition, to the notion of a natural potential for something higher; nor does a pure perfection exclude an obediential potency in the subject. Every creature can be made better by God, and every natural intellect may be improved. Succinctly, de la Taille aligns grace, and the union with divinity that it grants, with the supernatural. He denies that the mixed perfection of grace is subject to natural and observable laws of growth and increase: it remains a hidden, supernatural reality, with its own "rule" of divine will and gratuity. By contrast, pure perfections, like the human intellect, may progress endlessly.[33]

This distinction in place, de la Taille argues that no one "should fret" because the created intellect may grow infinitely, while grace—including the grace of Christ—cannot do so. Nor is there any "scandal" in acknowledging that "among perfect things, grace is counted mixed," even though it is discerned among things "naturally pure." De la Taille averts any "scandal" by depicting *both* mixed and pure perfections as dependent upon the supernatural:

> Now [the pure natural perfection] is so from the nobility of grace, by which such goodness is brought in, so that every natural perfection whatsoever *is always supernatural and gratuitous,* marking therefore the unworthiness of the subject.[34]

Are these words a robust statement against the notion of "pure nature"? I believe so. Apparently, de la Taille *allows* for a notion of *natura*

33. *ME,* 520.
34. *ME,* 520.

pura in outlining the difference between pure and mixed perfections. Yet he qualifies that even these pure perfections depend upon grace—and here I suspect he means grace in Thomas's first sense: "the will of God freely granting something."[35] De la Taille confirms this direction of thought by stating that the perfection of anything pertains finally to grace, although the "imperfection" of every thing is attributed to nature, for nature can always be transcended by grace. In simpler terms, he concludes thusly: "In the end, the smallest grace of beatific vision carries with it an infinitely greater light of intelligibility than the keenness of natural intelligence in any degree."[36] If the created intellect (pure perfection) possesses an infinite capacity by the gracious will of the Creator, when the divine unites itself to this intellect in the *lumen gloriae,* that light and union surpasses every natural potential of the mind.[37]

Furthermore, de la Taille meets the false implication that divine impotency must be responsible for the fact that habitual grace in Christ cannot be made better. He shows to the contrary that this "limitation" in Christ's created grace is a consequence of the intrinsic end of the form itself—"which cannot become superior to itself." For the end of grace is union with God, and the greatest possible union with God for a created nature is the hypostatic union. Therefore, the grace of Christ reached the highest measure possible for grace. Though finite in the order of being, Christ's grace is infinite considered in terms of the *ratio* or form of grace. Put otherwise, Christ's grace is in fact the *plenitude* of grace, and as such cannot be made greater—even as God's power is not to be faulted "because the number four cannot be made greater than it is."[38]

Having responded adequately to the matter of Christ's grace being created, incapable of increase, and yet *highest,* de la Taille summarizes

35. Cf. discussion above, 157.

36. *MF,* 520.

37. On the question of pure nature, see also de la Taille's cryptic digression in "Dialogue on the Grace of Union," 53–54. De la Taille here seems to suggest that pure nature and grace are related as the imperfect to the perfect, and that they would therefore exclude one another—"like faith and the beatific vision." Which is not to say, however, that pure nature is an obstacle to grace (or faith to the beatific vision). His point is that a purely natural destiny and the supernatural last end do not "coexist."

38. *MF,* 521; cf. *ST* III, q. 7, a. 11 and *ST* I, q. 25, a. 6, c.

his metaphysical analysis about this grace in the following way. Unlike human beings, Christ can be said to possess grace connaturally, but also said to be connaturally the subject of that grace: "[T]he plenitude of that grace is both the proper corollary of the hypostatic union, and, apart from the hypostatic union, cannot exist."[39] Because God makes a gift of himself in the Son's assuming of human nature (the grace of union), the grace of Christ is the "chief *analogum*" in the whole order of grace. Indeed, every grace in creatures is oriented to the grace of Christ as a deficient participation in perfect plenitude.[40]

Conceiving Christ's grace as prime *analogum* allows de la Taille to hold two neat theological positions. On the one hand, even though grace, "by the pleasure of God," may be increased always in creatures, still that grace, "however intense," remains "incomparably inferior" to Christ's. Here again, a Thomistic image proves salutary: as fire is to the sun, so is the grace of any creature to the grace of Christ (cf. *ST* III, q. 7, a. 11, ad 3). The grace of the believer participates in, but nonetheless never attains to, the plenitude that is the very source of grace. On the other hand, and somewhat paradoxically, de la Taille denies that Christ's grace is thereby a *limit* to the creature's grace. For although grace has its beginning and end under God, and is also "permitted some sort of endless progress under him," Christ's grace would be limit or boundary *only* if it were commensurate to grace in the believer and greatest in a relative, not absolute, way. Retrieving the words of Fulgentius, de la Taille concludes that the greatness of Christ's grace, a consequence of the hypostatic union, is best conceived as "the plenitude of perfection and the perfection of plenitude."[41]

Let us sum up the theological work done in these appendices on Christ's grace. We have seen, in the first place, that the hypostatic union is *the* determinative theological factor in considering created grace in Christ. The intimate union of the human flesh and the Word, the personal actuation of the *esse* of Christ by the *Esse* of the Word, "demands" a concomitant divine presence and assistance in the soul of Christ: thus a habitual sanctifying grace caused by the entire Trinity—if also rightly attributed to the indwelling of the Spirit. The very intimacy

39. *MF,* 521.
40. *MF,* 521.
41. Fulgentius, *Ep.* 14, n. 28; *MF,* 521–22.

of the union, which determines that Christ lives a divine life, likewise necessitates that this grace be the highest. As *summum,* Christ's grace inevitably stands as principal *analogum* and source of all created grace, grace that participates in his fullness. We likewise acknowledged de la Taille's preference for denominating habitual grace as "perfect, consequent disposition," a preference that, I suggested, enhances his vision of created grace in humans, particularly in relation to the sanctifying grace of the Eucharist: grace is a consequent disposition to the gift of divine indwelling.

To this point, we have confirmed that eucharistic communion with Christ amounts to a sharing in his divine life, a sharing that is a participation in the fullness of his created grace. In the final section of this chapter, we have yet to analyze the *nature* and *effect* of this participation in the grace of the Redeemer. De la Taille's theological observations about sin and salvation and the headship of Christ reveal even more profoundly the role of *devotio* in eucharistic sacrifice.

The Sanctifying Grace of the Eucharist: Sin and Redemption

Three interrelated topics structure this section: (1) de la Taille's thought on the nature of sanctifying grace in the Eucharist, which is the grace of the Redeemer; (2) the nature of the sin from which we are redeemed in the Eucharist by Christ, who is Head; and (3) the dynamic of desire in receiving from the font of grace. For the most part, de la Taille leans upon Thomas for his understanding of sanctifying grace as elevating and healing (*elevans et sanans*); however, it is likewise clear that he extends the thought of his "master" with his own presentational accents. For instance, de la Taille heavily stresses that this grace comes to human beings not only through the incarnation and the cross, but particularly through union to the flesh of Christ, the victim offered and returned by God for the worshipper's salvation. More, he richly and extensively treats Thomas's suggestion about the fundamental dynamic of desire and *intentio* in the flow of grace from the Eucharist.

Sanctifying Grace: The Elevating and Healing Grace of the Redeemer

An illuminating comparison commences de la Taille's explication: he asks about the relationship between the grace bestowed upon believers in the Eucharist and the grace offered to the innocent Adam and to the angels. As we discovered earlier, the very *ratio* of grace, its *raison d'être,* is to raise creatures to union (*consortium*) with the divine. This grace, available (and necessary) to the unfallen Adam and to the angels, is the same grace granted to believers in the Eucharist—though the latter possesses a "more particularized" power, *specialior* because directed to a nature weakened by sin. De la Taille is keen to state that this sanctifying grace is not "of another species" than the grace of the angels and prelapsarian humanity, but rather is grace in an "allotropic" state, a grace discharging *two* gifts—one elevating and one healing. He enumerates the "special" difference of this grace in a threefold way. Principally, the difference derives from the "diverse condition of the subject"—the integral human being (or angel) and humanity wounded by sin.[42] Secondly, the difference may be noted both in terms of power and in terms of benefits: "Not only did a more powerful grace arrive in the grace of the Redeemer, but also a grace with greater benefits, insofar as these are conferred to us not simply unmerited but while we are sinners."[43] Thirdly, this difference of eucharistic grace is considered from the perspective of the *end* of sanctifying grace. It is this point of difference that de la Taille accents. Even though all grace is directed to uniting creatures to God, a different *quality of desire* can mark the rational creature's movement toward this end. For the unfallen Adam and for angels, the end of union with the divine is looked to "only as desirable"—simply, as it were, and without agony. However, for post-lapsarian man, that end of union surely is desired, but also is perceived as fraught with difficulty (*arduus*). In the postmodern milieu, this desire for divine union would likely be termed not just arduous, but "impossible."[44] If de la Taille attends to eu-

42. *MF,* 522, 522n1.

43. *MF,* 522n2. In this note, de la Taille again points us to a more detailed treatment of the elevating and healing powers of grace in his *De gratia.*

44. Cf. Catherine Pickstock's *After Writing: The Liturgical Consummation of Philosophy* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1998), esp. 176ff.

charistic grace as elevating and healing, he focuses even more directly on its power to "*operate*" upon the desire of the wounded human will. The Eucharist "brings in a by far more powerful grace, advancing man beyond every level of human strength and constancy, *to fix the desire of his love in God*."[45]

This suggestion about the *virtus* of sanctifying grace to "fix" human desire aptly segues into the topic of human sin, a topic not addressed *in se,* but one that can be instructively gleaned from de la Taille's remarks throughout *Mysterium Fidei.* I would argue that de la Taille's understanding of sin colors his entire theology of eucharistic sacrifice. De la Taille locates sin in the fragmented will, conceiving sin as a weakness within the *intentio,* a weakness that impedes a pure desire for God. Recall that in our first chapter on sacrifice we noted that sacrifice is offered not to the omnipotence of God, by which he creates and holds all things in existence, but rather it is offered to God's goodness and lovableness, through which he calls all creatures to a share in his own divine life. Sin and its consequences are marked by the incapacity to firmly orient desire toward that divine offer of union. Desire is distracted, misdirected by the concupiscence of both the flesh and the spirit. In such a state, reparation for sin—even venial sin—cannot be given to God apart from the grace of Christ, apart from his own offer of perfect love on the cross. Why is this so? De la Taille explains that human sin, as a failure in love, signifies an eternal debt, in the sense that a simple and eternal God cannot be "partly loved" or "partly rejected." What was necessary for the redemption of humankind was the complete love and perfectly ordered desire manifest in the eternal sacrifice of Christ.[46] Participation in the oblation of Christ's sacrifice, by way of which one likewise participates in the sanctifying grace of Christ, re-forms and purifies an imperfect and fragmented desire of God.

De la Taille invokes principles of Thomistic Christology in describing how both Christ's grace and *caritas* effect redemption, and how Christ is most properly considered "Head" of humanity. Grace clearly

45. "Quo longe potentior importatur gratia, et *caritatis in Deum defixae intentio,* ultra omnem humanae firmitatis atque constantiae gradum, provecta"; *MF,* 522 (emphasis mine).

46. See footnotes 41 and 42 in *MF* 1:209, where de la Taille is arguing for the necessity of Christ's *eternal,* celestial sacrifice.

assumes a central role in de la Taille's soteriological vision. To be sure, the Son assumes human nature in order to heal it: the end of the incarnation is this healing. However, de la Taille follows Thomas in construing this healing as the effect of Christ's habitual grace, which, as we have argued above, is consequent to the grace of union. He thereby defends Thomas's configuration of the "curing" of human nature: "the human nature of Christ is the cure through Christ's habitual grace."[47]

Now for Thomas and for de la Taille, in order for the sacrifice of Christ to be truly redeeming—"adequate for the compensation of sin"—it had to manifest the greatest sorrow that could be "*endured through grace*" and love (*ST* III, q. 46, a. 6, c; ad 3, ad 6). This greatest love and grace are important features to de la Taille's understanding of sacrifice and the redemption of human desire. His selection of the following passage from Cano evidences this, for Cano's language points to the seat of desire in the will as the place of greatest suffering in Christ:

> Truly it is probable that, in the intellectual will of Christ, which is his own will, the degree of sadness was not only highest but also greatest. For it is desirable in the victim for sin that there be a contrition of heart and a sorrow of the will (the sacrifice wanted by God is a contrite spirit, etc.); also this spiritual sorrow is a contrary medicine for sin, because its seat is *chiefly in the will*.... Augustine, moreover, asserts that Christ took up those defects of our nature, which in the perfection of grace were not repugnant at all, but which emerge from a love of good things and from holy charity.[48]

We underscore here both the reality that Christ's greatest suffering occurs in the will, in the seat of love and *intentio,* and the importance of the operation of grace in the act of redemption. This supreme sorrow of Christ is necessarily accompanied by a grace powerful enough to heal and strengthen every infirmity of the human condition.[49] It is this very grace that Christ merited in his sacrifice, a grace offered to all sinners—"however fallen, however overthrown, however broken."[50] Citing Hebrews, the Epistle so seminal to his thought, de la Taille emphasizes that there is no limit to the healing and assistance that come forth from

47. *MF,* 522.

48. Cano, *De locis theologicis,* 12.c.13; *MF,* 523 (emphasis mine).

49. Interestingly, if oddly, de la Taille suggests that the presence of the comforting angel in Luke's Gospel provides an outward sign of this inner, assisting grace in Christ; see *MF,* 522–23.

50. *MF,* 524.

the "throne of grace," from the High Priest who sympathizes with our every weakness.[51] Moreover, because this grace was won in a particular way through Christ's sacrifice, the dispensing of this grace is tied to the victim of the sacrifice and to a participation in that sacrifice:

> For what he procured through the oblation of sacrifice is obtained through a participation in the sacrifice, the fruit of the oblation coming back from God through the most acceptable victim. Thus the grace of our reparation is present to us by participating in the body and blood of Christ, which is the Eucharist.[52]

Christ's supreme love and sorrow, as well as the plenitude of grace attending the oblation of his sacrifice, thereby clarify how eucharistic grace is proclaimed the cure for sin, for the feeble and misdirected desire of the fallen human will. As we have come to expect, de la Taille provides a wealth of testimony from early and medieval fathers, supplemented by a sampling of liturgical prayer, to corroborate this teaching about sin and eucharistic grace. I cite here but a single example of this tradition, one that seems to reflect best our author's mind-set, and one that again comes from Cyril of Alexandria. The text is from Cyril's *Commentary on John,* a selection that the church read during the octave of Corpus Christi:

> You partake of the Eucharist (*eulogiae*), believing it capable of *vanquishing not death alone but also of removing our every vice.* For Christ calms in us, the fallen, the savage law of the flesh in our members. He stirs up our love of God, he mortifies the agitated motion of the soul, not imputing sin to us, though we stand in it, but rather curing us as those that are sick. He binds up what is fractured, he lifts up the fallen, just like a good shepherd and one who would lay down his life for the sheep.[53]

Eucharistic grace, a sanctifying grace that flows from participation in Christ's perfect and redeeming love, works upon the fragmentation of the will: it calms agitation in the soul and ascetically shuffles desire; it enflames love and encourages virtue; it cleanses by an "all-powerful as-

51. "Therefore, since we have a great high priest who has passed through the heavens, Jesus, the Son of God, let us hold fast to our confession. For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but one who has similarly been tested in every way, yet without sin. So let us confidently approach the throne of grace to receive mercy and to find grace for timely help"; Heb 4:14–16.

52. *MF,* 524.

53. Cyril of Alexandria, *In Johan.* 4.c.2; *MF,* 524–25n2.

persion"; and, it strengthens the will against temptation, against every distraction of desire for God.[54]

Such reflection upon the redeeming effects of Christ's grace also leads de la Taille to include an "Epilogue" to his Elucidation on sanctifying grace, an addition that discourses more fully upon the *headship* of Christ—a theme that also emerged in book 1 of *Mysterium Fidei*. This meditation upon Christ's headship underlines (a) the centrality of Christ's body, to which we are "added" in the Eucharist and (b) the reality that Christ first "takes up" into his own divine life the flesh of those who desire to receive his body in the Eucharist. De la Taille establishes that the theological title of Christ as Head is understood "chiefly" in terms of "the flow of grace," or in terms of that activity and power of infusing grace.[55] He specifies that this activity properly begins only after Christ's sacrifice, as it is only consequent to the sacrifice that humans become Christ's members, "knit" to his body and grace, as it were, through partaking of the Eucharist.

This concept of headship also indicates that Christ is head *differently* over the angels and over humanity. The angels do not receive grace through a sacramental participation in the Eucharist, by which flesh and blood Christ merited grace for humans.

> Now the angels are neither sacramentally nor spiritually capable of such a communion—although Christ, through his sacrifice, merited for himself the state of glory in which he would illumine the angels. On this account the angels praise him more abundantly, because they are now associated and joined together spiritually to the Son of God in their intellectually subsisting created nature. Whence they are both more closely kindred and more truly to be called "sons of God."[56]

Angels acknowledge and seek their Head not through his body, but through his creative and enlightening mind—their means of intimacy with the Son. Humans desire and cling to the body of Christ because of the life and the grace that flow from it, and because of a longing for *consortium* with Christ:

54. See de la Taille's rich presentation of sources on this question of the effect of grace upon the will in *MF,* 524–25.

55. Cf. *MF* 1:36, 176–80, and *Liber* III, 525. De la Taille naturally acknowledges that Christ is also considered Head as ruler over all creation. However, he is most interested here in a eucharistic context of head, body, and grace.

56. *MF,* 525–26.

> Hence we cling to Christ's body much differently than the angels: it is through grace by which we are truly made concorporate to him, not only according to a communion of [human] nature but also according to the *consortium* of one spiritual sanctified body. For our participation in the Lord's sacrifice introduces this union to the divine body.[57]

De la Taille's meditation upon Christ as Head among angels and humans further unfolds the mystery of access to union and grace through the eucharistic body of Christ. Humans hold fast to the body of the glorified victim, for the flow of grace is through the sanctified Head.

The theological significance of Christ's headship is richly explored in an earlier (book 1) discussion of Christ's *own partaking* of the Eucharist at the Last Supper.[58] In the first part of *Mysterium Fidei,* de la Taille is not addressing grace directly, but is rather concerned with looking at Christ's partaking from the aspect of *sacrifice.* He argues that the headship of Christ makes it "intrinsically fitting" that Christ should partake before his disciples at the supper. The crux of the question is the signifying value of Christ's partaking: Christ, as "head of the human race," "opens the way" to the kingdom and to the gifts of God (*bona Dei*). We can summarize de la Taille's lengthy and spiritually impressive discussion of Christ's partaking by focusing on the two pivotal features of his reflection: (a) Christ's own eating and drinking perfectly signify that influx of grace from head to body; and (b) his feasting signifies *causally* the sanctification of his followers.

Turning to patristic testimony,[59] de la Taille affirms that *alone* "we are unable to eat of the bread and drink of the chalice"; rather, believers only partake "under Christ and in Christ and with Christ (*sub Christo et cum Christo et in Christo*)." Hence it is fitting that he who now "sups with us and through us in the church," both as banquet (*convivium*) and as fellow-guest (*conviva*), should himself not only provide the food "by which we should be vivified," but also first partake of it himself.

57. *MF,* 525–26.

58. De la Taille argues that indeed Christ did eat and drink of the Eucharist at the supper, a position he holds with Thomas (*In 4 Sent.* D. 11, q. 3, a. 1, ad 3) and with an extensive host of patristic and medieval witnesses. This position is also congruent with a number of early liturgies—Coptic, Syrian, and Armenian; see *MF* 1:165–74.

59. He particularly has in mind passages from Cyprian, Jerome, Ambrose, Honorius, and Augustine, which he cites in the preceding pages; see *MF* 1:165–74.

Christians cannot eat the "bread of the children of God" unless he, as head, *initiates* them into the feast of his Father.[60] Christ is the "principal" guest, the guest "by nature," of the Father's banquet. By his own eating and drinking, he granted his disciples "admittance" to his table "throughout the ages." He made his followers "with himself one household of God, one family, one stock," securing for them a share of all the goods of his Father's banquet. Granted, Christ himself receives nothing in his partaking, but as head of the body he "pours forth" "both the privilege and the fruit of eating."[61] For de la Taille, then, Christ's eating signifies that his partaking in grace and sanctification leads the way for the sanctification of his followers. The believer is not incorporated to Christ unless Christ is first, i.e., unless the believer is "taken up," gathered to, and drawn by the banquet of Christ's flesh.[62]

It is hardly surprising to find de la Taille taking this signifying power of Christ's eating a step further, asserting that what is signified by Christ's action is in fact realized in those who also eat. Two integral points emerge about the causality of Christ's eating and drinking at the supper. When de la Taille articulates that Christ's eating signifies banquet-fellowship with him in his Father's household, he intends that this symbolic action *causes* that "family relationship." We noted above that Christ's partaking of the victim does not indicate any growth in sanctity in him—for he was already replete with sanctifying grace. His partaking, however, shows forth that he is in fact the sanctified one, he himself feasting upon the victim offered to God, the victim made sacred in its approach to God. This very unity of identity in the signification—for in Christ (the partaker) there is the very sanctity of the victim, the victim who in fact possesses the sanctity of God—accounts for the sacramental *virtus* in those who eat, in those who participate in the truth of that signification as Christ's members.

> Therefore, from the perfect truth of signification [in Christ's partaking] flows the efficacy of the sacrament among us. And thusly, according to the gospel promise,

60. *MF* 1:177; *MF,* 127.

61. *MF* 1:177; *MF,* 127.

62. "Non incorporamur quidem Christo nisi percepta aliqualiter carne Christi (ut infra, in libro tertio, constabit): sed nec percipimus carnem Christi vitaliter nisi Christo incorporati"; *MF,* 127. This line is oddly (perhaps inadvertently) missing from the English translation.

do grace and truth descend from the only-begotten to brethren, from the head to the members. Christ intended all this in his one prayer: *For them do I sanctify myself, so that they themselves also may be sanctified in truth.* Or, "I scarcely acquire the sanctity of the sacrifice for myself than I distribute it to the very ones who partake with me of my supper."[63]

De la Taille's evocative interpolation of Christ's eating and drinking at the supper accentuates the immediacy and efficacy of the shared sanctification deriving from Christ's self-offering.

This reflection on Christ's headship at the Last Supper powerfully reinforces his central thesis on the *res tantum* of the Eucharist: partaking of the Eucharist is sign (and cause) of union *ad Christum,* a union that grants a sharing in the divine life and in the sanctifying grace of the eternal victim and sacrifice. Christ is "head" and "font" of the grace that raises and heals fallen nature. His own partaking of the Eucharist is both signifying and *demonstrative.* It signifies the believer's access to or initiation into the divine sanctification, the pathway into the very heart of Trinitarian life. And Christ's partaking is *demonstrative:* it reveals his desire to take to himself those for whom he offers his life, even as he shows his followers where this grace can be found.

Eucharistic and Sacramental Grace: Desire and the Necessity of the Eucharist

We have seen that the Eucharist effects intimate union to Christ, and that in that union one receives, or better, participates in Christ's elevating and healing grace—grace superlatively belonging to him on account of the hypostatic union, and grace "won" for all in the greatest love and sorrow of his sacrifice. Two essential questions remain in our analysis of de la Taille's theology of grace. The first inquiry explores the relationship between eucharistic grace and the grace of the other sacraments, which de la Taille distinguishes as "sacramental grace." We shall briefly indicate how this sacramental grace *borrows from,* or depends upon, the Eucharist. De la Taille's second question treats of the necessity of the Eucharist for salvation. His handling of this topic fascinates, for it fully brings to the surface a theology of desire that, I maintain, is

63. *MF* 1:177; *ME,* 127–28.

a critical but overlooked facet of his thought. In a rather nuanced way, but one consonant with Thomas and a broad spectrum of voices from both the East and West, he argues that the Eucharist is indeed necessary for salvation—albeit this is a *necessity of means,* not of law. Significantly, it is a necessity that can be met through a sincere desire for the sacrament of union *ad Christum.*

De la Taille's treatment of the relationship between eucharistic grace and the grace of the other sacraments confirms a central principle of book 3 (and of this chapter)—namely, that all grace is a participation in the grace of the Redeemer. Specifically, all grace flows from the eucharistic body of Christ—the victim offered, accepted by God, and returned as sanctifying food. Citing from the *Catechismus Romanus,* de la Taille assumes the burden of "proving" the metaphor found therein, that the Eucharist is "the fountain of all graces" from which the other sacraments flow as rivulets. According to the sixteenth-century catechism, the Eucharist is such a fountain because "in a marvelous way" it contains Christ the Lord, who is the "fountain itself of every heavenly gift and grace."[64] De la Taille pursues this metaphor by establishing the difference between *sacramental* and *sanctifying* grace, and by showing that all the sacraments do in fact draw upon the fountain of the Eucharist *by desire.*

De la Taille unpacks this teaching about the nature of eucharistic grace by first considering the question of sacramental causality. He posits that the *res et sacramentum* is the mediating cause of the *res tantum.* The *res et sacramentum* of the Eucharist is the body and blood of Christ, which alone signifies and causes grace by itself (*ex seipso*), imparting a "participation in divine sanctity and life."[65] If the Eucharist alone causes sanctifying grace, the *res et sacramentum* of the other sacraments signify—by themselves (*ex sese*)—only "something towards

64. *Catechismus Romanus,* 2.c.4.n. 47–48; *MF,* 573.

65. De la Taille is here drawing upon Thomas, *ST* III, q. 79, a. 1, ad 1 and 2. It is worth quoting de la Taille's own confirmation of this point, which he articulates in the language of sacrifice: "For, as we have said frequently, the sharing (*consortium*) of divine life and holiness is not obtained other than from a partaking of the living and vivifying victim—sanctified and sanctifying. Now to give and indicate this sharing in his life and sanctity is truly an act of the victim himself, even as it is placed before us for the partaking"; see *MF,* 583n3 and 581.

grace," as "disposing or ordered" to grace ("*aliquid ad gratiam, ita consideratam, quasi disponens vel ordinatum*").[66] De la Taille identifies this "dispositive" grace as "*sacramental grace,*" even as he is quick to add that it must be understood, "materially speaking," to be the same as grace—but in truth a grace ultimately imparted by the flow of grace from the Eucharist, a grace "placed on top (*superimpendente*)" of the other sacraments, as it were.

In short, the other sacraments are thought to cause grace *imperfectly.* They participate in an incomplete way in the power of the Eucharist, which is said to "causally complete" them. One could query, justly, about the purpose of the other sacraments and whether the Eucharist *needs* them. De la Taille attends to both of these concerns. He offers two possible models for understanding the causal relationship between the Eucharist and the other sacraments. First, he suggests that the Eucharist can be seen as universal cause, while the others are particular causes; or, second, that the Eucharist can be viewed as "the maker," and the other sacraments as "tools of the craft."[67] Manifestly, these comparisons expose that the other sacraments cannot operate without the principal cause—namely, without the Eucharist. Of themselves, "particular causes" and "tools" remain *in potentia,* ineffectual without the principal cause. De la Taille, however, also wants to argue that the Eucharist *requires* the collaboration of the other sacraments, not in terms of "receiving power from them," but in terms of supplying particular *dispositions* in the subject. The Eucharist "employs" the other sacraments insofar as the *res et sacramentum* of each sacrament, bestowed at a particular moment in time, "modifies a passive potency in the subject with respect to the grace of the Eucharist."[68] This modifying of an obediential potency is no mean work of grace, as we discovered in our discussion of grace above. If the Eucharist is deifying union with Christ and therefore with the Father, it is not surprising that it requires the preparatory effects of the other sacraments. In a manner of speaking,

66. "For all the sacraments through sanctification prepare one either for receiving or consecrating the Eucharist" (*ST* III, q. 73, a. 3 and q. 65, a. 3); see *MF,* 573–74, 583.

67. *MF,* 577; 581–85.

68. *MF,* 577–78.

the sacraments remove or forestall obstacles to sanctifying grace; they open a new passage for the power of the sacrificial banquet, a power from which these sacraments "borrow" for their own work.[69]

De la Taille provides a number of engaging, corroborating passages from the tradition. We shall look at only a single passage, a quotation from Denys's *Ecclesiastical Hierarchy* (c. 3.1). In the *Ecclesiastical Hierarchy,* Denys gives to the Eucharist the proper name of "communion or synaxis," and then adds that it is "the sacraments of sacraments (τελετῶν τελετήν)," because without the Eucharist the other sacraments are not only incomplete, but without power to gather one fully into union with God: "Now if therefore each of the hierarchical sacraments [apart from the Eucharist] remains incomplete (ἀτελής), *our communion and gathering to the One is not perfectly accomplished, and thus our full perfection is denied because the sacrament alone is inefficacious.*"[70] In other words, it is only from the perfective grace of union to God, accomplished in the Eucharist, that the other sacraments derive their power and obtain perfection.[71] Summarizing this teaching, de la Taille adds his own poetic image to that of the fathers and doctors he has summoned for witness. He writes that just as all churches are built to face the East, so all the sacraments ("as well as the whole Christian liturgy and ecclesial discipline") look to the rising sun of the Eucharist, in which "*our Sun visited from high to illumine those who live in darkness and the shadow of death.*"[72] The Eucharist is the light and *energia* of the whole sacramental system.

The sacraments therefore have the power to induce their proper effects through the outpouring of sanctifying grace from the Eucha-

69. De la Taille does not hesitate to acknowledge here the application of the reciprocal logical order of priority and posteriority; *MF,* 584n1.

70. *MF,* 575.

71. The preaching of Vincent Ferrer speaks to this same doctrine with a charming image of the planetary system: "Now among them all, the sacrament of the Eucharist is principal … because this great sacrament gives power to the others. This is demonstrated in the heavens, in which there are seven planets: first the moon, second Mercury, third Venus, fourth the sun, fifth Mars, sixth Jupiter, and seventh Saturn. And just as the sun stands in the middle, as in the fourth place, and gives power and light to the other planets, so the sacrament of the Eucharist is reckoned as in the fourth place, from which the other sacraments receive power and light—and it receives nothing itself from the others"; *Sermones de tempore, In octava corporis Christi, sermon unicus,* 1497 edition, Codicis 00 fol. III a., 245; *MF,* 576.

72. *MF,* 575.

rist. Thinking congruently with Thomas,[73] de la Taille maintains four (*apparently* contradictory) assertions about the relationship between sacramental and sanctifying grace: (1) sacramental grace "adds" something beyond sanctifying grace; (2) sacramental grace, however, is not actually distinct from sanctifying grace—except according to purpose (*ratio*); (3) sanctifying grace can exist without sacramental grace; and (4) when sacramental grace is present, it exists always in relation to and *from* sanctifying grace (the grace of the Eucharist).[74] Paradoxically then, we can say that sacramental grace is antecedent (dispositive) to sanctifying grace, that it is consequent to the grace of the Eucharist, and that it is within (*intra*) eucharistic grace.

Sacramental causality thus indicates the Eucharist as source of Christ's redeeming grace in the church's sacramental economy, yet de la Taille also discusses the relationship between the Eucharist and the other sacraments in terms of *desire*. We have established that union *ad Christum* and a participation in the grace of the Redeemer is necessary for salvation, and we have seen that this *consortium* derives from eating of the eucharistic flesh of the Gift offered, Christ. De la Taille now argues, in line with traditional teaching, that this eucharistic grace and union can be received by desire (*ex voto*). I postpone until chapter 9 an exposition of the dynamic of desire operative between the primary sacraments of baptism and the Eucharist, a particular dynamic that, I contend, stands at the heart of de la Taille's theory on sacrifice. In the meantime, we can observe how he regards each of the sacraments as "charged" with desire for the uniting and healing grace that flows from the Eucharist. A fervent orientation of the will toward the Eucharist, if *authentic* (that is, a genuine desire to receive it *in re*), is itself efficacious of this grace.

How are we to understand this power of desire? Why does a sincere *devotio* and attraction to the grace of the Eucharist itself apprehend sanctifying grace? From the sacrament of the Eucharist, understood as the "union of love in Christ to God," streams the grace that "meets," creates, and enflames the devotion of the subject disposed toward it.

73. Cf. *ST* III, q. 62, a. 2; *In 4 Sent.* D. 1, q. 1, a. 4; *Veri.* q. 27, a. 5, ad 12.
74. *MF,* 583.

All sacramental grace, indeed salvation itself, "hangs (*pendeat*)" upon this desire for the Eucharist.[75] De la Taille cites with high approbation the "illustrious" Toletus, sixteenth-century Spanish Jesuit:

> Hence it is that, not in baptism alone, but also in the other sacraments, the desire for the Eucharist is included. Indeed, within the desire of each of these sacraments is the eucharistic desire. For the one who possesses the desire for baptism, at once has the desire for the Eucharist; similarly with the one who holds confirmation, penance and the other sacraments in desire. Thus, even though the Eucharist is necessary for salvation, the sinner may be justified through contrition with the desire of confession, as the Council of Trent held in Session VI. For within confession itself is the desire for the very grace of Eucharist—for the end of every sacrament is the Eucharist itself.[76]

Concluding from Toletus's reflection, de la Taille affirms that every sacrament of the new law can give the grace of union because they all "touch" upon this grace through ardent longing for the Eucharist. In short, the Eucharist is received in the other sacraments by way of desire.

De la Taille likewise draws explicitly upon the authority of Thomas, who, in Question 80, article 11 of the *Tertia Pars,* provides an eloquent summary of his teaching about the centrality of the Eucharist and the necessity of *spiritual eating*—eating *ex voto*—for salvation.[77] De la Taille understands Thomas to be making four interrelated points in q. 80: "(1) incorporation to Christ is necessary for human salvation; (2) for that reason, the spiritual eating of the Eucharist is necessary; (3) consequently, one must say that a desire for receiving the Eucharist actually (*in re*) is necessary; and (4) therefore, if it is in one's power, the sacramental reception of the Eucharist is necessary for salvation of every man."[78] In a word, spiritual eating—the desire to receive the Eucharist—is, at the very least, essential for salvation. With Thomas, de la

75. *MF,* 605.

76. Toletus, *In Joan.* 6.54, Colon Agrip. 1589, col. 605; *MF,* 577.

77. In more detail, de la Taille brings together three separate statements from the *Tertia Pars:* (1) "Before the reception of this sacrament [the Eucharist, *in re*], a man can possess salvation through the desire of receiving this sacrament, just as before baptism, one can receive salvation by the desire for the sacrament of baptism"; (2) "[So that one may possess life *simpliciter*] it suffices to have [the Eucharist] by desire"; and (3) "[Infants] desire the Eucharist by the intention of the church, and consequently, they receive the reality of the sacrament itself"; *MF,* 605. *Desire* clearly plays the critical role not only in attaining the benefits of the Eucharist, but also in enjoying the grace of any of the sacraments.

78. *MF,* 605.

Taille clarifies that this desire is merely "empty," thereby inefficacious, if it remains *unsatisfied* when the opportunity to receive sacramentally presents itself. In our final chapter, we shall explore why de la Taille also argues for a frequency of communing *in re*. For now, let it suffice to say that the very desire to receive needs to be inflamed by the actual grace of the eucharistic banquet.

This teaching about reception *ex voto* permits a defense of the idea that, even before the advent of Christ and his sacrificial oblation, salvation was possible through faith and a desire for the Eucharist. De la Taille admits that this doctrine can appear "odd" and "even absurd," though amply supported by fathers in the East and West.[79] But the doctrine seems less strange in the context of sacramental desire and the sacrificial meal of the cross, by which all "are made to participate in that one sacrifice" of redemption:

> For just as it was necessary that a man should live toward God in (implicit) hope of the true victim to come, so also now the (implicit) desire of receiving the true victim is deemed necessary. Thus the fruit of the sacrifice, which is received from the victim of the sacrifice, is properly gathered by that desire.[80]

Desire for the genuine victim-to-come is also effective desire. More robustly, de la Taille follows Thomas, as well as a number of patristic voices, in interpreting Paul in 1 Cor. 10:3–4. Paul, writing about Moses and the Hebrews, says that "all ate the same spiritual food and all drank the same spiritual drink, for all drank from the same rock that followed them, and the rock was Christ." The manna is understood to be "a sign of eucharistic desire," and therefore one can say that the ancients ate and drank "spiritually" of the Eucharist. De la Taille here quotes Thomas's apt reflection in his *Commentary on 1 Corinthians:*

> *All ate the same spiritual food*, that is the body of Christ—understood spiritually by way of a sign.… *And all drank the same drink,* which is to say the blood of Christ, also spiritually by way of a sign (*in signo*).… Because the desire for the

79. *MF,* 599. See the texts he cites from Augustine (*In Joan.*, tr. 26.c.6.n.12); from Ephraem, rather boldly in *Hymni Azymorum* 17, no. 5, in *Sancti Ephraem Syri hymni et sermones,* edited by Thomas Josephus Lamy (*Mechlinae: H. Dessein, Summi Pontificis, 1882–1902),* 1:618; from Hugh of St. Victor (*Quaestionum et Decisionum in Epistolas Pauli* 80, PL, 175, 529); from Chrysostom (*In 1 Cor.*, h. 1, PG 61, 191); and from Ambrose (*De mysteriis,* c. 9, n. 58) (*MF,* 597–99).

80. *MF,* 599–600.

food and drink is sufficient, he [Paul] says *All ate;* and because that desire is unfailing [*indeficiens*], he says that they ate *the same.*[81]

However, de la Taille does acknowledge a difference between the spiritual eating of the ancients and the spiritual eating of believers after the institution of the Eucharist. In the latter, the salvation and eucharistic nourishment *ex voto* is by efficient causality, for after the sacrifice of Christ, the grace of the Eucharist indeed works upon the human soul and its desires in a way that indicates something newly created, a change accomplished by God *efficienter.*[82] For those who lived before the institution of the eucharistic sacrifice, that causality can only be described as *final* or *intentional.* In other words, if the Eucharist does not yet exist, it cannot save through a mode of efficient causality, but it can operate in a mode of final causality, whereby "it already *summons the desire,* and also will *inform* that desire, and consequently *make it worthy* of the end."[83] Such is the power of eucharistic grace to attract those who lived in faith and expectation before Christ's sacrifice; and so great is its saving influence that, those who desired it, in fact received it *in voto.*[84]

In this last section, we have seen how de la Taille's theology of grace and the sacraments upholds the necessity of the Eucharist for salvation. The individual sacraments depend for their own causal power upon the Eucharist, from which their "dispositive" grace flows. More, each of the sacraments is ordered, according to *intentio* and *desiderium,* to the sanctifying grace of the Eucharist—to union with Christ.

De la Taille has prepared us for such theological assertions by his delineation of grace in Christ, that is, by his insistence that the source of all grace and divine life is the body of the sacrificial victim. No secondary principle of grace can "stand" unless subordinate to the "source of sources (*principiorum principio*)" and connected to the "perfection of

81. *In 1 Cor.*; *MF,* 600.

82. Cf. discussion in chapter 6. What de la Taille seems to be saying here in terms of efficient causality is that the sanctifying grace of the Eucharist, received either *in voto* or *in re* by those existing after Christ, effects a real change in the believer—a real actuation of a potency *ad Deum*, a real *union* to the divine life.

83. *MF,* 600 (emphasis mine).

84. See de la Taille's clarifying remarks in *MF,* 600n2.

perfections"—the sacrificial banquet. De la Taille's rich account of the superlative grace of Christ, his effort to show the essential connection between the grace of union and habitual grace in Christ, and his full exposition of the saving effects of participating in the Redeemer's grace all serve to enhance a theological vision of the magnitude of the grace that flows through the Eucharist. In the end, every desire for grace is a desire toward the Eucharist, a desire directed toward intimate union with Christ. While the sacraments do indeed dispose the believer in grace to the Eucharist, it is the desire for the Eucharist itself that *perfects* these dispositions of grace. We close this chapter with a statement that again reveals the principle of reciprocal priority and causality, a mark of de la Taille's theology of grace: "For the Eucharist itself begets both the desire, which disposes one toward grace, and the grace from which desire proceeds."[85] The Eucharist is essential for the life of desire, for life *ad gratiam*.

85. *MF,* 611 and 612.

6 "Created Actuation by Uncreated Act"

The previous two chapters have focused on de la Taille's theology of grace as it was articulated in *Mysterium Fidei,* particularly in book 3—"De sacramento." We observed, first, his exposition of the threefold signification of the Eucharist, which immediately alerted us to de la Taille's propensity to think of grace in terms of deifying union to Christ and of the fulfillment of that grace in resurrected glory. De la Taille's predilection for the thought of Cyril of Alexandria accentuated that sharing in divine life depends on the willingness of Christ to take up the believer into his own flesh and divine life, a reality communicated as the sanctified victim disperses himself, spreading his grace through bread/flesh and wine/blood. Secondly, in chapter 5, we attended to the careful delineation of grace in Christ in order to perceive how profoundly Christ is "fountain" and "head" of the sanctifying grace that elevates and heals. We noted as well de la Taille's rich treatment of the necessity of the Eucharist, a truth founded upon the reality that all grace flows through the sacrificial victim. He underscored how, within the sacramental economy of the church, this necessity for eucharistic grace is neatly entangled with desire for the flesh and life of Christ.

The present chapter explores de la Taille's later writing on grace, in which he introduced a central insight summed up in the phrase "created actuation by Uncreated Act." As described above, the two journal essays he dedicated to this topic generated significant response, attract-

ing the attention of theologians intrigued by questions of grace in relationship to the hypostatic union and divine indwelling.[1] The burden of this chapter is less to defend de la Taille's theory than to examine his proposal about created actuation in light of *Mysterium Fidei* and his theological project therein. Additionally, we shall remain attuned to his peculiar mindset on the question of nature and grace in an effort to further ascertain and assess his contribution to the topic.

Apart from a level of technical diction, I see little substantial difference between what de la Taille develops about grace in book 3 and his presentation in these later journal articles. In *Mysterium Fidei* he was eager to demonstrate that sanctifying grace belonged most properly and in the highest way to Christ, as connatural to the grace of union. The later essays are more keenly directed to proving that the hypostatic union results in a real change or modification, "a *passive* actuation," in the human nature. What appears to be at stake in this effort is an analogy for divine indwelling (whether we are speaking of the hypostatic union, the beatific vision, or sanctifying grace). The analogy distinctly excludes any extrinsicist reading, for the actuation described by de la Taille is *an actuation of a potentiality in the subject that really inheres (is something "created") and that unites that subject to the Act,* without affecting that Act. In a word, what obtains in this created communication is a *union*—a union that neatly concurs with the explication of sanctifying grace communicated in eucharistic participation. I am suggesting that de la Taille's "created actuation" formula was incubating as he prepared and wrote his major work on the Eucharist, a work intently interested in the grace consequent to partaking of the sacrificial victim.

Both Prudence de Letter, S.J., and Malachai Donnelly, the key expositors and supporters of de la Taille's theory of created actuation, fail to acknowledge that his thought on grace is embedded in this context of eucharistic sacrifice and union. The connection between the two articulations is a seminal one. How does the theologian explain, in philosophical terms, the eucharistic *circumincessio* between Christ and his members, an effect of the Eucharist given potent expression by tradi-

1. See note 12 in chapter 4.

tional voices like Cyril of Alexandria?[2] Does eucharistic union give rise to "created actuation" or, more accurately, is sanctifying grace a kind of created actuation effected by the transcendent Act? I shall contend that de la Taille's later metaphysical construal of hypostatic union bears the marks of a theological articulation contextualized by eucharistic sacrifice: hypostatic union is depicted as oriented to the dispersal of grace belonging to Christ.

The two realities promoted by the theory of "created actuation by uncreated Act" resonate with what we already know about sanctifying grace from *Mysterium Fidei:* first, the reality that sanctifying grace is the self-donation of God to spiritual creatures, and secondly, the reality that such grace is a consequence of God's desire to unite with creatures, actuating a capacity—*which is itself the union*—for deifying friendship with the Godhead. We shall see that de la Taille's "created actuation" goes beyond the (natural) relationship of efficient causality by which every creature is oriented to God as Creator (as final end). Rather, "created actuation" indicates an immediate (supernatural) union of divine actuating presence in the human soul. Behind de la Taille's analogy from potency and act lies the image of that intimate and vivifying union of incorporation into the body of Christ. Let us explore this thesis in the course of unpacking and analyzing de la Taille's theory of created actuation.

"Created Actuation by Uncreated Act"

We begin with a careful explication of what de la Taille means by "created actuation" before attending to how he applies it analogically to the beatific vision (*lumen gloriae*), sanctifying grace, and the hypostatic union. I will rely predominantly on the article "*Actuation créée par acte incréé*" (1928), drawing upon his second dialogue piece, "*Entretien amical d'Euxode et de Palamède sur la grâce d'union*" (1929), only to clarify questions raised about the application of his theory to the grace of union. A preliminary observation ought to accompany our explication: de la Taille

2. De la Taille applauds Pierre Pourrat (*La spiritualité chrétienne* [Paris: V. Lecoffre, 1918], 18) for employing *circumincessio,* a term used of the union of the Trinity, to describe the nature of the unity between Christ and the believer in the Eucharist; see *MF,* 511n2.

bristled at the accusation that this theory posed something "new"—that is, something specifically incompatible with Thomistic principles. In fact, at the end of his "Dialogue," he (as Palamedes) confesses that he is a mere "plagiarist" in expressing that believers are, through grace, "actuated in a created fashion by the Uncreated."[3] As with his allegedly "new" theory of eucharistic sacrifice, de la Taille again finds himself in a position of shaking off the unwanted title of "theological innovator."

At the heart of de la Taille's formula, "created actuation by uncreated Act," is the concept of *actuation*. An actuation is a "communication" by an act to a receptive "potency," a communication that bestows a perfection upon that which is imperfect. On the side of the subjective potency, then, actuation involves a "change" and "amelioration."[4] De la Taille chooses his words with extreme care as he describes the relation that obtains in actuation: what the act communicates is *itself,* thereby initiating a union between the subjective potency and the act. Actuation is "a union, a self-donation (*un don de soi*)."[5] Actuation is not principally in the order of efficient causality, which is to say that it has little to do with "generation" or "production." Rather, *relation* and *union* are the key terms in actuation. It might be salutary at this point to recall that when God operates by efficient causality, a real relation of dependence obtains in the creature, but such a relation does not necessitate the divine self-gift. In the order of grace, on the other hand, divine causality "builds upon" created nature to the end of union. Divine indwelling means the self-donation of the triune God; it intends union.

However, if efficient causality is ruled out as proper to an account of actuation, de la Taille does not eliminate all causality from his discourse,

3. De la Taille, "Dialogue on the Grace of Union," in *The Hypostatic Union and Created Actuation by Uncreated Act* (West Baden Springs, Ind.: West Baden College, 1952), 76. In a similar self-deferential way, de la Taille claims earlier in this same essay that the phrase "created actuation by uncreated Act" *may* be a "new" one, but that he lacks the "erudition" to substantiate such a possibility (66). He writes this at a point in the dialogue when his interlocutor is challenging his reading of Thomas. De la Taille would object likewise to any suggestion that his theory of the supernatural is at odds with a patristic teaching of divine indwelling.

4. De la Taille, "Created Actuation by Uncreated Act," in *The Hypostatic Union,* 29. I will be using this English translation, except where de la Taille's native French proves illuminating; cf. de la Taille, "Actuation créée par Act incréé: Lumière de gloire, grâce sanctifiante, union hypostatique," *Récherches de science religieuse* 18 (1928): 253–68.

5. De la Taille, "Created Actuation," 29; de la Taille, "Actuation créée par Act incréé," 253.

for indeed, actuation *modifies* a potency. Hence, he inclines toward the category of formal causality, but not without making several distinctions. Actuation is not de facto "information"—though it certainly can be, and, in the natural order, is so. When actuation is information, the act is in some way dependent on the potency for its own perfection, that is, there is a certain reciprocity, "an exchange of resources," even though the exchange be imbalanced.[6] The readily apparent example of this information-actuation is the human soul. The soul actuates the corporeal matter of the body, informing it, yet also needing it for the "integration" of its powers. The potency, in this case, complements the soul's own perfection.

Still, though formal causality holds true of actuation in the natural order, it cannot be applied strictly to actuation by the uncreated Act of being. This restriction is for an obvious reason: "The uncreated Act cannot be dependent on a creature in any way whatever. It will give itself and receive nothing."[7] Thus the dynamic of actuation must be qualified when we focus on the last part of de la Taille's phrase, "*by uncreated Act*." Act, de la Taille maintains, does indeed communicate itself, but there is no formal causality—"properly so called," and thereby no "formal effect" in the subjective potency. Enmeshed in these Aristotelian and Scholastic categories, can one say anything more precisely about this actuation? A strong advocate, Prudence de Letter, argues that what de la Taille has in mind is a "quasi-information" by uncreated Act, or "quasi-formal causality," a concept that Rahner, apparently independent of de la Taille, employed in his early work (1939) on uncreated Grace.[8]

De Letter grants that he has not found this phrase in de la Taille's work; nor have I, and I would be more hesitant than de Letter in apply-

6. De la Taille, "Actuation créée par Act incréé," 253.

7. "Created Actuation," 30. De la Taille was taken to task by Thomas Mullaney, O.P., precisely for blurring the "distinction" between the supernatural and natural orders; see Mullaney, "The Incarnation: De la Taille vs. the Thomistic Tradition," 2 and *passim*. It will be clear that de la Taille amply protects himself from such an accusation.

8. De Letter, "Created Actuation by Uncreated Act," 63; also de Letter, "The Theology of God's Self-Gift," 417–18; cf. Karl Rahner, S.J., "Some Implications of the Scholastic Concept of Uncreated Grace," *Theological Investigations* (London: Darton, Longman, and Todd, 1961), 1:319–46. In added footnotes to this essay on grace, Rahner acknowledges the thought of de la Taille and the similarity between his and de la Taille's work (esp. 319, 340).

ing Rahner's concept to de la Taille's metaphysical vision. Thomas Mullaney, O.P., and, much later, Matthew Lamb, have faulted de la Taille for misunderstanding or misappropriating the categories of act and potency.[9] Without attempting to refute either critic (de la Taille's "Dialogue" solidly justifies his Thomistic use of act and potency), it may well be said that de la Taille is stretching these categories—without, however, transgressing them. In fact, de la Taille does employ the term "quasi-formal *effect*" as he is discussing John of Thomas's understanding of the incarnation and of the anointing of Christ's soul by the "uncreated Sanctity."[10] The passage at least suggests de la Taille's approval of John's phrase, for it indicates that there was, in the human nature of Christ, an intrinsic change and effect in the grace of union. This much is absolutely clear about de la Taille's position: the uncreated Act effects, in its actuation, a modification in the subjective potency, and this change in the potency is real (and permanent). More, it is "an adaptation of the potency to the Act," which adaptation signifies union.[11] De la Taille offers no firm objection to thinking of this as a "quasi-formal effect" in the subject. But he distinctly prefers to eschew language of cause and effect in order not to divert attention away from the *result* of this actuation, which, considered either from the side of the Act or of the receptive potency, is *a relation of union.*

Before turning to de la Taille's threefold analogical application of "created actuation by uncreated Act," we give heed, finally, to the first component of the formula. What does calling this actuation "created" underscore? I suggest that "created" identifies four theological realities about grace as actuation—some of them obvious and already intimated above. First, a *created* actuation has a *beginning:* there was a "time" when the eternal Logos was not united to human nature, and there was a moment when the believer was not yet sanctified by Trinitarian grace.[12] Secondly, something created suggests a *new reality,* for what previously existed only in potency has received a perfection of be-

9. T. Mullaney, "The Incarnation," 10–21; Lamb, "An Analogy for the Divine Self-Gift," 131–35.
10. De la Taille, "Dialogue," 69.
11. De la Taille, "Created Actuation," 30.
12. Cf. de la Taille, "The Schoolmen," in *The Hypostatic Union,* 20–22.

ing. We can propose, thirdly and concomitantly, that this new reality is gratuitous and *accidental* to the potency. This new relation of union might not have existed; this actuation by the Uncreated includes an act of volition on the part of the Act. Fourthly, and perhaps most importantly, in calling this actuation in the subject something "created," de la Taille understands the actuation (which we shall soon name sanctifying grace) as intrinsic to the creature, which is to say, the actuation by uncreated Act (God's self-gift) "intrinsically affects" the believer.[13] In other words, the term "*created* actuation" militates against any sense that God's grace, God's actuation of a created potency to union with himself, is something "alien"—an extrinsic adaptation or a mediate reality, rather than an immediate union and reality. Can one go further and claim, irrefutably, that de la Taille's non-extrinsicist approach to grace stems primarily from his work on the Eucharist? Perhaps not; but it is very nearly impossible to imagine his depiction of eucharistic intimacy, along with his saturation in the Eastern fathers, as founding any other theory of grace than the kind he here articulates.

De la Taille both explores and tests his "hypothesis" of created actuation in looking analogously at (1) the light of glory, (2) sanctifying grace, and (3) the hypostatic union—three instances of God's self-donation to humans or, in his words, three examples "*où Dieu se fait l'Acte d'une puissance créée.*"[14] Prudence de Letter suggests that this order of explication, beginning with the *lumen gloriae,* proceeding to sanctifying grace and ending with the grace of union, is simply pedagogical: de la Taille is going from what is simplest to understand to that which is most difficult. This may be the case, even though the hypostatic union, as we discussed above, is *the* analogum and the font for all created grace. However, in both articles on grace, de la Taille himself intimates why his explication begins with the light of glory: his insight into created actuation comes most directly from Thomas's discussion of the light of glory in *Contra Gentiles* III, c. 53.[15] Clearly de la Taille understands his theory as a coherent and faithful reading of Thomas's heuristic portrayal of the *lumen*

13. Cf. de Letter, "Created Actuation by Uncreated Act," 64.
14. De la Taille, "Actuation créée," 254.
15. De la Taille, "Created Actuation," 30–31; de la Taille, "Dialogue," 48–49.

gloriae. We thus shall begin where de la Taille does, with an exposition of his interpretation on the light of glory.

Lumen Gloriae

In *Contra Gentiles* III, c. 53, quoted at length in de la Taille's article "Created Actuation," Thomas details what is necessary for the possibility of beatific vision: the divine essence, by way of its own intelligible, uncreated species, must be immediately joined to the created intellect, enabling it to see what otherwise is beyond its capacity—namely, the divine substance. Now, for the divine to be united in this way to the creature requires a change in the created intellect, a change that Thomas understands as the "acquisition of a new disposition."[16] From Thomas's account of the *lumen gloriae,* de la Taille seizes upon these two details—*union* and *disposition*—arguing that the disposition is both the "only new reality" formally to obtain from this actuation "by the uncreated species" and also the reality of the union "in all its newness." To clarify, this disposition does not *precede* the actuation of the intelligence by the divine species. Rather, the union of the divine to the created intellect *is* the immediate disposition, the radical adaptation of the soul to the Uncreated. We could say then that the *lumen gloriae* is the created actuation; it is the immediate disposition for union; it is the communication of the Act to the potency—and its *reception*. It would be equally true to say that the light of glory is the perfection of the receptive potency to seeing the divine substance.[17] De la Taille is confident that Thomas's treatment of the light of glory "confirms" the general theory of created actuation by an uncreated Act.

In keeping with the concerns of his own theory, de la Taille highlights that the light of glory is not an *in-formation* of the intellect by God. This created gift of union determines that the *visio Dei* be an operation "exclusively" of the "potency joined to the actuation"—that is to say, the uncreated Act is not limited by the receiving potency of the human intellect. The *lumen gloriae* is pure gift, pure grace, and intimate union to the divine. It is not, however, purely uncreated Act. It

16. "Created Actuation," 31.
17. "Created Actuation," 30–32.

is a created actuation that depends upon the potency of the subjective intellect "as on its material cause," for the actuation creates a proportion between the potency and what is "all-divine," the Act. Hence it is not difficult to understand why the created actuation can be called a "habitual power" of the subject, a "*dispositio imperfecti ad perfectum*."[18]

The Grace of Union

Since I want to discuss sanctifying grace in the third position, we shall consider next how created actuation applies to the union of the Word to human nature. This application of de la Taille's theory proves most controversial, which is the reason he wrote his second article ("Dialogue on the Grace of Union"). As we outlined above in chapter 5, *Mysterium Fidei* provides its own metaphysics of the incarnation; while there is no significant shift in his thought, the journal articles do offer a much richer depiction of the grace of union. In this later writing, de la Taille is less interested in confirming Christ's possession of habitual grace, a question relegated to a page or so at the end of his "Dialogue," where he rather amusingly quotes himself from *Mysterium Fidei*.[19] Instead, he is eager here to demonstrate that his theory of grace as created actuation holds true for the grace of union.

De la Taille's presentation of the hypostatic union as an instance of created actuation is marvelously straightforward in his initial essay; I shall appeal to his more convoluted "Dialogue" only where necessary for elaboration. We have established already that the actuation of the intellect for the beatific vision is a habitual actuation or disposition, an "accidental" quality adapting that soul to the vision of God as he is. The essential difference in applying created actuation to the incarnation lies in the contrast between an *accidental* and a *substantial* actuation. This substantial actuation is uniquely the grace of union, whereby the un-

18. "Created Actuation," 32.

19. From the lips of Palamedes (de la Taille in this dialogue), we have these words: "Dear friend, I told you I was keeping that [habitual grace in Christ] for the last. I shall not say much about it, for I can rest content with quoting what I have found on the subject in an author whom I shall refrain from recommending, as he is a contemporary. But on this point at any rate, he seems to echo the ancients, and that is why I take the liberty of making my own what he writes on page 516 of a work devoted rather to the mystery of the altars than to the economy of the incarnation"; "Dialogue," 75–76.

created Act, the Word, uniting itself to the human nature, actuates the very potency of the human soul to existence. That human potency to existence is thereby substantially united to the *esse* of the Act: it exists by the *Esse* of the Word.[20] Again—and even here in this case of the hypostatic union—de la Taille qualifies that this actuation by the Word "does not inform," but rather perfects, absolutely, the obediential potency of the human nature.[21] Is this then an immediate communication of the Word to the human nature? Indeed: in the grace of union, the created actuation is a substantial adaptation (in the order of being) of the nature to the divine *Esse*. As we heard also in *Mysterium Fidei,* de la Taille repeats here that the entire Trinity efficiently causes the grace of union, whereas the Word alone is the *term* of the union.

Perhaps this is an apt juncture to reiterate this critical feature of de la Taille's theory of created actuation. He is attempting to find a way of speaking of God's self-donation to a creature in a manner that is not *only* of the order of efficiency, though de la Taille knows and insists that the very foundation of the transcendence "proper to the supernatural depends upon efficient causality."[22] The causal "mechanics" of created grace appear to interest him less than does the relationship of union that obtains when the uncreated Act gives itself to created being.

> Undoubtedly every created gift is an effect produced by God: the hypostatic union as well as the light of glory or sanctifying grace. But what makes a thing supernatural is not, in the last analysis, a causal relationship but is, either proximately or remotely, *a relationship of union* between a created passive potency, whether nature or faculty, and an uncreated Act.[23]

It is, therefore, the new reality of *relation* and *union* that proves fundamental to the theory of created actuation, a reality brought into being by the self-gift of the Divine.[24] Not surprisingly, it is the question of

20. "Created Actuation," 35–37.

21. Unlike the actuation that occurs in the beatific vision, there is no material causality on the part of the human nature; see "Created Actuation," 35.

22. "Created Actuation," 36.

23. "Created Actuation," 35–36 (emphasis mine).

24. I gather that this emphasis is what P. de Letter intends when he notes de la Taille's "inversion" of perspective on grace: namely, that the whole question of created grace is seen from the "angle" (the activity and initiative) of uncreated grace; see de Letter, "Created Actuation by Uncreated Act," 61 and 84.

relation that demanded significant clarification and that de la Taille addresses at some length in his second article on the hypostatic union. We shall make a final observation from "Created Actuation" before turning to his more extensive remarks on relation and the grace of union in "Dialogue." When God makes himself the act of a created potency, this supernatural event and union require a "divinely infused adaptation or disposition" (be it substantial or habitual) in what is created. This "ultimate disposition" for the Act, which is itself introduced by that Act, is "found to be *indissolubly joined* to the Act *within* the potency which it actuates."[25] I underline this point because of what it alerts us to—namely, to the fact that de la Taille firmly aligns disposition (or grace) with the reality of union. Again, this honing-in on relation and union is not accidental, but rather a consequence of de la Taille's earlier research and writing on the sacrifice and sacrament of the Eucharist.

In "Dialogue on the Grace of Union," de la Taille defends his theory of created actuation in its application to the hypostatic union, and particularly in reference to questions about relation and union. I shall focus briefly on these points of contention, for they prove illuminating about sanctifying grace, as well. De la Taille argues with his interlocutor about the created grace of union between the human nature and the Word. Drawing upon Thomas and two Thomists of the "first rank"—Cajetan and Billuart—de la Taille counters his opponent's objection that the grace of union adds something "mediate" between the conjoining of the Word and the human flesh. De la Taille asserts, with Thomas, that this grace of union is not a "medium," any more than the light of glory is medium between the intellect and the uncreated.[26] On the contrary, this grace is taken to be the *union itself*. There is no prior modification of one of the two extremes before the union, no in-between state, as it were, that readies the human nature for union with the divine. The created grace of union is the modification: it is the union.

De la Taille approaches this from a second perspective, addressing the question of relation. His interlocutor proposes that Thomas allows for something created in the hypostatic union, but that this something

25. De la Taille, "Created Actuation," 37 (emphasis mine).
26. "Dialogue," 48–49; cf. *Contra Gentiles* III, c. 53 and *In III Sent*. d. 2, q. 2, a. 2, questiunc. 3.

is only a relation, a relation that is, of course, real only from the side of the humanity, and founded upon the "two natures as united." In other words, the interlocutor finds that Thomas allows only for a *created relation,* a relation that is not a constitutive element of the union, but subsequent to that union.[27] De la Taille disagrees. He responds that Thomas's true teaching on relation is otherwise. The relation of the incarnation demands a foundation, a foundation that is not eternal—as the Word existed eternally without this relation—but rather temporal, one that is "distinct from the humanity," but that can "sustain the relation." The distinctive value of created actuation here emerges. De la Taille shows that the divine unifying action, "formally immanent" but "virtually transitive," requires a foundation in time.[28] This foundation is the passive receptivity of the subject, "corresponding to the unifying action of the agent":

> This passion, correlative to the unifying action of the Trinity, is the passive union: exactly what I myself say is the foundation of the relation.[29]

Later in the article, directly appealing to Thomas and Billuart, de la Taille delineates that the foundation of the relation is a *mutatio* and a *tractio.*[30] His argument proceeds in this (Thomistic) manner. Every union implies a relation, and every relation that has a beginning in time is the consequence of some change. Change involves both action and passion. In the incarnation, the action—the assumption of the human nature—belongs to the Word; the passion, or change, belongs entirely to the human nature and is the foundation for the relation. More, Thomas also calls this passion, or change, a *tractio*—a "drawing" of the human nature into the divine nature and being of the Word. *This passive traction is the unifying action of the Godhead, it is the created grace of union, and it is the foundation for the new, supernatural relation between the created and Uncreated.* Thus we have a created actuation by uncreated Act.

27. "Dialogue," 49–50, 54–55.

28. What de la Taille is suggesting by these phrases might be put this way: the transcendent and uncreated Act will not overtake and usurp the proper *esse* and activity of the created soul. Its actuating power will be transitive, in the sense that it will produce a divinizing change in the created, receptive potency.

29. "Dialogue," 50–51.

30. "Dialogue," 59–60.

We can summarize de la Taille's exposition on the grace of union as created actuation by accenting three realities. First, the unifying actuation of the Divine produces a created change, an actuation that modifies—or better—perfects that to which it unites itself. The grace of union is thus the last disposition to union with the Word, as well as the foundation and gift of that union. Secondly, the hypostatic union teaches us that actuation by uncreated Act pulls or draws the potency into the life of the divine, and that this traction occurs in the union itself. Thirdly, in the incarnation there is an absolutely perfecting change, a complete traction of the potency in the human nature, such that we recognize this actuation as a *substantial* union to the divine. Indeed, de la Taille has put a good deal of "flesh" upon his intimations about actuation in *Liber* III. The question of relation and union has been thoroughly propounded.

Sanctifying Grace

We now turn to de la Taille's application of created actuation to sanctifying grace. Based on the analogy to the grace of union and the *lumen gloriae,* similar features ought to emerge in his treatment of habitual grace. Is sanctifying grace a created actuation co-terminous with the union and with the real relation (on the part of the potency) arising from the self-donation of the uncreated Act? Is this grace a change and "traction" of the human soul? If in the hypostatic union the created *esse* is united immediately and substantially to the eternal *Esse* of the Word, and, if in the light of glory, the created intellective faculty is united immediately (though accidentally) to subsistent Truth, how does de la Taille cast the union of sanctifying grace through this lens of created actuation? In this section, we shall address these questions and also attend to how de la Taille's theory of grace corresponds with deiformity. For it seems that created actuation gives an account of divinization, an issue central to sanctifying grace in *Liber* III of *Mysterium Fidei.* I invite the reader to keep in mind the previous discussion of eucharistic grace, for de la Taille here adds to his intuitions about sanctifying grace as garnered from reflection on eucharistic union to Christ—though the addition is, to be sure, in another key. Even so, we

note a similar emphasis upon participation in the one divine and divinizing life, and we are reminded as well about the significance of desire and the will.

De la Taille's depiction of sanctifying grace as a created actuation provides a fresh perspective on the (seemingly static) Scholastic notion of habitual grace as a "quality" in the soul.[31] Without departing from the Thomistic suggestion that grace is "something" in the soul, created actuation invigorates that concept with a radical dynamism. Sanctifying grace, de la Taille explains, is an actuation of the soul by the very life of the divine. This soul, moreover, already exists in potency toward union with that divine life:

> There occurs in the just, even during their present life, an actuation of their souls, as substances that at first exist and live by virtue of their rational life, but that are in potency to an accession (*surcroît*) of divine life through an uncreated Vital Principle (*un Principe Vital incréé*). In communicating itself to them (but without informing them), this Vital Principle equips them radically for the functions of their new life, of which the beatific vision is the full flowering.[32]

This Vital Principle, which recalls the eucharistic life flowing between Head and members, between the vine and the branches, actuates the very essence of the soul *by its presence*. Still, that actuation is by way of a created gift, which constitutes the union of the divine essence with the essence of the human soul. A union of "essence with essence"? Indeed, this is what de la Taille insists upon; this, in fact, is how he interprets the much contested New Testament verse from 2 Peter 1:4, with its suggestion of deified creaturehood: the soul is a "recipient of the divine nature (*divinae consortes* [κοινωνοι] *naturae*)."[33] In the essence of the soul, "underneath the faculties, intellect and will," the uncreated Act of divine life comes "to actuate the receptive capacity of the soul,

31. I say "seemingly static" because we are often too quick to judge Scholastic notions as static, especially in comparison to the more dynamically conceived theological concepts that emerge from the Eastern tradition. Following de la Taille's lead, I have attempted in this study to challenge this perceived theological bifurcation. De la Taille avoids using the language of "quality" in reference to the light of glory and to sanctifying grace; still, he employs the term at one point in his presentation, as if to allay any fear that "quality" is inherently opposed to created actuation; see "Created Actuation," 34; cf. *ST*, Ia-IIae, q. 110, a. 2 for Thomas's discussion about grace as a quality within the soul.

32. "Created Actuation," 32; "*Actuation Créée*," 257–58.

33. Cf. Kerr, *After Aquinas*, 153–55; "Created Actuation," 33.

in order that the corresponding actuation may arise" therein. This corresponding actuation *is* sanctifying grace. Henceforth the soul is "wedded to the divine essence and associated with the divine life."[34]

De la Taille does not leave us with the impression that once this "marriage" is effected, sanctifying grace is on its own, so to speak. Instead, emphasis is placed squarely upon the union and the vital participation in divine life. The actuation that constitutes this grace, and the grace itself, depend upon the indwelling of the uncreated Gift. Without that presence, habitual grace "would lapse into nothingness (*elle s'évanouit*)."[35]

This truth is approached from another angle when de la Taille addresses the lifelong journey of the graced soul toward the beatific vision, a journey that is undertaken in love and desire, and a journey that is possible *only* through an already-existing union with God. In other words, de la Taille articulates the theological point (which we often associate with Denys) that our desire for God is measured by God's own desire for his creatures.[36] Charity alone holds "the office of seeking and causing us to seek God," of desiring him above all things and as he is in himself. Ideally, this love so longs for God that one's happiness is situated "in the happiness of the Creator," "*just as* God himself first of all (*tout le premier*) freely offers his changeless beatitude to beatify his loved ones."[37] Such a relationship obtains only between friends, and friendship requires a *community of life*—for how can another's happiness be mine without this deep sharing of life? De la Taille clarifies that God does not depend upon this fundamental union for the bestowal of his beatitude upon others: God's love suffices to share his divine life with a creature. However, on the part of the creature, friendship with the divine requires—"as a preliminary condition"—a "radical union between the soul and God." Such is the union of sanctifying grace, effected by God's intentional actuation. "Underlying (*sous-jacente*)" the believer's love for God, this union enflames desire for the divine; it

34. "Created Actuation," 33.

35. "Created Actuation," 33; "*Actuation créée,*" 259.

36. Cf. Pseudo-Dionysius, *Divine Names,* 4, 12–14, in *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works,* translated by Colm Lubheid (New York: Paulist Press, 1987), 81–83.

37. "Created Actuation," 33 (emphasis mine).

thereby moves the will to "reach with an ardor that *takes its measure from* [God]."[38] This "measure," we should underscore, is not external to the human soul, nor is it a matter of divine initiative alone. Rather, it is a consequence of the possession of the Act. De la Taille proposes that even "while being an actuation of the potency by the Act," the soul "possesses" God in sanctifying grace, just as the intellect possesses God in the light of glory.[39] Concomitant then to the created actuation that is sanctifying grace, the desire of God becomes an internal rule, as it were, of the creature's desire and *caritas*. Possessing God in sanctifying grace, the soul (its life, will, and intellect) is likewise possessed by God. The exchange that de la Taille treated in speaking of eucharistic union is here an exchange of love understood in terms of the union between act and potency.

We can understand more sharply how this is the case by analyzing de la Taille's proposal about deiformity and the supernatural. Led again by Thomas,[40] he asserts that "nothing more resembles the uncreated Act than its created communication." Naturally, this resemblance is supreme and most sublime in the created grace of union, where there is a "true and substantial communication of natural sonship": Christ is Son by "eternal generation that is accomplished in the bosom of the Godhead."[41] But de la Taille assigns a divinizing transformation to sanctify-

38. "Created Actuation," 33 (emphasis mine).

39. De la Taille adds a note citing Thomas in *I Sent.*, d. 14, q. 2., a. 2 ad 2: "In the [temporal] procession of the Holy Spirit [to creatures] … regarded as containing the donation of the Holy Spirit, a new relation of the creature to God, of whatever nature it may be, is not enough; the creature must be referred to God as that which is possessed"; "Created Actuation," 34. If we look to his second essay, "Dialogue on the Grace of Union," de la Taille seems to go beyond this, saying that even as an actuation, it is a possession: or, *because* it is an actuation it is a possession of the act. I quote the passage in full, as it illuminates de la Taille's mind: "An efficient cause produces; an act gives itself, communicates itself to a potency which receives the act and thereupon finds itself united to the act. Accordingly, the actuation of the potency by the act is related to the act, not as to an efficient cause, but as to the term of a union: of a union that enriches, ennobles, perfects, but has nothing in common with an autonomous or intermediary form, a 'mode of union.' For it is nothing else than the possession of the Act by the potency and, in the case before us [hypostatic union], the substantial anointing of the humanity by the Chrism of the divinity"; 65.

40. De la Taille refers us to *Contra Gentiles* III, c. 53, and to *ST* I, q. 12, a. 5 and ad 3. Both passages suggest that the *lumen gloriae* makes the creature *deiform:* through this created communication the intellect has some share in the divine likeness.

41. "Created Actuation," 40–41. Traces of de la Taille's attraction to Cyril of Alexandria are evident here, as well.

ing grace, as well. The souls of the just are deiform even now, due to the created actuation by which God communicates and unites himself to the soul.

> Grace is the seed of God (*semence de Dieu*) in our souls, so closely bound up with the light of eternal life that by itself it excludes all darkness of sin (1 John 3:9). It is light, though dim as yet, because it is the illumination of the essence of our souls by God all holy, who is uncreated Light, *lumen vitae* (John 8:12).[42]

The seed of God, which can only resemble God, actuates the soul of a redeemed creature, making her like to God. Interestingly, the image engaged for this created likeness is that of light, a prevalent metaphor in the tradition of contemplation and mystical union, and one that we shall explore in the next chapter, where the light of the all-Holy is shown to be painfully purgative in the prayer and oblation of the baptized. For now, we merely remark that this deifying actuation of grace, which unites the soul to the Act, involves a change and traction, as well as an assimilation to the divine Act.[43] In the context of *Mysterium Fidei,* the central image for the change and traction of divinization is that of a participation in the eternal life of God through the intimate exchange of eucharistic feast, that divine Gift made possible by the Son's loving will to take up and offer the flesh of humanity.

Whether sanctifying grace be thought of in terms of divinizing life or light, de la Taille focuses on the *actuation*—a result of God's self-donation. This self-donation and union, along with the traction, change, and movement of the soul in sanctifying grace, are, without question, a supernatural event. God wills to become the act of a receptive, created potency: this can be construed only as "an occurrence surpassing all connaturality."[44] Therefore, as we noted above in discussing the hypostatic union, the potency will be obediential (not natural) in reference to the Act, and some "divinely infused" adaptation or dispo-

42. "Created Actaution, 40; "*Actuation créée*," 267.

43. Prudence de Letter pointedly dismisses any surprise concerning this transformation into divine likeness: "It [the created communication of grace] is a supernatural likeness to God; it assimilates the creature to God and makes it deiform. This is not surprising, since the created actuation, of its essence, is nothing else than the last disposition or adaptation to the uncreated Act—or, seen in another perspective, it is His effect that of necessity bears a similarity with Him"; de Letter, "Created Actuation by Uncreated Act," 66.

44. De la Taille, "Created Actuation," 37.

sition will be necessary for the union. Created actuation, sanctifying grace, "ultimate disposition" for the Act: these are all synonymous for de la Taille, and, significantly, they all transcend the connatural. De la Taille instructs that sanctifying grace (as much as the light of glory) be thought of as supernatural, not because it is caused by God, but because it is the foundation of a real union with the Act.

As intimated above, sanctifying grace is the "substratum" of the creature's love and desire for God, and as such makes the will's movement toward the divine Act also supernatural.[45] Since the principle of sanctifying grace is God, "essentially possessed within the very heart of our essence," every disposition toward this grace and possession—"whether proximate or remote, whether habitual or actual"—will also belong to the order of the supernatural, and will also be an assimilation to, or imitation of, God's *caritas*. This is hardly a negligible assertion. De la Taille is saying something utterly consonant with what he argues about the dependence of the other sacraments on the Eucharist in *Mysterium Fidei,* but also something both more direct and inclusive. What invests the other sacraments (and he here leads us to assume that prayer and other spiritual disciplines are included, too) with *virtus,* with the transformative power of eucharistic grace, is the "relationship of union" tied up with sanctifying grace. The other sacraments, he demonstrated, "borrow" power from the grace of union to Christ, the reconciling Victim of the Eucharist. Here he proposes something similar: any movement toward the Act that is undergirded by sanctifying grace—the substratum of divine-like charity in the soul—will also be supernatural—for every such movement of desire must be "on the same plane as its term," and, as de la Taille has established, the *term* of created actuation is the very life of the Trinity. Put differently, and more boldly, within the grace of the Eucharist every movement or disposition in love toward God is supernatural (though building upon a potency), because in each of these there is an "implied" relationship of union to the Godhead.[46]

45. "Created Actuation," 37.

46. "Created actuation," 37. De la Taille specifies that this relationship is *implied*—"either formally or at least by way of reduction."

To conclude this exposition of de la Taille's "created actuation by uncreated Act," I shall highlight those aspects of his theory that seem to emerge organically from his earlier mini-treatise *de gratia* in *Mysterium Fidei.* First of all, we have shown that "created actuation by uncreated Act" provides a manner of understanding the self-donation of God without erasing the distinction between Creator and creature, and, critically, without allowing any possibility of conceiving this gift as radically extrinsic to the creature. Actuation touches and perfects the potency; it results in the potency's union to the act. De la Taille is particularly attracted to the relation and intimate union that created actuation implies, an attraction consonant with his work on eucharistic union. Actuation is principally concerned with the kind of deifying union initiated by divine indwelling. The created actuation, the sanctifying grace, would dissolve without that union and presence.

Secondly, we acknowledged de la Taille's clever analogical application of his theory to the light of glory, to sanctifying grace, and to the grace of union. His application manifests that the actuation in each of these instances is created but nonetheless *supernatural,* and thereby dependent upon the "ultimate" adaptation and deifying assimilation effected by the presence of the Act. In regard to sanctifying grace, we have seen that this created actuation is a union of the soul's essence to the divine essence, a union that can only obtain through a substantial transformation in the soul's capacity for God—just as de la Taille described of sanctifying grace in his eucharistic treatise. More, we have underscored how the union of sanctifying grace becomes the substratum for every movement of desire in the just toward God, a desire measured, as it were, by the presence and possession of God in the depth of the soul. Neatly, his thought here dovetails with his theology of Christ's redeeming grace in the Eucharist.

De la Taille's contribution to twentieth-century Catholic thought on grace and divine indwelling stands on its own, amply indicated by the number of scholarly articles responding to "created actuation." What I have hoped to bring to the fore in this presentation are some of the resonating links between the features of "created actuation"—relation, union, and divinization—and de la Taille's earlier articulation of

sanctifying grace in terms of eucharistic union. We might wonder why de la Taille did not "complete" his picture of grace in these later articles with some explicit discussion of eucharistic union. One could simply respond by saying that he was writing *to accommodate* the expectations of those who would be reading these journal articles. As I pointed out earlier, none of the respondents to de la Taille's theory either engaged his earlier work or made their own connections to the indwelling promised by eucharistic grace. I would submit that, were de la Taille's purported work *De gratia* to be found—even in an outline form—we would no doubt see the more synthetic propensity of his thought. What cannot be overlooked is de la Taille's unique and heuristic place in the development of thought on the supernatural in the first half of the twentieth century. Using the Thomistic tradition at hand (but distancing himself from the two-tiered nature/grace thought of Suarez) and employing the context of eucharistic grace, de la Taille articulated an appealing, intrinsicist approach to the supernatural, one with which De Lubac could sympathize, and one that likely provided momentum to Rahner's work on grace.[47]

Finally, *pace* Lonerganeans like Matthew Lamb, who fault de la Taille for choosing the "wrong" analogical image, i.e., for beginning with act and potency ("composite being") instead of with what the human intellect can know of God,[48] de la Taille's selection of an analogy is spot-on, at least if we consider the context of his eucharistic theology. For, as we have shown, created actuation harmonizes well with, and fills out, his delineation of sanctifying grace and the grace of union in *Mysterium Fidei*. More, his Eastern theological predilection demands an analogy that is principally *dynamic*, an analogy that places indwelling first, and an analogy at home, so to speak, with deification and the

47. While it is clear that de Lubac was familiar with *Mysterium Fidei*, I have found no evidence that he engaged de la Taille's later and more technical journal articles on the topic of created actuation. For a reference to Rahner's recognition of de la Taille's thought on grace, see note 7 above.

48. The reader may judge whether or not Matthew Lamb is successful in proving the superiority of the latter analogy; cf. Lamb, "An Analogy for the Divine Self-Gift," 124–27, *passim*. (A fuller response to the Lonerganean critique of de la Taille will have to await another opportunity.)

paradox of mutual priority and causality. "Created actuation by uncreated Act" meets all of these demands.

Reprise

The threads of these three chapters (part 2) on grace are many. Let me gather them by reminding the reader of the lodestone to which they all return: the grace of the Redeemer, a grace found in partaking of the sacrificial banquet. In focusing on the Eucharist as sacrament, *Liber* III has given us a further perspective on the theory of eucharistic sacrifice detailed in the three opening chapters of this study. The *res tantum* of the sacrament, sanctifying grace—healing, elevating, strengthening, enflaming, and fixing desire—is the gift won by the victim who offered himself in sacrifice at the supper and shed his blood on the cross. The fruits of the sacrifice are all from and through the victim, most especially the fruit of union with the divine life in the eucharistic banquet.

De la Taille has shown that partaking of the Eucharist, efficacious only for those who willingly *offer* sacrifice, is a *commercium carnis* with the sanctified Christ. In the Eucharist, Christ takes to himself the wounded flesh and desire of believers; he disseminates his holiness and pours out divine grace, a grace superlatively his. Christ is the "head" and fountain of grace; through the Eucharist he initiates the believer not only into union with himself, a sharing both of his human and divine nature (by participation), but also into union with the whole Trinity. De la Taille's theory of created actuation eloquently displays that the Act unites itself to the human being, adapting the essence of the soul for intimate union with the divine. Both in his metaphysically articulated articles and in his citing of Eastern patristic sources, de la Taille exhibits a dynamic vision of the relation of sanctifying grace, such that the life flowing from the body of Christ becomes a vital necessity to the Christian.

De la Taille has insisted that the union to Christ and the members of his Body, a consequence of eucharistic grace, creates a new substratum of love and desire that becomes the measure and the *energia* for every act of virtue, every ascetic practice. In addition, we have witnessed

in this discourse on grace the emergence of a more replete theology of desire: the Eucharist is essential to the very life of desire and crucial to the formation of a single-hearted *caritas*. In the following chapters on contemplation, "mystical" theology, and baptismal transformation, several of these threads will again be picked up—particularly those of divine indwelling, union, and desire. We shall begin to explicate a twofold, salient convergence in de la Taille's eucharistic theology: the intersection of sacrifice with the life of prayer, and a merging of the grace that pours forth from the Eucharist with the gifts that accompany contemplation.

The Nature of Contemplation 7

The preceding three chapters on grace have acted as a kind of yeast upon the detailed exposition of sacrifice that began this study, for I have intended to make manifest how the dynamic of eucharistic sacrifice is subsumed in the life of grace. De la Taille's thought on grace also reveals why oblation and the movement of desire are central to his theory of sacrifice-as-gift. Our chapters on grace have shown that all grace flows from the immolated and vivifying flesh of the Son; that God's self-gift to the soul—which is a real union—constitutes de la Taille's first principle of supernatural life; and that this deifying union is the grace of sacramental reception of the eucharistic banquet. The grace and life, poured out by Christ upon the one who eats and drinks of his flesh and blood, is received according to the measure of oblative desire, a desire that itself responds to God's own ecstatic *caritas* in the Eucharist.

Hence we have seen that sacrifice necessarily engages the will and that eucharistic grace not only aligns with the recipient's desire, but "raises" it—enflames it further, orienting and strengthening it through union to Christ and his ecclesial body. The present chapter frames this interlacing of sacrifice and grace in terms of a broader picture of the spiritual life and, particularly, within the perspective of contemplative prayer. In short, I shall argue that the context of contemplative prayer is fundamental to de la Taille's theory of eucharistic sacrifice. Contemplation does not simply add another layer to the mix, but rather provides a view, *sub specie aeternitatis,* as it were, of the theology of sacrifice and union with which we have been engaged.

De la Taille's three-volume *Mysterium Fidei* contains no distinct Elucidation on the topic of contemplation and its relationship to eucharistic sacrifice. However, it is evident—and not just in his prefatory remarks—that prayer and the spiritual life motivate his extended reflection on the Eucharist.[1] In the course of this chapter I shall draw attention to some of the key passages in *Mysterium Fidei* that do directly address prayer; they are rich and suggestive. But we shall be concerned primarily with de la Taille's two short works devoted to contemplation. The first is a densely compact essay written for *Recherches de science religieuse* in 1919, entitled simply, "L'oraison contemplative." In his own words, the article is written to "indicate briefly" how "traditional theology" speaks to "certain questions touching passive contemplation." De la Taille desires to avoid "awakening echoes" of theological controversy over matters of contemplative principles and experience, controversies that have spanned some "three centuries." With very few footnotes and a striking paucity of direct references to texts or specific mystical accounts, de la Taille provides a calm and lucid description of contemplation (its method, its trials, its place in the spiritual life, the role of a director) from a *theological* perspective.[2]

The value of this piece was recognized quickly: in 1921 it was published in booklet form in France, and then in 1926 it was translated into English and published as *Contemplative Prayer.*[3] We should not fail to note the early date of this journal essay. Contrary to one of his biographers, de la Taille's interest in prayer was not simply a topic for the "last years of his life."[4] Rather, his theological interest in contemplation was *coincident* with *Mysterium Fidei*. "L'oraison contemplative" was his

1. De la Taille defines that theology ought to be engaged with those matters of most significance to "our spiritual progress," and should be a "science" of revealed truth aimed at "fostering piety"; *MF* 1: Preface, viii–ix.

2. In the course of his essay, de la Taille points briefly to four Thomistic texts. The only other theological figure mentioned is Catherine of Genoa: in a footnote, de la Taille suggests that readers consult her *Dialogues* for an example of God's purgative action upon the soul in contemplation. We shall return to this predilection for Catherine's works later in the chapter.

3. De la Taille, "L'oraison contemplative," *Récherches de science religieuse* 10 (1919): 273–92; and de la Taille, *Contemplative Prayer*, trans. Carmelite Tertiary (London: Burns, Oates, and Washbourne, 1929). Hereafter I refer to this work as *CP*, and will use the English translation, except where otherwise noted.

4. Leeming, "A Master Theologian," 39–40.

first postbellum writing, and I wonder, in fact, if this essay were not composed as a tribute to his beloved former teacher, René de Maumigny, S.J., who died in 1918. A well-respected spiritual master, Maumigny directed de la Taille's tertianship year at Mold in 1904 and had a shaping and lasting influence upon the young Jesuit.[5] Maumigny's much-reprinted two-volume treatise on prayer, *La pratique de l'oraison mentale* (1905), was often brought into conversation with Poulain's widely read *The Graces of Interior Prayer.* For our purposes here, it will be of profit to note that in this comparison to Poulain, Maumigny's thought on prayer is characterized by a practical and ascetical orientation, as well as by a strong emphasis upon the role of love in contemplation.[6]

De la Taille's second and more substantial work on contemplation and mystical theology appears in a 1928 lengthy review of Dom Cuthbert Butler's *Western Mysticism*.[7] In the second edition (1927) of this spiritual classic, Butler appends some seventy-five pages of "Afterthoughts," an addition that de la Taille describes as a "critical study" of the contemporary literature on mysticism. For the most part, de la Taille's review is an extensive gloss upon the central issues raised by Butler's supplemental reflections. The essay thus proves an invaluable resource for assessing how de la Taille negotiates some of the knotty, controversial questions facing theologians interested in prayer and mystical experience. Unlike his earlier piece on contemplation, this essay is well documented with

5. Lebreton, "In Memoriam," 7. According to Lebreton, the influence of Maumigny's spiritual teaching was not only incredibly "dear" to de la Taille, but also particularly "fecund."

6. Bainvel, in his introduction to the 10th edition of Poulain's *Graces of Interior Prayer* (St. Louis: Herder, 1950), draws an extensive comparison between these two great "masters" of the spiritual life (see pages lxiii–lxvi). Significantly, he details both that Maumigny's work was originally elicited as a response to Poulain's first edition of *Des Grâces* in 1901, and that Maumigny amended and expanded the later editions of his work as he continued to learn from and respond to Poulain (lxvi). (Apparently, the two never met.) While de la Taille's style and thought are distinctive, it is nonetheless easy to see traces of Maumigny's thought upon his pupil. We shall have occasion later in the chapter to note a specific dependence, which de la Taille himself acknowledges, on the question of an intermediate state between common prayer and passive prayer.

7. De la Taille, "Théories mystiques: A propos d'un livre récent," *Récherches de science religieuse* 18 (1928): 297–325. Hereafter, I refer to this essay as "Théories." We should also note a third and rather surprising little piece that de la Taille wrote on the English mystic Teresa Helena Higginson (1844–1905): "Une mystique anglaise d'aujourd'hui: Thérèse Hélène Higginson," *Études* 193 (1927): 474–79. The essay seems to be prompted by a biography on Higginson: Lady Cecil Kerr, *Teresa Helena Higginson: Servant of God, "The Spouse of the Crucified"* (1927; repr. London: Gracewing, 2008).

footnotes and reveals his careful reading of contemporary figures (e.g., Garrigou-Lagrange, Gardeil, Poulain, and M. Saudreau). More importantly, it shows de la Taille consistently supporting his thought with two figures he considered "authorities" on the spiritual life: Thomas and John of the Cross. If Thomas and John are generative of his thought on contemplation, de la Taille nevertheless gives the reader a sharp taste of his own distinctive stance on the difficult issues raised by the work of his teachers. These two essays on contemplation together provide a vital (and overlooked) component to his theological vision of eucharistic sacrifice and grace.

This first chapter on contemplation addresses the fundamental aspects of de la Taille's understanding of the life of prayer and spirit progress. We shall be engaging features of his thought on contemplation—faith, love, and purgation—that clearly resonate with matters exposed in preceding chapters. A second chapter on contemplation will treat some of the more controversial and telling aspects of de la Taille's mind on contemplation: the question of a "transitory state" between meditative prayer and passive prayer; questions about mystical union and the sanjuanist terminology of "the substantial touch" of contemplation; and lastly, epistemological questions raised concerning passive prayer. His writing on these topics, topics perennial in academic discourse about contemplation, reveals not only the centrality of contemplation to his theology of the Eucharist, but also his concern for legitimizing contemplation in the theological enterprise as a whole. I shall conclude our discussion of contemplation by accenting how de la Taille leads us, again by a focus on Christ and sacrifice, to an integrated vision of Eucharist, grace, and passive prayer. The connection between contemplation and the Eucharist is more often than not taken for granted; rarely is it descriptively pushed. De la Taille shows us the way to think about and to articulate more explicitly this elusive relationship.

The Contemplative Journey—Faith, Love, Purgation

J. V. Bainvel, S.J., both admirer and critic of de la Taille's *Contemplative Prayer,* has called the work a "theologico-mystical" treatise, and in-

deed the terse essay focuses the reality of passive prayer with precise, if profound, theological observations. Bainvel, in fact, questions whether de la Taille's treatment is a bit too neat and tidy, set forth as truth without substantiating argument.[8] We shall have occasion in this section to "hear" how de la Taille defends himself (since Bainvel graciously published de la Taille's letters of response),[9] but let us first elucidate his specifically theological discussion of contemplation. How, for instance, does de la Taille define the "object" and "medium" of contemplation, and how does he construe the role of love and faith in such prayer? That he sees his writing in the trajectory of Thomas and John of the Cross will surface in a clear way here. After some basic definitions, I shall turn to his vision of contemplation in the whole economy of the spiritual life, engaging questions about the limits of human virtue, about grace and the supernatural, and about the purgative, sacrificial aspects of passive prayer. All too briefly, we shall see that de la Taille's thought on the work of purgative love in contemplation echoes the writings of both Catherine of Genoa and John of the Cross. *Contemplative Prayer* and the redressing letters to Bainvel are the key sources in this part of the chapter, with his essay "Théories mystiques" exercising an amplifying role.

Contemplation and Faith

At his most precise, de la Taille defines contemplation as "a loving fixing of the gaze on the Sovereign Good in the luminous and dark medium of faith."[10] We shall investigate, in the first place, that closing phrase concerning the "luminous and dark" medium of contemplation, words that bear the marked influence of John of the Cross. In what sounds like a characteristically Scholastic discussion, de la Taille begins his discourse on contemplation by asking about its *object* and its *medium,* an exercise engaged in order to disclose the central theological category for contemplation—namely, *faith.* He aims to establish the

8. Bainvel, "Introduction," lxxvi–lxxxiv.

9. Bainvel, "Introduction," xcviii–civ.

10. "Or, la contemplation, nous l'avons vu, n'est pas autre chose qu'un arrêt amoureux du regard sur le Souverain Bien dans le milieu lumineux et ténébreux de la foi"; de la Taille, "L'oraison contemplative," 280.

unique nature of contemplation, how it is different from ordinary abstractive intellectual activity and from angelic knowledge of God, and how it is distinct also from the *lumen gloriae,* from the beatific vision when there will be no intermediary between the mind and God.[11] Angelic knowledge of God occurs without abstraction, without deduction or inference; it is a single intellectual act, but one that nevertheless occurs *through* an "image or resemblance," rather like a "luminous medium" or a "refracting prism"—though not through a middle term.[12] Similarly, contemplation in the human soul is not a kind of abstractive knowing, nor is it a knowledge that supplies the contemplative with "distinct pieces" of information or representations of supernatural objects.[13] On the other hand, de la Taille also discounts the possibility that contemplation is like the light of glory, involving a new species "placed in the spirit miraculously by God." Put differently, contemplation does not follow the rule of human knowing—it is not abstractive; but then again, neither is it a supernatural "intrusion" upon the nature of the human intellect.

De la Taille reminds us that the object of contemplation is the Supreme Good, the infinite Love of future life, which reveals itself "splendidly" as "transcendent darkness," a kind of luminous darkness that

11. The light of glory raises the power of the human intellect that it might see God "face to face." In this graced light, God is known *not* by a mental species "borrowed" as it were from the senses; rather, the divine essence of God itself becomes the intelligible form of the human intellect by which God is seen as he is. The *lumen gloriae* disposes the created soul for this supernatural vision *and* is the light by which the divine essence is seen; *ST* I, q. 12, aa. 5–6.

12. *CP,* 2.

13. De la Taille does admit that a saint may, on rare occasions, receive some "particular" piece of supernatural knowledge—outside of the deposit of faith (e.g., knowledge of the state of a soul after death), but such "intellectual vision is not essential to contemplation"; *CP,* 3. I suspect that de la Taille has in mind John of the Cross's careful division of the kind of intellectual thoughts apprehended by the soul in contemplation; cf. John of the Cross, *Ascent to Mount Carmel* II, x. When John is parsing *spiritual* (as opposed to "corporeal") *supernatural knowledge,* he argues that one finds both "distinct and particular" and "dark and general" knowledge. Without the assistance of the bodily senses, "particular" knowledge can be communicated to the soul in "visions, revelations, locutions and spiritual feelings." This seems to be the "particular" knowledge that de la Taille allows a peripheral place in contemplation. We can note also that he is closely following John's definition of "dark and general knowledge": "The dark and general knowledge (*contemplation, which is imparted in faith)* is of one kind only. We have to lead the soul to this contemplation by guiding it through all these other apprehensions, and, beginning with the first, divesting it of them"; see John of the Cross, *Ascent* II, x, 4.

increases as the contemplation is higher and purer: "This is the contemplative way of knowing the Divine Goodness in all its excess."[14] But if this divine revealing does not depend on intellectual abstraction or representation, and if it is not an immediate communication, as it will be in the beatific vision, what is the medium of contemplation? The *medium* of this divine revelation is the light of faith: faith that "emerges and disengages" itself from a rational knowledge grounded in the senses—faith, that is, that enlightens the soul as an "obscure ray of the eternal brightness," which is its origin. Briefly, here faith is understood as that divine light, at once luminous and dark, in which the contemplative can "see" God ("*in lumine tuo videbimus lumen*").[15]

We thus can identify three features of de la Taille's predilection for defining contemplation in terms of faith. First, in contemplation, God is revealing himself in and through the light of faith, a light that has its source in the divine light. Secondly, this medium is not an abstractive knowing, but rather more analogous to angelic knowing, in which the intellect becomes a kind of mirror or refracting prism of God's own light. Yet, and thirdly, because the human intellect is less pure than the angelic, the medium of faith is *obscure*. This medium is a *fides qua* by which the soul clings in "unknowing" to God, a faith that is God's infused gift.

To be sure, contemplation as situated under the theological category of faith is well established in the work of John of the Cross. De la Taille's dependence on John's "dark faith" as a medium of contemplation can be vividly heard in the following passage from John's *Ascent of Mount Carmel:*

> For the likeness between faith and God is so close that no other difference exists than that between believing in God and seeing Him. Just as God is infinite, faith proposes Him to us as infinite … and as God is darkness to our intellect, so does faith dazzle and blind us. Only by means of faith, in divine light exceeding all understanding, does God manifest Himself to the soul.[16]

Though de la Taille stands on solid sanjuanist ground, he anticipates protest to his view on the medium of faith in a rare footnote in *Con-*

14. *CP,* 3–4.
15. *CP,* 4.
16. *Ascent* II, ix, 1; cf. also *Ascent* II, i and vi.

templative Prayer. The footnote outlines five reasons that contemplation aligns, or is *conveniens,* with the theological virtue of faith. The first reason accentuates that contemplation is *not* direct intuitive vision of God as he is. Appealing to scripture, de la Taille dismisses the possibility that contemplation entails a state between faith and the beatific vision: faith will pass away, and there will be the intuitive vision of God (2 Cor. 13:8–13; 1 John 2:37). Rather, contemplation is fully under the aegis of faith. Secondly, we know that the just live "on God by faith," and it is by contemplation that the worshipper "feeds upon" divine food. We will return to this eucharistic image for contemplation at the end of this chapter. Let it suffice for the present to note that, as in sacramental eating, so in contemplative eating: faith is essential. De la Taille's third reason for linking contemplation and faith leans upon the witness of mystics themselves, who use the "very expressive" phrase "*naked faith*" when describing contemplative light. Fourthly, de la Taille draws upon Thomas and the relationship between the gifts of the Holy Spirit and the theological virtues: the gifts flow from the theological virtues and are both regulated by, and in service to, the theological virtues.[17] De la Taille spells out this relationship more fully in the main text when he describes that faith in the just soul is "furnished" with an octave of seven notes/gifts, susceptible in contemplation to the pressure of the Spirit, the *digitus* of God. God reveals himself in an infinite number of ways, playing upon these notes made vulnerable and receptive in faith.[18]

For de la Taille, the fifth and theologically "decisive" reason for situating contemplation in faith is that the (Thomistic) definition of faith *applies* to contemplation. Faith is a "kind of religious knowledge" defined by its relation to the divine—an adherence to the First Truth, which is believed, believed upon its own testimony, and believed in light of the content that accompanies it (*qua creditur, cui creditur, in quam creditur*).[19]

17. Cf. *ST* Ia-IIae, q. 68, a. 4, ad 1; a. 8, c.

18. *CP,* 5–7; cf. *Ascent* II, xxix, 6, for a passage in which John of the Cross speaks of the Holy Spirit communicating to the intellect in the light of faith. Perhaps this is fitting place to acknowledge that de la Taille does not detail, as did John, a threefold purification of intellect, memory, and will. As we shall see, de la Taille articulates a purgation of the intellect and will in the contemplative journey; but he does not appear to have developed a theory on the transformation of the memory.

19. *CP,* 5; cf. *ST* Ia-IIae, q. 2, a. 2.

Because this "triple relationship" is found also in contemplation, contemplation justly belongs to the order of faith.

However, as we have noted above, contemplative faith does *appear* to be different than non-contemplative faith, for contemplative faith does not "borrow" its "materials" from "abstractive reasoning." Are we, therefore, actually speaking of an altogether different kind of faith? De la Taille insists that only a philosopher "who considers psychological facts from the point of view of their relation to consciousness" would announce a *difference in kind* between contemplative and non-contemplative faith. Instead, de la Taille encourages the reader to consider a scientific analogy: the difference is better understood in terms of an "allotropic" state of "the same chemical body."[20] This is a neat escape, if you will: contemplative and non-contemplative faith are elementally the same; only the form has been altered. The chemical analogy is apt, especially in light of the fact that *transformation* (without destruction) is the substantial aim of sacrifice, grace, and contemplation. Here we are speaking of a purification of faith (not a radical change to its nature), a faith loosened from its normal state of dependence upon the senses and becoming the medium by which God communicates his very self to the soul.[21]

But the Jesuit J. V. Bainvel pointedly critiques de la Taille on his theological categorizing of passive prayer, arguing that he too facilely "reduces" contemplation to an act of the theological virtue of faith. To address this issue is to segue into our next topic: the role of love in contemplation. In a letter of reply to Bainvel, de la Taille offers a twofold defense for understanding contemplation as an exercise of faith. Both responses underscore the reality and significance of desire for the divine object of faith. First, de la Taille reiterates how contemplation "matches" the definition of faith, adding here the element of love: contemplation is "an adhesion *to* the last end, *on the testimony* the last end gives to itself, and *by love for* the last end." He distinguishes, secondly, what is commonly considered an "act of faith" from what in fact he intends by the act of faith or *instinctus fidei*. Typically an act of faith is thought to be an

20. *CP,* 5–6.

21. Eight years after his first publication on contemplation, de la Taille would refine—without dramatically shifting—his position on the nature of contemplative faith and knowledge. We shall note ahead how this slight shift appears in "Théories mystiques."

act accompanied by discursive thought and dependent upon "historical motives" of credibility, whereas, for de la Taille, the contemplative act of faith is conditioned only "by the presence of faith." In other words, contemplation can "do without" the circumstances of common faith, because in contemplation the divine object "becomes present … in that divinely rooted love in which it reveals itself."[22] We can better understand de la Taille's mindset about the dynamic of faith, love, and passive prayer if we examine two particular components of his thought: (1) his portrayal of the "door of entry" to contemplation and (2) his distinctive interpretation of Thomas on the question of whether contemplation is essentially an intellective or volitional act.

Contemplation and Love

Calling forth the witness of Thomas, de la Taille argues convincingly that contemplation is "born under the empire of love," a love marked by the charity of friendship. In fact, love "*presides*" over contemplation.[23] Contemplation does not find entrance into the soul either by a specific intellectual effort at sublime thought or by the negative effort to eliminate thought and shut down the mind. Rather, its mode of entry is of "the affective order, *per viam voluntatis*."[24] In his commentary on Butler's *Western Mysticism,* de la Taille addresses this question at length, for he is unhappy with Butler's sharp division between those who follow Bonaventure, underscoring the will and the primacy of love in engendering contemplation, and the Thomists, who exalt the role of the intellect and depict contemplation as engendering love.[25] To the contrary, de la Taille contends that Thomas is quite close to Bonaventure on the question of contemplation and love; Thomas simply brings "his particular gifts of precision and analysis" to the

22. Bainvel, "Introduction," civ. Interestingly, de la Taille here recalls John of the Cross's "certainty" about founding contemplation in faith, and how John exalts this contemplation over such gifts ("*gratis datae*") as visions and revelations, which are "*exterior* to faith" (emphasis mine).

23. *CP,* 10; "Théories," 302.

24. *CP,* 8. De la Taille here cites Thomas, *In Lib. Boet. de Trin.,* lect. I, 9, I, a.1, ad 4.

25. "Théories," 301. Butler places John of the Cross in the Bonaventure camp, while Dominicans of every stripe, and even the Benedictine John Cuthbert Hedley, are aligned with Thomas.

topic.[26] Is de la Taille slanting the evidence here, giving volition a leading role in contemplation—in the same way that volition is central to his theory of grace and eucharistic sacrifice? Or rather, is he providing a legitimately nuanced interpretation of Thomas's thought on the relationship between the will and the intellect in contemplation? Let us review with some care the key passages that de la Taille brings forward from the Thomistic corpus.

Without question, Thomas defines contemplation as an essentially intellectual act: "Contemplation pertains to the simple intuition itself of truth" and, as an act, it terminates in love.[27] This definition granted, de la Taille asserts that Thomas does not thereby preclude love from *preceding,* as well as following, contemplation. Indeed, is it not the case for Thomas that love both "triggers" and "carries" the contemplative gaze?[28] De la Taille here cites Thomas at length:

> Although contemplative life does consist essentially in the intellect, it nevertheless has its *beginning* in love; for it is charity which *prompts one to contemplation* of God. And it is precisely because the beginning must correspond to the end that the final term of contemplative life is found in love, under the form of the joy that one takes in seeing *what one loves*.[29]

With Thomas, de la Taille acknowledges that love of God enflames the intellect with the desire to see God. If this is so, then we need to investigate how the will, how love, engages the intellect. Thomas distinguishes that the will acts upon the intellect in one of two ways: by exciting a love of the object, or by exciting a love of knowing itself. Yet in contemplation, the love that moves the intellect is decidedly *not* "a love of knowledge alone," but rather "the love of the object in view," namely, God.[30] Consider a mother who looks with joy at her son, a look not motivated by an aesthetic interest in the child's features, but a look motivated by love: "Elle le dévore; et voilà ce qui s'appelle aimer parce qu'on aime, et pas pour une autre raison.… St. Thomas est avec la

26. "Théories," 302–3.

27. *ST* Ia-IIae, q.180, a. 3, ad 1 and ad 3.

28. "Théories," 301.

29. *ST* IIa-IIae, q. 180, a. 7, ad 1. The emphasis is de la Taille's. Curiously, de la Taille does not complete the sentence from the *Summa,* which finishes: "and that very joy (*delectatio*) in seeing the beloved excites an even greater love."

30. "Théories," 302n6. De la Taille reminds us that Thomas is following Gregory the Great in asserting the centrality of the will in contemplation; cf. *ST* Ia-IIae, q. 180, a. 1, c.

mère."[31] For de la Taille, none of this imperils Thomas's foundational statement that the contemplative life, "in so far as its essential action, belongs to the intellect." Assuredly, the contemplative gaze is essentially a knowing (*connaissance*)—but it is a loving intellection.

De la Taille presses his interpretation of Thomas further. That love "presides" in contemplation ought not to surprise if one recalls that faith itself, though substantially in the intellect, is nonetheless there *as* a product of love.[32] Faith owes its beginning to a "pressure" upon the will, to an attraction for the good that "promises itself in eternal life." So actuated by this desire (*appetitus*), the intelligence attaches itself to "the Supreme Good by a voluntary and loving affirmation." The act of faith is "commanded by the will" (even if, in the beginning, this is a love of the concupiscent will). Because contemplation is carried out in the light of faith, this admission is exceedingly significant:

> Thus the light of faith, although residing in the spirit, did not enter man by way of the spirit, but by way of the heart: there is its door of entry; there is the passage through which God pours it more or less vividly, according to the degree to which love itself is living in us above every other affection or contrariwise is dominated or oppressed by self-love.[33]

As with the modality of faith, so with the act of contemplation: de la Taille seems to be saying that, although contemplation is essentially of the intellect, an act of the intellect, it nonetheless "enters" through the will, as does faith. Contemplation owes its existence to a "pressure" arising from the will. To sum up the question, de la Taille writes that all the great spiritual masters can remain faithful to Thomas while claiming that the "divine touch" of contemplative prayer is directly received by the will and then communicated to the intellect under the mode proper to the mind, namely knowledge. "Love prompts, carries, orients, and bathes the contemplative gaze."[34] I suggest that this high-

31. "Théories," 302–3.

32. *CP*, 9; "Théories," 303.

33. *CP,* 9–10; cf. Thomas, *De Verit.,* q. 14, a. 2 ad. 10.

34. "Théories," 303. "Rien d'étonnant dès lors que les plus grands maîtres de la théologie mystique puissent sans infidélité à saint Thomas dire que la touche divine dans l'oraison contemplative atteint directement la volonté. C'est la volonté qui reçoit le don d'abord, sous forme d'amour, et puis le communique à la intelligence selon le mode de l'intelligence, et par conséquent sous forme de connaissance. L'amour lance, porte, oriente et baigne le regard."

lighting of the will, of the role of love in contemplation, is entirely in keeping with what we have seen in his discussion of sacrifice and grace: sacrifice begins in and is measured by the love in the oblatory action of the will; sanctifying grace, for its part, operates in tandem with the receptive capacity of charity within the soul.

Contemplation and Purification

We have established thus far that contemplation is an exercise in and of the dark light of faith, and that the will is principal in this act of prayer. We now turn to de la Taille's vision of contemplation within the scope of the life of grace and spiritual progress. I want to address three queries here: (1) If faith and love exist in all the just, why are not all the baptized contemplatives? (2) Is contemplation in fact an extraordinary phenomenon in the life of grace? and (3) What are the particular trials and perils of the soul undergoing contemplative purgation? Each of these topics sharpens the angle on de la Taille's theology of passive prayer, with the third issue opening directly upon the connection between sacrifice and contemplation.

De la Taille does not shrink from our first, unavoidable question. He has argued that it is love that "actuates" faith, determining that charity exists in the souls of all the just. Yet it remains true that many faithful Christians are *not* contemplatives; they might enjoy meditative prayer and that "knowledge of faith" upon which falls, discursively, the light of reason—but not the light of faith.[35] How does one theologically account for this anomalous divide? De la Taille rather quickly dismisses the suggestion that it is simply, or necessarily, a matter of a *greater degree* of charity in the contemplative than in the noncontemplative. For we cannot ignore the likelihood that the Good Samaritan possesses more charity than a contemplative, within whom the gifts of the Spirit are in play.[36] De la Taille proposes that the difference lies in

35. *CP,* 11.

36. *CP,* 11. A contemplative must avoid at all costs considering herself "superior" in charity to noncontemplatives. However, de la Taille does assert the principle that, within a single pray-er, charity does "grow in proportion to the development of contemplation and vice versa." Which is to say that a self-comparison is valid: "a mystic who notes his own progress in con-

a depth of awareness about the *source* of the love that precedes, holds, and follows contemplation. When asked, the contemplative frequently speaks of an "*infused*" love. Neatly, de la Taille notes that the theologian knows well (from scripture and tradition) that *all love is infused*—the "least clairvoyant" to the "most developed." Still, the contemplative knows this reality from the strength and certitude of experience:

> *The mystic has the consciousness of receiving from God a ready-made love,* if such a phrase may be allowed, and this is why he says that he is passive, although love is an act, and the prayer proceeding therefrom also an act. Nevertheless, there is also passivity and conscious passivity in the fact that the soul knows and feels itself invested with the love of God.[37]

The contemplative knows a passively received charity, a love that "swoops" on the soul and lifts it above itself and toward the divine, attaching it to the divine "in a dark light." More clearly, the "infused" love of all the just may be known by the non-contemplative as a theological datum in the knowledge of faith; but the *caritas* of the contemplative, on the other hand, is known in the dark light of prayer as seizing, attracting, and divine.[38]

This brings us to our second and more substantial query: How is contemplation understood in "the economy of the spiritual life"? Is it an extraordinary event in the normal course of the life of grace, something like a miracle found in the natural world? Or is contemplation a "normal development" in the life of grace, rather like the flowering and bearing fruit of a living tree?[39] De la Taille's answer to this question, which draws further critique from Bainvel, sheds new light upon his theology of sacrifice and grace. Like a well-trained disciple of Thomas, he suggests that we can consider this question in a twofold way: first, from the perspective of the will of providence, and second, with regard to the moral and intellectual limits of human nature. In relation to divine providence, we rightly maintain that contemplation is the

templation has the right to consider himself more highly endowed with charity *than in the time in which he had not entered the contemplative path,* and to believe in his further enrichment in proportion to his progress in contemplation." But even this principle depends on remaining in the state of grace, which sin interrupts; *CP,* 11.

37. *CP,* 12.

38. *CP,* 13.

39. *CP,* 20.

"normal prolongation" of the life of grace. All the just are destined for contemplation—whether this purgative prayer begins here on earth or only in purgatory.[40] More on this fascinating point in a moment. However, considered in light of the reality of human nature, we reach a different conclusion. Given the human process of abstractive knowing (contemplation is *not* this, as we saw) and the limits of human virtue, contemplation clearly "transcends" and exceeds natural human capacities. Progress in the spiritual life under grace does reach a point beyond which the Christian cannot proceed by the exercise of the virtues and spiritual gifts alone. At this juncture (certainly different for all souls),[41] there is nothing left in the way of "regular and normal" spiritual progress "except the path of passivity."[42]

It is instructive to listen more closely still to de la Taille's description of the nature of spiritual progress (which he terms a "Providential law"): progress is made incrementally by small victories over self-love "for the advantage of" one's love of God, so that this self-love ends, "if not by dying, at least in being separated from that inaccessible term by only a negligible distance." Such a spiritual "conquest" cannot sustain itself indefinitely, unless by means of the "inappreciable help furnished by contemplative love."[43] The reality of fallen human nature poses a limit to moral resources. In order to surpass and advance beyond such a limit, "contemplation and increasing contemplation may well be needed."[44] For de la Taille, then, it is the extraordinary grace of contemplative prayer that allows for greater victories over self-love, once (even *graced*) moral capacities are exhausted.

Bainvel raises two related objections to de la Taille's position, objections that seem to resist the notion of a limit to spiritual progress under grace. The first disputes de la Taille's conclusion to passive prayer as

40. *CP,* 23.

41. De la Taille explains that for some this juncture is "close to the beginnings of the Christian life," while for others it occurs at a much higher spiritual level; see *CP,* 22.

42. *CP,* 22

43. *CP,* note on 21–22.

44. "This moral impossibility will appear at various points of growth, according to the vigour of the natural temperament and character, the relative richness of the individual's sentimental and intellectual resources, the degree of abundance of external supports, etc."; *CP,* note on 22. De la Taille refers the reader to the *Dialogues* of Catherine of Genoa as a "sufficient" text about the limits of human conquest over self-love.

the necessary "exceptional grace" to human spiritual progress; the second questions his implicit vision that progress over self-love becomes ever more difficult in the spiritual life.[45] In short, Bainvel challenges de la Taille to *demonstrate* the truth of his proposal about grace and the role of contemplation in the spiritual life. We shall analyze de la Taille's fairly extensive epistolary response to Bainvel, for it provides a clearer picture of the relationship between "ordinary" grace and contemplation, while also detailing in a more explicit and pastoral way the moral limits experienced in the battle over self-love.

To begin, de la Taille distinguishes that ordinary ("non-mystical") grace does "nothing more" than engage and "supernaturalize" the "means and resources" of our human psyche—affections, dispositions, and the potentiality therein. But the sum total of these resources, "even when superaturalized," must reach a limit. Otherwise, one would have to (falsely) suppose infinite potentiality and energy in the human being.[46] Therefore, when an individual's maximum moral power (aided by grace) has been exhausted in the battle over self-centered love, "*normally*" it is necessary that "the divine action should bring into play something other than strictly human elements, and consequently call into being new and ultra-human states of soul."[47] While Bainvel contends that grace supplies for the insufficiency of human nature, de la Taille hones the discussion. Ordinary grace does indeed supernaturalize what is "borrowed" from nature; still, such grace raises and strengthens what we have already acquired, or causes what was latent within us to "spring forth," but it does not, *tout court,* increase the moral potential of our nature. Rather, it increases our moral forces "only by comparison with our moral state at the moment."[48] In other words, ordinary grace must "give way" to mystic or contemplative grace, a grace that engages

45. Bainvel, "Introduction," lxxxi. Bainvel suggests that, contrary to de la Taille's vision of spiritual progress, it is the first steps that are most difficult and decisive: "The exercise of a virtue makes the virtue more easy; the will is tempered by its own activity and its victories" (lxxxii).

46. Letter to Bainvel, Dec. 22, 1921, from Università Gregoriana, Roma, reproduced in Bainvel's "Introduction," xcix.

47. Letter to Bainvel, xcix. De la Taille accents the adverb "normally," as he wants always to "leave room" for the miraculous interventions of divine omnipotence, which belong to "extraordinary Providence"; cf. the same Letter, c, and *CP,* 22.

48. Letter to Bainvel, xcix.

"resources foreign and superior to our nature," thereby increasing "the whole sum of psychological resources, whether actual or potential."[49]

In his reflecting deeply about the realities of human sin and grace, and about the more potently transformative grace of passive prayer, I suspect that de la Taille is forging an interesting synthesis here, even though certainly leaning upon both Thomas and John of the Cross. We can summarize his thought by highlighting three crucial premises. First, grace aids, actuates, and strengthens our moral capacities, "supernaturalizing" them, in effect. To be sure, this is but an echo of the solid Thomistic principle that grace builds upon and perfects nature. Secondly, this graced moral capacity and effort reach a limit in the battle of *caritas* over self-will and self-love. Though the demarcation of this limit varies from person to person, it is "in all cases real." Thirdly, as providence destines all the just for union with God, this limit must be passed, "under penalty" of arrested growth in the "illimitable way of grace and holiness."[50] De la Taille therefore concludes that contemplation is "required" to elevate humans beyond the limits of moral strength—this particular requirement, this superior grace, being infused by God. Has de la Taille "proved" his thesis about the necessity of contemplation for ongoing growth in the spiritual life? Has he demonstrated irrefutably this providential law of the spiritual life? Bainvel is not convinced that he has done so.[51]

Of course, it is not clear what sort of "proof" would satisfy, or what sort could be given. De la Taille has formulated a sharp concept of grace and the moral limitations of human strength and effort. Contemplative or mystic grace does not simply elevate human moral capacities; rather it infuses divine, Trinitarian love, and power. De la Taille's attempt to demonstrate his thesis gains additional momentum from his riposte to Bainvel's second criticism, a criticism that casts doubt upon the portrayal of spiritual progress as one of increasing difficulty. Here de la Taille invokes practical spiritual experience, the wisdom and experience of spiritual writers, the *lex orandi* of the church, and, we might add, the doctrine of purgatory.

49. Letter to Bainvel, xcix–c.
50. Letter to Bainvel, c.
51. Bainvel, footnote on page lxxxiii.

He concedes to Bainvel that the long practice of a virtue will often grant a certain facility of action, action attendant upon that particular virtue. But, he argues, surely this principle applies only to that virtue *already acquired,* and not to a virtue that has yet to be possessed.[52] More, Bainvel's thought would entail that the first "polishing" of the soul and its labors toward "comeliness" necessarily pose a greater moral difficulty than those "last and sublime purifications from self-love" in preparation for perfect union with God. "Who will believe this?" de la Taille rhetorically asks. For, first of all, there is the fairly universal experience of "powerlessness" that consumes one in a more striking way after years of effort than it did in those "first steps" toward the "foot of that so rugged and steep mountain." De la Taille acknowledges the appearance or "illusion" of ease: when divine help is "poured" so "abundantly and superabundantly" into the soul, the feeling of difficulty all but vanishes.[53] Still, the reality of the arduousness remains. Should that profuse divine aid be withdrawn or "come in more sparing measure," the soul again sinks "under its burden, beseeching grace."[54]

It is tempting to suspect that de la Taille is speaking from personal experience here, so robust and raw is his language. Yet he posits this teaching as coming from two of the "most reliable" spiritual doctors: Augustine and Francis de Sales. Both figures teach that the difficulty of overcoming self-love is so great that, "regularly speaking," it is reserved for the next life. And why should this be the case if, in fact, the "facility" of progress augments as one indeed progresses in the spiritual life?

Liturgical prayer, moreover, also witnesses that the "annihilation of self-love in favor of charity" is all but impossible in this life. In the church's liturgy, the worshipper is constantly beseeching God to purify the heart—"a perpetual paraphrase of the verse *Cor mundum crea in me Deus, et spiritum rectum innova in visceribus meis*."[55] The Christian is never finished, as it were, imploring divine aid to transform human and earthly desire into pure and godly love. Though de la Taille does

52. Letter to Bainvel, c.

53. "The divine succour is so strong that in comparison the difficulty is a bagatelle"; Letter to Bainvel, ci.

54. Letter to Bainvel.

55. Letter to Bainvel.

not here connect this spiritual doctrine to his treatment of eucharistic sacrifice, the tenor of his comments in this letter are certainly heuristic. He writes that the first commandment, to love God with an absolute and sovereign friendship, is, finally, "the business of heaven." Here below, there is constantly "some gap in God's empire over our mind, our soul, our strength, our heart."[56] Here below, in other words, the believer offers sacrifice in expression of her desire to close that gap and to invite God's charity to reign over worldly and self-directed loves. The reader, now familiar with de la Taille's theology of eucharistic sacrifice and grace, might be curious if this exceptional grace of contemplation is analogous to or identical with the grace of union received in the Eucharist. The question is of course central to our exploration of de la Taille's work on contemplation; we shall give it full attention in the next chapter.

At this point, we return to the intriguing suggestion introduced earlier—namely, that all shall be contemplatives in purgatory. What is de la Taille intending here, and who are the traditional voices behind this theology? First, and most obvious, de la Taille is pointing to the continuity of the soul's purification in this life and the next. He is also reiterating that passive prayer is a *purification,* one fueled by the desire for God, and one accomplished by divine love. For indeed, since every soul reaches a point beyond which moral effort cannot extend, and because death often arrives before the moment of transition into passive prayer, both contemplative and non-contemplative alike will pass through a final purification (which the Catholic tradition names purgatory). De la Taille maintains that in purgatory charity "makes things equal," no matter the soul's state of prayer on earth. In purgatory, therefore,

> the contemplation of the soul who possessed the highest degree of charity … will be incomparably higher, more lost in joy, and yet (all other things being equal) more rigorous and consuming, more painful as regards the purification that may remain to be accomplished; because *love itself is the fire that attacks and devours the impurities of the soul,* and that with a greater violence proportionately to its greater intensity and consequent hostility to them.[57]

56. Letter to Bainvel.
57. *CP,* 23 (emphasis mine).

Passive prayer thus resembles purgatory, because the purifying love of God is at work in the pray-er according to the measure of love in the one who stands before God longing for union. As in his theology of sacrificial oblation, so here with the intensity of contemplative purgation: love determines efficacy. Perhaps de la Taille would add that the primary difference between the *devotio* commonly operative in ritual eucharistic offering and the love of contemplation is not that one is purgative and the other not, but, as we earlier noted, that contemplation possesses a deeper consciousness of that transforming love as offered to and received from God.

On this question of contemplation and purgation, we can easily trace the influence of both Catherine of Genoa and John of the Cross. This genetic connection, I argue, raises the volume on de la Taille's (understated) theology of desire. In one of the few footnotes in *Contemplative Prayer,* de la Taille draws attention to Catherine's work. Arguably one of the more distinctive features of her writing is the notion of the soul's ongoing purgation by pure love—God's ecstatic, attracting, and purifying love.[58] Catherine attests that the soul's purgation, both in this life and the next, is primarily the work of God's fiery love, to which the soul, attending to God, need only freely consent.[59]

But de la Taille's overlay of contemplation and purgatory is likewise remarkably sanjuanist, though here he makes no immediate reference to John's corpus of writings.[60] Reference to a single passage from *The*

58. *CP,* 22 (note). Commentators on the work of Catherine of Genoa have suggested that she was influenced significantly by the neo-Platonism of Denys the Pseudo-Areopagite; see Benedict Groeschel's "Introduction" in *Purgation and Purgatory: The Spiritual Dialogue,* by Catherine of Genoa, translation and notes by Serge Hughes (New York: Paulist Press, 1979), 24ff. The following passage does sound particularly Dionysian: "When God created man, He did not put Himself in motion for any other reason than His pure love alone"; Catherine of Genoa, *Vita.* 61a, cited by Friedrich von Hügel in *The Mystical Element of Religion as Studied in Saint Catherine of Genoa and Her Friends* (London: J. M. Dent and Sons, 1927), 1:261–62.

59. For Catherine, the primary spiritual battle is that of the "subtle" self-will of the soul against the grace of God's pure love. For example, see von Hügel's *The Mystical Element,* 1:262–67. Von Hügel quotes from Catherine of Genoa's *Vita* (49a), describing the purgation of our self-love as God's work: "Every day I feel that the motes are being removed, which this Pure Love casts out.… [A]ll the time God does not cease from continuing to remove them" (267). De la Taille's frequent statements about the difficulty of conquering self-will and the consequent need for divine action certainly resonate with Catherine's vision of the battle against self-love.

60. See for example, John of the Cross, *Dark Night* II.vi.6 (on the experience of "purgatory"

Living Flame of Love will no doubt suffice to mark the affinity and to illumine de la Taille's words about the intensity and violence of love in contemplative purgation.[61] In this passage, John is reminding readers about the "afflictive," "oppressive," and far from "gentle" love that wounds and attacks the impurities of the soul in contemplation. The "severe dryness" of the intellect, the "distress of the will," the "burdensome" awareness of one's sins: "A person's sufferings at this time cannot be exaggerated; they are but little less than the sufferings of purgatory." This purgatory "here on earth" is not without purpose, for the soul desires "to be transformed in Him *through love* in this life." John is also quick to underscore that the very fire of love (the Holy Spirit) that assails and purges the soul in contemplation is not a different love than that which later unites with and "glorifies" the soul.[62] Both in John and de la Taille's view, contemplation *here* and *there* is carried out by the same divine love, operative on the same desire and yet resistant will.

Our third query about the trials and sufferings of contemplation follows naturally. De la Taille's continued use of sanjuanist language spotlights our thesis about passive prayer and sacrifice: if contemplation is purgative, its sufferings are a cruciform denuding. De la Taille portrays the suffering inherent in contemplation as having "no proportion" or "common measure" with external suffering, particularly, but not exclusively, in that last suffering of the spirit before perfect union with the divine.[63] Indeed, the very emergence of the contemplative light of faith involves a "tearing (*déchirement*)"—painful, alien, and unsettling.[64] Like John of the Cross, de la Taille acknowledges two dis-

here on earth through contemplation) and *Dark Night* II.vii.7 (a comparison of contemplative purgation and purgatory). In *Dark Night* II.xii.1–4, John creates an extended analogy between the purgation of God's loving contemplation here on earth and that of both spirits and angels in the next life. In these paragraphs, John asserts that God's purgative and illuminating fire is never infused without love. It is this love that David calls out for in Psalm 51 (*Cor mundum crea in me Deus*…, cf. de la Taille's use of this verse above); this loving wisdom that Jeremiah describes when he says *He sent a fire into my bones and instructed me* (Lam. 1:13); this loving spiritual fire that cleanses souls in purgatory; and, this loving illuminating fire through which God "purges the angels of their ignorances."

61. *The Living Flame* I, 18–24.

62. *The Living Flame* I, 19; 20–21; 24.

63. *CP,* 14, 19.

64. I recommend Sarah Coakley's fascinating study of the origin and contours of pain in the Carmelite contemplative tradition, "Palliative or Intensification? Pain and Christian Con-

tinct stages in the contemplative way to union, both of which demand a continual oblation of all that distances the soul from God.

The first stage, that occurring in the "natural domain" of the prayer, is the night of the senses. Here the senses—exterior and interior—undergo a deep "confusion" and "stripping." The "whole *ensemble*" of abstract knowledge, the judgments it fosters and the affections swayed by these thoughts, must all be subjected to a painful denuding by the light of contemplation.[65] At the same time, the early "work of contemplation" demands both a disciplining of the spirit, that it might remain still and attentive rather than agitated and in flight, and a "cutting off' of those "tendencies" pursuant to following one's own will, tendencies "full of impurities and irregularities." These mortifications are all the more painful because frequently carried out "without any compensation" or promise of reward.[66] De la Taille has this sober advice for directors guiding souls through this stage:

> Once … contemplation has been constated, the soul should be urged to feed upon it and make progress in it, which means that she should devote herself to it and make the necessary sacrifices: the sacrifice of curiosities of the spirit, of wanderings of the imagination, of the futilities of conversation, of occupations not definitely ordained to charity towards God and neighbour, and, above all, of the liberties of the heart and sentiments, liberties which for charity are a slavery and fetters from which it has to be freed. It is most important to put the soul on her guard against self-love and egotism.[67]

Discipline, sacrifice, and the shedding of disordered intellectual and volitional habits thus mark this initial stage of contemplation. The dark night of the senses is typically a long, slow oblation (active and passive, we could say) of desire. The soul is doubly in the dark, for light of the senses and abstractive knowing has "gone out," while the pure and supernatural light has yet to establish itself ("le rayon purement surnaturel, n'a pas encore sa netteté ni sa familiarité").[68] This leaves the soul suspended, as it were, in its relations with God: all light seems extinguished.

templation in the Spirituality of the Sixteenth-Century Carmelites," in *Pain and Its Transformation: The Interface of Biology and Culture,* edited by Sarah Coakley and Kay Kaufman Shelemy (Harvard University Press, 2008), 77–100.

65. *CP,* 16.
66. *CP,* 16–17.
67. *CP,* 25.
68. De la Taille, "L'oraison contemplative," 283.

But the suffering of the first stage is normally less severe than the "incomprehensible" suffering of the spiritual night. This suffering occurs not in the "natural" but in the "spiritual man," in the "ultra-human" sensibilities of the soul—its "peaks and hidden depths"—where the contemplative light resides and the divine gift is received and experienced.[69] Why should this divine presence be experienced as intolerably painful? Because the gift of divine goodness is "so great, so immeasurably lovable," it can give birth to a "thousand tortures" in the yet unpurified will. As the contemplative progresses in the night of the spirit, the light of purgative love causes the soul to see with horror her own disordered desire and imperfect love. This illumination of the soul's own "insufficient love," as well as the painful consciousness of the sin of others,[70] prompts the soul to flee from the light and "to hasten to expiate." For, as God's goodness and love shine more potently, "the more *crucifying* becomes the soul's impotence to return it"; she cannot escape knowing the "discord and incompatibility" that she has permitted to "slip between her and perfect union." Every shadow of self-love, and every "fraudulent dealing with God," every egotistical pleasure alien to the divine will, causes a "*magnum chaos*."[71] De la Taille's language is strikingly harsh. The nearer to God, the greater the contemplative's grief and sorrow for her own unbecoming and dissimilar being before God—or, we could say, for her incapacity to exchange a pure gift with God. God's exceeding goodness and attractiveness cause the soul, in her every movement of self-centered love or skewed desire, an excruciating pain.

The goal, the ultimate desire of the pray-er, is described in terms of a perfect union with God that optimally reflects the union and love among the three divine persons:

> They [the triune God] are distinct in this sense only, that One is not the Other; but there is no diversity between them: All that One of them is, the Others are, without exception. So the soul is not lost in God, as long as there remains even the slightest backward look on the self which does not correspond to the manner in which God loves us and wishes us to love ourselves.[72]

69. *CP,* 16–17.

70. De la Taille adds that the contemplative, as did Jesus, keenly feels the sins of others, feels "our every voluntary and culpable … injustice towards … Living Goodness"; *CP,* note on page 18.

71. *CP,* 18–19.

72. *CP,* 19.

The perfect, trinitarian state of friendship with God does not occur "in plenitude" in this life. The journey of the contemplative is a long one, perpetually involving the willing and painful sacrifice of yet unpurified love. Nevertheless, de la Taille is quick to add that contemplation is not thereby engaged without hope: indeed, hope keeps the soul "concentrated in the gaze of a filial love."[73] Like John of the Cross, he also acknowledges that this suffering is both heightened and endured *because* of the love that simultaneously urges the contemplative to seek life within that divine light. None of the willing oblation and surrender of desire happens without the fire of a greater and divine love.[74] In fact, the movement of love and desire, even "impetuous movements," definitively characterizes contemplative transformation. The Holy Spirit flames a desire for deeper knowledge of how the Beloved is "more truly … beautiful, good, glorious, happy and perfect." It is desire and hope that keep the contemplative at the altar of sacrifice.[75]

We have now set forth the essential features of de la Taille's thought on passive prayer. We noted the relation of "reciprocal precession" between love and faith, which constitutes the beginning and increase of passive prayer. We saw, too, de la Taille's vision of contemplation as both connatural (a natural prolongation of progress in grace) and supernatural (the transformation and divinization of the limited moral and intellectual capacities). Finally, we established the purifying and sacrificial nature of contemplative prayer, showing that de la Taille construes contemplation (à la Catherine of Genoa and John of the Cross) as a painful, ongoing purgation of the ungodly desire that impedes perfect union with God. The nearer the pray-er comes to union with God,

73. *CP,* 20.

74. Cf. for example the classic statement in John's *Ascent* I, xiv, 2–3.

75. For John of the Cross, even the penultimate *telos* of contemplation is depicted in terms of a perfect sacrifice-as-gift. In his Commentary on the third stanza in *The Living Flame of Love,* John describes the soul's participation in a trinitarian exchange of the gift of God's very Self. The purified bridal soul, loving God in God, now gives forth God to God "by offering God the Holy Spirit." Here is the sacrifice most like Christ's and most truly a genuine gift, for the soul possesses God "as something of its own" (having so received God from God), and returns this gift in "voluntary surrender." And this gift of God to God is, at last, sufficient love. It repays God for all that He has given to the soul, and is "gratefully" accepted by God (*Living Flame* III, 78–79). If de la Taille stops short himself of describing such a reality, it nonetheless informs his approach to contemplation and its sacrificial trials.

the more crucifying the experience of contemplation and the more radically enflamed with love is the sacrifice of misdirected desire.[76] In the next chapter, we turn to some of the disputed questions of mystical theology treated by de la Taille. These more technical matters of contemplative prayer take us into the heart of de la Taille's thought and cast a solid bridge to our discussion of the analogy between contemplative and eucharistic union.

76. In *Contemplative Prayer,* de la Taille examines what happens to the contemplative who has "fallen," i.e., who has returned to the illusion of pride and the ways of self-love. This is, he writes, a "deplorable" and "dangerous" state, one that can readily lead to despair (cf. Heb 4:4–6). Once one has "tasted" the heavenly delights of contemplation, there is no beginning again at the beginning—with "an initial rupture" from sin—but only an attempt to "resume" the course where it was left. De la Taille specifies that this "picking up again" when "Grace knocks" will not be in the form of a union of delight; rather, it will "come as a union of crucifixion": God breaking down the pride that "resists" him. De la Taille counsels an absolute cooperation with grace at this point, a complete surrender. In other words, the pathway back for the errant contemplative is even more crucifying than her first entrance in the "dark night"; *CP,* 26.

Contemplation and the Eucharist

8

This chapter develops more fully de la Taille's theology of contemplation, going beyond basic questions of the nature and role of contemplation in the spiritual life to more specific issues concerning contemplative experience and theory. We shall witness de la Taille's serious engagement with the contemporary discussions over mystical theology, as well as his effort to enunciate an analogy between contemplation and the grace of the Eucharist. His impressive "Théories mystiques" uses Dom Cuthbert Butler's appended text to *Western Mysticism* as a springboard to engage some important and controversial questions on passive prayer. Three of these questions will occupy our attention, as they significantly nuance what we have outlined already about his thought on contemplative prayer. I shall consider first the question of an "intermediate" state between common prayer and contemplation: if such a state exists, how is it defined, named, and related to contemplation, properly speaking? Secondly, since Butler inquires into what John of the Cross intends by the "substantial touch" of contemplation, de la Taille offers his own astute gloss, illuminating the concept with his theology of grace—"created actuation by uncreated Act." Finally, de la Taille grapples with the issue of contemplative *knowledge*. He appears particularly eager to counter the position that intellection is "annihilated" in genuine passive prayer. This defense of contemplative knowing neatly circles back to his portrayal of the relationship between the intellect and the affect in passive prayer.

The second part of this chapter collects what we have learned from de la Taille about passive prayer and focuses on how he confirms his intuition about the integral relationship between contemplation and the Eucharist. We shall see that this integration is founded upon Christ and an integral connection between the eucharistic and contemplative altars of sacrifice.

Disputed Questions in Mystical Theology

The "Passage" between Common Prayer and Contemplation

De la Taille joins Butler in reflecting upon the boundaries of common and passive prayer. He presents his own solution, based on theoretical and practical concerns, for a possible middle or transitional state of prayer before contemplation. Butler, leaning upon the authority of John of the Cross, Francis de Sales, and the anonymous fourteenth-century author of *The Cloud of Unknowing,* calls the intermediate state of prayer "the prayer of loving attention," a terminology that de la Taille finds apt for Butler's theory.[1] De la Taille purports that there is little *practical* difference between what Butler intends by this "prayer of loving attention" and the so-called "prayer of simplicity," popularized by Poulain in his *Graces of Interior Prayer.* Even so, the crucial difference between the two thinkers lies in where this "intermediate" prayer is placed. Is it really outside of passive prayer, properly speaking (Poulain's assertion)? Or does it in fact lie within the interior of contemplation itself (Butler's position)? The distinction might appear to be without significance, but de la Taille carefully presents each position, giving the "two schools" their day in court. If Butler is correct, then the prayer of loving attention *belongs* to the "body" of contemplative prayer, and one is "already on the way" to the successive stages of passive prayer. For Poulain, on the other hand, this intermediate state is yet distinct from contemplation: its physiology, one could say, is different from that of contemplation. It is yet a "working moment" directed toward infused prayer. More, if Poulain is right, this "inferior" sort of prayer

1. De la Taille, "Théories," 297.

can develop indefinitely "according to its own rule."[2] Dissatisfied with both positions, de la Taille cleverly charts a third course.

Drawing attention to the work of his own teacher, Maumigny, de la Taille accepts that there is some intermediate state between common and contemplative prayer. However, he argues for a more salutary distinction, namely, that within the "prayer of simplicity" or "loving attention" there are actually two sorts of prayer that often appear so much alike that it takes a shrewd spiritual director to discern the difference.[3] The first sort of prayer of simplicity occurs in "favorable circumstances," emerging from a serendipitous temperament and from effective pious practices. By contrast, the second sort is pure gift: a special grace "carrying the will" away to "a habitual adherence to God." The will is "under the sway of a secret taste" for the uncreated divine; its desire is purely set upon God, and the soul is "taken" in a sustained way. Here, one has entered the mystical order,

> characterized by an experiential knowledge of God, deriving from the single persistent power of divine attraction; and therein the experience is one in which spiritual thirst is satisfied.[4]

But if, in this second form of the prayer of simplicity, the soul moves within the order of mystical prayer, is this completely identical then to the passive prayer of contemplation?

To clarify, de la Taille offers an important distinction about passive prayer. There is a passivity of which the subject is conscious, a passivity perceptible in the very act itself of attending to, gazing upon, God. But there is also a passivity that "only reveals itself" to the eye of an experienced director, a hidden passivity that finds expression "in the *continuity* of the movement which carries the soul." The subject has no con-

2. "Théories," 297–98, 300.

3. "Elles peuvent se ressembler assez pour qu'il y ait quelquefois, pendant un temps au moins, difficulté à les reconnaître: et c'est où excelle le tact de l'homme spirituel"; "Théories," 298. De la Taille encourages readers to consult de Maumigny's *Pratique de l'oraison mentale,* vol. 1, L'*oraison ordinaire,* 9th ed. (Paris: Beauchesne, 1905–1907), 183–212, for a clear description of these two kinds of prayer.

4. "Théories," 298. We need also acknowledge de la Taille's prejudice at this stage: he absolutely excludes from the mystical what he calls that radically affective "feminine prayer"—almost always belonging to a female—that is not "under the Holy Spirit's special action, inclining and grasping the soul" (299).

sciousness of the beginning of such a movement—of placing herself in such a vulnerable position—but only of the insistence of the "*regard*" for the Object "by the force of divine attraction." The passivity of the gaze is common to both states, but in the latter case the passivity has not yet *touched* the pray-er's intellect in an appreciable way—that is, it has not yet revealed itself "clearly as ultra-human."[5] Consistent with what he wrote in his earlier essay on contemplation (and in agreement with other "grave authors"),[6] de la Taille reserves the term "contemplation" for that state of prayer in which the mystic is in "full consciousness of her passivity." Affective prayer, the prayer of loving attention, or the prayer of simplicity: all of these terms can be employed for that state of mystical prayer in which the divinely infused passivity remains "hidden" to the subject, "hidden" and thus an inferior spiritual passivity, but one that "should normally transition into a superior type."[7]

What is the theological nub of de la Taille's distinction about the intermediate state between common prayer and contemplation, properly speaking? Theoretically, de la Taille desires to reserve the term "contemplation" to that prayer fully aware of its passivity. Yet, at the same time, he also wishes to underscore the *continuity* between the prayer of loving attention and contemplation. Following the inclination of his pastorally oriented mentor, Maumigny, de la Taille reminds us that this argument between Butler and Poulain has very little *practical* interest; for, whether one supports the Butler or Poulain thesis, counsel at this intermediate stage of prayer is necessarily the same: "repose, simplicity, passivity," as opposed to "initiative and industry or multiplicity."[8] We could say that the repose and simplicity of this intermediate state of

5. "Théories," 299.

6. Libermann is specifically named as one of the serious authors; "Théories," 299.

7. De la Taille does not give his approbation to the term *acquired*—as opposed to *infused*—contemplation, in naming this genre of affective, lovingly attentive prayer. Poulain made "acquired contemplation" a popular phrase, though it has a lengthier history; cf. *Graces,* 61–62, 635–36. De la Taille stipulates that what is *acquired* in this intermediate prayer are concepts "naturally" formed by the mind; as such, they are materials "used" in this transitional state of prayer. By contrast, the "spontaneous insistence of the gaze which pierces love is *not acquired*"; "Théories," 299–300n3 (emphasis mine). In other words, the passivity of the prayer of loving attention, that force of divine attraction, cannot be called "acquired," even if the one praying is not fully aware of receiving love as divinely infused.

8. "Théories," 300.

prayer dispose one toward contemplation—the infusion of God's love and an *awareness* of that divinely transformative activity upon the soul.

It is salutary to highlight de la Taille's democratizing predilection in regard to this transitional state into conscious passive prayer. Unlike Poulain, he insists that the liminal phase of passive prayer cannot proceed indefinitely and independently according to its own order. Rather, the prayer of simplicity or loving attention is *in via:* it will reach that point, again defined by human moral limits, at which the path of passivity becomes necessary. Most significantly, de la Taille stresses the continuity between these different stages of prayer[9] because it is *the same light of faith* operative in this transitional prayer and in contemplation, properly speaking:

> In this prayer which marks the beginning of the mystical way, the indication of this found in the *application* of the look passively engaged, this is already—even though in a weak and imperceptible measure—the light of faith beginning to liberate the soul from the sensible, and, consequently from abstract concepts; otherwise said, the light has begun to pierce in its nudity, but so feebly that the soul does not know it, and thinks that she yet sees in the ordinary light of the intellect.[10]

In less formal language, all believers are on their way to becoming mystics. The pray-er may dispose himself for infused prayer, but the initiative will be God's. For de la Taille, a growing awareness of this inflow of God's burning *caritas* defines the state of contemplation *proprie dictu.*

In belaboring this question about the passage between ordinary and contemplative prayer, I have wanted to underscore both de la Taille's competency in controversial topics of mystical theology and the generous pastoral and practical aspect of his theology of prayer. Most importantly, I have intended for the discussion to begin to surface an analogy between the grace of eucharistic union and contemplation. To the point, the grace of union bestowed on those receiving the Eucharist is not a reality absolutely distinct from what de la Taille has argued about the nature, work, and experience of passive prayer. We shall spell this out in greater detail at the conclusion of this chapter, but we turn now

9. On this question of the continuity between the "prayer of loving attention" and passive prayer, de la Taille claims the support of John of the Cross—a support of the "highest authority"; "Théories," 300.

10. "Théories," 300.

to another contested question about contemplation, one that again bears on de la Taille's theology of grace.

The Sanjuanist "Substantial Touch"

De la Taille addresses Butler's concern—indeed, his surprise—that one would be so bold as to use John of the Cross's phrase "substantial touch" in relation to those "inferior" states of prayer, namely, the "prayer of loving attention" or the "prayer of simplicity."[11] If de la Taille is sympathetic to Butler's worry, he nonetheless surpasses Butler in parsing the "touch" of mystical prayer.[12] His analysis rests, perhaps predictably, upon an understanding of divine indwelling and grace that we have already seen in this study. John of the Cross's "substantial touch" is explicated within the template of "created actuation by uncreated Grace."

De la Taille begins by suggesting that one would be correct—"and more than one thinks"—to assert a "touch of substance to substance between God and the soul" in that inferior prayer that leads to contemplation proper. He argues that the indwelling of the Triune God in the graced soul is "a presence of their own essence to the proper essence of the soul."[13] Naturally, he immediately qualifies that this is not the substantial unity of being that obtained in the Word Incarnate; rather, this is a *habitual union,* accidental but nevertheless permanent. Though habitual, the union between the substance of the soul and God is *real* and *immediate,* made so by the created reality of sanctifying grace, a consequence of and disposition for the divine indwelling. In fact, de la Taille advances the notion that the grace of prayer is best understood in terms of this created reality deriving from the indwelling of God:

> And if one wants to say more, that the whole apparatus of mystical prayer (like all prayer inspired by a living faith) is founded on this latent substructure, and that all grace of prayer, even ordinary grace, has its source and its root in this divine presence, one would be right in a thousand ways.[14]

11. "Théories," 303.

12. Rowan Williams has recognized de la Taille's effort to "distentangle" the problem of *toque sustanciales* in his essay "Butler's *Western Mysticism:* Towards an Assessment," *Downside Review* 102 (1984): 197–215. However, I would suggest that he too readily translates de la Taille's effort into sanjuanist terms without identifying the illumination provided by his theory of grace (205). Still, this ready compatibility is a tribute to de la Taille's close and faithful reading of John of the Cross.

13. "Théories," 303–4.

14. "Théories," 304.

De la Taille's confidence is appealing. Still, having made this correlation between prayer and the "substantial" union resulting from God's indwelling in the soul, he is well aware that John of the Cross intends something more specific, if not entirely different. Indeed, de la Taille's interpretative strategy here again shows him to be an astute and sympathetic reader of a Thomistic John of the Cross.

De la Taille acknowledges that John reserves the term "substantial touch" for a state of passive prayer exceeding all intermediary stages of prayer, a state in which the soul is conscious of the "ray of light" in which it sees the divine object. The contemplative light of faith not only radically enflames the will, but now also enlightens the intellect with a new mode of knowing. In John's concept of spiritual marriage, "for the first time … the direct union between essence and essence ends in a way that *informs* the eye of the mind."[15] De la Taille quickly affirms that "the *term* of the union," the uncreated Trinity, remains unchanged (not *informed*) by this union of "substantial touch." Indeed, this habitation of the Trinity, "the *presence* or *communication* of the Trinity," is not to be confused with the Trinity itself.[16] Rather, we properly understand this union in terms of sanctifying grace, in terms of a habitual union to uncreated Grace.

More pointedly, then, how does de la Taille interpret the *substantial* in John's "substantial touch"? This touch of the Trinity, this inhabitation and union of grace reaches beyond the acts, beyond the virtues, and even beyond the superior faculties of soul, reaching into the very depth and "visual sphere" of the soul. There, this substantial touch "teaches the soul as much as the soul in this world can be taught about Him to whom she unites as essence to essence—or rather that by her [this touch] we are held in His essence, or rather He gives Himself to us by her."[17] Once this "substantial touch" resides in the soul, progress

15. "Théories," 304 (emphasis mine).

16. De la Taille goes on to say, crucially, that the "touch" is correlative to sanctifying grace: "*L'habitation* de la Trinité, la *présence* ou *communication* de la Trinité, ne se confond pas avec la Trinité, dont elle n'a ni l'éternité ni l'immutabilité; mais elle se confond en revanche avec la grâce sanctifiante, notre union habituelle à la Grâce increéée"; "Théories," 304–5.

17. "Théories," 305. "Et c'est ainsi qu'en entrant dans le champ visuel de l'âme par delà les actes, facultés et vertus, elle renseigne l'âme autant que l'âme peut être renseignée en ce monde

in this state is illimitable. But let us be clear: this progress is not further movement to something more interior or divine. Rather, the soul moves toward greater and greater peaceful familiarity and intimacy with this substantial presence—a presence that always increases according to charity.[18]

De la Taille cautions that it would be a mistake to understand this substantial presence to the soul as revealing herself by some "mental substitute," as if the union were not absolutely real and intimate. To the contrary, this substantial touch reveals herself, seizes and grasps the soul, "by her reality alone"—a created reality, to be sure. This is quintessential de la Taille. The substantial touch of contemplative spiritual marriage is on a continuum of the created union of sanctifying grace, and yet it "informs" the soul more intimately, more deeply. As in his doctrine of created actuation, de la Taille insists that this union with, or touch by, the Trinity, while created, is not thereby distant or lacking in immediacy. Created, intimate, immediate: such is the presence of the Trinity to the soul in the created actuation of sanctifying grace, in the grace of union in the Eucharist, and in the substantial touch of contemplation.

To verify this theologically, de la Taille does not hesitate to call upon the witness of mystics, who themselves describe this touch as a "*direct*" perception of God, however guardedly this directness must be taken. The soul's experience of the divine "touch" in contemplation is unique; the mystic knows this touch by its "inimitable originality":

> The sovereign Good penetrates them [contemplatives] with his sweetness, or arouses their desire with his odor; it is his savor which delights them, it is his fire which enflames them, it is his embrace which possesses them, his breath which refreshes them, his caress which touches them—or his reproach which turns them upside down, his holiness, his justice, his majesty which humbles them.… They cannot not recognize Him by his touch, He who plunges into their depths where only He can write, with that radiance which is His alone, with the grace that He alone distills, and which has the taste of eternal life, so different from everything which is not this touch.[19]

sur Celui à qui elle nous unit d'essence à essence, ou plutôt que par elle nous étreignons en Son essence, ou plutôt qui par elle Se donne."

18. "Théories," 305.

19. "Théories," 308.

Indeed, de la Taille's distinctive, impassioned expression affirms that the soul perceives this inimitable touch "directly." These are the signs and traces and presence of the One who leaves his imprint upon all of creation, and more, who happily enough extends himself over the soul, "as the prophet over the body that he wishes to reanimate: feet upon feet, hands upon hands, mouth upon mouth."[20] Such real traces, such erotic touches cannot be experienced without leaving the pray-er "affected by *Him*" and "enjoying Him": this contemplative union satisfies the pray-er's desire. De la Taille maintains, however, that properly speaking, this intimate experience of God is still labeled "indirect"—much as, indirectly, one experiences the rose by its scent, or the "heart of friend in the shaking of her hand."[21] Even when the mystic enters the state of spiritual marriage, which de la Taille boldly calls a "*compénétration,*"[22] even in this "commerce of essence to essence," God is but "glimpsed" in a sort of "prelude" to the beatific vision.[23] Intimacy, without a doubt. But contemplative union is not the perfection of the *lumen gloriae*.

Is de la Taille merely splitting hairs here? If not, what is at stake? First and foremost, de la Taille is concerned to "guard" divine transcendence, to explicitly keep before the eye the distinction between Creator and creature.[24] We reiterate: God's presence to the soul in contempla-

20. "Théories," 309.

21. "Théories," 309.

22. What does de la Taille mean by this "*compénétration*" of substances, this "*échange total*"? Why does he find this terminology most apt? "We have been speaking just now of the presence of God in the soul as the means of contemplation proper to spiritual marriage; and this is quite true. But the mystics speak almost as often of the presence of the soul in the divine essence; and that is perfectly true as well, and in some regards more expressive. But the full truth is that this substantial presence is *reciprocal;* God is in the soul and the soul in God. However, since this event poses something new in the soul, subject of the sanctifying grace, without posing something new in God, who cannot be the subject of any modification, we prefer in this study to regard the dwelling or habitation from the aspect of the soul, and from the aspect of God the Guest, who is received"; "Théories," 309n10.

23. De la Taille provides a neat analogy of the difference between the direct experience of God in heaven and that of the "substantial" touch of passive prayer: "Dieu fixé directement dans la pureté de son essence, c'est le ciel. Dieu entrevu dans le prélude de cette vision, qu'est le commerce d'essence à essence, c'est le mariage spirituel. Il y a un abîme infini entre les deux, bien que l'une soit comme une répétition de ce que sera l'autre, mais une répétition où l'acteur principal reste voilé; à peu près comme on répète le couronnement des rois sans que du roi s'aperçoive autre chose que le trône"; "Théories," 310.

24. At one point, de la Taille suggests that one mark of the height and purity of contem-

tion remains a fact of the created order, even though that presence is immediate—that is to say, the divine essence proper to the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit is present to the essence of the soul. God does not send an "ambassador" for the divine presence. God is the gift he communicates, but this advent in the creature is something created.[25] At stake, secondly, is the contentious early-twentieth-century question as to whether or not the highest contemplative vision was in fact *intuitive vision*—that is, the immediate vision of the divine essence to the intellect. Apparently, there were some thinkers (Maréchal and Gardeil, for example) who were inclined to argue for this by employing Thomas and his interpreters.[26] By contrast, de la Taille sharply contends that both Thomas and John of the Cross unambiguously hold that seeing the essence of God is reserved for the next life. He specifically cites three short passages from *The Spiritual Canticle,* the substance of which are this: even at the highest limits of spiritual marriage, the soul has yet to experience the "clear transformation of glory," at which time, "in the strong union of glory," she will know God face to face and love him perfectly.[27] Only then will the night of contemplation take place in the full and open light of day. For de la Taille, the entire question is reduced to what he calls the "first principle" for the "science" of mystical theology, a principle taken from the prologue to John's *Spiritual Canticle:* mystical wisdom proceeds *according to the mode of faith.* Even the "substantial touch" of a nuptial contemplative union is not yet the intuitive vision of God.[28]

Desire and Contemplative Unknowing

We have witnessed how de la Taille employs his theology of grace both to understand an intermediate state of prayer "before" contempla-

plation is that the prayer bestows a "certitude that God is other than" that which was experienced; "Théories," 313.

25. "Théories," 311; cf. 311–12n13.

26. Cf. Dom Cuthbert Butler's "Afterthoughts" in his *Western Mysticism: The Teaching of SS. Augustine, Gregory and Bernard on Contemplation and Contemplative life. Neglected Chapters in the History of Religion,* 2nd ed. (London: Constable, 1927), lxxiii–lxxix; and de la Taille's lengthy footnote 14 ("Théories," 312–14), in which he critiques Gardeil and expresses support of Garrigou-Lagrange's position.

27. John of the Cross, *The Spiritual Canticle*, Str. 36.5, 38.3, and 39.13; "Théories," 315.

28. "Théories," 315.

tion and to interpret John of the Cross's "substantial touch." We turn now to the third contested issue, a more directly epistemological question about the nature of knowledge in contemplation. The topic grants us a deeper insight into de la Taille's perspective on the union of contemplation. Once again, he reveals himself to be a thinker who does not exalt the intellect at the expense of diminishing the role of the will in the life of grace and prayer.

If de la Taille rejects the thesis of a contemplative *intuitive* vision of God, he likewise discounts the suggestion that all intellection is excluded in passive prayer—an exaggeration, he writes, by those "most affective mystics" who are ill-disposed to analysis.[29] This question is of interest to de la Taille as an opportunity to spell out more carefully the dynamic between the intellect and love in contemplation. He paradoxically asserts, on the authority of many spiritual writers (especially John of the Cross), that contemplation is knowledge "sans savoir ce que c'est que l'on connaît." This is the case because, although it is the intelligence that knows, the knowledge is procured under a "borrowed light"—that is, borrowed from the light of the soul's desire, or, "more profoundly yet," from a light that is the union of the soul to uncreated Love. What sort of knowledge is this, a knowledge that emerges in this ecstatic light where the "central object is neither represented nor conceived"? The knowing of such contemplation

> is *suffered* (*subi*); it is felt (palpé); it is possessed, or better yet, possessing; it holds us in the grip of its hand, and carries one—*corps à corps*—to Life Eternal, which is Himself.[30]

This description of contemplative knowing is remarkably corporeal. De la Taille's language suggests a spiritual knowledge that presses and ravishes the soul in a *tactile* way. It is a passive, suffered, but "learned ignorance"—the more learned as it is unknowing. The more the soul experiences divine transcendence the less she knows of the object of her knowing, and therefore the more she loves God for his very being: "and this is that divinely infused knowledge, which is the highest knowledge."[31]

29. "Théories," 315–16.
30. "Théories," 316.
31. Cf. de la Taille's short piece on Thérèse Hélène Higginson, in which he provides a

On this topic of a *suffered* knowledge, de la Taille invokes "our teacher" [Thomas]. When Thomas addresses the passions and their "locus" in the soul, he explains what Denys the pseudo-Areopagite meant in writing that his teacher, Bishop Hierotheus, was instructed in a godlike way, that is, in such a way that he "suffered" divine things (cf. *Divine Names* II.9).[32] For Thomas, this *patiens divina* indicates an affection "towards things divine" and a "union of love" with them. In fact, Thomas goes further and suggests that it is loving *passio* or desire itself that instructs: "*Ex ipsa enim divinorum affectione provenit manifestatio eorumdem.*"[33] De la Taille thus desires to claim that contemplative knowledge is surely not nothing, but rather an affective knowledge.

This affective knowledge, moreover, is suffered *in the love* the mystic possesses for God, and it is learned in the dark light of that union that is God's gift of himself. Such *scientia* is weighted, "proportioned" to the desire that bears it.[34] What theology, de la Taille asks, is better matched to its subject than this contemplative knowing? In this school, where love and knowledge are always companioned, the soul is taught by "the mysterious Love of which she is the student" and in a classroom of silence. In this silent instruction the soul experiences a "denuding of every false notion of knowing," an exposure of every idolatry, all in and by the "unique embrace of the Friend." De la Taille concedes that mystics will portray this affective knowledge of contemplation differently: some accentuating its emptiness, some its plenitude. But such variation is only a matter of temperament or circumstance. For in truth, he writes, the "plenitude is in the void (*vide*)" and "the void fills the plenitude"—a paradox engendered by love, since it is *by love* that the "caverns of the intellect" are both hollowed out and filled up. In a word then, de la Taille heralds contemplation as theology *par excellence*. There is no "higher lesson" than the possession of, the *passio* of, divine love.[35]

lengthy passage from her writing about the experience of spiritual marriage to the divine, an account that he finds thoroughly authentic; "Une mystique anglaise d'aujourdhui," 474–77.

32. *ST* Ia-IIae, q. 22, a. 3.

33. Thomas, *De Veri.* q. 26, a. 3, ad 18; "Théories," 316n17.

34. "Théories," 317.

35. "Théories," 317.

This reflection on the "suffered" knowledge of contemplation begs a thorny question that must surely emerge in a theology that conjoins eucharistic sacrifice and contemplation: namely, is there not an unavoidable tension between prayer that is active and involves the senses, for example the sacrifice of the Mass, and prayer that is passive—prayer that dislodges the senses and sense-knowledge, prayer that is, as it were, divine *action* upon the soul and its desire? We have no choice but to press this question if we are to go forward with an exposition of the relationship between Eucharist and contemplation in de la Taille. I suspect that de la Taille would have two responses to this perceived tension. First, he might remind us that love is the *activity* and measure of both ordinary and contemplative prayer. Love, the movement of *devotio,* is the central activity in the offering of the public, ritual sacrifice of the Eucharist. As we saw, this desire "measures" the fruit of the sacrifice and places itself in a position to be "operated" upon—purified—by the grace that comes through sacramental reception of the sanctified victim. Desire is comparably "active" in prayer. The soul's desire is in movement from the lowest to highest states of prayer, even in that perfect passive prayer of nuptial union where it offers the pure love of God Himself, perfected and divinized in Holy Spirit.

Alternatively, de la Taille would also point out the soul's passivity in the prayer of eucharistic sacrifice as well as in contemplation, such that both in the public liturgy and in contemplation the soul is passive to the divine operation. As we have seen, de la Taille envisions the altar of our earthly sacrifice to be contiguous, so to speak, to the ascetic altar of contemplation. In fact, the eucharistic sacrifice may well be for some that transitional stage of contemplative prayer explicated above. What prevents the translucent prayer of "holy souls" at the altar from becoming that liminal moment between ordinary prayer and passive prayer, when divinely infused love remains hidden to the worshipper?[36] Recall de la Taille's criteria for contemplation proper: a depth of awareness in the subject of being grasped, stunned, "taken" in the loving regard of the heart. This raises a question worthy of more reflection:

36. Cf. Clement of Alexandria's depiction in the next section of holy Christians praying the Eucharist.

what would a eucharistic sacrifice look like if more and more of its participants were to become highly conscious of their passivity before the divinely infused fire of God's love in the wonderful exchange of eucharistic sacrifice? Indeed, what more auspicious moment for the soul's self-will to be "carried away" than at the offering of the divine victim, or in the reception of the returned gift, which effects union to Christ and the whole Godhead? In any event, I think we may conclude with de la Taille that there is a point, perhaps in the "inferior" states of contemplation, where the "active"/"passive" distinction simply dissolves. At the very least, it becomes a moot issue when both human and divine desire are moving through the one praying. When the church is praying Christ's great prayer of offering to the Father, it is Christ's divine love pulsating through the worshippers. For de la Taille, this Christic desire is operative both in the church's Eucharist and in contemplation.

Contemplation and the Eucharistic Altar

In the course of this chapter, we have gestured toward an emerging analogy between contemplation and eucharistic sacrifice and union. We shall now attend directly to de la Taille's explicit evocation of this comparison. At a most basic level, the Eucharist—as the sacrament of *caritas*—cannot be incidental to the life of contemplation. In fact, de la Taille urges in *Contemplative Prayer* that children ought to receive the Eucharist at an early age because love "is the force which initiates the soul into contemplation."[37] But de la Taille's reflection on the rich and fruitful relationship between prayer and the Eucharist is more theologically profound. Before examining some revealing passages from *Mysterium Fidei,* I want to highlight the closing Christological reflections from "Théories mystiques," for they are preparatory for de la Taille's synthesis.

As he comes to the end of his extensive review essay, de la Taille

37. De la Taille defines "early age" as that point at which a child can "profit" abundantly from God's gift—at the age of "knowledge of God." His words are fully supportive of Pius X's efforts to bring children to the eucharistic banquet. Not surprisingly, de la Taille advocates the same early reception of the Holy Spirit (with his sevenfold gifts) in the sacrament of confirmation, for in contemplation the Holy Spirit plays upon this octave of gifts; see *CP,* 15.

applauds Dom Butler's hope that *Western Mysticism* might spark a desire among "young clergy" to read Bernard's *Commentary on the Song of Songs* (and in its "inimitable Latin"). His reasons for supporting Butler's wish are telling. In fact, de la Taille delivers here a striking *apologia* for his interlocking portrayal of contemplation and eucharistic sacrifice, and thus I quote the passage at length. Bernard's *Song of Songs* is critical reading because

> one finds there a taste of Jesus, and looks upon a precious lesson about the place that the incarnate Word occupies in the whole life of contemplation: He is the originator, the initiator, the mediator who takes us all the way to the Father, and who opens the eyes of the soul to the infinite repose of the Holy Trinity. It is his mysteries, the mysteries of his life and of his death, through which it is necessary to pass in order to arrive at the foretastes of eternity and glory. The Word in the flesh is also the Word within the Father, from which proceeds the Holy Spirit, the source of life in our souls. Nothing is more traditional than this view. For what did Clement of Alexandria intend by "epoptic contemplation"—knowledge of the divine Power and Essence—*if not union, spiritual as well as sacramental, to Christ?*[38]

De la Taille's train of thought here is clear: Bernard's contemplative writing is particularly attractive because indisputably Christocentric. Just as there is no grace but that which flows from the incarnate Word who became the Lamb of sacrifice, so too there is no contemplative or eucharistic union apart from the mystery of Christ's passion, apart from the human-divine gift who takes up the worshipper into the Father's presence.[39]

But should we require a more distinctive pronouncement than this reference to Bernard and Clement (to whom we shall return momentarily), de la Taille continues with an endorsement of Ignatius of Antioch's crystalline language about contemplative purgation, sacrifice,

38. "Théories," 323 (emphasis mine).

39. It is worth noting here that de la Taille's language about participating in Christ's mysteries—"It is his mysteries, the mysteries of his life and of his death, through which it is necessary to pass in order to arrive at the foretastes of eternity and glory"—bears strong resemblance to the language of Odo Casel, the German Benedictine of Maria Laach, whose liturgical theory of *Mysterientheologie* would greatly overshadow the work of de la Taille in the mid-twentieth century. Casel would claim that his understanding of mystery was founded in scripture and the early fathers (and not only in ancient mystery religions); perhaps de la Taille's reading of the fathers was orienting him in a similar direction of thought; cf. Casel, *Le Mystère du Culte dans le Christianisme* (Paris: Éditions du cerf, 1945), or Casel, *The Mystery of Christian Worship and Other Writings*, trans. I. T. Hale (Westminster, Md.: The Newman Press, 1962).

and eucharistic union. He cites Ignatius's Letter to the Trallians, in which the faith and love necessary for contemplative union are connected to the Eucharist: "Refresh yourself in faith, which is the flesh of the Lord, and in charity, which is the blood of Jesus Christ (*Tral.* 8.2)."[40] More pointed yet is the well-known passage from the bishop's Letter to the Romans. Ignatius memorably describes the sacrificial purification of his desire ("every passion is crucified in me; there is no longer any fire of earthly desire in me"), an ascetic purgation that now grants him a pure desire for perfect union to Christ: "'I desire the Bread of God, which is the flesh of Christ, son of David, and for drink I desire the blood of Jesus Christ, which is immortal charity.'"[41] De la Taille attributes this "divine wisdom" to Ignatius's activity of longing prayer. Ascetic prayer is linked to the cruciform purification of desire and the longing for eucharistic union to Christ. Ignatius articulates this layered theological vision in a way that looks forward to Bernard's work and backward to Paul.[42] What is the common thread uniting the vision of these three Christian thinkers? De la Taille delineates a shared twofold theme that includes a contemplative piety "*concentrée sur le Christ*" and a spiritual theology in which ascetic prayer and the Eucharist coalesce.

These important Christocentric comments in "Théories mystique" provide an interpretive lens to several passages in *Mysterium Fidei* where, drawing upon the early church fathers, de la Taille forges a connection between prayer, sacrifice, and eucharistic union. As mentioned earlier, *Mysterium Fidei* does not provide an Elucidation solely devoted to contemplation and its relationship to the Eucharist. This fact alone may indicate de la Taille's seamless vision of the activity of prayer, sacrificial offering, and eucharistic reception. In any event, the patristic passages on prayer and sacrifice in *Mysterium Fidei* make clear his synthetic thought. I shall draw attention to only two illuminating examples, one that engages the words of Clement of Alexandria and the other that sets on display the mind of the Cappadocian Gregory of Nazianzus.

40. "Théories," 323–24.

41. *Romans* 7:2ff; "Théories," 324.

42. De la Taille recognizes that Paul "says it all" in one short phrase: "My life is Christ"; "Théories," 324.

De la Taille examines Clement's writing on the Eucharist and contemplation at a particularly rich moment in book 2, one laced with references both to eucharistic sacrifice and prayer—the prayer of the liturgy, meditation on the Word, and elevated contemplation. In this particular Elucidation (XVIII), de la Taille has two objectives: to demonstrate that the earliest fathers of the church understood the ecclesiastical sacrifice to be an offering of the body and blood of Christ (and not simply an offering of prayer, or an offering of bread and wine),[43] and to show that the worshipper's offering is joined to Christ's in the prayer of the church. Clement of Alexandria figures centrally in this Elucidation, and de la Taille's enjoyment in exposing Clement's thought on contemplation and the Eucharist is palpable. Weaving together several excerpts from Clement's work, he traces two significant ideas: (1) that the church's eucharistic action includes a prayer that is external (oral action) and internal (the prayer of those willingly vulnerable to God); and (2) that union with Christ by contemplation and by the Eucharist are not divisible, for both are "won" *pro nobis* by the same sacrifice.

We shall treat first the external and internal aspects of eucharistic action. De la Taille contends that for Clement (and for many other early fathers, including Justin and Irenaeus), "prayer" and "sacrifice" were frequently synonymous, or at the very least, interchangeable. The following passage from *Stromata* 7.6 situates de la Taille's own concept about ideal purification *for* eucharistic praying and the purification *of* such prayer. Clement here speaks eloquently of an inner transparency of desire that is brought before God at the altar of sacrifice:

43. I have referred in chapter 2 to de la Taille's well-supported interpretation of key passages from Ignatius, Origen, Justin, Irenaeus, and Clement, in which he argues that the eucharistic sacrifice (the sacrificial action) is understood as the prayer of community (which includes the consecratory words over the bread and wine) and that the *sacrifice offered* (understood in a passive sense, i.e., of the thing offered) is the body and blood of Christ—who is the sacrifice. The sacrificial action and the sacrifice are not two distinct things: the prayer that gives thanks and praise and that contains the words that "make" the sacrifice is also the oblation.

De la Taille's interpretations stand in opposition to the work of Robert Daly, S.J., whose study of many of the same passages concludes differently. For example, Daly contends that Justin's notion of sacrifice is "primarily the spiritualized sacrifice of prayer"—without any clear indication of a ritual action over the bread and wine or of an offering of the body and blood of Christ; compare Daly's *Origins of the Christian Doctrine of Sacrifice,* 87–90, to *MF* 2:60–64. Similarly, when Daly treats Clement of Alexandria, he is less likely than de la Taille to grant that Clement, especially in passages from *Stromata* 7.6, has the Eucharist "in mind at all"; Daly, *Origins,* 118.

> The altar, therefore, which is with us here on earth, *is the congregation of those who are devoted to prayer,* having one voice and one mind, so to speak.… For the sacrifice of the church is the prayer which is breathed by holy souls, when sacrifice, and at the same time *our whole mind, is exhibited to God.*[44]

De la Taille underscores the essential link between the offering of the body and blood of Christ and the voluntary nudity of soul before God, a conjoined oblation made possible by the Christ-bestowed "internal sanctity" of the church. To step into the action of the eucharistic sacrifice is, as it were, to place oneself willingly in the procession of prayer to the altar—with its risks, its graces, and its ascetic demands.

The reality of this connection between the worship of prayer and the eucharistic altar is crucial. Contemplation, a metaphoric immolation to God of the believer's desire,[45] and the worship of liturgical prayer is possible only because of the perfectly "spiritual worship" of Jesus. Jesus's sacrificial worship was perfectly pure and spiritual: pure because of his unmitigated *devotio* and divine power, and spiritual because only the eyes of faith would be able to see the "divine things offered beneath the sensible signs"—that is, only faith recognizes that Christ is priest, altar, and victim in the offering of bread and wine at the supper.[46] In the sensible earthly worship, beholden to the limits of human nature and means, priest, altar, and victim are different, necessarily distinct. If the perfect sacrifice is defined by an identity of altar, victim, and priest, ecclesial offering necessarily falls far short. Still, de la Taille insists that earthly worship can be (imperfectly) pure and efficacious, for, carried out "according to the divine power of God," it transcends "the whole order and differentiation of sensible things"—and perhaps, we could

44. *MF* 2:75, emphasis mine. De la Taille provides a remarkable citation from Tertullian's *Apologetics* 30, in which Tertullian vividly links prayer and sacrifice:

> I offer him a richer and a greater *victim,* the victim he himself demands, *prayer* from a pure flesh, from an innocent soul, inspired by the Holy Spirit, not grains of incense to the value of one *as,* or the sap dripping like tears from an Arabian tree, or the blood of a wretched ox.… And so let nails pierce us whose hand are outstretched to God; let us be hung on the cross, let fires lick our flesh … the Christian with the habit of prayer is ready for any torture.

De la Taille does not argue that this passage directly refers to the Eucharist, but he does note that Tertullian's words state what other fathers stress "over and over again," namely, "that the visible sacrifice avails nothing without the invisible sacrifice, *and the whole efficacy of the invisible sacrifice is found in prayer and the adoration of a devout soul*"; *MF* 2:68–69n1 (emphasis mine).

45. Cf. de la Taille's comments in *MF* 1:202.

46. *MF* 1:218; cf. *MF* 1:218n5.

add, the whole order of imperfect desire. Such sacramental privilege is granted by Christ's own worship, to which eucharistic sacrifice and contemplation are conjoined.

It seems, therefore, that Clement's depiction of the eucharistic altar *as* the congregation, the people who offer prayer with a transparency of soul and desire, is a liberty of worship (and language) possible only because the church's sacrifice is carried out in the divine power of Christ's pure offering. De la Taille's argument in chapter 3, that the ecclesial sacrifice depends upon Christ's *virtus,* holds here, as well. The language of tradition acknowledges a continuity between the ascetic practice of prayer, contemplation, and eucharistic sacrifice; tradition speaks of the "altar" of holy souls offering prayer; the fathers preach about the "priestly" immolation of unpurified desire to God at the Eucharist:[47] this marvelous conflation of the "distinct" things of earthly worship springs from the grace poured out by the acceptable offering of the Victim, a grace that intimately unites the pray-er to Christ.

Clement's second theological observation supplements what we have just proposed. Clement sees Christ and his sacrifice as "purchasing" for believers the opportunity to contemplate the divine things of God and, more, that feeding upon the Eucharist is the way that Christ imparts the mysteries of divinity. In a passage from *Stromata* 5 (§10), having suggested that Paul's reference to "milk for little ones" indicates a first instruction in the faith, Clement identifies the "solid food" as the Eucharist. It is the Eucharist that grants contemplation and an entrance into the realm of divine things:

> [F]ood [will be understood] as the contemplation of those fully initiated in the mysteries (*epoptica contemplatio*): the very flesh, I mean, and blood of the Word; that is, knowledge of the divine power and essence.… "Taste and see, for Christ is the Lord." *For it is thus that he imparts himself to those who are more spiritually partakers of this food:* namely when the soul nourishes herself.[48]

Christ provides in the Eucharist—at least for the more "spiritual" or purified souls, those who have progressed further in the discipline of

47. Our next chapter shall explore this further, directly addressing the question of a baptismal obligation to offer sacrifice, an obligation rising from a new participation in Christ's priesthood.

48. *MF* 2:83–84.

prayer—a fuller initiation into the mysteries of contemplative union. De la Taille accents that eucharistic eating is not simply the symbol of "spiritual eating which is done in a *living faith*"; rather, he urges that contemplation is *procured* by the eating of the body and blood (or by the desire for it).[49]

We have noted already that a deep appreciation of the Eastern fathers repeatedly surfaces in *Mysterium Fidei*. Here again, de la Taille manifests a predilection for Gregory of Nazianzus, and especially for Gregory's strong and "graphic" language about prayer and sacrifice. Two passages will highlight the Cappadocian's theological interlacing of contemplation and sacrifice. The first citation occurs in book 1 of *Mysterium Fidei,* at a point where de la Taille is reflecting on Christ as the eternal altar. In this oration by Gregory, he preaches in defiance of those who seek to expel him from the eucharistic altar and take away his bishopric. Gregory proclaims that the violence of his enemies cannot successfully drag him from the altar of sacrifice:

> What then? Will they forbid us their altars? Even so, I know of another altar, *and the altars which we now see are but the figures of it;* neither axe nor hand of man had been raised above that altar … all the activities round about that altar are spiritual, *one ascends to it by contemplation.* At this altar I will stand, upon it I shall make immolations pleasing to God.… The great David seems to be thinking of this altar, when he says: "I will go up to the altar of God, to God who giveth joy to my youth." No matter who he be, no one shall cast me out from this altar.[50]

These impassioned words from Gregory depict the church's eucharistic altar of sacrifice as intimately associated with that celestial altar upon which the pray-er makes "sacrifices" in contemplative prayer—and both altars are Christ. De la Taille applauds this theological analogy, along with Gregory's exhortation that believers immolate themselves to God upon the celestial altar.[51] Keeping one's gaze "fixed" upon that invisible altar is desirable even as the ecclesia offers at its earthly altars.

In a second set of passages, appearing later in volume 2 of *Myste-*

49. *MF* 2:76, 84. De la Taille acknowledges that some scholars deny that Clement is referring here to the Eucharist—even indirectly. Yet, he defends *textually* his own reading as the "more probable opinion"; cf. also our discussion in chapter 4 on the desire for the Eucharist as the possession already of its grace.

50. Gregory of Nazianzus, *Oratio,* 26.16; *MF* 1:225n18 (second emphasis mine).

51. *MF* 1:225; cf. *Or.* 26.16.

rium Fidei, Gregory of Nazianzus robustly states that prayer—at either altar—is a participation in the sufferings of Christ. Here de la Taille is invoking Gregory's distinctive articulations about the divinization of the worshipper within the action of offering sacrifice. He first cites Gregory's early work, *Invecta contra Julianum* and *Oratio* 4, where believers are named sharers in Christ's passion and divinity *by* their sacrifices.[52] Gregory's vision of this sharing/mingling/co-working is quite staggering. He proposes that the *passio* of suffering, both in contemplation and in eucharistic sacrifice, constitutes a sharing in that *passio* of the incarnate Son. In his autobiographical *Carmina,* Gregory affirms that Christians are "partners" in the incarnation of God and in his suffering *when* offering the eucharistic sacrifice (*Carm.* I.1.2.34). The believer's offering is, as it were, "mixed" with Christ's. When sick, Gregory laments that he can no longer mingle his prayer with the sufferings of Christ: "No longer do I lift up my hands to the holy sacrifices, taking my part in (*admixtus*) the dread sufferings of Christ."[53] For Gregory, then, even though the philosopher-ascetic can ascend to the heavenly altar of sacrifice in contemplation, the prayer of sacrifice at the earthly altar is not only integral to that immolation of contemplative sacrifice, but also makes one to be a sharer both in Christ's suffering and in his divinity.

Although de la Taille does not expand upon Gregory's theology of contemplation and theosis, I want to underscore two aspects of Gregory's thought that vitally supplement de la Taille's project—and my own argument in this study. First, according to Gregory, the liturgical and sacramental life of the church is a parallel path to the contemplative, ascetic endeavor: in either, the Christian is purified and may ascend to union with the God-man, who descended that humans might be *deified*.[54] These are not two opposed paths to becoming godlike. Secondly,

52. *MF,* 240n1.

53. Gregory of Nazianzus, *Carm.* I, 2, sect. 1, poem 50, vv. 49–50; *MF,* 240n1.

54. While Gregory of Nazianzus often expresses a preference to withdraw from—indeed flee from—his active ministry in the church, so that he might again live the "deifying" life of an ascetic monk (e.g., *Oratio* 1.5; *Carm.* 1, 2, poem 10, v. 630 *passim*), he proclaims likewise an integrated vision of ecclesial sacramental life and ascetic-contemplative life. For instance, Gregory understands baptism and ordination as the beginning and facilitating of deification; see also *Or.* 39.13–14. Sharing in the priesthood of Christ, the priest is deified *and* deifying; see *Or.* 2. 22, 73.

if the altar is a "mystical table" leading the worshipper into the "mystery of deification" (*Or.* 25.2), the way to that altar—*baptism*—is central to the spiritual life. Throughout his orations, Gregory insists upon the significance of the initiatory rite of baptism: it purifies, deifies, and commences a life of Christic imitation.[55] I accentuate this feature of Gregory's sacramental thought because, as we shall see in the following chapter, de la Taille's own theory of eucharistic sacrifice is rooted in a vision of baptismal life that includes ascetic practice and prayer.

I have elucidated how de la Taille imagines the connection between prayer at the Eucharist, the purgative process of passive prayer, and the contemplative fruits of offering and receiving the Eucharist sacrifice. We have seen that Christ is the initiator of contemplation. His pure sacrifice and the spiritual food of his body and his blood procure the gifts of contemplation, taking the more purified into the very heart of the Trinity. Bringing forward the thought of Ignatius, Clement, and Gregory of Nazianzus, de la Taille discloses how the earthly altar of sacrifice is united to the heavenly spiritual altar and how the purgation of desire at one altar is related to immolation at the other. What secures this dynamism between liturgical, sensible worship and contemplative sacrifice? Christ secures it—and as priest and altar and victim. The oblative prayer of Christian worshippers is mingled with his pure and acceptable offering, so that their sacrifice might be both material and spiritual. Christ secures this relationship between ritual and contemplative sacrifice because, through his eucharistic flesh, he grants to the worshipper a taste of and for things divine, thereby exciting and purifying the desire for them.

To conclude these two chapters on contemplation, let us rehearse their central tenet: de la Taille casts the contemplative way as a purgative and sacrificial one. In the soul's movement toward union with God, a movement fired by desire, the ascetic battle against misdirected and unholy love is waged in a (frequently) long and painful process

See Norman Russell's discussion in *The Doctrine of Deification in the Greek Patristic Tradition* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004), 216–20.

55. See, for example, the Festal Orations, in Gregory of Nazianzus, *Selected Orations,* translated by Martha Vinson (Washington, D.C.: The Catholic University of America Press, 2003), 38–40; *Or.* 7.23; and *Or.* 14.23.

of oblation and purgation. This purification of desire only intensifies when progress in the virtues and charity reaches a human *finis,* and the soul awaits transition from ordinary to passive prayer (be it in this life or in the next purgatorial state). Recall how, with John of the Cross, de la Taille describes this purification in the light of faith and divine love as a *crucifying suspension,* a denuding of the self. We also witnessed de la Taille weaving his concept of "created actuation" into an understanding of the divine indwelling of contemplation, accenting the intimacy of union while preserving divine transcendence.

Finally, we illustrated how de la Taille's focus on Christ as altar, priest, and sacrificial victim is *the hinge,* the cardinal reality, that holds together these various threads of prayer, grace, and the Eucharist. The purgation of offering the eucharistic sacrifice, the purifying path of contemplation, the divinizing grace of eucharistic union, and the final states of passive prayer (the bridal union of the soul to God) are all are made possible and efficacious through the grace of the incarnate Word, through Christ who willingly became the pure oblation of desire. It remains for us now to examine more closely how the undertaking of purgative prayer is the *baptismal* obligation of all Christians. For de la Taille, baptism and the Eucharist constitute, respectively, the willing mortification of ungodly desire, and the enflamed desire for union with Christ and the participation of divine life. The next chapter provides evidence of de la Taille's competency as a scholar of mystical theology, while also displaying his unique theological integration of contemplation and eucharistic sacrifice.

9 Baptismal Mortification and the Eucharist

In this final chapter, the threads of this study converge under the *topos* of baptism, the sacrament that, for de la Taille, decisively orients the Christian to the ritual offering of sacrifice and to the reception of the eucharistic gifts of divine life and union. We have just seen that the contemplative places herself *willingly* in the path of purgative prayer, to the end that her desire for the divine beloved may be ever more purified. In de la Taille's theology, the continual mortification of disordered love falls under the purview of baptismal profession, for contemplative and non-contemplative alike.

Recall that we showed in chapter 5 how all sacramental grace hangs upon a desire for the Eucharist, from which flows—through the sacrificial Lamb—every healing, elevating, and unitive grace. This dynamic of desire and dependence is especially and most illustriously true of the ordering of baptism to the Eucharist. We shall thus conclude our presentation of de la Taille's thought on eucharistic sacrifice by elaborating a critical theological comparison: de la Taille aligns baptism with death, with the mortification of desires (through ascetic prayer and practice), with the cross, and with priestly oblation and sacrifice, whereas he positions life, grace, union, peace, and purified love under the fruits of the eucharistic banquet. What connects these two lines of parallel realities is desire, the movement of the will's affection. As we shall see, de la Taille argues that no one undergoes baptism, no one enters the way of

ascetic prayer or offers sacrifice, *apart from* a desire for the Eucharist and its divinizing union to God.

Our central task then is to delineate the dynamic of desire between baptism and the Eucharist, underscoring how baptism is necessarily *generative* of sacrifice and mortification. There are two primary sources for our analysis here: a lengthy and rich section of *Mysterium Fidei* (Liber III), which details the relationship between baptism and the Eucharist, and an address entitled "The Eucharist and Mortification," a lecture given by de la Taille at the 1924 International Eucharistic Congress in Amsterdam.[1] I shall begin with a discussion of how de la Taille casts the relationship between the two sacraments of baptism and Eucharist, a relationship based upon the signification operative in each sacrament and upon a movement of desire within the believer. De la Taille's explication of the sacramental *character* of baptism is particularly significant, for it is baptismal character that initiates the faithful into the sacrificial and oblative activity of Christ. This discussion of *character* prepares the way for de la Taille's congress address, in which he sharply spells out the salient interfacing of baptismal mortification and the Eucharist.

"Baptismus ad Eucharistiam"

In the third part of *Mysterium Fidei,* after having established that the primary effect of eucharistic grace is incorporation to Christ and his body, the church, de la Taille raises the question of the sacramental effect of baptism. Is it not also the case that the principal effect of baptism, like that of the Eucharist, is incorporation? If so, could it not be argued that they are essentially one sacrament? An identity of efficacy in the two sacraments would likewise indicate an identity of *signification.*[2] De la Taille entertains this legitimate "objection" in order to devote significant resources (and a good many printed pages) to exploring the "profound mutual relationship" between these two distinct sacraments. The discussion here captures a theologically potent moment in the whole of de la

1. The address "The Eucharist and Mortification" was translated from the Latin and included in de la Taille, *The Mystery of Faith and Human Opinion: Contrasted and Defined* (London: Sheed and Ward, 1930), 407–19. Hereafter, I shall cite the essay as "EM."

2. *MF,* 557.

Taille's *Mysterium Fidei*. Two critical aspects of his sacramental theology surface with clarity: the reader learns that baptism is integral to sacrifice and, for the first time, hears a distinctive articulation of a theology of desire—operative in the sacraments and in the economy of the spiritual life *in toto*. De la Taille's response to the mistakenly perceived conflation of baptism and Eucharist thus warrants careful attention.

De la Taille begins by denying that the incorporation effected by these two sacraments is either "procured" or "signified" in the same way. We are asked to recall, in the first place, that the Eucharist, through the apt sign of a meal, signifies "*in itself (per seipsam)*" incorporation to life, to "an existence in the vital and living body of Christ."[3] Baptism, on the other hand, signifies union to this life only "*through its intrinsic ordering to the Eucharist,*" or, put differently, in a secondary or oblique way. De la Taille suggests that baptism be understood as possessing a double signification. First and foremost, and "by act," baptism signifies *death*. This death is *directly* signified: the sacrament shows forth the death of the first Adam, which is the life of sin, just as Christ "died on the cross to a corruptible and passable life, bearing the likeness of sinful flesh." While Christ endured a real death in the likeness of sinful flesh, those to be initiated, who are held by the reality of a sinful flesh, endure a death in similitude. "Buried" by the "flood waters" of baptism, the believer dies and is entombed with Christ.[4]

Yet if death is the direct signification of baptism, baptism also signifies life—*indirectly* and "by intention." For in baptism, we do not die

3. *MF,* 557; cf. chapter 4 for the details about eucharistic signification.

4. *MF,* 557–58. In two different footnotes, de la Taille takes up the following objections: (1) that our resurrection to new life is the primary symbol of baptism, and (2) that burial is only represented in baptism by immersion—but not through infusion or aspersion. To the first, de la Taille grants that many fathers "unfolded" symbolic meaning in the emergence from the baptismal waters; he contends, however, that this emergence is not itself properly "sacramental"—i.e., it is not *essential* to the signification of baptism. The very source of this teaching is Romans 6, about which Suarez definitively states: "In Romans 6, *only the sepulcher* is said to be *properly and formally* represented through baptism; the resurrection is represented only *consequentially*, insofar as that death *is ordered to it, so that* we might walk in the newness of life"; Suarez, *De baptismo,* disp. 20.s.7), in *MF,* 557n3. De la Taille likewise discounts the objection that burial is only represented in baptism by immersion. Here, Thomas and Chrysostom are cited as *auctorites*. In *ST* III, q. 66, a. 7, ad 2, Thomas writes: "In whatever way the ablution happens, the body of a man, or *some part* of him, is put under water, just as Christ's body was placed under the earth." And before Thomas, Chrysostom had also answered the question eloquently: "For as the head

"any death whatsoever," we are not baptized into some anonymous death. Rather, we die the death of Christ, a death taken up "for the purpose of changing corruptible life into incorruptible life":

> Therefore the true Priest, Christ the Lord, dedicated to God through death his holy and expiating gift—the lamb of God who takes away the sins of the world—so that it might be raised to glory by God, the sacrifice consummated. By that death there is only the *transitus* into life; for it is the passover of the Lord. And so also our baptismal death, implanted in the death of Christ, is nothing but the way to life, that life which Christ lives in God.[5]

In other words, one is conformed in baptism to a death that is itself intrinsically ordered to life. If baptism according to its own "demonstrative power" signifies death, its "co-symbol (*consignificatio*)" is the desire for life. In a critical simile, de la Taille purports that the designation of death, accompanied by the intimation of a "coming forth" of life, is like sacrificial oblation: for *the act of offering sacrifice marks the beginning of its reception,* in which the consummated victim is returned to the participants, bestowing heavenly gifts.[6] Here we have the first striking indication of a vital alliance between baptism and sacrifice. Baptism and sacrificial oblation are both signs of death, but they are both oriented to divine life and perfected in the fruits of the Eucharist.

Before explicitly treating this alliance, I want to convey the tenor of de la Taille's writing on this subject. Half apologetically, he "heaps up" a number of patristic authorities, eager to display the spiritual wealth behind the twofold signifying reality of baptism: death, in the first place, conjoined to wished-for life, or mortification and the beginning of vivification.[7] He notes upfront that these "authorities" stand upon Paul's own theology in Romans 6:2–10, which delineates a baptism into Christ's death, a burial with him so that the "old body" of sin might be destroyed. This death and burial are both aimed at life with Christ.[8]

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is dipped in water, immersing us in a tomb, so the old man is entirely buried or cast down"; *In Joan.* hom. 25.2; *MF,* 558n1.

5. *MF,* 558.

6. *MF,* 558.

7. Cf. *MF,* 561: "Excusatum me habeat lector, quod tantas congero auctoritates, ut Augustini, ita aliorum Patrum."

8. De la Taille provides a passage from Chrysostom's *Commentary on Romans* (*P.G.* 60, 480), which dramatically links baptism and the cross: "What did [Paul] intend by the words *We are baptised into that death of His?* The meaning is that we are to be among the dead, just as he was

However, it is the passage from 1 Pet 3:21–4:2, underscored earlier in this study, to which de la Taille again turns. Baptismal death is endured so that one might live "*not for the desires of men, but for the will of God,*" living unto God "according to justice" and with a "*good conscience*." This passage from 1 Peter suggests that the sacramental rite by which "we are conjoined to Christ's passion" is the petition for, the longing for, a life of pure desire before God, a longing fulfilled in sharing the resurrected life of Christ. It is "not surprising (*non mirum*)," de la Taille writes, that "our death thus offered in the death of Christ" is the desire for life, because "every sacrificial offering is a prayer for divine consummation, and the consummation of an acceptable gift is life in the presence of God."[9] Powerfully then, baptismal death is aimed at the offering and immolation of ungodly desire, so that the desire for life with God may be primary—and realized.

We can address only two of the more significant patristic passages from the "heap" of sources collected by de la Taille, both of which clearly indicate a distinction-in-connection between the double signification of mortification and new life in baptism. First, we hear from Zeno of Verona, whose enflamed language vividly portrays the death of baptism:

> O great power, great knowledge, great love that judges us!—to which the whole race of sinners *hastens to be chastised so that they might live in blessed happiness*. For the merciful sword [of baptism] descends into the bowels of the sinner and in one and the same stroke, with the material of the body remaining unharmed, it slays the old man and creates the new, and buries the old in the element of the sacred waters.… O necessary damnation! Man *is slain, that he might live!*[10]

If Zeno highlights that baptism is a violent—though merciful—chastisement oriented to life, de la Taille also cites the more familiar words of Basil (*De Spiritu sanctu* 15.35), words that underscore the necessity of death prior to the life-giving work of the Spirit. For Basil, there is no baptismal newness of life without the definitive *interruption* of a previous, sinful life. To be buried with Christ clearly intends the "end" and "destruction" of a prior life so that a new one may emerge:

also. *For the cross is baptism* (σταυρὸς γάρ ἐστι τὸ βάπισμα). Thus, what the cross and sepulcher was for Christ, baptism is that for us—even if they are not the same things in reality; for he died and was buried in his very flesh, whereas we died and were buried in sin"; *MF,* 559n4 (emphasis mine).

9. *MF,* 559.

10. Zeno of Verona, *Tractatus* 2, tract. 39–42; *MF*, 560.

> Thus there are two ends proposed by baptism: namely, that the body of sin be destroyed, lest it later bear the fruit of death, and then that it be vivified by the Spirit, and bear fruit in holiness. The water exhibits the image of death, the body, as it were, being received into the tomb. But the Spirit sends forth vivifying life, renewing our souls from the death of sin into pristine life. This is what it means to be born *from water and the Spirit.* Indeed, *because* death is accomplished in the water, the Spirit thus effects our new life.[11]

We can readily discern what de la Taille accomplishes in bringing forward these and similar passages from the fathers. Through an accumulation of witnesses, he demonstrates a strictly ordered, twofold signification of baptism: life, resurrection, and union in Christ are *consequent to* the mortification directly and primordially signified in baptism. Near the end of his discussion, he summarizes that the tradition "distinguishes," though not always with rigor, between what is "induced by the baptismal rite itself, that is, death, and that which enters from another direction, namely, life from the Spirit."[12] In truth, baptism is "set towards" mystical death, mystical immolation, penance, the cross, and the tomb—*from which* the "new man" emerges.

To this point, we have allowed de la Taille to enunciate a baptismal theology that aligns baptism with death and sacrificial offering. We have seen how he underscores the direct and principal signification of baptism: death and the mortification of desire. But he does so without divorcing the secondary, indirect signification of baptism—life unto God, a life of "good conscience," of purified desire. Yet de la Taille pushes the reader further. In an effort to disclose the full import of the relationship between the dual signs of baptism and between the rite of baptism and the Eucharist, he analyzes the sacraments in terms of cause and efficacy.

Because sacraments also cause what they signify, de la Taille pushes the question of causal efficacy in regard to the double signification of

11. *ME,* 562; emphasis mine.

12. *ME,* 563. A too literal reading of this distinction would err in surmising that the Spirit is not also engaged in the "first" act or signification of baptism—that of the slaying of the sinful creature. We shall return to this interesting question momentarily, when the theology of Sarah Coakley is engaged. In the meantime, recall that de la Taille sees the Spirit operative in the sacrificial oblation of Christ at the Last Supper (see chapter 2); thus, one would suppose the Spirit to be present and active as well in the believer's baptismal offering of the death of sinful flesh and desire.

baptism: can we say that baptism causes *both* death and life? To be sure, there is nothing surprising about the suggestion that baptism in fact occasions death, for burial is clearly represented.[13] But how does baptism, through an "indirect" sign, also effect new life? His answer to this question takes us into the heart of his theology of desire. Baptism can cause life because baptism specifically *desires* the life of the eucharistic banquet, desires that vivification that comes from a participation in the sanctified victim. Now, to desire that life is already to possess it in some measure: "there is no death without the desire for life and there is no desire for life which entirely lacks life (non sine appetitu vitae mors, non appetitus vitae sine vita)."[14] De la Taille unfolds this principle of desire with rich detail.

We have already noted that the death of baptism is ordered to life, since it is an imitation of Christ's passion and transitus to life and glory in the Father's presence. De la Taille proposes something more specific, namely, that baptismal mortification is "taken on (*assumitur*)" not as an end in itself, but on account of the life of Eucharist. Eucharistic vivification, he writes, perfects baptism and "belongs to those who have already come to know what it means to die."[15] But is it indeed the case that every baptism into the death of Christ is received with a longing for the Eucharist? It must be so, de la Taille confirms, because baptism—"unless it be false"—is administered "according to the desire of faith (*secundum intentionem fidei*)." This desire of the Christian faith seeks for that death that "exists in order to obtain life, the communication of which is the proper fruit of the Eucharist."[16] We are reminded again of the reciprocal ordering that marks Thomas's theology, this time applied by de la Taille to the dynamic of desire between baptism

13. *MF,* 558.

14. *MF,* 558.

15. *MF,* 564.

16. *MF,* 566. De la Taille does not ignore the question of desire in infant baptism. Doubtless, infants are not capable of the desire, either elicited or actual, for the Eucharist in baptism. However, they can possess a "*habitual* desire" for this life. For adults, there is both elicited and actual desire, as they express their desire *in actu.* By their desire for and their submission to the sacramental rite, they consent to its signification and publicly declare an intention to conform their desire to the faith of the church. Infants, on the other hand, are said to desire the Eucharist *by* the faith of the church, which orders death to life. They can "conform" to this faith only by a habit. Indeed, since baptism effects what it signifies, it "imprints upon infants the habitual desire for the eucharist, by which they receive the fruit of the eucharist"; *MF,* 568; cf. *ST* III, q. 73, a. 3.

and the Eucharist. Baptism does signify and cause a desire for eucharistic life, but this it does through a "prior" desire for the Eucharist:

> Indeed, no man receives baptism unless he desires the Eucharist according to faith. To that point, the desire for the Eucharist is prior to the desire for baptism, just as St. Thomas believes: "Now the sacrament of Eucharist, although it be posterior to baptism in its being received [*understand*: sacramentally], it is nevertheless first in the order of desire" (*ST* III, q. 73, a. 5, ad 4). Therefore, no one would desire baptism unless she had already desired (in some way/*aliqualiter*) the Eucharist.[17]

The attractive and attracting power of eucharistic grace becomes increasingly evident in de la Taille's discussion of baptism and the Eucharist. This grace, which is union to Christ and a sharing in his divine life, is the efficient cause of all movement of desire toward divine life, and especially of the willingness to offer sacrifice. No life of graced union to God's divine life is embraced except through death.[18]

Yet none of this makes sense without an explication of the *efficacy* of this desire for the life of the Eucharist. Why is the desire itself for this life already a partial attainment of it? In fact, this basic principle of a theology of desire is applied in a preeminent way to the eucharistic food. A desire for the life of the Eucharist is a "movement of the mind and spirit towards the living flesh of Christ—the source of our life" and, just as any "genuine and powerful" movement toward life is already a "movement *of life*," so "Christ is not absent to those who fittingly move towards (*tendunt*) Christ."[19] The transformative power of the end desired is paramount: the good end changes into itself the desire for that end.[20] This reality of a theology of desire staggers. Look-

17. *MF,* 566.

18. Not surprisingly, de la Taille here notes Thomas's marvelous discussion of the role of desire in the justification of the sinner; *ST* Ia-IIae, q. 113, a. 5. Thomas argues that a sinner enters the life of grace only by some movement of the free will away from sin (hatred) and toward grace (desire): "It is necessary, therefore, that in the justification of the ungodly there be two movements of the free will: one by which it leans (*tendat*) toward the justice of God through desire, and the other, by which sin is detested"; *MF,* 564n1. The analogy here is salutary: the willing of baptismal death marks a movement away from the deathly life of sin and includes a movement of desire toward the life of grace in the Eucharist. In the unjustified, the will's movement away from sin also marks a movement of desire toward life in God's saving grace. In both cases, the double movement of *intentio* is requisite.

19. *MF,* 565 (emphasis mine).

20. De la Taille provides an informative footnote here, one that gives us an epistemological example of this principle: the human mind, which takes in concepts that exist outside of itself,

ing simply at its ramifications in terms of the desire for life present in every baptism, we must say that the desire is efficacious because any movement toward divine life—"which derives from Christ through his flesh"—is itself divine, transformed by him who is the terminus of that hunger.[21] For de la Taille, desire is not only the key to linking baptismal mortification and the life of divine union offered in the Eucharist, but also the key to understanding how baptism may be said to *effect* incorporation into Christ's divine life.

Tradition supports this notion of the operative power of the Eucharist in baptism. One of the more potent symbols of this sacramental dynamic is found in that common teaching of the fathers about the fittingness of Christ's baptism: the waters of the Jordan receive life-giving power from contact with the *flesh* of Christ. As an example of this baptismal-eucharistic reality, de la Taille cites Ephraem's verses on the baptism of Jesus. Here Ephraem portrays the Eucharist itself as the "leaven [*fermentum*]" of our baptism: "Behold, God mingled his leaven in the water. That leaven raises up those formed from the dust, and joins those beings to God. For the leaven of the Lord flowed into his servant and led him to freedom."[22] In other words, baptismal incorporation into

as it were, is thereby ennobled or defiled by that which it desires to know, for every "motion is specified by its terminus"; *MF,* 565n1.

21. "Sed motus sincerus et efficax in vitam jam est motus vitae; nec deest Christus iis qui in Christum debite tendunt: propterea quod bonitas finis transit in ipsam finis appetitionem"; *MF,* 565.

22. Ephraem, *Hymns on the Feast of the Epiphany,* 4.5–6; *MF,* 567. "Ecce Deus in aquis suum immiscuit fermentum. Istud fermentum attolit plasmatos e pulvere, eosque Deo coadunat. Fermentum enim Domini illapsum est in servum, eumque in libertatem adduxit." My translation is from the Latin, which de la Taille is reading from the Lamy edition (Syriac-Latin) of Ephraem's work. I am indebted to Syriac scholar James F. Coakley for the following translation of these two verses from the original language—a translation in which, I suspect, de la Taille would rejoice:

> Divinity has mixed its leaven in water;
> The leaven raises the dough of dust
> and causes it to mix with divinity.
>
> The leaven of the Lord, which can bubble up in the servant
> and raise him to freedom, has joined his servant
> to his family, that of the Lord.

Thomas, less poetically, also attributes the efficacy of baptismal water to the sanctifying power of Christ's flesh: "That it may touch the body and cleanse the heart, this power the water of baptism possesses by contact with the flesh of Christ (*ex tactu carnis Christi*)"; *In* IV Sent. D. 26, q. 2, a. 3, ad 1 and *MF,* 567–568.

the divine life of Christ happens *through* the eucharistic flesh of the Lord. We could transpose this truth into Augustinian imagery: just as the eucharistic bread changes us into Christ's body (we do not change the sacramental food into our own bodies), so the baptismal waters of the Jordan effected no change upon Christ's flesh, but rather were transformed, divinely empowered, by the presence of his body.

Indeed, de la Taille would argue that if baptism were "perfectly (*perfecte*)" desired, then one would "already eat spiritually the flesh of Christ and drink from the wound in his side."[23] We shall see presently, however, that baptism is but the critical *beginning* of a long purification of desire for the Eucharist and union to God. De la Taille does emphasize that baptism, though it be "the sacrament of death" vis-à-vis the sinful flesh of the old Adam, may nonetheless be called "*the sacrament of desire,*" particularly in regard to the "flesh of life" found in the new Adam, Christ.[24] Baptism and the Eucharist thus hang together tightly, baptism itself being "sacramental movement" toward the Eucharist, which in turn is the completion or end of baptismal mortification.[25] We conclude this section with these utterly transparent words about the sacrificial character of baptismal death as oriented to the Eucharist:

> For just as no immolation is celebrated except in view of its consummation, a consummation not approached apart from the sacrificed victim, so neither shall we be assimilated to the atoning death of the Lord unless it be for the end of our being conformed to this heavenly life. Through baptismal death we are united to the Lord's death and *make our own* the propitiation of his death for us, *so that* it may obtain for us union to the life-giving victim.[26]

The continuity and intentional identity between baptism and the offering of the eucharistic offering are clear. We now turn to a briefer discussion of baptismal character, the means through which the baptized are granted a participation in the sacrificial action of Christ.

23. *MF,* 566.

24. *MF,* 566 (emphasis mine).

25. It goes without saying, of course, that all of this makes for a potent theological argument in favor of administering the Eucharist immediately after baptism—even infant baptism. De la Taille does not draw this conclusion, but we have seen above (chapter 8) that he advocates early communion and confirmation in children.

26. *MF,* 565 (emphasis mine).

Baptismal Character and Interior Immolation

While according to de la Taille desire for union with the divine strictly conjoins baptism to the Eucharist, he illuminates a further connection in terms of the *res et sacramentum* of baptism, namely, in terms of the *character* of Christ's priesthood. We have already discussed above that the sign and reality of the Eucharist are the very body and blood of Christ—a sacramental reality most proper to the Eucharist, in which the "victim of salvation unites himself" to the believer so that she may have divine life in him.[27] But in baptism, the sacrament of the Lord's passion and death, it is enough that we are "touched" by the power of his passion. That is to say, between "those being mortified, and the one slain [Christ], no union *in esse* is required"; rather, it suffices that the death "pass from one to the other." Again, whereas it is fitting that in the Eucharist something sacred would be hidden and contained in the sacramental material of the bread and wine, nothing sacred need be held in the material element of baptism—"except as ordered to something else and in a passing way," as signifying the power of Christ's death. Unlike the material reality of the Eucharist received in communion, it is not the water that one receives in baptism, but the *res et sacramentum:*

> I mean, one receives the character of Christ, which is impressed upon us who, in baptism, profess to have received some share in the priesthood of Christ (in as much as it pertains to the priesthood of Christ that the death and immolation of Christ is offered to God, a death to which we are symbolically conjoined in the water).[28]

When speaking of the ecclesial sacrifice earlier in book 2 of *Mysterium Fidei,* de la Taille has already given witness to this traditional doctrine concerning the character of baptism as a participation in Christ's priesthood.[29] Here in book 3, he is focused on underlining the baptismal

27. De la Taille continues here: "There would not be a practical signification of this reality unless the flesh and blood of the victim himself were placed before us as something to eat and drink, or as something to be taken up within us (*intussusceptibilis*). For to participate in vivification requires union to the principle of life, in so far as it is union to the cause—formal and intrinsic, as it were." Put differently, the *res et sacramentum* of the Eucharist is the formal and intrinsic cause of our deification in sacramental eating; see *MF,* 570.

28. *MF,* 570.

29. Cf. *MF* 2:236 *passim;* also see chapter 3 in this volume.

signification and dynamic of receiving this priestly character. Articulated in Thomistic terms, the water and verbal formula of baptism do not effect grace directly; rather, they bestow the priestly character. The character, however, "immediately introduces, just as it immediately signifies, our spiritual immolation, which does happen through grace."[30] This is no minor point. De la Taille draws to the fore the baptismal reality of immolation in the sacrificial death of Christ. Baptismal character "indicates in us an *interior immolation* to God (in terms of an immolation of the life of sin, of the flesh, and of the death-dealing world, in order that we might live unto Christ through grace)." After all, de la Taille reminds us, every visible sacrifice is a sign or sacrament of an invisible sacrifice. Baptism thus inaugurates Christic life, impressing the priestly character that allows the believer, in grace, to offer his own interior immolation with the sacrificial death of Christ.

An epistolary passage from Fulgentius eloquently illumines de la Taille's theological insight about baptismal participation in the priestly death of Christ. Fulgentius is assuring the letter's recipient that baptism *begins* a participation in the one bread of the Eucharist. This is particularly so because the faithful are inserted in the sacrificial immolation of Christ at baptism:

> "Though we are many, we are one body in the one bread." When anyone begins to be a member of that one body, at that point one begins to participate in the one bread, because, *for any member, when joined in baptism to Christ the head, that one is already immolated to God in the living victim*.... Therefore, whoever becomes a member of the body of Christ, in what way does that one not receive what he himself becomes, when indeed that one becomes a true member of the body, the sacrament of which is in the sacrifice?[31]

De la Taille explicates two lines of thought from this passage. First, because one is inserted into the death of Christ at baptism, that mystical death also possesses an immolational and sacrificial character. Second, because baptism marks a union to the living and eternal sacrifice, the initiated are given a share in Christ's priesthood. Baptismal character thus allows the ecclesial sacrifice of Christ's body to be a true sign of the believer's interior immolation. In this next section, we shall see

30. *MF,* 570n2; cf. Thomas, *In* IV Sent. D. 26, q. 2, a. 3, ad 2.
31. Fulgentius, *Epist*. 12, 11, 26; *P.L*. 65, 392; *MF,* 569.

more explicitly how the whole of spiritual life, including prayer and ascetical practice, is a prolongation of baptism oriented to the eucharistic sacrifice, or, put differently, is an unfolding of the grace of Christ's priestly character.

The Eucharist and Mortification

In 1924, de la Taille addressed an international eucharistic congress in the city of Amsterdam. He opened his "instruction" by assuring his audience that he had no intention of engaging in speculation about "sublime and recondite" eucharistic questions. Rather, he announces that his aim is pastoral and practical, that he desires "to propose … a simple form of eucharistic life" derived from the church's genuine sources for spiritual improvement.[32] The substance of de la Taille's proposal caps the argument that has been mounting in the course of this study. His discourse on eucharistic spirituality patently weaves together the two threads of *sacrifice* (oblation, baptismal death, contemplation) and *sacrament* (grace, charity, divinizing union).

The point of departure for his lecture is taken from 1 Corinthians 9:27: "*I chastise my body and bring it into subjection*." Admittedly, de la Taille is not interested in a critical, contextual scholarly exegesis of this Pauline verse. He wishes instead to examine it in light of the sacrificial dynamic of eucharistic life. His exposition begins by alerting his hearers to the two central concepts contained in this verse. Paul is enunciating both (a) the mortification of the body, reflected in the words *I chastise my body,* and (b) the intrinsic end of that mortification, seen in the words *bring it into subjection*. His lecture first treats the mortification of the body, demonstrating how it is "bound up together" with the *offering* of the sacrifice. De la Taille then shows how the subjection of the flesh—or "its *adjustment to the spirit*"—is "traced back" to the *fruits* of the eucharistic banquet.[33] In what follows, I shall outline the salient features of this twofold explication, underscoring those elements that remarkably clarify our argument about the intersection of his theory of eucharistic sacrifice with the spiritual life of the baptized Christian.

32. "EM," 407.

33. "EM," 407.

Mortification and Sacrifice

De la Taille closely parses Paul's *I chastise my body,* noting first that the apostle does not say that he "bridles" or "checks" the passions of the flesh, but rather that he chastises (*castigare*) them. De la Taille argues that the former pair of words connotes a sort of restraint, or the "*resistance*" that falls under the "negative precepts of the law." *Castigo,* however, implies a sort of "*violence*" against natural ("and by no means dishonorable") human desires.[34] Chastisement indicates something contrary to, something "repugnant" and painful to, the appetites that move the will. Such action against desire is not, he specifies, an "obligation that presses upon us at every moment"—even though, as we shall soon hear, the baptized cannot escape it altogether.

De la Taille inquires more deeply into the motive, purpose, and method of such "aggression" against our desires. He contends that such chastising action presupposes "guilt" or "sin," and that it derives from a recognition of transgression—either of mortal sin "directed against that charity of God or of our neighbor," or of venial sin, the disordered desire by which one moves and chooses in a direction opposed to "what the pursuit of the last end commands."[35] De la Taille depicts disordered desire as striking against the spirit and "right reason." Within this state of warfare, the chastisement of which Paul speaks is that of a medicinal correction, the kind that aims at drawing nearer to the goal of the spiritual life: the "empire" of divine charity in the whole of the human being. In a word, the *finis* of the struggle is "the sweetness of peace."[36] What of the weapons employed by this chastisement? De la Taille acknowledges that such chastisement will "at certain times" be "afflictive punishment"; but it is to the "privative" form of chastisement that he devotes his attention. Privative chastisement is the withdrawal of things "*pleasurable,* though licit" from the senses and from the mind, all to the end "that there may be room for the sole *enjoyment* of God, loved in himself and for himself, above all gifts, whether bodily or spiritual, that are not God."[37] De

34. "EM," 408.
35. "EM," 409.
36. "EM," 409–10.
37. "EM," 411. John of the Cross, in a letter addressed to a prioress of a Carmelite monas-

la Taille's language potently echoes the sanjuanist dark night of contemplative purgation; he does not hesitate to name this mortification "the purest love of God." Such purgative and ascetic love can accomplish the spiritual progress that Paul invokes with the Corinthian verse, "I chastise my body and bring it into subjection."

Yet how does this privative chastisement of desire, fueled by love of God, converge upon the eucharistic sacrifice? De la Taille here articulates a crucial theological correlation, one less explicitly stated in *Mysterium Fidei*. In brief, he provides an account of how to understand the atoning, propitiatory nature of ecclesial oblation, while at the same time revealing how the ascetic practices of the baptized are absolutely integral to this communal sacrifice. In a fallen world, every Eucharist is an "atoning sacrifice" and bears the "sign of mortification," both represented and "pledged" to God. Recall what we have outlined at the beginning of this study about the nature of gift-giving between creatures and the all-Holy God: each gift *must* be accompanied by a sign of sorrow or regret. The offering of eucharistic sacrifice is, therefore, a sign, a sacrament, and a "vow" before God of "personal immolation." Sacrifice is the sign of a willingness "to undergo hardships" and to offer oneself "*in expiation*."[38] De la Taille calls upon Gregory the Great, that "Doctor of the spiritual life," for a description of penance and ascetic prayer practice as a kind of "sacrificial celebration." I quote the passage at length, for it captures well the spiritual dynamic of sacrifice envisioned by our author:

> Mindful of the eternal judgment, the saints daily immolate themselves to God as a sacrifice by the weeping and wailing of compunction. They, as foretold, chastise their bodies, and thus fulfill what is said by the Apostle to the Gentiles: *That you present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy, pleasing unto God* (Rom. 12:1). For a victim *is slain* that it might be offered. But a *living* victim is the body afflicted for the Lord: and it is called a *sacrifice* … because it is already dead to this world, being

tery in Cordoba, strictly cautions against the "discipline of the rod," a practice that has all but "expired" from the ferial Carmelite office (cf. Letter 13, *Collected Works,* 695). I suspect that de la Taille is attuned to John on this question, for he clearly recognizes that ascetic practice and contemplation "touch" the body with the purifying "rod" of the Spirit, and, often enough, with a cruciform suffering. (I am indebted to Sarah Coakley for directing my attention to this reference to afflictive punishment in John's letters.)

38. "EM," 411.

free from evil deeds; but a *living* one because with all the might at its disposal, it performs good deeds.[39]

De la Taille glosses Gregory's sacrificial metaphor as a positive reference to the church's eucharistic liturgy. Gregory teaches that penance and mortification coalesce in the offering of ecclesial sacrifice; indeed, propitiatory sacrifice *intends* this penance—internal and external.

Significantly, however, the theological *ratio* for this correlation is founded upon Christ's atoning sacrifice—the Lamb "slain for our salvation"—*and* upon a baptismal participation in that passion and death. In baptism, the believer has died in Christ *mystically,* but the sincere offering of eucharistic sacrifice (an obligatory act for the baptized) perpetuates the "very profession of baptism" *practically* (*pragmatice*). A ritual participation in baptismal death thereby radically commits the believer to a lifelong battle against disordered desire. The baptized accepts that a "mortification of the concupiscences" belongs to the reality of new life in Christ. In Christian sacrifice, then, the believer aligns herself "with Christ stripped, in death, of the likeness of sinful flesh."[40] To participate in the church's ritual oblation indicates an "amen" to disposing oneself for death and mortification: he or she offers sacrifice like a "true Christian" who is willing to suffer the slaying of inordinate appetites and the "crucifying"—to employ Pauline language—of that desire that yet resists the divine will.[41]

Yet again we are alerted to John of the Cross's influence upon de la Taille. John likens the long, sacrificial purgation of contemplation to baptism, suggesting that contemplation is the unfolding of a baptismal promise and grace. In the *Spiritual Canticle* (23.6), he vividly describes the relationship between contemplative espousal and the espousal of baptism. Baptismal espousal, "made on the cross," is accomplished "immediately" when God gives the first grace at baptism. Contemplative espousal, on the other hand, "bears reference to perfection" and is attained "gradually and by stages." Even so, John makes the remarkable statement that the two espousals are but *one.* De la Taille, I submit, preaches this sanjuanist vision of baptism and the sacrificial spiritual life. He would

39. Gregory the Great, *In Ezech* 1.2, Hom. 10.19, PL 76, 1069–70; "EM," 412.
40. "EM," 412.
41. "EM," 412–13.

clarify that all ascetic practices leading up to and disposing the believer to passive prayer fall within this baptismal-contemplative espousal, an espousal renewed as often as the eucharistic sacrifice is celebrated. To sum up what we have argued thus far, because baptism inserts the believer into Christ's propitiatory death, the Christian "contracts" the obligation to offer the ecclesial sacrifice and to immolate soul and body to God.

But de la Taille wishes to reveal a yet more profound theological truth: this chastisement of desire lacks full meaning and efficacy *apart from* the sacrificial oblation of the eucharistic liturgy. Ascetic practices acquire their "highest value" and "attain a liturgical dignity" in the eucharistic sacrifice. Concomitantly, they also invest the celebration with "truth and sincerity," giving it "fullness and perfection."[42] De la Taille carefully stipulates that nothing the believer does, whatever the chastising practices, can of themselves "wash away" sin and expiate guilt. However, when these practices are "laid with Christ upon the altar of sacrifice," when the purgations of prayer have been "grafted upon the atonement of our Head," when the mortification of desire has been mingled with the chalice of Christ's blood—changed like the water at Cana "into the wine of salvation"—then do they share in the liberating efficacy "that belongs to the Cross."[43]

We do well to pause at this rather astounding passage from de la Taille's lecture. He announces here a robust theoretical vision of how the whole spiritual life is oriented to and completed in the ecclesial offering of Lamb of sacrifice. Ascetical practices, the Christian's "pragmatic" promise in the ritual of baptism, are depicted as providing sincerity and authenticity to the ecclesial oblation. More, such practices, inefficacious alone, procure latreutic and expiatory power through their ritual participation in Christ's sacrificial offering. Spiritual mortifications, transformed by being united to the immolated and acceptable Victim—the gift that always "opens" the divine font of grace—cannot fail to have a bearing upon the flow of redeeming gifts from the

42. "EM," 413.

43. "EM," 414. De la Taille would have us remember that sacrificial oblations are made not simply for the reparation of our own sins, for the straightening of our own crookedly directed desires, but also, and "nobly," for the sins of others and the self-centered, unholy loves of the world.

source of salvation. We can revisit here de la Taille's impassioned plea in book 2 of *Mysterium Fidei* for an ecclesial sacrificial oblation that would be offered with such great *devotio* (enflamed hearts and pure lips) that the river of redeeming grace would flood all of humanity.[44] We are in a better position now to see how this affect, so fundamental in the dynamic of sacrifice, is caught up with the willing purgation of ungodly desire. The oblatory will is manifest in a whole set of ascetic disciplines, especially and including that vulnerability of passive prayer, as well as the liturgical practice of offering sacrifice. When these practices, fired by love, are brought nakedly to the altar of sacrifice, they are sanctified in being conjoined to the death of the pure Victim offered to God.

Eucharistic Banquet

To this point, we have attended to but half of the equation in de la Taille's discourse to the Eucharistic Congress. We turn now to his reflections on eucharistic *reception,* which he links to the second part of Paul's verse: "*and bring it into subjection.*" If the chastisement of worldly desire is integral to the offering of the sacrifice, how does de la Taille understand participation in the Eucharist—sacramental reception of the body and blood—as bearing upon this baptismally motivated oblation? In short, the fruits of the banquet operate upon the disordered appetites of the flesh and spirit, providing peace in the midst of the normal earthly warfare of bodily existence. De la Taille reminds his audience that eucharistic grace is, properly speaking, the union of the soul to Christ, and that this grace of union is maintained through a fervent bond of charity. The charity flowing from eucharistic union, a charity that mirrors God's own trinitarian love, is intended to so suffuse the believer as to promote an ordering of desire in the body and in the soul. Christ's grace in the Eucharist transformatively quells human desire, bestowing satiation and peace upon the soul. De la Taille specifies that these gifts of fulfillment and peace are "compatible with our human and earthly condition," which is to say that they remain but a shadow of what shall be enjoyed without peril of interruption "in our Father's home."[45]

44. *MF* 2:240–41.

45. "EM," 415. Our peace here below, de la Taille cautions, must be an "armed" one: the house-

Reiterating the sacrifice-as-gift dynamic that has occupied this study, de la Taille here elucidates that eucharistic nourishment and peace correspond in a significant measure to the "generosity" of the oblation, to the love with which the baptized offers his or her own mortifications, joined to the gift of the High Priest. The more ecstatic and pure the desire in offering of sacrifice, the more efficacious is the removal of every obstacle to the "inrush" of eucharistic grace.

> Therefore the Eucharist will bring the body into subjection so much the more, as it finds that body more perfectly adorned with the sacrificial marks of Christ, and more generously immolated, through mortification, as victim with Him. *He who soweth sparingly of that sacred and sacrificial wheat, shall also reap sparingly; and he who soweth in blessings, shall reap blessings* (2 Cor. 9:6).[46]

Once again, even though the sacrificial oblation of Christ is fully efficacious, the *devotio* of the worshipper at the ritual offering figures centrally in determining the power and richness of the banquet gifts received.

Above and beyond the "settling" or ordering of desires, the blessings of eucharistic reception can entail "delight." De la Taille describes this delight as a spiritual one "born of charity," "whereby the friend rejoices for the sake of his friend, and a son delights in the goodness of his father, a bride in the bridegroom's comeliness."[47] This fruit of eucharistic grace is a preparatory one, readying the believer for the beatitude of heaven. Not surprisingly, this delight is poured with increasing abundance upon those whose taste has become "estranged" to earthly delights by the "spice of mortification." In fact, de la Taille points to how the church's liturgy frequently enunciates this pattern of movement from earthly to heavenly delight: many post-Communion prayers directly petition that the received eucharistic food, which frees the communicants from earthly desires, might also *adapt* them to heavenly gifts. For the worshipper who has entered the sacrifice marked by the purifying practices of ongoing baptismal death, and marked as well by a vulnerable desire for God, eucharistic grace bestows with ever greater abundance a foretaste of eternal things and "*a thrill of divine life*."[48]

hold cleared of demons by Christ cannot grow "drowsy and slothful," lest "the foe return with sevenfold fury" and "tear down the structure … and abandon it to unclean spirits"; "EM," 415.

46. "EM," 415.

47. "EM," 416.

48. "EM," 416–17 (emphasis mine).

Two clarifications are important before I offer some concluding remarks. First, while de la Taille does not explicitly say to his audience at Amsterdam that the very offering of sacrifice is, in and of itself, purifying of desire, he nevertheless implies that this is so. Emphatically, he calls for an oblation *aware* of its baptismal promise to prolong an *imitatio* of the death of Christ. This disciplining of desire is an obligation that presses upon daily spiritual life only with unequal and intermittent force; nonetheless, de la Taille sees it as fundamentally one with the *devotio* of the ecclesial sacrifice. If this is so, then each time the believer participates in the sacrifice of the Mass, however generously or sparingly she offers, that oblation is being mingled with that one death that redeems all (minimal) efforts and failures of love. In the very activity of ecclesial offering, the worshipper's desire encounters that "sharp knife" of being adjoined to the perfect love of the Priest and Victim, which gift attains to the bosom of the Father. A refusal to participate in the ecclesial offering of sacrifice is analogous to a refusal to be touched by the cleansing baptismal waters, made efficacious by contact with Christ's own body. In baptism the believer is inserted into the purifying death of the Lord and thereby marked with the Christic character of priestly oblation. In the ecclesial offering of the only truly acceptable death and mortification, the believer similarly is marked by the very sacrificial Victim whose purity circumcises and transforms misshapen loves. She raises up that gift that converts impure desire into the holy image of the Son's desire for the Father.

The second and more involved clarification concerns the frequency of receiving the Eucharist, a question I postponed intentionally in chapter 5 in order to take it up in this more illuminating context. Recall that we showed in that earlier chapter how de la Taille defends the necessity of receiving the Eucharist, a position founded upon a theology of desire: one who sincerely desires the eucharistic grace of union to Christ does in fact receive that grace *in voto*.[49] I now wish to explore briefly why de la Taille proposes the necessity of frequent reception, a proposal elegantly interwoven with his thought on grace and the

49. A desire is deemed "sincere" and efficacious if, when the opportunity to receive sacramentally presents itself, one would hasten to receive.

movement of desire. His argument for frequent reception neatly corroborates the obligation of the baptized to offer sacrifice, even as it reveals how the ritual sacrificial banquet is absolutely integral to growth in grace and spiritual perfection.

De la Taille's treatment of the question begins with a reminder of the fact—"noticed by theologians everywhere"—that Jesus instituted this sacrament in the form of a common meal, so that by the sacramental signs of ordinary bread and wine a *repeated* partaking is indicated.[50] We have recently attested to the theological reality that the first grace of baptism is always received with a desire for the grace and life of the Eucharist. This desire is itself molded and shaped after the original form of the sacrament as a meal. Hence, one is justified not by "a once-for-all desire" for the Eucharist, but rather by a desire "to receive it again and again."[51]

But there is a second intrinsic reason the eucharistic banquet should be frequented often, a reason based upon utility (*utilitas*) and the necessity of growth in the spiritual life. From the eucharistic fountain "pours forth" both "first grace" and the *increase* of grace: "every sanctifying grace, which is the grace of union with Christ, flows from the Eucharist as from a proper cause."[52] To be sure, frequent reception of the Eucharist would be unnecessary if an increase of grace proved to be superfluous to the Christian *viator.* As it is, the necessity for Christian growth in grace aligns ineluctably with a repeated sacramental participation in the Eucharist. De la Taille's teaching unfolds in an instructive way. He attends to the weakness of human nature, while concentrating upon key principles of spiritual growth and desire.

Human nature itself dictates a lengthy process of perfection. Unlike angelic nature, "perfected at once from the beginning," humans are not complete at creation—either according to nature or according to grace. Rather, by divine ordination the human creature must "stretch forth toward his perfection little by little" and according to his "mixed

50. *MF,* 612.

51. *MF,* 612. De la Taille cites Thomas in support of this view (*ST* III, q. 80, a. 11, c). Moreover, he is quick to suggest that "incorporation to Christ" and "living communion" with the church "slips" when the believer does not receive the sacrament with a corporeal frequency.

52. *MF,* 612.

intelligence"—that is, discursively. This anthropology determines that the believer cannot escape the "law" of the human condition simply by a desire to do so. Indeed, this "law" dictates that the human moves with difficult and creeping progress toward perfection, being frequently subverted from the order of God. Only gradually (and never entirely) is that law "excised" by grace—and increased grace.[53]

De la Taille invokes more than one pertinent *auctoritas* to illuminate the need for increased grace and to advocate for the frequent reception of communion. He cites an extraordinary passage from Francis de Sales's *On the Love of God,* in which Francis insists that the Lord's words, "Be holy, because I am holy," are without ambiguity for the spiritual life:

> The words by which our Lord exhorts us to strive and stretch toward perfection are so strong and urgent that we can only lie to ourselves if we ignore the obligation we have to engage ourselves according to [that] design.… The one who is holy, let him be yet more sanctified; and he who is just, let that one be more justified! Be perfect, just as your Father in heaven is perfect.… In regard to spiritual goods, he has not sufficient who is satisfied with what is enough; and sufficiency is not sufficient, because true sufficiency in things divine consists partly in the desire for affluence.[54]

De la Taille highlights Francis's precept about continued growth in holiness, leading to longer reflection upon the notion of *increased desire,* or a desire for affluence in the love of God (a desire, I want point out, rhetorically aroused by this passage!). *Sincere* love, de la Taille enjoins, desires more love. In fact, one who "lacks" the desire for more love is deficient "in the beginning of love." When it comes to the *caritas* that flows from, and is enflamed by, the Eucharist, tepid or slumberous desire is culpable. More, if one's desire for an affluence of love ceases entirely, then that one is cut off from love and life. De la Taille permits Augustine the final and severe word: "Now if you would say *it is enough,* you have died."[55] Unless the believer is inclined toward progress and perfection in the spiritual life, the possibility of losing grace and charity lurks dangerously. On the other hand, a desire for the increase of love and holiness is a desire aimed at, and sustained by, the frequent reception of eucharistic grace.

53. *MF,* 612–13.
54. Francis de Sales, VIII.8, cf. 9; *MF,* 613.
55. Augustine, *Sermo* 169.xv.18; *MF,* 613.

A similar reason for the necessity of progress in grace takes seriously the "wounded" human condition and the consequent need for a *perseverance* granted only through grace. Because the wound of original sin is never erased completely from the soul of the *viator,* the believer's moral strength is not indomitable; rather, that strength will likely weaken or grow weary over time. Constancy (*constantia*), de la Taille submits, is the "most difficult and arduous" challenge in the spiritual life. A perpetual victory over the same evils and temptations would require the continual stirring-up and augmenting of love by the Holy Spirit. The grace of union to Christ in the Eucharist is needed "at each step," so that love may be extended throughout the soul, making whole and keeping intact its broken powers. In sum, the Eucharist is necessary for growth *and* for the protection of that new life.[56]

From the many traditional sources that de la Taille calls forth to corroborate the necessity of *repeated* eucharistic reception, we shall listen to a single historical witness, Rupert of Deutz. De la Taille rehearses Rupert's thought with obvious relish, an appeal, I would argue, rooted in the fact that Rupert's teaching discloses how the grace of the Eucharist "corrects" errant human desire. Two writings from Rupert's corpus, a passage from his *Commentary on the Gospel of John* and a section from *On the Victory of the Word of God,* are neatly overlapped. Rupert is here concerned to contrast the food of the tree of life with the food of the cross—that is, with the eucharistic banquet. In the Johannine commentary, Rupert is explicating Jesus's words "*Unless you eat my flesh and drink my blood, you shall not have life within you*" in terms of a physician's prescription of an herb or potion, an antidote against a specific illness. According to Rupert, Jesus is offering fallen humanity the opportunity to believe and to desire *in rectitude,* a reversal of what was falsely believed of, and wanted from, the deceiver. The Eucharist is provided from the cross

> so that [man] may eat the bread and drink that chalice of Christ with as much faith as he once ate with great infidelity the fruit of the tree of life, that he may believe about this [food] more than he can see; and, who from the Eucharist will be able to see more and will be able to be altogether more and something else—all of which he had not believed possible by any stretch of the imagination.[57]

56. *MF,* 613–14.
57. Rupert of Deutz, *In Joan.* VI, *P.L.* 169, 455; *MF,* 615–16.

If the tempter promises and excites desire for "a godlike" life through the eating of the fruit of the tree of life, with the eucharistic promise, Christ reorders that desire toward a truly divinizing and eternal banquet. A second passage, from *De Victoria Verbi Dei,* confirms that in the Eucharist Christ is testing the believer's faith in "what the eye cannot see"—namely, testing belief that his living flesh and blood *alone* communicates divinity. In this way, both the believer's faith and desire are found acceptable: a Christian believes in the words of Christ and longs for his flesh no less than Adam and Eve believed the words of the devil and illicitly craved the flesh of apple.[58] De la Taille's exposition of Rupert's thought concludes with the affirmation that it is through the eternal victim of the new supper, and therefore through the ecclesial *mysterium fidei,* that faith and desire are rightly exercised by, and directed to, the life-giving flesh and blood of the Eucharist. The Eucharist schools belief and desire; it is a lesson, as it were, that believers need to repeat frequently for the health and well-being of their faith and errant loves.

I have added these two clarifications—about the purifying action of eucharistic offering and the necessity of frequent sacramental reception—to exhibit fully de la Taille's thought about ongoing baptismal asceticism and the eucharistic sacrifice. He leaves us no possibility to imagine progress in the spiritual life apart from the altar of sacrifice and banquet. The baptismal obligation to offer sacrifice in the rite of the church, and to offer one's own mortifications along with the Victim, is counterpoised with the necessity of receiving from that sacrificial banquet the fruits of grace, fruits that promote and protect spiritual growth.

This final chapter has drawn together and articulated the distinguishing and defining characteristics of de la Taille's theory of eucharistic sacrifice. It now should be evident that his theory properly requires "thick description." De la Taille conflates the lifetime commitment to practices of baptismal death with the liturgical action of sacrifice and its concomitant theology of graced union to Christ. As we have sug-

58. Rupert of Deutz, *De victoria Verbi Dei* XII.13; *MF,* 616.

gested here and earlier in the book, contemplation, and the transformation of desire that occurs therein, is the destiny of all the baptized. Such purgation and transformation are a prolongation, both of baptism's mystical death and of its embedded desire for sanctifying grace, for the eucharistic food that intimately unites the believer to Christ. Baptism, ascetic practice, passive prayer, and the ritual sacrifice of the church: all of these actions (wondrously) inaugurate and enflame desire for the Eucharist—though, at the same time, they derive *responsively* from the divine life and grace that flow from that sacrificial banquet table.

Conclusion

De la Taille's early-twentieth-century work on eucharistic theology provides a new (and not new), forward-looking (and ancient) vision of sacrifice. *Mysterium Fidei* accomplishes this largely through a retrieval of biblical and patristic sources. But de la Taille also casts a discerning eye toward the best history-of-religions research available at the turn of the twentieth century and seeks an impressive integration of Thomistic thought, as well. His methodology aligns him closely and nascently to the spirit of *nouvelle théologie* emerging in the second quarter of the twentieth century—but not to the increasingly trenchant refusal of scholastic categories *tout court*.[1] As we have seen, de la Taille's work on grace demonstrates that he was a creative thinker deeply interested in questions about the supernatural, questions that would polarize theology in the 1940s and that perdure in these first decades of the twenty-first century.

I suggested at the opening of this study that contemporary eucharistic theologians portray a deep divide on the question of sacrifice, presenting two divergent tracks or approaches. The first approach is described as a magisterial teaching that yet articulates the church's theology of sacrifice in the language of Trent, employing scholastic categories and borrowing "misleading" categories from a history-of-religions ap-

1. In his article "Thomism and the Nouvelle Théologie" (*The Thomist* 64 [2000]: 1–19) Aidan Nichols highlights that some voices within the movement, J. Daniélou, for instance, suggested that Scholastic theology had reached an "obsolete" point in Christian thought (4–6). Such a sentiment is far beyond the letter and spirit of de la Taille's writing.

proach to sacrifice. In recent years, an emerging desire within the church for worship in the Tridentine rite seems to accord with this "official" vision of sacrifice. The second track, heralded by a majority of post-Vatican II theologians, rejects this earlier notion of sacrifice and desires to radically transform the theology of eucharistic sacrifice. In large part they renounce the temple-ritual denotation of sacrifice, along with its accompanying aspects of violence and propitiation, preferring instead to think of "sacrifice" in terms of an ethic of gift, of self-offering. These theologians tend to focus their attention both on "sacrifice" as the self-gift of God and on the transformation of the eucharistic worshippers—rather than attending to sacrifice as a human action directed to God and to the transformation of the bread and wine.

I have hoped to demonstrate that de la Taille's own mystical-theological synthesis leads a nuanced way through this perceived opposition. While he refuses (and rightly so, I think) to disown the ritual-liturgical context of sacrifice, he also argues that oblation—and not immolation—stands at the heart of sacrifice. At the same time, he proposes that sacrifice falls under the genus-definition of gift, thereby requiring a close exploration of the nature of gift-giving between creature and Creator. Critical to his endeavor is a careful parsing of the external-internal signifying function of the gift dynamic, emphasizing the necessity of an exterior sign of the soul's desire and longing for union with the divine. By way of conclusion, let me rehearse the six central aspects of de la Taille's thought, which define a viable third alternative for contemporary eucharistic theology. This alternative embraces a wide spectrum of the tradition.

First, de la Taille does indeed "spiritualize" sacrifice, but he does so *without* divesting sacrifice of its temple-ritual context. He engages the history-of-religions context (as does recent teaching from the Roman magisterium),[2] and, in fact, finds therein the central key to his theory: the distinction between oblation and immolation in sacrificial acts. De la Taille contends that oblation (and not destruction)—specifically an external, ritual offering—is the central and determining element of

2. See, for instance, John Paul II's *Ecclesia de Eucharistia* (2003).

sacrifice. However mundane this may sound to contemporary ears, his insight marked a decisive shift away from post-Tridentine immolationist theories. This delineation of oblation and immolation in sacrifice allows de la Taille to argue that the Last Supper and the cross are a *single* sacrifice: the priestly actions of Jesus with the bread and wine in the cenacle manifest the oblation of the sacrifice; his violent crucifixion represents the immolation of the sacrifice. The supper-oblation is fundamental for two principal reasons. First, it is the critical outward sign of Christ's interior *devotion,* that is, it is Christ tendering his gift to God. Here is the Son, voluntarily and with love, offering his death to the Father. We can recall that de la Taille leaned heavily upon the Eastern fathers to demonstrate the reality of this oblation at the supper. The priestly offering at the supper is important, secondly, as a *sign* of the believer's own intended mortification and of the conversion of desire from the worldly to the godly (1 Pet 3:18–4:1).

De la Taille's theology of eucharistic sacrifice is distinguished by the *modus oblationis* that, as it were, closes the impossible divide between Christ's sacrifice and that of the church, as well as the impossible divide between the Son's pure love of the Father and the believer's yet disordered desire for God. To exalt the act of oblation, giving primary place to Christ's words, his gestures, and the external manifestation of his will, bears distinctive theological fruit, the substance of which comprises the next two features of de la Taille's teaching.

Placing the theological accent on oblation provides a distinctive understanding of how the Mass is a "proper" sacrifice. Once theology ceases to look for immolation in the eucharistic liturgy and focuses instead upon oblation, a striking answer to the Tridentine conundrum of a "true and proper sacrifice" readily surfaces. De la Taille argues that the Mass is a sacrifice because, doing as Christ did at the Last Supper, and doing such through his power, the church offers a Victim to God. The signal difference between the supper and the Mass is that, unlike Christ's offering, when the victim was yet to be immolated, the church now offers a victim *already immolated.* Such a theory need not strain to discover in the Mass an (unbloody) immolation, though de la Taille is content to acknowledge that the separated species could signify a mys-

tic immolation; rather, the ritual offering of a *present* Victim already-slain suffices to constitute a sacrifice. The ecclesial sacrifice is one with Christ's sacrifice on account of a unity that exists between the realities being offered (*unitas ex parte rei oblatae*).

A second ramification of this emphasis on oblation underscores the role of the will in the offering of sacrifice, a concept that represents de la Taille's modern "subjective" turn. Attending to the movement of the will reveals the crucial dynamic between the external and internal action of sacrifice as gift-giving. In the early chapters of this study, we saw that de la Taille's sophisticated idea of sacrifice includes a salutary tension between the *external* sign of ritual sacrifice (a necessary component because, in fact, sacrifice belongs to the category of gift) and the *internal* reality (*res tantum*) of sacrifice—namely, the loving disposition to surrender or dedicate one's own will to the divine. Both are necessary for the integrity of sacrifice. Without the ritual sign of the gift being handed over into the possession of God, or without the accompanying *devotio* for this gift-giving, there is no sacrifice.[3] Rather boldly for his theological era, de la Taille also asserts that the truth and efficacy of this gift-giving correspond to the sincerity and desire of those offering the sacrifice. Not, however, that the redeeming power of the gift, already eternally accepted and infinitely efficacious, can ever be diminished; nor that the church's offering can ever be ineffi-

3. De la Taille's interest and emphasis upon the centrality of the *sign* is a feature of his thought that caught the attention of the twentieth-century English artist and poet David Jones. De la Taille's theology suggests that at the Last Supper Christ is not only sign-maker par excellence, but that he, the God-man, willingly "placed himself" in the order of signs: He placed himself in the order of signs, in the order of symbols, to have the joy of symbolizing, and by symbolizing it [his body], of building up the mystical Body of which we are members" (de la Taille, *Mystery of Faith and Human Opinion,* 212). That the very "goal and term" of all creation should himself become a sign and figure bespeaks a radical potentiality and nobility in human sign-making. To borrow the language of Catherine Pickstock, Christ's words and gestures at the Last Supper supply the truth and *esse* to all signs, allowing there to be "concelebrants" in that original and supplementing oblation-event; Pickstock, *After Writing,* 261–63. In other words, de la Taille's focus on the nature of sacrifice as sign and gift, and his theology of the intimate and signifying link between the rite of the Last Supper and the cross-immolation, prove generative of postmodern thought about signs and reality. Indeed, one could say that they lead the way to a theological alternative to deconstructionism. For a discussion of David Jones's indebtedness to de la Taille, see Rowan Williams, *Grace and Necessity: Reflections on Art and Love* (Harrisburg: Morehouse, 2005), 82–90; and John B. Breslin, S.J., "David Jones: The Shaping of a Poet's Mind," *Renascence* 38 (1986): 83–102.

cacious—since the sanctifying presence of the Holy Spirit never withdraws entirely. Even so, de la Taille establishes a clear subjective correlative: the *affect* of those offering the gift can limit or restrict the fruits flowing from the sacrifice. To be most theologically precise, although the whole church offers any eucharistic sacrifice, de la Taille attaches a vital significance to the individual worshipper's *devotio.* The believer's own affect impacts that of the *totius Ecclesiae* (which is *not* an unchanging reality). What makes the Monday morning Mass-sacrifice at a parish different from, or more efficacious than, the Mass celebrated on Thursday? The *intentio* of those offering—from the presiding priest and ministers, to the one who offered the stipend, to those assisting from the pew—constitutes the difference.

We come now to the fourth distinguishing feature of de la Taille's thought: this focus on the will and desire of those offering the sacrifice gestures toward the scope of his theology of sacrifice, one that encompasses the whole spiritual life of the baptized Christian. I have argued that grace, ascetic practice, and contemplative prayer are integral components to de la Taille's theology of sacrifice—integral, and held together by this theologian's understanding of human life as directed to union with the divine, directed to theosis. But this life with and in the divine, beginning with the sanctifying grace of God's intimate presence to the soul, is one of continual growth and maturation. Such in-process deification *needs* the eucharistic sacrifice and banquet. The Eucharist attracts; it is the believer's object of desire when grace and union with God are longed for. On the other hand, from baptism to the highest levels of contemplation, a purification and enflaming of desire for God are being effected in the *offering* of sacrifice. The eucharistic sacrifice is the site in which the promise of baptism (ongoing death in Christ) is repeatedly reenacted. It is the site in which ungodly desire is offered and purified in the oblation of the eternally accepted Victim.

Let us clarify further why this spiritual growth depends upon the eucharistic sacrifice. I want to address here the predominant concern in contemporary eucharistic theology about the connection between ethics and the Eucharist. De la Taille proposes that both the offering of the sacrifice (the obligation of the baptized) and the reception of the

Eucharist operate upon human desire; both are also the fountains of ascetic virtue and *caritas*. A believer may make a private promise to God to curtail an ungodly desire or behavior. A believer may give a dollar or two to the homeless woman sitting outside the subway station, judging her act to be one of charity or almsgiving. A believer may decide to fast on a certain day each week or pray the Liturgy of the Hours. A believer may, in the course of the day, stop and offer up a word of thanks and praise to God for the beauty of created life, or spend part of an hour in silent prayer. According to de la Taille, these are not sacrifices *proprie dictu,* though they certainly constitute praiseworthy acts of devotion, ascetic discipline, or virtue. However, when the smallest acts and efforts to direct one's life and love to God are lifted up and exhibited to God in the ecclesial sacrifice, when they are conjoined with *devotio* to the external ritual offering of Christ's sacrifice, then not only do they invest this ecclesial oblation with truth and sincerity, but they also are themselves transformed into "wine" and share in the liberating efficacy of the cross. In the church's oblation of the body and blood of Christ, those ascetic efforts (or mortifications, to use de la Taille's language) are transformed by the *end* they seek. There they claim their full significance and, along with the *devotio* of the one offering, they "determine" the efficacy of the fruits received in the sharing of the sacrificial banquet. Plainly said, all ethical and ascetic practice is oriented to the oblation of the eucharistic sacrifice.

Before moving to a fifth—and perhaps a more controversial—aspect of de la Taille's eucharistic theology, we need to reiterate the distinctive place that passive prayer holds in his overall vision of sacrifice and the spiritual life. De la Taille is rather unique in twentieth-century theology for his explicit conflation of the Eucharist and contemplation. Recall his assertion that all Christians are contemplatives-in-the-making. Prayer and desire of God *here* are on a continuum with the prayer and love of a purgatorial life after death, as the believer's soul is readied for the beatific vision. Contemplation, sacrifice, and eucharistic eating are integral to the purgatorial process of the spiritual life. De la Taille's sanjuanist writings on mystical theology present the passive purification of contemplation as analogous to the baptismal promise of mortification and

oblation; more, the practice of such prayer is portrayed as a pragmatic and real moment of the offering of love and desire in conjunction with Christ's own oblation. By the same token, union with the divine, which is the grace of contemplation, is likened to that intimate communion of grace and peace bestowed in the sacramental reception of the Eucharist. The food of contemplation and the food of the Eucharist thereby derive from the same source: the grace that flows from Christ, incarnate God and reconciling Lamb of sacrifice. As the worshipper at the eucharistic liturgy would not expect to enjoy the fruits of the sacrificial banquet without a participation in oblation, so the contemplative would no more expect to enjoy the fruits of communion with the Divine without the discipline, and indeed the risk, of passive prayer—that naked vulnerability in faith to God's fiery love.

Fifthly, then, we can enumerate de la Taille's distinctive treatment of the propitiatory nature of eucharistic oblation. The church's sacrifice, to be sure, is *latreutic*—giving thanks and praise and worship to the beginning and end of all things, to the holy and highest Good. Additionally, the church's oblation is a sacrifice of impetration, that is to say, on account of the infinitely acceptable gift that is being offered, worshippers may ask for particular blessings and favors, either for themselves or for others (living and dead). But it is the aspect of propitiation that meets with pointed contemporary rejection, even as the magisterium continues to speak in these terms. How does de la Taille's theory of sacrifice address this impasse?

I have suggested that it does so in a twofold way: first, through his analysis of sacrifice-as-gift in the context of human sin, and second, by his vision of eucharistic sacrifice in terms of the entire spiritual life and growth of the baptized. De la Taille's definition of sacrifice as belonging to the genus of gift demands that any *genuine* gift-giving to God from within the fallen world of humanity must bear a mark of sorrow, sorrow for the impurity of desire and lack of charity in the giver. Put differently, in a fallen world, any gift-theology without the sacrificial-propitiatory element stands incomplete. Without denying that the baptized are being made godly by a sharing in the eucharistic grace of Christ, that divinization must be acknowledged as *in via*. Thus the sac-

rificial worship of the pilgrim church will be marked by a penitential gift-giving—even as the individual Christian suffers purgation *on the way* to a contemplative bridal union with the triune God.

Concomitantly, we saw that receiving the graces of the Eucharist in this fallen (if redeemed) world is a possibility thoroughly entangled with the will to offer and undergo the mortification of desire. To such entanglement is the Christian mystically committed in baptism. For de la Taille, the oblation of eucharistic sacrifice aligns neatly with baptism and contemplation, both of which express the will to undergo, ever more completely, the conversion of desire to a purer and more single-hearted love of God. With language saturated in the sanjuanist dark night of the spirit, where the advanced contemplative is acutely aware of her distance from the all-Good divine, de la Taille vividly portrays the desire to add (in expiation) this failure in love to the pure oblation of the one acceptable gift.[4] The path of baptismal transformation and spiritual growth is ineluctably marked with propitiatory intention.

In sum, to pass too quickly over the "abrasive" penitential and propitiatory character of the church's (and thereby of the individual believer's) offering, to focus exclusively on the reception of the gift—as happens frequently in contemporary eucharistic theology—is not only

4. Were we to acknowledge a singular limitation in de la Taille's theology, it would have to be the absence of a fully developed theology of how, in trinitarian terms, the purification of the believer's desire occurs in contemplation and in sacrificial oblation. The thought of theologian Sarah Coakley provides a striking systematic understanding of this purgative transformation. Coakley suggests that the Christian Eucharist is an unavoidably vulnerable and "*sacrificial*" site. It is the site, as in the silence of passive prayer, in which the believer is "invited" into the circle of divine desire, the point of entry being that of the Spirit. But that invitation carries risk. In what Coakley calls a "double-pressure," the Holy Spirit both breaks open and purges sinful desires and the conceptual idols of soul, and also *intensifies* desire for the divine. Coakley provocatively illuminates this dynamic in trinitarian terms: the Spirit—"homousian" with the Father and Son—cannot circumvent the reality of Gethsemane and Golgotha. "One might say, she writes, "that the Spirit progressively 'breaks' our sinful desires, *in and through* the passion of Christ"; Coakley, "Prelude," in *God, Sexuality and the Self: An Essay "On the Trinity,"* vol. 1 (Cambridge University Press, forthcoming in 2013); cf. also Coakley, *Flesh and Blood: The Eucharist, Desire and Fragmentation,* The Hensley Henson Lectures (Oxford: Oxford University Press), 2004–2005, see Lecture 3: "Gift Retold: Spirals of Grace," and "Conclusion." Coakley's sanjuanist proposal that the Spirit's work upon human desire leads the believer *through* the cross would likely have been attractive to de la Taille. However, he would no doubt add that even before Gethsemane there is the decisive oblation at the supper (and thus also at the ecclesial offering), in which the will is surrendered in love and given over to the Father's divinizing and purifying acceptance.

to skirt the reality of gift-giving between creatures and an all-holy Creator, but also to bypass the pragmatic continuation of the mystical death of baptism. De la Taille provides a theology of eucharistic sacrifice that supplies a robust *ratio* for the ecclesial sacrificial oblation, as opposed, for example, to a communion service. This is not an insignificant point for theological reflection. Given the growing situation in some dioceses, where a shortage of priests has resulted in a greater frequency of Communion services, the church needs to elucidate what is "lost" when the sacrificial action is replaced with reception alone. The moment of sacrificial oblation is charged with divinely transformative power, and it is this moment into which the believer (and the entire ecclesia) is invited to enter—indeed "marked" to enter—in baptism.

Finally, and sixthly, it is not the case that de la Taille's theology ignores God's initiative in salvation and the Eucharist, a concern frequently raised by eucharistic theologians who advocate the suppression of "sacrifice" in favor of "gift." We have substantiated this by showing how God *operates* upon human desire in sacrifice, as well as by detailing how de la Taille's theology of grace is driven by the priority of God's self-gift, namely, God's divinizing indwelling in the soul. Recall that in de la Taille's theory of sacrifice-as-gift, God is implicated in the exchange, an implication theologically admissible because, for de la Taille, it is the divine who *stirs up* the desire and love with which the sacrifice is offered. This is equally true, as we saw, of the sanjuanist gift-exchange between the purified soul and God in the bridal union of contemplation, which may well be the inspiration behind de la Taille's theology: the purified soul, fired by the love of the Spirit, can offer God to God, and God returns the gift, further enflaming the soul's desire. In fact, from the subjective viewpoint of the worshipper (or the church) and her desire, the eucharistic sacrifice is oddly proleptic of that perfect union and gift-exchange between the purified soul and God. In the Mass, then, it is God who both elicits the gift-giving and purifies the desire of the ecclesial offering. And, as we have been saying, the return fruits of the sacrificial banquet are received in accord with the measure of the offerer's desire. God's initiative thus saturates the entire sacrifice—but without nullifying or usurping the directionality and *real* oblation of the worshipper's

gift, even as that intention is taken up into Jesus's eternal and pure offering of his death at the supper-cross.

On the other hand, we have noted that de la Taille's articulation of sanctifying grace, "created actuation by uncreated Act," also reveals how, in eucharistic sacrifice, the initiative lies with God and in the Victim. In at least two distinctive ways, his theology of grace revolves both upon God's self-gift, the divine desire for union with the human soul, and upon the grace poured forth from the flesh of the sacrificial victim. First, sanctifying grace, or created actuation, is the means, the last disposition *and* the very union itself between God and the believer. In that presence of divinity to the soul, God communicates his love, his divine desire for the creature, which in turn becomes the measure of the soul's own desire for God. But it is not divine initiative alone. For in this real union of potency and act (a real relation in the creature only), there is a possession of the Act by the soul, even as she is possessed by God.

De la Taille likewise posits that all grace flows through Christ, and particularly through his eucharistic flesh. We have seen his lengthy demonstration that habitual grace in Christ was *summa,* and necessarily so because of the grace of union between the Word and human nature. Every grace that the human enjoys is thereby a participated grace in that highest grace of Christ, who is "Head" of the human race. It is a grace communicated to those who eat of his glorified flesh, now "returned" to the ecclesial altar in the church's sacrificial banquet. Contact with that eucharistic flesh divinizes and initiates within the recipient the vital life of resurrection. For de la Taille, the primary effect of receiving the sacrament of the Eucharist is union *ad Christum,* a grace of union that makes the soul deiform even as it strengthens the believer's love of God. Every desire for life and union to God is essentially a desire for the eucharistic Victim, for that grace which unites the believer to Christ and thereby to the divine Trinity. The understanding of theosis that emerges from de la Taille's theory of eucharistic grace is a theory he gleans especially from a deep reading of the Eastern fathers. Without doubt, God is the initiator in this transformation by grace.

Still, the sinner and the ecclesia *must offer.* Attraction to the grace of the Eucharist does not bypass sacrifice and oblation. We acknowledged

at the opening of this study that many leading sacramental theologians have placed an emphasis upon the reception of the eucharistic gift, and then upon the "return" of that gift in ethical action to one's neighbors. De la Taille would surely agree that the *caritas* communicated in the Eucharist manifests itself in works of virtue and charity; in fact, he depicts the Eucharist as the fountain of all charitable and ascetic activity. De la Taille's thought, however, distinctly refocuses theological attention to the transformative potential of the ecclesial action of offering sacrifice. His eucharistic spirituality roots itself in baptism and purifying oblation. Baptism orients the believer to share in Christ's priestly offering of his sacrifice, and in baptismal death the believer already desires and is "touched" by the life-giving and transformative flesh of the Eucharist. The devotion with which the gift is ritually offered in sacrifice is a movement of the will that reflects Christ's own committed heart at the Last Supper. Oblatory desire measures the grace received from the banquet table, and it is this grace that itself measures and amplifies the depth and breadth of desire for prayer and for union with the Lamb of God, even as it determines perseverance in *caritas*.

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